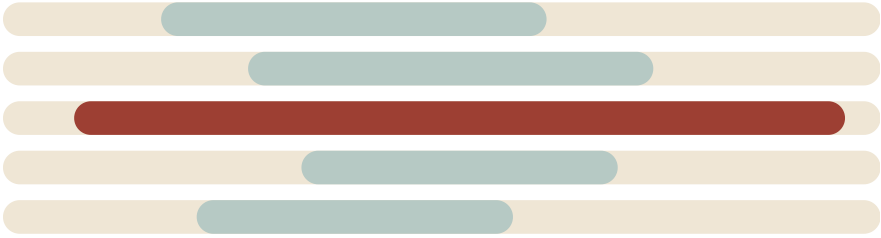
INCLUDED WITH SUEDE PRO

The Voice Atlas

Who sings what, how it sounds, and how to borrow it: the range, tone and technique of every voice in the library.



SUEDE SING · SING.SUEDEAI.AI

CONTENTS

The Voice Atlas

Every line below is a link — tap a chapter to jump straight to it, and the names under each chapter are the voices it covers. Every chapter links back here and on to the next one.

HOW TO READ A VOICE 7

1 How to read an entry 8

2 Notes, octaves and the keyboard 12

3 Voice types in the wild 16

4 A vocabulary for tone 21

THE BORROWER'S METHOD 27

5 How to borrow a voice 28

6 The safety rail 32

POP 36

7 Pop women: the founders 37

Barbra Streisand · Diana Ross · Cher · Linda Ronstadt · Karen Carpenter · Olivia Newton-John · Bonnie Tyler · Kate Bush · Annie Lennox · Cyndi Lauper · Madonna · Whitney Houston · Janet Jackson · Celine Dion · Mariah Carey · Björk

8 Pop women: the moderns 47

Beyoncé · Britney Spears · Christina Aguilera · Pink · Kelly Clarkson · JoJo · Rihanna · Leona Lewis · Miley Cyrus · Taylor Swift · Sara Bareilles · Adele · Demi Lovato · Katy Perry · Lady Gaga · Kesha · Selena Gomez · Ellie Goulding · MARINA · Jessie J · Lana Del Rey · Sia ·

Grimes · Ariana Grande · Camila Cabello · Charli XCX · Lorde · Tori Kelly · Zara Larsson · Meghan Trainor · Melanie Martinez · Aurora · Bebe Rexha · Halsey · Sabrina Carpenter · Billie Eilish · Lizzo · RAYE · Dua Lipa · Kim Petras · Ava Max · Madison Beer · Caroline Polachek · Doja Cat · Faouzia · Chappell Roan · Gracie Abrams · Tate McRae · Olivia Rodrigo · Reneé Rapp · Lola Young

9 The pop men 74

Brian Wilson · Frankie Valli · Tom Jones · Neil Diamond · Barry Gibb · Michael Jackson · Elton John · Billy Joel · Barry Manilow · Christopher Cross · George Michael · Morten Harket · Rick Astley · Robbie Williams · Justin Timberlake · Adam Levine · Jason Mraz · Brendon Urie · Adam Lambert · Justin Bieber · Bruno Mars · Harry Styles · Liam Payne · Louis Tomlinson · Niall Horan · Ed Sheeran · The Weeknd · James Arthur · Nate Ruess · Sam Smith · Zayn · Matty Healy · George Ezra · James Bay · Shawn Mendes · Troye Sivan · Calum Scott · Charlie Puth · Lewis Capaldi · Conan Gray · JVKE · Benson Boone · Stephen Sanchez · David Kushner · Myles Smith · Alex Warren · Sombr

ROCK, METAL AND ALTERNATIVE 99

10 The classic rock men 100

Little Richard · Elvis Presley · Roy Orbison · John Lennon · Mick Jagger · Paul McCartney · Roger Daltrey · Jim Morrison · Joe Cocker · Robert Plant · David Bowie · Ian Gillan · Rod Stewart · Paul Rodgers · Jon Anderson · Peter Gabriel · Don Henley · Kenny Loggins · Freddie Mercury · Glenn Hughes · Sammy Hagar · Steven Tyler · David Coverdale · Geddy Lee · Bruce Springsteen · Dennis DeYoung · Brad Delp · Phil Collins · Tom Petty · Lou Gramm · Meat Loaf · Steve Perry · David Lee Roth · Kevin Cronin · Sting · Klaus Meine · Bono · Brian Johnson · Bryan Adams · Joe Elliott · Jon Bon Jovi · Axl Rose · Lenny Kravitz · Scott Stapp · Matt Bellamy · Chris Martin · Chad Kroeger · Jack White · Caleb Followill · Brandon Flowers · Dan Reynolds · Sam Fender · Damiano David

11 The women of rock 128

Tina Turner · Grace Slick · Janis Joplin · Ann Wilson · Stevie Nicks · Debbie Harry · Joan Jett · Pat Benatar · Dolores O'Riordan · Gwen Stefani · Sharon den Adel · Floor Jansen · Avril Lavigne · Amy Lee · Hayley Williams · Lzzy Hale

12 Alternative, punk and new wave 137

Ian Curtis · Nick Cave · Dave Gahan · Boy George · Robert Smith · Anthony Kiedis · Morrissey · Michael Hutchence · Chris Cornell · Kurt Cobain · Layne Staley · Billy Corgan · Eddie Vedder · Scott Weiland · Thom Yorke · Billie Joe Armstrong · Jeff Buckley · Rivers Cuomo · Alanis Morissette · Chino Moreno · Shirley Manson · Fiona Apple · Brandon Boyd ·

Serj Tankian · Chester Bennington · Julian Casablancas · Gerard Way · Patrick Stump · Alex Turner · Kellin Quinn · Tyler Joseph · Mitski

13 Metal 156

Ozzy Osbourne · Rob Halford · Ronnie James Dio · Glenn Danzig · Bruce Dickinson · King Diamond · Geoff Tate · James Hetfield · Michael Kiske · Mike Patton · Sebastian Bach · Peter Steele · Devin Townsend · Maynard James Keenan · Jonathan Davis · Till Lindemann · Tarja Turunen · Ville Valo · Corey Taylor · David Draiman · M. Shadows · Simone Simons · Myles Kennedy · Oli Sykes · Ronnie Radke · Andy Biersack · Tobias Forge · Elize Ryd · Noah Sebastian · Tatiana Shmayluk · Josh Kiszka

SOUL, R&B AND GOSPEL 174

14 The soul men 175

Ray Charles · James Brown · Jackie Wilson · Sam Cooke · Curtis Mayfield · Smokey Robinson · Marvin Gaye · Otis Redding · Bobby Hatfield · Stevie Wonder · David Ruffin · Wilson Pickett · Aaron Neville · Al Green · Donny Hathaway · Bill Withers · Philip Bailey · Teddy Pendergrass · Barry White · Lionel Richie · Daryl Hall · Michael McDonald · Prince · Luther Vandross · Seal · Brian McKnight · Usher · CeeLo Green · D'Angelo · Maxwell · Musiq Soulchild · John Legend · Leon Bridges · Rag'n'Bone Man

15 The soul and R&B women 193

Etta James · Aretha Franklin · Gladys Knight · Patti LaBelle · Dusty Springfield · Chaka Khan · Minnie Riperton · Anita Baker · Mary J. Blige · Toni Braxton · Brandy · Monica · Lauryn Hill · Erykah Badu · Macy Gray · Jill Scott · Alicia Keys · India.Arie · Amy Winehouse · Joss Stone · Fantasia · Jennifer Hudson · Jazmine Sullivan · Emeli Sandé · Andra Day · Yebba

16 Modern R&B 208

Aaliyah · Faith Evans · Tamia · Kelly Rowland · Pharrell Williams · Ashanti · Akon · Ciara · Chris Brown · Keyshia Cole · T-Pain · Trey Songz · Ne-Yo · Kid Cudi · Solange · Drake · Jason Derulo · Janelle Monáe · Mac Miller · Miguel · Childish Gambino · Frank Ocean · Tyler, the Creator · Coco Jones · Jhené Aiko · Normani · FKA twigs · Tinashe · Bryson Tiller · Kehlani · Post Malone · Anderson .Paak · H.E.R. · Daniel Caesar · Steve Lacy · SZA · XXXTentacion · Ella Mai · Halle Bailey · Juice WRLD · Ravyn Lenae · Ari Lennox · Summer Walker · Giveon · Teddy Swims · Victoria Monét

17 Gospel and a cappella 233

Mahalia Jackson · Karen Clark Sheard · Marvin Winans · Amy Grant · Sandi Patty · Michael W. Smith · Fred Hammond · BeBe Winans · CeCe Winans · Yolanda Adams · Tamela Mann ·

Kim Burrell · Donnie McClurkin · Marvin Sapp · David Phelps · Chris Tomlin · Smokie Norful · Tim Storms · Avi Kaplan · Kirstin Maldonado · Mitch Grassi · Scott Hoying · Geoff Castellucci · Tasha Cobbs Leonard · Lauren Daigle

COUNTRY, FOLK AND JAZZ 247

18 Country 248

Hank Williams · George Jones · Johnny Cash · Patsy Cline · Loretta Lynn · Willie Nelson · Merle Haggard · Waylon Jennings · Tammy Wynette · Dolly Parton · Glen Campbell · Kenny Rogers · John Denver · Emmylou Harris · Reba McEntire · George Strait · Vince Gill · Wynonna Judd · Randy Travis · Alison Krauss · Garth Brooks · Alan Jackson · Trisha Yearwood · Martina McBride · Faith Hill · Tim McGraw · Shania Twain · LeAnn Rimes · Trace Adkins · Kenny Chesney · Keith Urban · Blake Shelton · Josh Turner · Carrie Underwood · Miranda Lambert · Kacey Musgraves · Sturgill Simpson · Chris Stapleton · Kane Brown · Luke Combs · Tyler Childers · Morgan Wallen · Cody Johnson · Orville Peck · Jelly Roll · Lainey Wilson · Zach Bryan

19 Folk and the songwriters 273

Joan Baez · Bob Dylan · Paul Simon · Neil Young · Leonard Cohen · Van Morrison · Joni Mitchell · James Taylor · Tom Waits · Sinéad O'Connor · Tracy Chapman · Tori Amos · Sarah McLachlan · Jewel · Rufus Wainwright · ANOHNI · Sufjan Stevens · Regina Spektor · Florence Welch · Justin Vernon · James Blake · Passenger · Hozier · Vance Joy · Jacob Collier · Clairo · Phoebe Bridgers · Dermot Kennedy · Lizzy McAlpine · Noah Kahan · Gigi Perez

20 Jazz and the standards 290

Louis Armstrong · Bing Crosby · Billie Holiday · Ella Fitzgerald · Nat King Cole · Frank Sinatra · Peggy Lee · Mel Tormé · Sarah Vaughan · Dean Martin · Dinah Washington · Tony Bennett · Julie London · Johnny Mathis · Bobby Darin · Nina Simone · Al Jarreau · Bobby McFerrin · Harry Connick Jr. · Rachelle Ferrell · Diana Krall · Norah Jones · Michael Bublé · Cécile McLorin Salvant · Gregory Porter · Samara Joy · Laufey

THE TRAINED VOICE 305

21 Opera and classical crossover 306

Enrico Caruso · Maria Callas · Mario Lanza · Yma Sumac · Birgit Nilsson · Leontyne Price · Montserrat Caballé · Joan Sutherland · Luciano Pavarotti · Plácido Domingo · Ivan Rebroff · Jessye Norman · José Carreras · Samuel Ramey · Sarah Brightman · Sumi Jo · Cecilia Bartoli · Bryn Terfel · Dmitri Hvorostovsky · Renée Fleming · Andrea Bocelli · Anna Netrebko · Jonas

Kaufmann · Juan Diego Flórez · Josh Groban · Diana Damrau · Philippe Jaroussky · Jackie Evancho

22 Musical theatre 322

Ethel Merman · Judy Garland · Julie Andrews · Bernadette Peters · Michael Crawford · Patti LuPone · Colm Wilkinson · Lea Salonga · Audra McDonald · Idina Menzel · Hugh Jackman · Kristin Chenoweth · Sutton Foster · Nicole Scherzinger · Jonathan Groff · Lea Michele · Aaron Tveit · Sierra Boggess · Ramin Karimloo · Jeremy Jordan · Ben Platt · Cynthia Erivo · Auli'i Cravalho · Loren Allred · Rachel Zegler

THE WORLD'S VOICES 337

23 Latin voices 338

Celia Cruz · Elis Regina · Mercedes Sosa · Vicente Fernández · Caetano Veloso · Milton Nascimento · Julio Iglesias · José José · Juan Gabriel · Camilo Sesto · Luis Miguel · Gloria Estefan · Selena · Thalía · Ricky Martin · Alejandro Fernández · Cristian Castro · Marc Anthony · Shakira · Enrique Iglesias · Luis Fonsi · Natalia Lafourcade · Jenni Rivera · Maluma · Ozuna · Bad Bunny · Christian Nodal · Karol G · Rosalía · Ángela Aguilar · Kali Uchis · Carín León · Omar Apollo · Rauw Alejandro · Peso Pluma

24 K-pop, J-pop and global pop 358

Édith Piaf · Lata Mangeshkar · Charles Aznavour · Teresa Teng · Jacky Cheung · Faye Wong · Laura Pausini · Lara Fabian · Ayumi Hamasaki · Hikaru Utada · Misia · Park Hyo Shin · BoA · Jay Chou · Vitas · JJ Lin · Taeyang · Mika · Taeyeon · G.E.M. · IU · Jonghyun · LiSA · Stromae · Sohyang · Ailee · Baekhyun · Chen · D.O. · Kenshi Yonezu · Loreen · Arijit Singh · Hua Chenyu · Jimin · Jin · Jungkook · V · Solar · Wendy · Rosé · Dimash Kudaibergen · Jongho · Ado · Fujii Kaze · Sam Ryder

25 Reggae, Afrobeats and African voices 383

Miriam Makeba · Fela Kuti · Jimmy Cliff · Toots Hibbert · Bob Marley · Peter Tosh · Dennis Brown · Salif Keita · Grace Jones · Youssou N'Dour · Angélique Kidjo · Sade Adu · Cesária Évora · Buju Banton · Shaggy · Wizkid · Burna Boy · Tems · Rema · Ayra Starr · Tyla

APPENDICES 395

26 The records 396

27 Every voice by type 403

PART I

How to read a voice

1 How to read an entry 8

2 Notes, octaves and the keyboard 12

3 Voice types in the wild 16

4 A vocabulary for tone 21

CONTENTS

1 How to read an entry

Every entry in this atlas has the same skeleton: a name, a voice type, a cited range, sometimes a full-voice ceiling, occasionally a whistle flag, a signature song, and two short paragraphs — one on what the voice sounds like, one on how it works and how to practice toward it. This chapter is the key to that skeleton. Read it once and every one of the hundreds of entries after it becomes legible.

The cited range

The headline figure — F2–G7, C3–Bb5 — is a *cited* range, and the word is doing real work. It means: this is the span between the lowest and highest pitches that circulate in public discussion of this singer, transcribed by listeners from recordings and performances. Nobody ran the singer through a range test. The low note may come from a murmured album cut in one decade and the high note from a single live shriek in another. The companion book, *The Measured Voice*, spends a whole chapter on how those figures get made and what they flatten; the short version is that a cited range is an aggregate of best moments, not a description of an ordinary night.

Most of these figures have not been individually verified against a named recording or score. Where public figures disagree, which for famous singers they usually do, read the entry as one defensible version rather than a ruling, and treat the edges as claims to check, not measurements.

Where the extreme notes happened

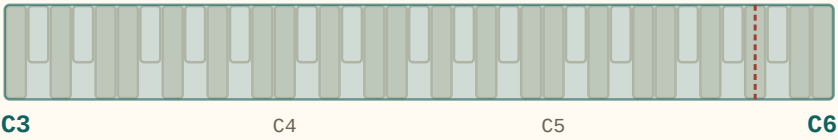
Where an extreme is strongly tied to one recording, the entry names it: the note and the song it lives in. Axl Rose's cited top comes from "Ain't It Fun." Minnie Riperton's F#7 sits in "You Take My Breath Away." Chris Cornell's A5 is the wail in "Beyond the Wheel." Mariah Carey's G7 belongs to "Emotions."

Treat those citations as listening assignments, because they carry information the bare note cannot. A top note *sustained through a chorus* tells you the singer owns that pitch. A top note that is one glissando at the end of a live take tells you they visited it once. Both are real; they are not the same fact. When an entry names no source, the extreme is the kind that appears across many recordings rather than famously in one — or the honest answer is that the commonly cited figure travels without its receipt, which is itself worth knowing.

The full-voice ceiling

Many entries carry a second, smaller number: the highest note the singer takes in full, connected voice — a belt or a strong mix — before handing the rest of the span to falsetto, head voice or whistle. On the singers chart it is the solid part of each bar, and a bar drawn dashed means none is cited; a singer's page states it in words as the catalog's highest full or belted note. In print it reads "full voice to G5."

For a working singer this is the most useful number on the page. The gap between it and the cited top is the falsetto-and-above zone. Two singers can both show a span to C6; if one belts to A5 and the other flips at E4, they are running different machines.



A cited span of C3 to C6 with full voice to A5, the dashed line. Everything above the line is falsetto, head voice or whistle.

No ceiling listed means the catalog has no cited full-voice figure. Some voices, often operatic ones, do take full voice to the top; often nobody has documented the handover. Read the technique paragraph before assuming either.

The whistle flag

A few entries note whistle register: the flute-like mechanism above head voice. The flag exists so you do not read a G7 as a G7 of singing in any ordinary sense. Whistle notes are real, rare and almost entirely separate from the rest of the voice — a different valve, not a higher gear. The safety chapter has more to say about chasing them; the summary is *don't, yet*.

The two paragraphs

The first paragraph, in the singer's entry, is the sound: what you would notice in ten seconds of listening. The second is the mechanism and the lesson — how the voice appears to be produced, what to practice if you want to borrow from it, and the mistake imitators reliably make. These are editorial. They describe technique as it presents on recordings; they are not claims about a singer's private practice, health

or biography. Where a voice has paid obvious costs for its style, the entry says so plainly, because you are reading this book partly to decide which costs to pay with your own.

What an entry will not tell you

An entry cannot tell you the singer's tessitura — the narrow band where the voice actually lives night to night — because no public figure records it. It cannot tell you what the voice sounds like this year. And it cannot tell you what *your* voice should do with the information. The method chapters at the end of Part II exist for exactly that translation, and the range test in the app will give you your own numbers to translate from. The atlas is a map of other people's territory. The point of a map is to plan your own route, not to stand on it.

NEXT Notes, octaves and the keyboard →

2 Notes, octaves and the keyboard

Every range in this book is written in scientific pitch notation: a letter, maybe a sharp or flat, and a number. The system takes five minutes to learn and then never leaves you, and without it the atlas is a wall of code. Here is the whole thing.

The letter and the number

The letter names the note inside an octave — the white keys run C, D, E, F, G, A, B, and then the pattern repeats. The number tells you *which* octave, and octaves change at C, not at A. So the count runs A3, B3, **C4**, D4 — the number ticks up as you cross C.

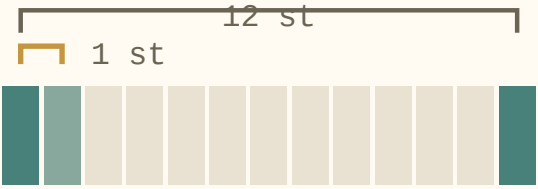
C4 is middle C, the C nearest the middle of a piano. Everything else hangs off that anchor. A4 is the A above middle C, the orchestra's tuning note at 440 Hz. C5 is an octave above middle C; C3 an octave below. The lowest note on a standard piano is A0, the highest C8. Almost every singing voice on earth lives somewhere between C2 and C6; the atlas's outliers stretch past both ends, which is what makes them outliers.

For quick intuition: most men speak somewhere around C3, most women around G3–A3. Find your speaking pitch on a keyboard once and the whole notation system snaps into focus, because every figure in this book becomes "so far above where I talk, so far below."

Sharps, flats and the same-note problem

The black keys carry two names each. The key between F and G is F# — F raised a semitone — and also Gb, G lowered one. F#5 and Gb5 are the *same pitch*, and which spelling you see is convention and habit, nothing more. The atlas mostly picks one spelling per entry and sticks with it, but when you cross-reference other sources you will meet the twin. Do not read Eb6 versus D#6 as a disagreement; it is one note wearing two name tags.

A semitone is the distance between any key and its immediate neighbor, black keys included — the smallest step Western music uses. Twelve of them make an octave. Those two facts are the entire arithmetic of this book.

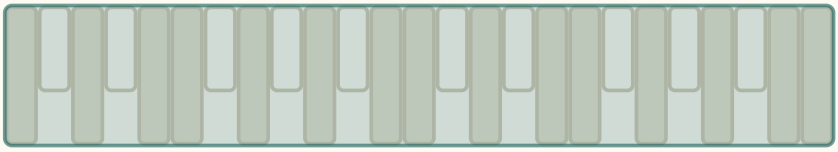


One semitone is one key to its neighbour, black keys included. Twelve make an octave.

Counting a span

A range like C3–C5 spans two octaves: count the Cs. When the ends do not line up so neatly, count semitones and divide. B2 to E5 is 29 semitones; 29 ÷ 12 is 2.4 octaves, and the entry will say so. The singer

pages do this math for you, showing both the semitone count and the decimal.



C3 to C5: count the Cs, and the span is two octaves, with middle C between them.

Two warnings about spans, because they are the most misread numbers in the atlas. First, a span says nothing about what fills it. A 2.1-octave voice that is strong everywhere is a better instrument than a 4-octave figure held together by two party tricks — the full-voice ceiling from the last chapter tells you which you are looking at. Second, octaves are not linearly impressive. Each extra half-octave at the edges is harder won than the last, and the far ends depend more on anatomy and on switching between mechanisms than on practice, which is why the method chapters keep pointing you at the middle of your voice instead of the ends of someone else's.

Why sources disagree

Look up any singer in this book elsewhere and you will find a different figure — sometimes wildly different. The variance has boring causes, and knowing them inoculates you against range-war arguments online.

Different evidence pools: one transcriber counts studio recordings only, another counts every live bootleg, a third counts a warm-up clip posted

on social media. Different rules: some count vocal fry rumbling below the chest voice, some count a squealed glissando as the top, some insist a note must be sustained and musical to count at all. Different ears: transcription at the extremes is hard, and a note at the edge of hearing on a distorted live tape gets called D8 by one listener and C#8 by the next. Stack three lenient rules and a singer gains an octave without singing a note.

The atlas does not settle those disagreements. Its figures are the ones that circulate, so they carry the same mix of rules; what it adds is a whistle flag where whistle is documented and, where an extreme is tied to one recording, the song it lives in. When your favorite singer's number here differs from one you have seen elsewhere, one of the causes above is usually why.

What to do with all this

Learn to hear the notation, not just read it. The singer pages will play any cited range out loud on a keyboard — use that until F#5 is a sound in your head and not a string. Then take your own range test, write your own two numbers in the same notation, and the atlas stops being trivia. Every figure in the next several hundred entries becomes a point on the same ruler you have been measured with, which is the only way a compendium like this becomes useful rather than merely long.

NEXT Voice types in the wild →

3 Voice types in the wild

Every entry carries one of eight labels: soprano, mezzo-soprano, contralto, countertenor, tenor, baritone, bass-baritone, bass. The labels are old, they come from a world with different rules, and applied to popular music they are useful exactly as long as you know how loosely they are being used. This chapter is the loose-usage manual.

Where the labels come from

The system is operatic. In that world a voice type — the traditional word is *fach* — is a job description: it says which roles you sing, which orchestra you must be heard over without a microphone, and where your voice can sit for three hours a night without wearing out. Classifying an opera singer involves range, yes, but also timbre, weight, agility, and above all *tessitura* — the band of pitches where the voice works comfortably for hours, which is always much narrower than the range and matters far more.

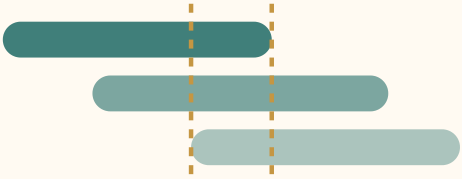
The eight labels run low to high. For the voices historically classified as male: bass (the cellar), bass-baritone, baritone (where most men actually sit), tenor (the high-demand commodity), countertenor (a trained voice living mostly in falsetto-family production, rare everywhere and rarest of all in pop). For the voices historically classified as female: contralto (genuinely deep and genuinely rare), mezzo-soprano (where most women actually sit), soprano (the top). Notice the symmetry: in

both columns, the *middle* label is the common one. Extremes are scarce by definition.

What the label means in this book

When this atlas calls a pop singer a mezzo-soprano, it is making a much smaller claim than an opera house would: roughly, "the comfortable center of this voice sits in the mezzo neighborhood, and the timbre reads that way on records." Nobody has tested the singer against an orchestra. Pop classification is a description of habitat, not a certification.

Two consequences follow. First, do not be surprised when a pop soprano's cited range dips below a pop contralto's — range and type are different measurements. The type tracks where the voice *lives*; the range tracks the furthest it has ever been photographed. A soprano with a practiced low extension can show a floor below a contralto who never records down there, and the atlas is full of exactly that pattern. Second, do not treat another singer's label as a constraint on you. Microphones changed the game: amplification means a baritone can sing soft and high over a huge track, a mezzo can whisper where an opera house would demand a blade of sound. Half the innovation in twentieth-century singing is people ignoring what their fach was supposed to do.



Three voice types, overlapping. The notes between the dashed lines belong to all three, which is why a range alone rarely settles a type.

Tessitura, one more time

Range is the two extreme notes. Tessitura is where the melody spends its time — the middle of the histogram, not its edges. Two tenors with identical C3–C5 figures can have tessituras a fourth apart, and the one whose songs sit higher will feel unsingable to the other despite the matching numbers. When an entry's technique paragraph says a voice "sits low" or "lives above the staff," it is telling you tessitura, and that sentence predicts whether the singer's songs will fit you better than the headline figure ever will. The transposition chapter of *The Measured Voice* turns that prediction into a practical rule: match your comfortable band to the song's busiest band and move the key by the difference.

Guessing your own type

Without a teacher you can get usefully close in ten minutes.

- **Find your speaking pitch.** Say a relaxed sentence and match it on a keyboard. Speech usually sits near the bottom third of your comfortable singing band, so it hints at where that band starts, but

speaking pitch overlaps a lot between types: treat it as a clue, not a sorter.

- **Find your yawn floor and easy ceiling.** The lowest note you can sound with full tone before it crumbles to fry; the highest you can sing softly in connected voice without reaching. Ignore your extremes on both ends — comfort, not conquest.
- **Notice where songs betray you.** If everything on the radio feels slightly high, you are probably a step lower than the artists singing it; many male pop leads are tenors, while most men sit in baritone territory.

Then hold the conclusion lightly. Voices reclassify with training, with age, and with repertoire; plenty of working tenors spent their first years labeled baritone, and the label matters less than a decade of good habits. The type is a starting shelf in a library, nothing more.

How to use types when reading the atlas

Use them as a filter, not a fence. Reading entries whose type matches yours shows you what voices with your architecture have done — which is inspiration with a floor plan attached. Reading entries a type away shows you what to borrow with modification: a mezzo can steal a soprano's phrasing but should expect to steal it a third lower. The voice-type appendix at the back of this book groups every entry by label for exactly that kind of shopping, and the per-type pages on the site keep the same shelves. Borrow along your own shelf first; visit the others knowing the price of import.

NEXT A vocabulary for tone →

4 A vocabulary for tone

Range is easy to write down. Tone is where description usually collapses into perfume copy — "velvety," "angelic," "smoky" — words that sound like meaning and pin down nothing. The entries in this atlas avoid that by leaning on a small technical vocabulary, maybe fifteen words, each of which names something you can actually hear and, more usefully, something you can practice. This chapter defines them once, with singers from these pages as the reference recordings. Learn the words and every entry doubles in resolution; so does your ear.

Weight

Weight is how much of the vocal folds' mass engages in the sound — the difference between a flute and a cello playing the same pitch. Heavy production reads as thick, muscular, consequential: Céline Dion's middle voice, Luke Combs's belt, Patti LaBelle nearly everywhere. Light production reads as slim and quick: Chris Brown, Ellie Goulding, Juan Diego Flórez, whose entire career is proof of how high a voice can go precisely because it refuses to carry weight up the scale. Weight trades against agility and altitude — the recurring tragedy of amateur singing is hauling a heavy setup into territory only light setups can hold.

Placement and brightness

Placement is where the sound seems to resonate — a sensation with fuzzy physics but perfectly real acoustics. Forward placement, "in the mask," gives ring and cut: Steven Tyler, Ailee, Rema's high nasal shine. Back placement gives warmth and hoot: Josh Groban, Samara Joy's plush low register. Related but not identical is brightness — the balance of high overtones in the tone. Bright and dark are the equalizer; forward and back are where the equalizer seems to live in the singer's head.

Vibrato: rate, width, delay

Vibrato is the pitch oscillating around its center, and it carries three separate dials. *Rate*: fast flutter (Ellie Goulding, Dolly Parton) versus slow undulation (Christian Nodal's ranchera wave). *Width*: narrow shimmer versus Giveon's famously wide wobble that flirts with the next semitone over. *Delay*: immediate (opera, most of musical theatre) versus delayed, with straight tone first and bloom on beat three, the default across modern pop and jazz from Billie Eilish to Samara Joy. When an entry says "vibrato arrives late," that is the dial it means. All three are trainable; a delayed start is a good first one to practise, because it begins from a plain, straight tone.

Onset

Onset is how a note begins. A breathy onset lets air through before the folds meet: intimate, confessional, Enrique Iglesias's entire brand. A glottal onset snaps the folds shut first — the little click that starts so many Britney Spears and Björk phrases. A balanced onset starts clean, air and closure arriving together, which is the trained default and what

you should practice even if you never plan to use anything else, because the other two are choices only when you can do all three.

Breathiness

Air deliberately mixed into the tone throughout the note, not just at the start. One notch of it reads as closeness (Selena Gomez); several notches read as whisper-singing (Summer Walker, Gracie Abrams). Breathiness is expensive — it spends lung volume fast and disappears without a microphone — which is why it barely existed as a technique before amplification and why it fails on unamplified stages today.

Grit, rasp and distortion

The controlled noise family, from a light sizzle on the tone (Myles Smith, Anderson .Paak) through committed rasp (Joe Cocker, Luke Combs) to full distortion (metal's growls and screams). Produced sustainably, the noise comes from structures *above* the vocal folds fluttering against the airstream while the folds underneath keep vibrating normally. Produced unsustainably, it is the folds slamming — and the difference is invisible from the audience and hard to judge reliably from inside, which is why the safety chapter's rule is to get ears on it and to treat any grit that leaves you hoarse as the wrong kind. That chapter returns to this; the entries flag singers whose grit is a supervised skill rather than an accident.

Twang and nasality

Twang is a narrowing above the folds that adds a bright, brassy, penetrating edge — country's calling card (Morgan Wallen's curl, Dolly Parton), but also the secret cutting agent in most big pop belts. True nasality is air actually escaping through the nose; twang often gets mislabeled as nasal because both are bright. Test: pinch your nose shut mid-note. If the tone barely changes, it was twang; if it chokes, it was nasal. Both are legitimate colors — Peso Pluma builds a whole style on the pinched version — but you want to *choose* them, not default to them.

Cry

A slight sob placed in the tone — the larynx tilting into the posture of weeping — that makes intensity read as emotion instead of volume. Yebba's mix is the atlas's clearest exemplar; Jeff Buckley and Sam Smith run on it; Camila Cabello turns it into ornament. Cry is also mechanically useful: the tilt thins the folds and makes high notes easier, which is why "add a little whimper" is one of the oldest teacher tricks for a strained top.

Register colors

Words the entries use for where a note is made rather than how it is flavoured.

TERM	WHERE IT IS MADE	HEAR IT IN
Chest voice	The speaking mechanism: full and grounded	Your own speaking voice
Head voice	The lighter upper mechanism: clear and rounded	–
Falsetto	The flutey, disconnected upper voice, airy at the edges	Frank Ocean's confessional top
Mix	Chest and head blended so the seam disappears	Nearly every big modern pop chorus
Belt	Chest-dominant, carried above the natural break	Reneé Rapp, Idina Menzel
Whistle	A separate mechanism above head voice	Mariah Carey, Minnie Riperton
Fry	The creak below chest	Britney Spears's onsets, modern pop verses

Using the vocabulary

Two habits turn this list from glossary into equipment. First, when you listen to any singer — in this book or out of it — name three dials instead of reaching for an adjective: "light weight, forward placement, delayed narrow vibrato" says more than "airy" ever will, and it hands you a practice plan. Second, when an entry's technique paragraph names a dial, treat that as the entry telling you *what to isolate first* if you want to borrow the voice. The next chapter is the borrowing method itself.

NEXT How to borrow a voice →

II

PART

The borrower's method

5 How to borrow a voice 28

6 The safety rail 32

CONTENTS

5 How to borrow a voice

Imitation has a bad reputation in singing, and it earned it honestly: the karaoke Axl, the coffee-shop Adele, the church soloist doing a full Mariah on a congregation that asked for a hymn. But the reputation confuses bad imitation with imitation itself. Every distinctive singer you admire built their voice by borrowing — deliberately, specifically, and temporarily — from singers before them. The entries in this atlas each end with practice guidance, and all of it assumes the same underlying method. Here is the method in full, once, so the entries can stay short.

Step one: pick a trait, not a person

"I want to sound like Freddie Mercury" is not an executable instruction. It names a whole person — range, tone, taste, theatricality, four decades of habits — and whole people cannot be practiced. "I want Freddie's squillo-bright vowels on sustained notes" can be practiced this afternoon.

So the first move is always decomposition. Take the singer you admire and, using the tone vocabulary from the last chapter, write down the three dials that most make them *them*. For Amy Winehouse you might write: behind-the-beat phrasing, dark rounded vowels, lazy late vibrato. For Chester Bennington: clean-to-distorted onset control, forward placement, sustained belts. Then pick **one**. The technique paragraph in each entry usually does this decomposition for you and names the trait

imitators reliably get wrong — that sentence is the entry telling you where the bodies are buried.

Step two: match the habitat, not the notes

Almost every failed imitation fails here. You cannot practice someone's tone in a part of your range where you are fighting for survival; tone work only sticks in territory you already hold comfortably.

So find where the trait actually lives in the original — which notes, which part of *their* voice — and then move it into the equivalent part of *yours*. If they demonstrate the trait around their comfortable upper-middle, practice it around your comfortable upper-middle, wherever that is on the absolute keyboard. In practice this means transposing: take the song down (or up) until its busiest band sits where your voice is at ease, and do the trait work there. A baritone practicing Sam Cooke's end-of-phrase turns a fourth below the record is learning them; a baritone cracking at the record's pitch is learning to crack. Keys are a free parameter. Your vocal folds are not.

Step three: one dial at a time

Change a single variable per practice block. If you are working on Winehouse's timing, sing the phrase in *your own* tone with *her* timing — resist the tribute-act instinct to do the accent, the vowels and the attitude at once. Multi-dial imitation feels productive because it sounds superficially closer, but nothing transfers; you are performing a wax figure, not acquiring a skill. Ten minutes on one dial, done daily for two weeks, transfers.

Borrow in this order:

- **Rhythm and phrasing.** Cheapest, safest, most distinctive.
- **Vowel colour and placement.**
- **Onset and vibrato.**
- **Weight and grit, last,** and only in comfortable range. Grit follows the next chapter's rules: quiet before loud, none that leaves you hoarse, a teacher's ears as soon as you can.

Notice that "their high notes" appears nowhere on that list. The top of a famous voice is its least imitable part and its most expensive, which is why the entries keep steering you toward each singer's *middle*.

Step four: close the loop

Imitation without recording is guessing. The loop is: listen to four bars of the original, sing the same four bars, record, compare, name one difference in vocabulary terms, adjust, repeat. Twenty minutes of loop beats two hours of singing along, because singing along lets the original mask you — you literally cannot hear yourself failing to match. The recorder in the app exists for this; so does the compare-with-me strip on every singer page, which puts your measured range next to theirs and tells you honestly how much of their territory you currently hold.

Expect the comparison to be humbling in a specific, encouraging way: the differences you find will almost never be range. They will be onsets, releases, timing, vowel shapes — all learnable. Singers listen for pitch; listeners hear everything else.

Step five: time-box the costume

A borrowed trait starts as a costume: it only exists while you concentrate on it. Worn deliberately for two or three weeks, it either integrates — starts showing up unprompted in songs where it belongs, at which point it is wardrobe, yours — or it stays a costume, in which case take it off and pick a different trait. Both outcomes are wins. The failure mode is the permanent costume: the singer who spent five years being a knockoff of one idol and never noticed the lease expired. The cure is volume and variety — borrow from many voices, one trait each, and your own style assembles itself out of the overlaps. That is not a consolation prize; it is the actual mechanism by which every original voice you admire became original.

What borrowing cannot do

It cannot get you another person's anatomy — fold length, tract shape, resonance real estate. It cannot get you their extremes, and chasing those is where imitation stops being education and starts being expense; the next chapter draws that line precisely. And it cannot substitute for having something to say with the trait once you own it. The atlas gives you several hundred voices' worth of things worth stealing. Steal small, steal often, and pay attention to which thefts feel like coming home — that feeling is your own voice voting.

NEXT The safety rail →

6 The safety rail

Most of this atlas is safe to use. Phrasing, placement, vibrato behavior, vowel color, timing — you can borrow any of it at conversational volume in your comfortable range and the worst possible outcome is sounding silly in your practice room. But the book also documents extremes, because the extremes are real and people search for them, and four of them are expensive to chase without preparation. This chapter is the price list. It is short, it is not medical advice, and the entries assume you have read it.

Whistle register

The G7s and C8s in these pages are made by a mechanism most voices have never once engaged, not by pushing head voice higher. Hunting for it by singing your highest note louder and higher accomplishes nothing except grinding the top of your head voice against its ceiling, repeatedly, which is exactly the kind of friction voices dislike. If whistle interests you, the search sounds like the *opposite* of effort: tiny, quiet, squeaky experiments above your range, seconds at a time, abandoned instantly if anything scratches. Many perfectly complete singers never find it. Nothing in the whistle entries — Mariah Carey's, Minnie Riperton's, Dimash Kudaibergen's — is load-bearing for your development. They are documentation, not homework.

Extreme lows

The floor of your voice is set by fold mass, and no exercise adds mass. What practice genuinely improves is the *quality* of the lows you already own — resonance, evenness, usefulness — typically extending reliable range downward by a small handful of semitones as inefficiencies clear. The C2s and F1s in this book belong to specific large instruments; pressing your larynx down and gargling toward them produces a sound with no music in it and a throat that aches, which is your answer. If your mornings rumble, train them gently in the morning. If they do not, the basement is not yours, and the atlas's contraltos and basses would tell you their cellar came with the house.

Grit and distortion

Every raspy voice in this book falls into one of two categories, and from the audience they sound identical: noise generated *above* the folds by structures fluttering safely in the airstream, or noise generated *at* the folds by slamming them together under pressure. The first is a skill; the second is an injury schedule. You cannot reliably teach yourself the difference from text, this text included — distortion is the one technique in this book where "get ears on it" is the whole recommendation. The affordable rule until then: any grit that leaves you hoarse afterward was the wrong kind, and grit borrowed at high volume before it works at low volume will always be the wrong kind. Note how many of the atlas's raspiest entries — Cocker, Tyler, the metal chapter's screamers — describe effort that is *distributed*, built across a phrase, never detonated on one note. That distribution is the visible half of the skill.

Sustained belting

The belt is not inherently dangerous; the belt *schedule* is. One F5 proves nothing either way — the question is whether the production survives a chorus repeated forty times, which is what a song, a set, a run of shows actually demands. The belters in this book with long careers all show the same tells on recordings: they belt on narrow vowels, they place the loudest moment once per song rather than throughout, and they get *louder by getting brighter*, not by pushing more air. Practice belts at about eighty percent most of the time; once that version is easy, rehearse the full-volume version a few times in a session, so nothing you sing in performance is louder than something you have rehearsed — and treat any belt that requires a running start or a neck full of tension as a belt you do not own yet at that pitch. Take it down a whole step; own it there first.

The signals that mean stop

Practice that is working feels like effort in the torso and freedom in the throat. The reverse — comfort in the body, gripping in the throat — means the setup is wrong, whatever the sound says. Beyond that, three bright lines.

SIGN	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
Pain while singing	A stop sign	Stop for the session
Hoarseness that clears overnight	The habit costs too much	Practise less of it
Hoarseness that does not clear, a rough morning voice past two weeks, an easy note that is gone	Not a technique question	See a doctor who can examine the vocal folds, such as an ENT or laryngologist, often with a voice-specialist speech-language pathologist. There is no waiting period, and you need not be sure it is serious.

None of this is a reason to sing smaller. It is the reason the singers in this book got to sing big for decades. The rail is what makes leaning out safe.

NEXT Pop women: the founders →

III

PART

Pop

7 Pop women: the founders 37

8 Pop women: the moderns 47

9 The pop men 74

CONTENTS

7 Pop women: the founders

This chapter collects the women who built the job description "pop lead vocalist" — voices that defined eras before and just as the microphone era gave way to the streaming one. Reading their entries in sequence is watching an arms race unfold: each generation found a new way to make a chorus feel bigger, from orchestral restraint to gospel-fired melisma to the industrial-strength belt, and each new weapon became the next generation's entry requirement.

Three patterns are worth holding as you read. First, nearly every founder's entry shows a wide gap between speaking-range verses and a carefully rationed peak — the older discipline of *saving it* — where modern charts often demand the peak in every chorus. That rationing is why so many of these careers ran thirty and forty years, and it is the single most borrowable habit in this chapter. Second, the tone vocabulary works overtime here: these entries lean on weight, vibrato width and placement more than agility, because the era's records were built on sustained notes you could hang a key change on. Third, read the extremes here with the first chapter's caveats: each is one recorded moment. Where an entry gives a full-voice ceiling, it is the more useful number, because it marks where the connected voice tops out, but it is still a peak, not where the songs sat; several entries in this room give none.

Borrow from these voices the way the method chapter suggests: phrasing and dynamic architecture first. The founders are the atlas's

best syllabus in *building* a song — where to sit low, when to open, how to make the third chorus an event without screaming the first two.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Barbra Streisand

Bb2–C6 · 3 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 1963 · known for “The Way We Were”

Long legato lines with exact vowel placement; climaxes come from breath control, not volume.

Everything hangs on legato: notes connect with no gap, no scoop, and no restart of air, so a phrase can run long past where most singers would take a breath. The belt tops out around D5 and the range above it is sung as a lightened head tone, so climaxes come from lengthening and swelling a line rather than adding volume. Tall, exact vowels carry a slow and often delayed vibrato, while consonants land late, right on the beat — and that timing is what keeps a slow ballad from drifting.

Diana Ross

Eb3–C6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano USA · prominent since 1964 · known for “Ain't No Mountain High Enough”

Thin-edged bright tone with breathy onsets; phrasing stays conversational across the groove.

Thin cord closure gives a bright, narrow edge that cuts through a dense track without much volume behind it. Onsets are breathy, words are delivered conversationally on top of the groove, and the top of the range is reached as a light head tone rather than belted. What vibrato there is stays small, and it often disappears entirely. Ornament is sparse — a bend or a single turn, not a run. Restraint and forward placement are the whole appeal, and added soul weight or heavy melisma pulls against them.

Cher

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Contralto full voice to D5 USA · prominent since 1965 · known for “Believe”

Thick low-set chest voice with wide vibrato; hard consonants, phrasing that sits behind the beat.

Weight comes from a chest register set low and thick, with a dark, almost brassy edge that carries down toward F2 without going hollow. Vibrato is wide and slow — closer to a swell than a flutter — and it tends to open up on the last beat of a held word. Consonants hit hard, and phrases sit a hair behind the beat, which reads as weight. Above the D5 belt the tone releases into something lighter. Dropping the larynx to fake that depth just produces a hooty, unfocused sound.

Linda Ronstadt

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Soprano USA · prominent since 1967 · known for “Blue Bayou”

Full-bodied chest voice with clean intonation; carries weight high before easing into head voice.

Full chest weight is carried surprisingly high before the voice releases into a round head tone, and the handoff is done by easing pressure rather than by flipping — the sustained high line late in "Blue Bayou" shows the release clearly. Intonation is exact, onsets are firm and unaspirated, and vibrato is even and moderate in width, arriving after the pitch is established. Phrasing sits right on the beat with country-style bends on individual words. The roundness up there survives only because the height is eased into instead of forced.

Karen Carpenter

D3–Eb5 · 2 octaves + 1



Contralto USA · prominent since 1969 · known for “Close to You”

Warm low-middle register sung close to the mic, minimal vibrato, very even air pressure.

Nearly all of it lives in the low-middle, a region most singers pass through on the way up, and it is sung close to the microphone at a conversational volume. Air pressure barely changes across a phrase, vibrato is minimal, and there is almost no scoop into notes — pitches arrive already centered. Consonants stay soft so the line never breaks. Two things ruin an imitation: transposing it up into a brighter part of the voice, and adding vibrato, which immediately makes the evenness disappear.

Olivia Newton-John

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano Australia · prominent since 1971 · known for “Hopelessly Devoted to You”

Clear light tone with soft onsets and almost no rasp; relies on pitch accuracy over power.

Clarity does the work here. Onsets are soft and slightly breathy, the tone carries no rasp at all, and the transition into head voice is smoothed over so completely that the seam is hard to hear. A light vibrato usually waits for the end of a sustained note. Pitch lands dead center with only small country-style bends into a few words. Nothing is belted. This is a sound built by taking effort away rather than adding it, and too much air is what turns clear into foggy.

Bonnie Tyler

D3–G5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano full voice to F5 UK · prominent since 1977 · known for “Total Eclipse of the Heart”

HIGH G5 IN “SI DEMAIN (TURN AROUND)”

Gravel-and-flame rock mezzo — a torn, husky rasp that turns every chorus into a storm warning.

Rasp with architecture: Tyler's distortion is constant, a torn edge riding on full chest resonance, yet the pitch line underneath is disciplined. She belts F5 with a wide-open throat and huge breath spend, letting sustains fray deliberately at the tip. Verses sit low around D3, husky and confiding, before the register slams upward toward G5 peaks. Copying the gravel by grinding the throat is the classic error — hers sits high in the mask, powered by torso-deep support.

Kate Bush

C3–C6 · 3 octaves



Soprano UK · prominent since 1978 · known for “Wuthering Heights”

Fluttering vibrato and character placement; jumps from breathy speech to a piercing head voice.

Character comes first and tone follows it, so the placement shifts line to line: breathy near-speech, a nasal pinched middle, then a thin, piercing head voice reached by leap rather than by climb. Vibrato flutters fast and narrow, sometimes fast enough to read as a trill. Words get stretched, swallowed, or bitten off for effect, and glides between distant notes are audible on purpose. In "Wuthering Heights" the high writing stays in head voice throughout. Students squeeze the throat for that thinness instead of letting the cords stay light.

Annie Lennox

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Contralto full voice to Eb5 UK · prominent since 1983 · known for “Sweet Dreams (Are Made of This)”

Dark chesty low notes under a hard-edged mid belt; tall vowels, vibrato held back until late.

Two clear gears: a dark, fully chested bottom that stays resonant near G2, and a hard-edged mid belt topping out around Eb5 that gets its bite from tall, slightly covered vowels rather than from shouting. Vibrato is withheld — long notes sit straight and only open up in the final moment. Onsets are firm and precise, with no scooping, and phrases are cut off cleanly. Above the belt the tone thins into head voice. That edge is built in the vowel, never in the throat.

Cyndi Lauper

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano USA · prominent since 1983 · known for “Time After Time”

Bright edgy chest notes that flip abruptly into a thin, wide-vibrato upper register.

The register change is the signature: bright, nasal-edged chest notes flip suddenly into a thin upper voice with a wide, loose vibrato, and the flip is left audible rather than smoothed over. It reads almost like a yodel on wide leaps. Lower singing is conversational and often gentle, as in "Time After Time"; the edge only appears when she pushes forward into the nose and mask. Students hear the flip as a crack and try to eliminate it, which removes the whole effect — practice it deliberately at low volume.

Madonna

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano full voice to C5 USA · prominent since 1983 · known for “Like a Prayer”

Early records sit at speech-level chest tone; later work adds a rounder, trained middle register.

Most of the singing happens in a narrow band at speech level, delivered with a thin, bright chest tone and very little vibrato — the interest lives in rhythm and consonant placement, not in tone color. With the belt around C5 and the ceiling well above it, the upper notes come out as a light, sometimes deliberately girlish head voice rather than a pushed chest note. Later material sits rounder and lower in the throat. The rhythmic snap depends on that lightness; extra weight and vibrato blunt it immediately.

Whitney Houston

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 1985 · known for “I Will Always Love You”

Gospel-trained mix with a bright forward tone; runs stay in chest weight instead of thinning out.

Listen for a bright, forward placement with real thickness behind it: the tone sits high in the mask but the cords stay fully together, so a G5 belt lands with the same core as a D4. Onsets are clean and unaspirated, vibrato arrives at the tail of a held note rather than the start, and melisma keeps chest weight instead of lightening. In the final chorus of "I Will Always Love You" the size comes from breath speed and narrowed vowels, not from pushed volume or a clenched jaw.

Janet Jackson

C3–D6 · 3 octaves + 2



Soprano · USA · prominent since 1986 · known for “Rhythm Nation”

LOW C3 IN “NO SLEEEP” · HIGH D6 IN “HE DOESN'T KNOW I'M ALIVE”

Feather-light pop-funk mix: breathy, rhythm-locked phrasing and whispery stacked harmonies over machine grooves.

Janet works close to the microphone, favoring a light, breathy mix over open-throated belting. She stacks whispery harmonies in thirds and lets consonants land on the groove, so rhythm does the projecting that volume does not. Head voice stays airy and slightly straight-toned, with vibrato saved for phrase endings. Students copying her usually over-breathe the tone and lose pitch center; she keeps the breath shallow but the placement forward, and she never pushes the mix past its natural weight.

Celine Dion

Bb2–C6 · 3 octaves + 2



Soprano · full voice to G5 · Canada · prominent since 1990 · known for “My Heart Will Go On”

Narrow vowels and a nasal-forward mix let her hold long belted phrases at steady pressure.

Verses often begin almost spoken and quiet, with soft aspirate onsets, then build in one long ramp toward a sustained belt near G5. The vowels narrow as pitch rises, which keeps the resonance nasal-forward and lets the note hold at even pressure rather than blowing out. Consonants are crisp and slightly over-articulated. A fast, narrow vibrato usually switches on partway through a long note instead of at its start. The architecture is the point: the ending only reads as a climax because the opening was held so far back.

Mariah Carey

F2–G7 · 5 octaves + 2



Soprano · full voice to G5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 1990 · known for “Vision of Love”

LOW F2 IN “BYE BYE” · HIGH G7 IN “EMOTIONS”

Breathy low register, dense upper mix, and a whistle top used as melody rather than decoration.

Three distinct sounds get stacked in one phrase: an airy, half-voiced bottom, a compressed mix that belts to around G5, and a whistle that sits far above it and functions as a written line, not a stunt. Notice how the whistle enters without a scoop or a break — the cords are already set before air moves. Riffs are fast, rhythmically placed off the beat, and articulated with the tongue rather than the throat. The usual mistake is chasing the top of "Emotions" before the mix underneath it is stable.

Björk

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano Iceland · prominent since 1993 · known for “It's Oh So Quiet”

Swings from whisper to full-throat shout in a bar; open vowels and glottal attacks drive phrasing.

Dynamics move in jumps, not ramps: a near-whisper can become a wide-open shout inside a bar, which is exactly the device "It's Oh So Quiet" is built on. Attacks are frequently glottal, vowels stay open and unrounded, and consonants get rolled or trilled for rhythm. The upper range is bright and edgy rather than rounded, and there is a rasp available on demand at full volume. Vibrato appears irregularly, as an expressive choice. The shout has to be supported low; copying it from the throat gets tiring fast.

NEXT Pop women: the moderns →

8 Pop women: the moderns

The defining fact of modern pop singing is that the microphone finally won. Once every listener is six inches from the singer's mouth, intimacy scales better than volume, and this chapter documents the consequences: fry onsets as rhythm, whisper-verses as default, breathiness as an instrument rather than a flaw, and belts that arrive as *events* inside otherwise conversational performances. The whisper-pop generation — the entries here built on air and closeness — is not a decline from the founders' power; it is a different instrument optimized for a different playback device.

That said, the power never left. This chapter also holds the era's technicians — the whistle-register carriers, the gospel-schooled run machines, the theatre-trained belters moonlighting in pop — and their entries read like the founders' chapter with faster ornaments. The range extremes in this chapter are among the widest in the book, precisely because modern production loves a documented flex: the one whistle note, the one fry low, captured and cited forever.

Read these entries with the full-voice ceiling in view. Modern pop's most common imitation injury is copying a conversational singer's *loud moments* without noticing that ninety percent of the performance happens at speech volume — or copying a whistle flex that even its owner visits once per album. The habitat is quiet; the peaks are punctuation. Borrow the verse technique first — onset control, breath-

on-tone, diction that carries pitch — and treat every big note in this chapter as the founders treated theirs: rationed, placed, and paid for.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Beyoncé

B2–Eb6 · 3 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 1997 · known for “Crazy in Love”

Dense mezzo chest voice with rapid-fire runs; stacks a belted mix near Eb5 without thinning out.

Weight is the first thing you hear: a thick, chest-dominant tone that stays chest-dominant as she climbs toward that G5 belt. Onsets are percussive and consonant-driven, and the vibrato is fast and narrow, arriving only at the end of a held note. Runs work as rhythm rather than decoration, so count them in sixteenths. Students copy the riffs and skip the breath support underneath, and the top turns shouty.

Britney Spears

B2–F#5 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · full voice to C#5 · USA · prominent since 1998 · known for “...Baby One More Time”

The template for modern pop diction: creaky fry onsets, a nasal baby-doll mix, and a fuller natural voice saved for ballads.

Fry is the engine here: phrases start in a creak, slide up into a bright nasal mix, and land back in the creak at the end of the line. That onset is a stylistic choice layered over a real soprano, and the ballads show the rounder voice underneath. To borrow the sound, add the fry only at onsets and releases while keeping air moving; imitators who hold the creak through whole phrases end up pressed and pitchy.

Christina Aguilera

C3–C7 · 4 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 1999 · known for “Beautiful”

Heavy melisma over a thick, forward belt; adds whistle notes well above the staff when she wants them.

She ornaments almost everything: long melismatic chains, turns and slides on nearly every held syllable, all sitting on a thick, forward belt that keeps chest weight up near G5. Vibrato is fast and wide, usually started immediately rather than saved for the end. Above the belt she flips to whistle, which is a separate mechanism and not an extension of chest. Ornaments added before the support exists go sharp, and the throat grips to hold them.

Pink

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2000 · known for “So What”

Gritty mezzo with rock distortion; belts from a low placement instead of lifting into a lighter mix.

You can hear grit in the tone at every volume, made with a low, chesty placement rather than a lifted lighter mix, so the belt around F5 feels pushed up from underneath. Attacks are hard and often slightly scooped, and vibrato arrives late, at the tail of a long note. Because the placement is low, this is the hardest belt to copy: with shallow breath support the whole thing collapses into a shout by the second verse.

Kelly Clarkson

D3–Eb6 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “Since U Been Gone”

Open-throated, largely unornamented belt; sustains high chest notes with even vibrato and no scoop.

Simplicity is the point here. Notes arrive centered with no scoop, hold straight for a beat, then take an even, moderate vibrato. The throat stays open and the vowel tall, which is what keeps a belt around G5 round instead of shrill. Melisma is rare, so the melody carries itself. Most singers reach for this by lifting the chin and pushing volume, and the tone goes bright and brittle rather than full.

JoJo

A2–Bb6 · 4 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Leave (Get Out)”

LOW A2 IN “MAD LOVE.”

Dark, weighty mezzo with gritty low notes, muscular R&B runs, and a belt that punches to G5 without thinning.

Chest-dominant and thick through the middle, this voice carries real weight up to G5 by widening the pharynx rather than pushing volume. JoJo's runs are metronomic — each note articulated from the diaphragm, not slurred — and her low A2 speaks with honest cord contact instead of fry. She flips cleanly into head voice for color, reserving whistle squeaks as ornament. Imitators usually muscle the larynx up; she keeps it neutral and lets resonance do the lifting.

Rihanna

B2–B5 · 3 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · Barbados · prominent since 2005 · known for “Umbrella”

Nasal-forward mezzo with clipped consonants; strongest in a smoky lower-mid rather than up high.

Most of the character lives from B2 up through the middle of the staff: a smoky, nasal-forward tone with very little vibrato and consonants cut short. Phrasing is percussive, notes clipped and set tight against the drum rather than sustained. Where the line does rise, the tone stays narrow instead of opening out. Singers imitating this usually add vibrato and legato, which erases the flat, spoken quality that makes it land.

Leona Lewis

C3–F#6 · 3 octaves + 6



Soprano · full voice to A5 · whistle register · UK · prominent since 2006 · known for “Bleeding Love”

LOW C3 IN “HURT” · HIGH F#6 IN “LOVING YOU”

Feather-light lyric soprano with cushioned head voice, gentle onsets, and belts that stay round and unforced up to A5.

A light lyric instrument built on gentle onsets and a high, forward placement. Lewis blends chest and head early, so ascents toward A5 keep a rounded, covered shape instead of splatting wide. Her head voice floats with slow, even vibrato, and she saves F#6 flourishes for cadenzas rather than choruses. Students copying her often over-breathe the tone; the airiness sits on firm cord closure, not collapsed support. Keep consonants soft, vowels tall, and let phrases taper.

Miley Cyrus

G2–E6 · 3 octaves + 9



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2006 · known for “Wrecking Ball”

Sandpaper rasp anchored in chest voice; belts with a hard buzz and drops into a smoky low range.

A dry, sandpaper rasp runs through every phrase, riding a chest-anchored tone that stays thick from a low G2 up to a belt near F5. Twang supplies the cutting buzz, and vibrato is wide and slow when it shows up at all. She likes dropping an octave into a smoky low register mid-phrase for contrast. Chasing the rasp directly is the standard mistake, since it should be a byproduct of a bright, well-supported tone.

Taylor Swift

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 2006 · known for “Love Story”

Speech-level mezzo with light breath onsets; later albums lean on a firmer, better supported mix.

Delivery stays at speech level: light aspirate onsets, small vibrato that arrives late if at all, and a lot of syllables packed conversationally across the bar. The belt marker at D5 is the honest number, since power comes from consonant clarity and timing rather than height. On louder choruses the mix firms up and takes less air, but the placement never drops back into heavy chest. Copy only the breathiness and you lose pitch center, which is how this turns mumbly.

Sara Bareilles

B2–E6 · 3 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2007 · known for “Love Song”

Warm piano-pop mezzo with a chesty, ringing mid-belt and bright, easy head-voice extensions.

Speech-level singing anchors everything: Bareilles keeps the larynx relaxed and the tone conversational, so her belt up to G5 rings without strain. She mixes early, brightening vowels as lines climb instead of dragging pure chest, and her head voice pops out light and flute-like for ornaments near E6. Phrasing leans behind the beat with jazz-informed rubato. The common mistake when copying her is over-singing; the power comes from forward placement and crisp diction, not sheer air pressure.

Adele

C3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · UK · prominent since 2008 · known for “Rolling in the Deep”

Chesty mezzo with wide vibrato and audible glottal onsets; works a narrow, heavily supported belt band.

Listen to the onset: many phrases begin with a small glottal click, then open into a broad, chesty tone with slow, wide vibrato. The belt band is narrow, right around E5, so impact comes from support and vowel depth rather than from climbing higher. Phrases lean slightly behind the beat and often finish with a downward bend. The common error is muscling volume in the throat to match that weight instead of letting the ribs and breath carry it.

Demi Lovato

C#3–D6 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to A5 · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Heart Attack”

Big-lunged belter with heavy vibrato; drives chest voice high, then unspools R&B runs coming down.

There is no slow build. The belt lands wide and heavily vibrated, carrying real thickness all the way to A5, which is high for that much weight. Onsets are frequently glottal, and the biggest notes get hit straight on rather than approached from below. Runs mostly happen on the way back down, after the peak. Jamming the larynx upward to reach that top is the usual mistake, when the height should come from breath pressure and a narrowed vowel.

Katy Perry

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Firework”

Bright, forward belt with a hard nasal edge; head voice thins quickly above her chorus range.

Brightness comes from a high, narrow resonance with a real nasal edge, and the belt works a tight window around F5 where the tone is thickest. Above that it thins fast into a light head voice rather than continuing to open. Vibrato is minimal, so sustains stay loud and mostly straight. What goes wrong in imitation is chasing the edge with throat squeeze; the buzz has to come from resonance and firm breath instead.

Lady Gaga

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Bad Romance”

Trained mix with fast vibrato; jazz phrasing sits low, then she opens into a squared-off, brassy belt.

Two modes sit side by side: a low, conversational croon with jazz-inflected timing, and a brassy, squared-off belt near G5 that keeps a fast, even vibrato. Vowels narrow and brighten as she ascends, which is what lets the mix carry that much ring without spreading. Consonants land hard and right on the beat. Chase that brightness by clenching the jaw and the tone comes out pinched rather than ringing.

Kesha

D3–E6 · 3 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano | full voice to F5 | USA · prominent since 2009 · known for “TiK ToK”

HIGH E6 IN “PRAYING”

Talk-sung, processed verses give way to an open belt and thin, exposed notes at the very top.

Verses run close to rhythmic speech, delivered in a flat, wide-vowel drawl that sits low and leans on attitude more than tone. When she opens up, the belt around F5 is plain and unornamented, and anything above it goes thin and exposed rather than reinforced, which is the whole effect of the top notes in Praying. Vibrato stays minimal. Trying to fatten those high notes with weight defeats them; they need air and release.

Selena Gomez

C3–F5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano | full voice to Bb4 | USA · prominent since 2009 · known for “Lose You to Love Me”

A quiet, close-mic instrument: low-set, breathy, almost spoken, with the drama carried by restraint instead of volume.

Intimacy is the whole design. The voice sits low for a pop lead, stays soft, and leans on the microphone: breath on the tone, consonants barely touched, dynamics that move by millimeters. There is almost no vibrato until a phrase ends. This is one of the most learnable major-label styles because it never leaves the speaking range, and the trap is the opposite of most: adding more air than she does, until pitch smears. Keep the whisper on the cords, not around them.

Ellie Goulding

D3–A5 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · full voice to C#5 · UK · prominent since 2010 · known for “Lights”

A fluttery, folk-rooted soprano: fast tremulous vibrato, feathered head voice, and a bright childlike edge over dance production.

The flutter is the fingerprint: a fast, narrow vibrato that shimmers even on short notes, over a light head-dominant tone with a slightly reedy, folk-singer edge. She rarely belts; intensity comes from doubling and from pushing the head voice brighter, not heavier. To approach it, sing phrases in head voice at low volume and let vibrato run free rather than ironing it flat. Forcing chest weight up to imitate her power reads as a different, blunter voice.

MARINA

Bb2–C#6 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to B5 · UK · prominent since 2010 · known for “Primadonna”

LOW BB2 IN “SOLITAIRE” · HIGH C#6 IN “MOWGLI'S ROAD”

Theatrical mezzo with plummy low chest, campy register leaps, and a bright, brassy top.

Drama drives the registration: MARINA drops into a plummy, almost spoken chest voice near Bb2, then vaults into bright head-voice squeals up to C#6 for punchlines. Her belts around B5 are brassy and deliberately overdriven, vibrato wide and theatrical. Vowels are posh and exaggerated, consonants bitten. She connects registers cleanly when she wants smoothness, which is what imitators miss — the leaps are choices, not breaks, and each register keeps its own steady support underneath.

Jessie J

C#3–C6 · 2 octaves + 11



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to A5 · UK · prominent since 2011 · known for “Price Tag”

Loud, pitch-precise belter with R&B melisma; keeps tone compressed and bright at the top of chest.

Precision survives the volume here. Fast melismatic runs land dead center on pitch, and the belt stays compressed and bright right up to A5 rather than spreading wide. Onsets are clean and immediate with little scoop, and vibrato is fast, used mainly as an ending gesture. Dynamics move in steps, not swells. The imitation problem is spread: opening the vowel to get louder costs focus and pitch at the top.

Lana Del Rey

C3–D6 · 3 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Summertime Sadness”

Two voices: a heavy low chest croon and a thin, girlish head register she slips into mid-phrase.

She switches between two registers as if they were two characters: a heavy, breathy croon down around C3, and a thin, deliberately childlike head tone she flips into mid-phrase without smoothing the seam. That audible break is the effect, not a flaw to fix. Lines drawl behind the beat with long slides between notes and hardly any vibrato. The temptation is to blend the two into one polished mix, which removes the exact contrast the style depends on.

Sia

C3–C6 · 3 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to Ab5 · Australia · prominent since 2011 · known for “Chandelier”

Rasp-heavy belt that frays by design; wide vowels and long notes held high in full voice.

Rasp is the signature and it is loudest at the top, where notes around Ab5 are held in a wide, open vowel until the tone frays. Onsets often scoop up from below, and the vibrato is broad and late, sometimes replaced by a deliberate crack. Chandelier shows that held, splintering belt clearly. Producing the grit with throat friction wears a voice out inside one chorus; it has to ride on strong, steady airflow.

Grimes

D3–G6 · 3 octaves + 5



Soprano · full voice to Bb5 · whistle register · Canada · prominent since 2012 · known for “Oblivion”

LOW D3 IN “WE APPRECIATE POWER” · HIGH G6 IN “CIRCUMAMBIENT”

Wispy, girlish electronic soprano — cooing head-voice choirs, soft spoken lows, and sudden piercing peaks.

Head voice does most of the work: Grimes sings in a small, breathy, girlish placement, stacking self-harmonies instead of projecting one big line. Belts near Bb5 are bright yelps, punched and released, and her occasional whistle-territory peaks toward G6 arrive as pure, needle-thin tones. Down at D3 the voice turns to soft speech. The trap in copying her is treating breathiness as weakness — the pitch centering under all that air is exact, and the mic does the projection.

Ariana Grande

D3–E7 · 4 octaves + 2



Soprano · full voice to E5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “thank u, next”

Light lyric soprano; moves from breathy mix into whistle register with almost no audible gear change.

Placement sits high and forward, with a light, slightly nasal mix that never carries much chest weight. Notice that the belt is marked at E5 while the ceiling runs to E7, which tells you most of the upper range is head voice and whistle, not chest. Onsets are soft and aspirate, and the passaggio is hidden by staying quiet through it. Forcing air pressure into the whistle instead of releasing it shuts the tone off entirely.

Camila Cabello

D3–G5 · 2 octaves + 5



Soprano · full voice to D5 · Cuba/USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Havana”

A light soprano with a built-in sob: cracks, yodels and Spanish-inflected turns used as ornaments, not accidents.

The break is the instrument. Where most singers smooth the flip between chest and head, she leans into it, placing little yodels and sobs exactly on the beat, with a bright, forward, slightly childlike tone around them. Melisma bends toward Cuban phrasing: short turns that sit behind the beat. Practice cracking on purpose, softly, at the same pitch every time. Imitators who crack wherever it happens to land sound broken; hers land like grace notes because they are planned.

Charli XCX

F3–F5 · 2 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C5 · UK · prominent since 2013 · known for “Boom Clap”

A blunt, sing-shouted mezzo that treats processing as part of the voice: chants, talk-singing and hooks built from attitude.

Delivery beats ornament every time. The core sound is a flat-affect chant, almost shouted but pitched, with hard consonant attacks and no vibrato; the polish comes from stacking and processing, which she writes for rather than fights. When she does sing out, the belt is plain and square-toned. To work on this style, drill clean pitch at high speech intensity and rhythmic precision on consonants. Students who add runs and warmth are singing a different genre.

Lorde

D3–A5 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · New Zealand · prominent since 2013 · known for “Royals”

Low-sitting mezzo with a dry, spoken quality; layers her own voice instead of belting high.

Dark and dry, placed low in the voice, with almost no vibrato and breath left audible at the ends of lines. Consonants supply the percussion, and melodies stay inside a narrow band, repeating instead of climbing. Where another singer would belt, she stacks harmonies and octaves on the same low line, so the D5 ceiling rarely gets tested. Phrasing is speech-timed and often just behind the beat. Sing it big and it stops working.

Tori Kelly

B2–E6 · 3 octaves + 5



Soprano · full voice to E5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Should've Been Us”

A YouTube-era virtuoso: gospel-schooled runs, a ringing mixed belt, and an easy flip into whistle when the arrangement asks.

Agility is the headline. Runs are long, even and articulated from the breath, each note of a sixteen-note descent given equal weight, which is the gospel discipline underneath the pop surface. The mix rings bright without spreading, and the flip into whistle is treated casually, as one more color. Slow her runs to quarter notes and learn them exactly before returning to tempo; approximating the shape is what separates karaoke melisma from the real thing. The whistle is decoration, not the lesson.

Zara Larsson

D3–C#6 · 2 octaves + 11



Soprano · full voice to B5 · Sweden · prominent since 2013 · known for “Lush Life”

LOW D3 IN “FUNERAL” · HIGH C#6 IN “SKIPPIN A BEAT”

Gleaming Scandi-pop soprano with a laser-bright mix, athletic runs, and belts that climb to B5 while staying narrow.

Mix is everything in this instrument: Larsson narrows to a bright, twangy channel around the passaggio and rides it all the way to B5 belts that sound chesty but weigh almost nothing. Vowels get thin and forward — ee and eh shapes — as she climbs, with vibrato held off until the note lands. Runs are pattern-perfect, practiced shapes from R&B. The trap for imitators is pulling full chest upward; she trades mass for twang early and never looks back.

Meghan Trainor

Eb3–B5 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano · USA · prominent since 2014 · known for “All About That Bass”

Retro-pop mezzo — chipper doo-wop chest voice, swung phrasing, and bright, sassy spoken-sung asides.

Swing rules the phrasing: Trainor sings on the back of the beat with a chipper, forward chest voice built for doo-wop bounce. Her tone is bright and slightly nasal, vowels wide and grinning, with scooped onsets as a signature. Most lines live in a compact lower-middle zone above Eb3, saving head voice near B5 for background stacks. Runs are short, bluesy turns. Copying her means committing to the retro diction — crisp, cheeky, and rhythm-locked.

Melanie Martinez

F3–D5 · 1 octave + 9



Soprano · USA · prominent since 2014 · known for “Dollhouse”

Baby-doll alt-pop soprano — breathy, curled vowels, half-whispered chest tone, and quick falsetto flips.

Character voice comes first: Martinez curls vowels into a babyish pout, singing with a breathy, half-whispered chest tone that rarely rises above conversational volume. Her range in use is compact — F3 to D5 — so interest comes from cracks, flips into falsetto, and vocal-fry onsets used as punctuation. Vibrato is minimal, pitch glides constant. Singers copying the whisper usually lose pitch center; hers stays exact under the air, and the stylized diction never swallows the consonants.

Aurora

Eb3–E6 · 3 octaves + 1



Soprano | full voice to F5 | Norway · prominent since 2015 · known for “Runaway”

LOW EB3 IN “THE ESSENCE” · HIGH E6 IN “YOUR BLOOD”

Glacial Nordic soprano — childlike, bell-clear head tones, sudden fierce chest bursts, and wide dynamic swings.

Contrast powers this voice: Aurora alternates a tiny, vibratoless, childlike head tone with abrupt full-chest exclamations around F5, often within one bar. Her placement is high and masky, consonants percussive, vowels kept pure. Head-voice sustains near E6 stay straight until the last moment, when a slow vibrato blooms. Low phrases at Eb3 are whispered more than sung. Copying her requires dynamic discipline — the loud moments only land because the quiet ones are genuinely quiet.

Bebe Rexha

D3–B5 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano | full voice to F#5 | USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “I'm Good (Blue)”

LOW D3 IN “I'M GOOD (BLUE)” · HIGH B5 IN “I DON'T WANNA GROW UP”

Brassy dance-pop soprano with a hard-edged belt, husky low color, and punchy, syllabic phrasing.

Attack-first singing: Rexha hits consonants and downbeats hard, driving a brassy, slightly husky chest voice into belts at F#5 that favor edge over roundness. Her vibrato is quick and tight, mostly at phrase ends. Down near D3 she lets the tone go smoky and speech-like. Head voice appears briefly at B5 for climaxes rather than as a home base. The pitfall when copying her is jaw tension — that edge comes from twang and compression, not clenching.

Halsey

C3–G5 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Without Me”

A grainy, conversational mezzo that flips between diary-entry murmur and a hard, bratty belt with audible edge.

Texture does the storytelling: verses sit in a low, frayed murmur with fry at the edges, then the chorus jumps to a belt with deliberate rasp on the front of the note. The jump itself is the hook, so practice the gear change, not just the loud gear. Keep the rasp as a brief onset flare over solid cord closure. Students who manufacture the grit by squeezing the throat get the color for one chorus and hoarseness by the third.

Sabrina Carpenter

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Espresso”

Bright, compact soprano with breathy onsets and a light belt she rarely pushes to full volume.

Small and bright, and kept small on purpose: breathy onsets, a light belt around E5 that rarely opens to full volume, and plenty of near-spoken asides tucked between sung lines. Timing is playful, syllables pulled late or delivered flat and dry for a wink, and what vibrato there is stays decorative. The tone is compact rather than big, so the skills it actually asks for are control at low volume and crisp consonants.

Billie Eilish

A2–B5 · 3 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “bad guy”

Close-mic whisper singing low in the chest register, with controlled fry and layered falsetto stacks.

Everything is built at whisper volume and very close to the microphone: audible breath, light fry on low sustained notes, consonants quiet enough that you hear the mouth working. There is no belt in this voice, and height is reached instead with a thin, airy head tone, often doubled in stacks. Phrase ends slide downward by design. The trap is assuming quiet singing needs no support, which makes the fry squeezed and the pitch sag.

Lizzo

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano full voice to Eb5 USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “Truth Hurts”

Full chest belt with gospel weight; switches into rap cadence and back without losing tone.

Full chest weight, forward and bright, with the belt topping out near Eb5 and no thinning on the way up. Diction is percussive. She drops from a sung line into a rapped cadence and back without changing placement, which is the hard part to copy: the same forward tone has to hold through the spoken sections. Ornaments are gospel-shaped, short fast melisma with a growl on the accent, and sustained notes stay mostly straight until the last word of a chorus.

RAYE

C#3–D6 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · UK · prominent since 2016 · known for “Escapism.”

LOW C#3 IN “ESCAPISM.” · HIGH D6 IN “YOU DON'T KNOW ME”

Jazz-schooled British mezzo — smoky conversational lows, quicksilver runs, and big torch-song belts.

Storytelling steers the technique: RAYE slips between spoken asides near C#3, jazz-inflected bends, and full theatrical belts at F5, changing register mid-sentence like a scene change. Her runs are light, fast and thrown away, more swing-era than melisma-drill; head voice floats up toward D6 for cinematic endings. Vibrato is wide and expressive, arriving late on sustains. Imitators tend to over-commit to one mode — the style lives in quick, confident switching between them.

Dua Lipa

B2–G5 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano · UK · prominent since 2017 · known for “Don't Start Now”

Husky low-mid with cool, flat phrasing; sits in a narrow band and rarely reaches for head voice.

She uses less range than she has. Melodies live in a husky low-mid, and the G5 ceiling is barely tested, so the interest has to come from elsewhere. Tone is cool and level, close to straight, with only a light vibrato at phrase ends, and dynamics stay flat so the groove supplies the lift. Timing is the real technique: syllables land just behind the kick. Add emotive swells and you break the detachment the style runs on.

Kim Petras

D3–Bb6 · 3 octaves + 8



Soprano · full voice to G#5 · whistle register · Germany · prominent since 2017 · known for “Heart to Break”

LOW D3 IN “TRAMPOLINE”

Sugar-bright pop soprano with springy mixed belts and genuine whistle-register fireworks above the staff.

Bounce characterizes the phrasing: Petras attacks notes from above with a bright, poppy mix, keeping belts around G#5 springy rather than planted. Her tone is light and glossy, vibrato shallow and fast. The party trick is a genuine whistle register — tiny, flute-like tones far above the staff toward Bb6 — entered from a stopped, high-compression setup, not slid into from head voice. Imitators strain reaching for it; the whistle needs minimal air and total jaw release.

Ava Max

E3–C#6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano · full voice to F#5 · USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Sweet but Psycho”

LOW E3 IN “FREAKING ME OUT” · HIGH C#6 IN “KINGS & QUEENS”

Punchy dance-pop soprano — nasal-bright chest belts, clipped phrasing, and glassy head notes topping the hooks.

Twang forward, always: Ava Max sets a nasal, cutting placement that survives dense dance production, belting to F#5 with a hard, clipped attack and almost no vibrato. Sustains are straight-toned, released quickly to keep rhythmic drive. Above the belt she snaps into a glassy head voice for hook-topping notes near C#6 rather than mixing gradually. Copying the brightness by pinching the nose misses it — the sound comes from raised soft-palate twang with relaxed lips and jaw.

Madison Beer

C3–C6 · 3 octaves



Soprano | full voice to Bb5 | USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Selfish”

Glossy, darkened pop soprano — sultry low chest, liquid R&B runs, and cool, airy head voice.

Polish defines the sound: Beer sings with a darkened, rounded soprano placement, sliding through R&B runs legato-first, every note connected rather than punched. Her low register near C3 is intimate and slightly smoky; belts climb toward Bb5 with a covered, controlled shape, never shouty. Head voice up around C6 is cool and airy, used for texture. Copying her means resisting over-articulation — the runs blur on purpose, tuned precisely but delivered like an afterthought.

Caroline Polachek

G#2–F6 · 3 octaves + 9



Soprano | full voice to G5 | USA · prominent since 2019 · known for “So Hot You're Hurting My Feelings”

Elastic art-pop soprano that swoops, yodels, and glides through registers like a synthesizer with lungs.

Portamento is the calling card: Polachek glides between chest and head with bel-canto smoothness, then deliberately exposes the flip as an ornament — a controlled yodel landing anywhere up to G5 in full voice or F6 above it. Her vowels morph mid-note, treating the mouth like a filter sweep. Low phrases sink toward G#2 in a slack, speechy fry-chest blend. Students chasing the swoops usually smear pitch; hers are mapped, hitting exact targets at each end of the slide.

Doja Cat

C3–B5 · 2 octaves + 11



Soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2019 · known for “Say So”

A shape-shifter: cartoon brightness, silky R&B head voice and hard rap cadence, swapped mid-verse like costume changes.

Character work is the real skill. The sung tone is light, bright and slightly nasal, easy to bend into cartoonish colors or smooth out into a creamy head voice, and the rap delivery uses the same forward placement so the switch costs nothing. Nothing in it relies on brute power. Practice by picking two contrasting characters for one verse each and switching cleanly at the bar line, keeping breath low while only the resonance changes. Committing halfway to each color is what sounds amateur.

Faouzia

C#3–G6 · 3 octaves + 6



Soprano · full voice to F5 · whistle register · Morocco/Canada · prominent since 2019 · known for “Tears of Gold”

A technician's playground: huge belts with Arabic-inflected ornament, stratospheric whistle, and total dynamic control.

Ornament ties this voice to a lineage: the melisma bends through quarter-tone-flavored turns drawn from Arabic singing, over a Western pop belt that stays connected to F5. The belt is narrow-vowelled and laser-placed rather than wide and brassy, which is how it climbs so high without spreading, and the whistle sits on top as a separate, practiced register. Work the ornaments slowly on one vowel before chasing any of the altitude; the turns are the learnable part, the ceiling mostly is not.

Chappell Roan

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2020 · known for “Good Luck, Babe!”

Theatre-sized soprano belt with hard consonants, then a sudden thin head voice up top.

Stage projection is the baseline. Consonants get hit hard, vowels stay bright and narrow, and the belt runs up to F5 with a steady ring rather than a shout. The characteristic move is a drop into thin, quiet head voice right after a big line, letting the contrast carry the feeling; belt the whole song and half the effect is gone. Long notes finish with a wide vibrato that only surfaces at the very end.

Gracie Abrams

F3–E5 · 1 octave + 11



Soprano · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 2020 · known for “That's So True”

Whisper-pop with a diarist's cadence: airy, close, fast-worded verses that bloom into brief, clear head-voice hooks.

Everything happens within arm's reach of speech. Verses run wordy and fast, half-whispered, with the breathiness dialed so high that the consonants carry the pitch. The chorus lift is small but real: air comes off the tone, head voice clears, and that sudden clarity is the payoff. To study it, practice singing at true whisper volume while keeping every note centered, which is far harder than belting. The style fails loud; it also fails when the whisper goes off-pitch.

Tate McRae

E3–F5 · 2 octaves + 1



Soprano · full voice to B4 · Canada · prominent since 2020 · known for “Greedy”

Dancer's pop: a light, airy soprano that phrases in short exhaled bursts, built to sit inside a beat rather than on top of it.

Rhythm leads the singing. Lines are chopped into short, breathy cells that land with the choreography, vowels tipped forward and consonants softened almost to nothing. The tone is deliberately small; the mix above the staff is thin by design so the track keeps its punch. Copy the phrasing first: speak the lyric in time until the bursts feel like dance counts, then pitch it. Adding operatic legato to these songs misses the point of the style entirely.

Olivia Rodrigo

B2–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 11



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “drivers license”

Conversational verses that snap into a deliberately strained, edge-heavy belt on the choruses.

Contrast does the work. Verses sit near speech, with fry on the low notes and almost no vibrato, then choruses snap into a tight, edge-heavy belt around E5 with an audible cry in it. Onsets scoop up from underneath and consonants get chewed for attitude. That strain is shaped, not accidental. Students reproduce the sound by genuinely squeezing, which is a different thing: the cry comes from a narrowed vowel over firm support.

Reneé Rapp

E3–G#5 · 2 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “Snow Angel”

Broadway muscle in pop clothing: a thick, ringing belt with theatre-grade support, dressed down into conversational R&B phrasing.

Support gives the game away: this is an eight-shows-a-week belt, anchored low in the body, with a ring that cuts through a mix without EQ. What makes it read as pop instead of theatre is the phrasing on top, lazy, behind the beat, with R&B slides into notes a stage director would want struck cleanly. Practice belting E5 at half volume with full support, then loosen the timing. The order matters; loosening first just sounds under-rehearsed.

Lola Young

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 2024 · known for “Messy”

LOW E3 IN “MESSY” · HIGH BB5 IN “TOGETHER IN ELECTRIC DREAMS”

Raw, husky London mezzo — wide-open vowels, cracked edges, and yell-adjacent belts that spit feeling.

An open-throat shout, refined: Young sings on wide, undarkened vowels with a husky, grainy chest voice that cracks on purpose at emotional peaks. Belts around B4 are reached by yelling up from speech rather than mixing, which gives them urgency and bite; softer moments drop to a mumbled, fry-edged murmur near E3. Vibrato is scarce. Copying the rasp without her breath anchor wears a voice out fast — the grit rides on low, steady support and a loose jaw.

NEXT The pop men →

9 The pop men

Male pop singing has spent seventy years migrating upward. The crooners in this chapter worked at speech pitch and made softness a technology; the soul-influenced generations pushed the tessitura into high tenor territory; and the streaming era's leads live above the staff half the night, in mixes and falsettos their grandfathers' genre would have considered exotic.

Two practical observations for the reader who sings these songs. First, the modern male pop tessitura is a tenor's habitat, and most men are baritones. That mismatch — not talent — is why the radio feels high, and the transposition rule from the method chapters is the honest fix. The baritones in this chapter who thrived did it by refusing the arms race: they built styles where depth, restraint or rhythm carried the record. Their entries are the most useful ones here for the average male voice, which is exactly why they are less famous than the freaks of altitude around them.

Second, notice how many of these entries describe falsetto as a *primary* register rather than an escape hatch. The modern pop man trains his falsetto the way the founders trained their belt — as the money register, with its own dedicated hours. If you borrow one thing from this chapter, borrow that practice allocation. The full voice you already speak with; the top floor is built.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Brian Wilson

C2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 10



Tenor | full voice to G4 | USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “Don't Worry Baby”

Boyish tenor crowned by a feather-light falsetto; harmony-stacked purity over surf-pop changes.

Falsetto functions as a lead register, not an effect: light, straight-tone, and tuned for blend, floated on high breath flow with almost no vibrato. His full voice stays boyish and slim, shifting into head voice early to keep timbre uniform for stacked harmony. Intonation is arranged-choir strict. The frequent copying error is treating the falsetto as breathy decoration; his is focused and pitched dead center, and any airiness that blurs the tuning wrecks the stack.

Frankie Valli

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor | full voice to F4 | USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “Can't Take My Eyes Off You”

Plain mid-range traded for a hard, ringing falsetto that carries the whole lead line.

Something unusual happens at the register break. The plain, unremarkable chest voice tops out around F4, and the lead line simply moves into a hard, ringing falsetto that carries the rest of the way up. That falsetto is edgy and pressed rather than airy, with a fast tight vibrato, and it cuts straight through the arrangement. Students try to belt those notes in chest and either strain or lose the timbre entirely.

Tom Jones

G2–Bb4 · 2 octaves + 3

Baritone UK · prominent since 1965 · known for “It's Not Unusual”

HIGH BB4 IN “DELILAH”

Grainy baritone with wide vibrato and a full-throated belt; volume rather than finesse up top.

Grain and sheer size define this sound: a heavy baritone driven at high pressure, with rasp coming out of the tone itself rather than from bolted-on distortion. The vibrato swings wide and unhurried. Attacks frequently scoop up from below and then get hammered flat onto the vowel. Nearing Bb4 he leans in harder instead of thinning, so the top deliberately sounds effortful. The bulk of it is built from breath and an open pharynx, not a squeezed throat, which is why imitation tires out within a chorus.

Neil Diamond

D2–G#4 · 2 octaves + 6

Baritone USA · prominent since 1966 · known for “Sweet Caroline”

HIGH G#4 IN “HOLLY HOLY”

Chesty, resonant baritone; gravel-warm lows and declamatory phrasing built for big singalongs.

Depth of chest resonance defines the delivery: a low-set, speech-driven baritone with rounded vowels and a slow, wide vibrato at phrase ends. He declaims more than he croons, punching consonants and letting sustained tones spread. The range demands are modest; the demand is tonal consistency and rhythmic authority. Imitators pitch him too low and growl; the gravel is overtone color on a supported core, and faking it underneath collapses projection entirely.

Barry Gibb

F2–D6 · 3 octaves + 9



Tenor · full voice to G4 · UK · prominent since 1967 · known for “Stayin' Alive”

Natural voice sits low and reedy; the disco records ride an insistent, vibrato-heavy falsetto.

Two voices are really in play. The natural one sits low and reedy with a conversational delivery; the other is a bright falsetto held high above the G4 belt and driven with an insistent, wide vibrato on nearly every note. Onsets in that falsetto are firm, not breathy, and the rhythm lands right on top of the beat. Stayin' Alive is the clearest example of the falsetto carrying an entire lead line.

Michael Jackson

Eb2–F6 · 4 octaves + 2



Tenor · full voice to Eb5 · USA · prominent since 1969 · known for “Billie Jean”

Light, percussive tenor; hiccups and breath grunts used as rhythm, plus a thin high falsetto.

Listen for how much of the rhythm comes out of the mouth rather than the pitch: clipped consonants, inhaled grunts and hiccup syllables all land as percussion. Tone stays bright and forward, faintly nasal, with a narrow fast vibrato that arrives late on held notes. Above the Eb5 belt he thins into a light, reedy falsetto. Students copy the tics and forget the tics only work over dead-accurate time.

Elton John

F2–F5 · 3 octaves



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · UK · prominent since 1970 · known for “Rocket Man”

Full-throated tenor early on; after 1987 throat surgery the top went and the tone thickened.

Vowels get darkened and reshaped constantly, a broad rounded diction that turns ordinary syllables into something rhythmically odd but singable. Tone is full-throated and chesty up to the Bb4 belt, carried by a wide vibrato that starts early. Phrasing sits tight against the piano, pushing and pulling inside the bar. Higher than the belt the sound thins toward head voice near F5. Imitate the vowels alone and you miss that the vibrato is doing half the work.

Billy Joel

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · USA · prominent since 1973 · known for “Piano Man”

HIGH C6 IN “AN INNOCENT MAN”

Nasal tenor with hard consonants; belts to the ceiling of chest, then flips to thin falsetto.

Hard consonants and a nasal, forward placement give the lines their bite, and onsets are struck rather than eased into. Chest runs right to its ceiling around Bb4 and stays there, bright and tense, before flipping into a thin falsetto for anything above. Vibrato is quick and slightly uneven. Phrasing follows conversational stress, so accents rarely land where the meter would suggest.

Barry Manilow

D2–G5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1974 · known for “Mandy”

LOW D2 IN “ONE VOICE” · HIGH G5 IN “MY BABY LOVES ME”

Polished show-pop tenor; croon-soft verses that build to long, belted ballad peaks.

Croon fundamentals govern everything: low-larynx warmth, clean legato, and phrase-end vibrato applied like punctuation. Verses sit conversationally low, then he modulates energy upward, widening vowels into a ringing, sustained belt for the final refrain. Consonants are theatrically crisp. Dynamics are planned to the bar. Copyists jump to the big finish; the design depends on patient terracing, each chorus slightly larger than the last, and skipping a step makes the ending sound pasted on.

Christopher Cross

D3–A#4 · 1 octave + 8



Tenor USA · prominent since 1980 · known for “Sailing”

HIGH A#4 IN “RIDE LIKE THE WIND”

Placid, glassy high tenor; even, unforced tone that floats over smooth late-night arrangements.

Evenness is the whole method: a placid high tenor that keeps one dynamic, one color, and one unforced placement across the entire phrase. Onsets are soft, vibrato slight and slow, vowels tall with no rasp anywhere. He floats above the staff without announcing effort, because he never carries chest weight upward. Students mistake the calm for easiness and oversing it; the control required to stay this level, this long, without swelling is the hard part.

George Michael

E2–A5 · 3 octaves + 5



Baritone · full voice to C5 · UK · prominent since 1982 · known for “Careless Whisper”

Warm baritone with a smoky bottom; slides into a controlled, airy falsetto on hooks.

Down at the bottom the tone is thick and smoky, with breath mixed into the onset so lines begin soft-edged instead of struck. Chest carries comfortably to about that C5 belt; everything higher is a deliberate lift into airy falsetto, which is where the A5 lives. Vibrato is slow and enters late, often only on the last beat of a phrase. Imitators drag chest weight above C5 and lose the smoke.

Morten Harket

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · Norway · prominent since 1985 · known for “Take On Me”

HIGH E5 IN “TAKE ON ME”

Bright tenor that climbs into a ringing head voice; clean onsets, no rasp anywhere.

Everything about the sound is clean: precise entries with no scoop and no rasp anywhere, vowels kept tall and bright, vibrato even when it appears at all. Large interval leaps happen without an audible gear change, chest lifting into a ringing head voice that holds its brightness up to E5. Take On Me shows that head-voice top plainly. Grabbing at the leaps instead of placing them lands you under pitch.

Rick Astley

F2–D5 · 2 octaves + 9



Baritone UK · prominent since 1987 · known for “Never Gonna Give You Up”

Dark, resonant baritone with steady vibrato; the tone reads far older than the records.

What catches people out is the weight: a dark, low-larynx baritone with full chest tone, and a wide, even vibrato running through nearly every sustained note. Lines begin firm and legato with almost no breath in them, and the D5 top stays connected instead of flipping. Nothing is rasped or scooped, so that vibrato carries most of the interpretive work by itself.

Robbie Williams

F2–B5 · 3 octaves + 6



Tenor full voice to G5 UK · prominent since 1992 · known for “Angels”

LOW F2 IN “THE PILOT” · HIGH B5 IN “BRUCE LEE”

Cheeky, brassy pop voice; punchy chest belts, crooner vibrato, and music-hall swagger.

Showmanship organizes everything: punchy chest-led phrasing, music-hall diction, and a crooner vibrato switched on for ballads and off for swagger. The low and middle registers are the strong suit — dark, booming, and articulate — while belts up to G5 arrive bright and slightly brash, and the falsetto above stays thin. Phrases end with theatrical button-like cutoffs. Copying students usually oversell the wink and undersell the support; the cheek only works because the fundamentals are square: firm breath connection, centered pitch, and consonants delivered to the back row.

Justin Timberlake

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Cry Me a River”

Light tenor living in falsetto and mix; rhythm-first phrasing with very little vibrato.

Syllables get chopped into sixteenths and placed just behind the beat, with consonants doing the groove work while the pitch content stays deliberately plain. Tone is thin and breathy, vibrato nearly absent, phrases holding a straight tone until they end. The B4 belt is modest for a range topping C6 because most of that height is head voice and falsetto rather than pushed chest. Cry Me a River shows the falsetto sitting inside the mix.

Adam Levine

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “She Will Be Loved”

Thin tenor built on falsetto and a nasal mix; adds compressed rasp rather than volume.

Most of the sound lives above the A4 belt, in a thin nasal mix and a wiry falsetto that stretches to C6. Loudness is not the tool; compression and a thin edge of rasp are. Phrases begin breathy, the vibrato quick and narrow, and phrase ends often lift into falsetto mid-word. Pushing chest to chase the high notes is the wrong instinct here, since the placement needs to get narrower rather than bigger.

Jason Mraz

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “I'm Yours”

Loose, jazz-leaning tenor; scat phrasing and quick trades between mix and light falsetto.

Syllables tumble out in loose, jazz-inflected bursts, scatted between sung lines and rarely landing squarely on the beat, and that phrasing carries far more of the personality than the timbre does. The tone itself is light and slightly nasal, entries soft, and the climb upward is handled by trading into a small falsetto instead of belting, which is why the top of the range sits well above any comfortable chest note. What vibrato there is comes fast and sparingly.

Brendon Urie

E2–C6 · 3 octaves + 8



Tenor full voice to F5 USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “I Write Sins Not Tragedies”

Theatrical tenor with a forward mix; belts high without thinning, then slips into clean falsetto.

Theatrical placement: forward and bright, with clean vowels and crisply finished consonants. The mix is strong enough to hold a belt up to F5 without much thinning, and the falsetto above it is clear rather than breathy, so the changeover is easy to miss. Runs move fast and stay precisely articulated instead of smearing together, and the belt keeps its vowel shape at the top rather than spreading out into a shout.

Adam Lambert

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 2009 · known for “Whataya Want from Me”

Theatrical tenor with a metallic mixed belt, fast vibrato, and rock rasp layered on top.

Metal in the tone: a bright, ringing mix that holds its edge up to the C5 belt and can take rasp on top without losing pitch. Vibrato is fast and even, switched on deliberately at the end of a sustained note. Dragging chest weight upward for size is the common mistake, since the climb comes from narrowing the vowel instead. Sirens are a favorite move, one connected slide from low chest up through the mix with no audible gear change, dynamics swinging wide inside the phrase.

Justin Bieber

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor · full voice to A4 · Canada · prominent since 2009 · known for “Sorry”

Breathy tenor with a light mix; moved from a boyish head voice to a closer, quieter delivery.

The microphone does the amplifying here, which lets the voice stay breathy and half-spoken, engaging into a light mix around the A4 belt. Runs are small and rhythmic, tucked between words rather than displayed. Lines toward Bb5 go into head voice with the weight taken off. Project the whole thing loudly and the conversational feel the phrasing is built on goes with it.

Bruno Mars

G2–D6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “Just the Way You Are”

Bright, forward tenor; snaps into a hard mix on choruses with clean falsetto stacked above.

Everything is placed forward and narrow, a bright almost twangy ring that lets the E5 belt keep its chest flavour without shouting. Attacks land firm and often glottal, the vibrato underneath quick and slightly wide, phrase ends decorated with short retro-soul turns instead of long runs. Above the belt, falsetto comes in clean and stacked. The usual mistake is adding volume rather than twang, which closes the throat by the second chorus.

Harry Styles

E2–F5 · 3 octaves + 1



Baritone · full voice to C5 · UK · prominent since 2010 · known for “Sign of the Times”

Raspy baritone with a grainy upper mix; keeps the edge in the belt instead of smoothing it.

A dry, grainy rasp sits on top of a baritone core and stays there through the C5 belt instead of being polished off, so the grit reads as the point rather than a by-product. Notes come in breathy before they engage, phrasing is unhurried and a touch behind the beat, and the vibrato stays loose and irregular. The F5 top arrives thin and strained by design. Faking that rasp with throat squeeze instead of airflow never survives a full set.

Liam Payne

C#2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 9



Baritone · full voice to C5 · UK · prominent since 2010 · known for “Strip That Down”

Baritone depth with an R&B mix — clean C5 belts and cool, deliberate falsetto switches.

Smooth R&B machinery under a pop finish: a genuine baritone bottom with an unusually developed mix that lets him belt cleanly up to C5 without weight dragging behind. Liam flips deliberately into a cool, even falsetto for hooks, and decorates lines with clipped melisma placed on the backbeat. Onsets are precise, almost quantized. Students copying him usually blur the registers; his effect depends on crisp, intentional switches between full voice and falsetto.

Louis Tomlinson

C3–A4 · 1 octave + 9



Tenor · UK · prominent since 2010 · known for “Back to You”

LOW C3 IN “MISS YOU” · HIGH A4 IN “JUST LIKE YOU”

Bright, narrow light tenor with a built-in cry — compact melodies ridden at the top of chest voice.

Thin, bright, and instantly identifiable, this light tenor carries a permanent adolescent edge: forward placement, fast airflow, and a slight cry in every sustained vowel. Louis keeps melodies compact and rides the top of chest voice rather than mixing high, which gives choruses their strained-heart urgency. Vibrato is minimal. Copying the sound with a wide-open throat loses the character; it needs narrow vowels and a touch of nasality, kept honest by exact pitch.

Niall Horan

F#2–B5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor Ireland · prominent since 2010 · known for “Slow Hands”

LOW F#2 IN “BLACK AND WHITE” · HIGH B5 IN “THE SHOW”

Breath-hazed light tenor — conversational mid-range phrasing with gentle falsetto lifts.

Soft-grained and breath-led, this tenor works close to the microphone, letting air haze the edges of an otherwise centred tone. Niall writes inside his sweet spot, so phrases sit mid-range with occasional falsetto lifts, and his vibrato is light, arriving only on final sustains. Diction is relaxed, almost conversational. The mistake students make is adding polish; over-supporting kills the papery intimacy, which depends on low subglottal pressure and a barely-there onset.

Ed Sheeran

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor full voice to B4 UK · prominent since 2011 · known for “Shape of You”

Speech-level tenor, breathy tone; leans on rhythmic delivery and light head voice up top.

Think of speech pitched onto notes. Every entry is eased in rather than struck, soft and aspirate, vowels stay conversational, and volume barely changes across a verse. Rhythm carries the interest, with syllables crammed tight and rapped against the guitar. Above the B4 belt he lightens into head voice rather than driving. There is barely any vibrato, and often none at all. Push the tone out and the intimacy that makes the phrasing legible goes with it.

The Weeknd

G2–B5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · Canada · prominent since 2011 · known for “Blinding Lights”

Light tenor with a floating falsetto and heavy melisma; keeps chest weight off the top.

Chest engages to around Bb4 and stops there; everything above it floats in a soft, airy falsetto that reaches B5 without sounding pushed. The attack is always breathy, ornaments quick and constant, small three- and four-note turns closing almost every phrase. Vibrato runs fast and narrow, decoration rather than a way of sustaining. Belting those high lines is the common error, and it flattens the texture the whole style depends on.

James Arthur

Bb2–A5 · 2 octaves + 11



Baritone · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 2012 · known for “Say You Won't Let Go”

LOW BB2 IN “SAY YOU WON'T LET GO” · HIGH A5 IN “NAKED”

Raspy, soul-leaning baritone — gritty compressed belts an octave below his floating falsetto hooks.

Rasp is the engine of this baritone. James sings with a compressed, cry-tinged mix that peaks around a B4 belt, then vaults a full octave into falsetto for hooks near the top of his range. Runs are R&B-derived, executed with laryngeal flicks rather than diaphragm pulses. His vibrato stays narrow under distortion. The trap for students is copying the grit at low breath energy; without steady airflow the texture collapses into fry and the pitch sags.

Nate Ruess

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2012 · known for “We Are Young”

LOW G2 IN “MATCHES” · HIGH A5 IN “IT ONLY GETS MUCH WORSE”

Brassy, trumpet-bright tenor; huge sustained belts with fast vibrato and show-tune diction.

Brass characterizes the tone: a bright, trumpet-like tenor with fast vibrato, crisp diction, and phrasing that lands squarely on the beat like show-tune writing. Chest voice extends extraordinarily high, with belts up to G5 that stay fully connected and ringing rather than flipping to falsetto. Onsets are clean and confident, dynamics theatrical. The classic copying mistake is pulling raw chest weight upward until the sound shouts; his top notes narrow the vowel and add twang, trading mass for ring so the belt stays free and repeatable night after night.

Sam Smith

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5



Countertenor · full voice to Bb4 · UK · prominent since 2012 · known for “Stay with Me”

Light, vibrato-rich voice that lives in a high tenor mix and floats up in pure falsetto.

Light-weight tone that mostly lives high in a thin mix, so the G2 floor of this range almost never turns up in an actual song. Onsets are soft and aspirate; sustained notes take a quick, narrow vibrato that starts early and keeps going, and pushing weight into that mix to make it bigger flattens the flutter it depends on. Above the Bb4 belt the voice releases into an unmixed falsetto kept deliberately quiet, with melisma slow enough to hear every note in it.

Zayn

D3–B5 · 2 octaves + 9



Tenor | full voice to G#4 | UK · prominent since 2012 · known for “Pillowtalk”

HIGH B5 IN “YOU & I (ONE DIRECTION)”

One Direction's high-wire act turned R&B stylist: a light, agile tenor that lives in falsetto and ornamented upper mix.

Falsetto is home base, not a garnish. Most of the memorable notes float above the belt line in a clear, connected falsetto that he ornaments with fast, qawwali-flavored South Asian turns. The full voice underneath is soft-grained and used sparingly. Train the falsetto as its own instrument, with scales and runs at low volume, rather than as an escape hatch from failed belts. The runs betray imitators; his are precise at speed.

Matty Healy

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor | full voice to G5 | UK · prominent since 2013 · known for “Chocolate”

LOW F2 IN “LOVE ME” · HIGH A5 IN “LOVE ME”

Chatty, breathy tenor that smears words into melody; sudden falsetto leaps and yelped climaxes over glossy pop.

Conversation is the engine of this voice: half-spoken phrasing, smeared diction, and melodies that tumble out in irregular, chatty rhythms. The core tone is light chest with a breathy edge, flipping freely into falsetto mid-phrase without disguising the break. Climactic moments jump to yelled belts around G5, raw and uncovered. Copying the mumble is the classic mistake — underneath the casual surface the rhythmic placement is exact, and the breathiness is a controlled valve, opened and closed for emphasis rather than a default leak.

George Ezra

G2–B5 · 3 octaves + 4



Baritone UK · prominent since 2014 · known for “Budapest”

LOW G2 IN “ONLY A HUMAN” · HIGH B5 IN “THE BEAUTIFUL DREAM”

Plummy, buoyant baritone — enormous-sounding vowels over short, bouncing, low-set phrases.

Booming yet boyish, this baritone plays a trick: the timbre sounds enormous while the effort stays tiny. Ezra rounds his vowels into an exaggerated, plummy shape, keeps phrases short and bouncing, and almost never belts, preferring to sit low and let resonance do the projecting. Falsetto appears as light backing colour up high. Copying the vowel affectation without his relaxed breath flow turns it cartoonish; the depth must stay buoyant, never pressed.

James Bay

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor UK · prominent since 2014 · known for “Hold Back the River”

LOW G2 IN “IF YOU EVER WANT TO BE IN LOVE” · HIGH C6 IN “ONE LIFE”

Reedy, twang-forward tenor — percussive phrasing, raspy belts, airy falsetto over guitar-driven pop.

Reedy and bright through the middle, this voice trades weight for edge: James keeps the tone narrow and nasal-forward so it slices over guitars, belting with rasp into the upper fourth octave and flipping to an airy falsetto above. Onsets are percussive, phrases clipped to the groove. Copying him with a thick, covered production misses the point; the sound lives in twang and forward vowels, with the throat staying loose behind the buzz.

Shawn Mendes

G2–E5 · 2 octaves + 9



Tenor · full voice to B4 · Canada · prominent since 2014 · known for “Stitches”

Nasal tenor with a tight, compressed mix; rasp creeps in on sustained upper notes.

Placement is high and nasal, with a compressed, narrow mix that keeps the B4 belt sounding tight rather than open. Notes start clean, the vibrato shallow and late, and rasp shows up only after a note has been held a while. Toward E5 the sound thins rather than opening out, and that nasal placement is the only thing keeping it audible at such a small size.

Troye Sivan

C3–F5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to G4 · Australia · prominent since 2014 · known for “Youth”

Soft-focus synth-pop: a breathy, boyish tenor that hovers between chest and falsetto and never raises its voice.

Restraint is structural. The voice floats in the blend zone between light chest and falsetto, with enough air on the tone to blur which register is which, and dynamics that stay inside a narrow, intimate band. Consonants are softened; phrase ends dissolve rather than stop. Practice sustaining that half-falsetto blend on a five-note scale without letting it crack into either clear register. The style collapses if you push volume, because the ambiguity, not the power, is the sound.

Calum Scott

B2–C#5 · 2 octaves + 2



Tenor UK · prominent since 2015 · known for “You Are the Reason”

LOW B2 IN “HEAVEN” · HIGH C#5 IN “ROOTS”

Cried, legato pop tenor — swelling sustains that flip into a glass-clear falsetto at the top.

Everything here is legato: Calum joins notes with portamento-smooth onsets, swells through the middle of long tones, and releases with a taper instead of a cut. The money register is a cried, head-leaning mix in the fourth octave, flipping into pure falsetto for peaks. Vibrato is wide and emotional. Students copying him often start phrases at full volume; he begins small, which makes the climb audible and keeps the top from sounding pushed.

Charlie Puth

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor full voice to A4 USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Attention”

Clean, pitch-exact tenor; frequent falsetto flips and tightly stacked self-harmony.

Notes are hit dead centre with almost no scoop, and the tone stays clean with very little rasp, so intonation itself ends up being the signature. The A4 belt is modest, so the reach to C6 happens through an audible, deliberate flip into falsetto used as a hook in itself. Vibrato is light and even. Lines are often stacked in close self-harmony, so the melody alone can feel surprisingly thin.

Lewis Capaldi

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Baritone · full voice to Bb4 · UK · prominent since 2017 · known for “Someone You Loved”

Thick baritone with constant rasp; pushes into a strained high mix and lets the tone break.

Rasp is constant here, present even in a quiet verse, with a thick, low-placed tone underneath it. Verses stay close to speech; choruses arrive as one long crescendo into a high mix around Bb4, and the loudest word is often where he lets the tone come apart on purpose. The slow vibrato, when it appears, comes late. Reaching straight for that break produces noise, because the effect depends on how quiet the setup was before it.

Conan Gray

C3–G5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Heather”

Bedroom-pop drama: a delicate tenor that cracks upward into head voice at emotional peaks, diary-quiet one bar and keening the next.

Vulnerability is played as register. Verses sit in a thin, close chest voice; the emotional turn arrives as a deliberate lift into head voice, often with a small audible crack on the way up that functions as punctuation. Vibrato is minimal and late. To learn the move, practice sliding from chest to head on one vowel and placing the flip on a chosen word, not wherever the break happens to catch. Random cracks read as strain; his are cues.

JVKE

C3–F5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 2020 · known for “golden hour”

LOW C3 IN “THIS IS WHAT LOSING SOMEONE FEELS LIKE” · HIGH F5 IN “THIS IS WHAT LOSING SOMEONE FEELS LIKE”

Featherweight tenor living above the staff — sighing onsets gliding into stacked head-voice hooks.

Head voice is the main event: JVKE writes hooks that live above the staff, gliding from a light chest mix into ringing head tones and stacking falsetto harmonies over the top. His onset is soft, almost sighed, and he bends into peak notes with portamento instead of attacking them. Below the fourth octave he keeps things plain and rhythmic. Copying the top without slow siren practice ends in cracking; the transitions are the actual skill.

Benson Boone

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor full voice to D5 USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “Beautiful Things”

Bright tenor that jumps octaves fast, favoring an open-throated high belt and clean falsetto.

Wide leaps shape the lines: a low, quiet phrase, then a jump of an octave or more into an open, bright belt around D5. Those high notes stay vowel-forward, throat open rather than volume shoved, and the vowel has to be set before the leap; taken cold it comes out as a shout. Past the belt he flips cleanly to falsetto instead of hunting for more chest, with a quick vibrato that switches on late.

Stephen Sanchez

C#3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 5



Baritone USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “Until I Found You”

LOW C#3 IN “HIGH” · HIGH F#5 IN “HIGH”

Mid-century crooner baritone — plummy slides into a bell-clear falsetto with slow-bloom vibrato.

A time-capsule croon: Sanchez pairs a low, rounded chest voice with tall, old-radio vowels, sliding into notes the way mid-century balladeers did. The signature move is the sudden leap from that plummy bottom into a bell-clear falsetto, held straight before a slow vibrato blooms. Consonants are gentle, endings tapered. Students copying the style usually overdo the affectation and lose pitch centre; his slides always land, and the larynx stays low without muffling the words.

David Kushner

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 2023 · known for “Daylight”

LOW F2 IN “DAYLIGHT” · HIGH G4 IN “DAYLIGHT”

Dark, echoing baritone — hymn-like sustains, octave-down doubles, haunted falsetto floats.

Deep-set and resonant, this baritone gets its cathedral weight from a lowered larynx and darkened vowels rather than extreme pitch. Kushner sustains long, hymn-like tones with minimal vibrato, stacking octave doubles beneath choruses, then floats a haunted falsetto above the drone. Diction stays soft, almost swallowed. The student error is confusing depth with volume; he sings quietly into a big resonating space, and pushing the same material turns woofy and flat immediately.

Myles Smith

B2–G4 · 1 octave + 8



Tenor · full voice to F#4 · UK · prominent since 2023 · known for “Stargazing”

Festival folk-pop: a warm, sandpapered tenor built for singalongs, all short punchy phrases and open-hearted rasp.

Warmth with grit is the recipe. The tone carries a light, even rasp across its whole range, more texture than distortion, over short, rhythmically punchy phrases designed for a crowd to shout back. Melodies stay inside an octave; the energy comes from drive and repetition, not altitude. Keep the rasp consistent rather than saving it for peaks, and place phrases slightly ahead of the beat for urgency. Over-singing the simple lines with runs and swells works against what makes them land.

Alex Warren

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone · full voice to E4 · USA · prominent since 2024 · known for “Ordinary”

LOW G2 IN “CARRY YOU HOME” · HIGH A4 IN “ORDINARY”

Stadium-folk balladry: a husky voice that builds from hushed verse to a huge, hymn-like chorus with choir-sized reverb.

Dynamics do the storytelling. Verses sit husky and close, almost spoken over fingerpicking, then the chorus opens into a full-throated, anthemic belt with the vowels widened and a slight rasp on top, a shape borrowed from worship music as much as from pop. Vibrato stays narrow even at volume. Map the crescendo across the whole song and rehearse the quiet sections quieter than feels natural, so the lift has somewhere to go. Peaking in verse one flattens the entire arc.

Sombr

A2–F#4 · 1 octave + 9



Baritone · full voice to E4 · USA · prominent since 2025 · known for “Back to Friends”

Brooding bedroom rock: a low, reverb-drowned croon that murmurs through verses and aches upward at the hook.

Mood is managed through register contrast. Verses live in a dark, low murmur with fry at the onsets, mixed so wet that the words blur at the edges, and the hook lifts into a strained, yearning upper-chest push that stays deliberately unpolished. Vibrato is nearly absent. Practice the low murmur with clear pitch centers despite the softness, then let the lifted notes carry a little honest strain instead of smoothing them. Polishing the top note into prettiness breaks the ache.

NEXT The classic rock men →

IV

PART

Rock, metal and alternative

10 The classic rock men 100

11 The women of rock 128

12 Alternative, punk and new wave 137

13 Metal 156

CONTENTS

10 The classic rock men

No genre generated more range mythology than classic rock, and no chapter of this atlas asks for more care in reading its figures. The wailers here — the multi-octave figures fans argue about at pub volume — earned their reputations with real, documented extremes, but the entries are careful about *mechanism*: a great deal of rock's famous altitude is reinforced falsetto, head voice driven hard, or one-off screams captured live, not chest voice defying physics. Where an entry gives a full-voice ceiling, it tells you which was which; many entries give none, and for those the technique paragraph is the better guide.

The other half of the chapter belongs to the baritones — the art-rockers, the gravel merchants, the frontmen who made menace and character do the work of altitude. Their entries carry most of this chapter's borrowable technique, because their tools transfer: phrasing against the band, vowel theatre, controlled rasp built across a phrase. The wailers' tools mostly do not transfer, which their own entries say plainly.

A pattern worth noticing across both camps: the long careers in this chapter belong overwhelmingly to singers whose entries describe *distributed* effort — grit that rides on support, peaks rationed per set, intensity built through the torso rather than detonated in the throat. The short careers cluster on the other side of that line. Rock mythology celebrates abandon; rock longevity, on the evidence of these pages, was always a technician's game wearing abandon as a costume.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Little Richard

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1955 · known for “Tutti Frutti”

HIGH BB5 IN “LONG TALL SALLY”

Gospel shouter's tenor: hard chest attack, heavy rasp, falsetto whoops flipped in mid-phrase.

Everything begins with a hard glottal attack — notes are punched, never eased into. The chest sound is bright, heavily rasped, and driven to the top of its working range around C5; above that he flips mid-phrase into falsetto whoops that function as exclamation rather than melody. Time sits slightly ahead of the beat and drags the band with it. The attack and that forward timing carry the style, and the rasp falls out of both.

Elvis Presley

G2–Db5 · 2 octaves + 6



Baritone · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1956 · known for “Can't Help Falling in Love”

LOW G2 IN “PEACE IN THE VALLEY”

Baritone with a thick chest register, wide vibrato, and a gospel-trained bottom he drops into freely.

Listen for a dark, thick baritone placed low and forward, carrying a wide, slow vibrato that arrives late in a held note. Onsets are aspirate and scooped — he slides up into pitch rather than landing on it. The bottom near G2 stays relaxed and unpressed rather than ground into a growl. Everything moves unhurried: phrases start under-sung and open out, so the loudest moment usually lands on the last line instead of the first.

Roy Orbison

E2–E5 · 3 octaves

Tenor USA · prominent since 1956 · known for “Oh, Pretty Woman”

Operatic tenor that swells from a soft low murmur to full-voice high notes with no audible break.

Rather than belting, he crescendos. A phrase can start nearly murmured down low and grow through the transition with no audible seam, so the top arrives ringing rather than shouted — the long build in Running Scared is the clearest example of that crescendo. Vibrato stays narrow and quick, legato unbroken. The tone tilts lighter as it rises instead of thickening, which is why nothing jams up at the passaggio and the climb reads as one line.

John Lennon

G2–D5 · 2 octaves + 7

Tenor UK · prominent since 1963 · known for “Come Together”

HIGH D5 IN “TWIST AND SHOUT”

Nasal, slightly flat-toned tenor; pushes into a torn-edged shout at the top instead of smoothing it out.

Placement is narrow and nasal with very little vibrato, mostly straight tone, phrases delivered close to how he would speak them. Notes are often approached from just underneath and left sitting there, which is part of the sound rather than a fault. Near D5 the tone tears into a shout instead of smoothing into a mix. The usual imitation error is adding vibrato and polish and losing the conversational delivery.

Mick Jagger

F2–F5 · 3 octaves



Tenor · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 1963 · known for “(I Can't Get No) Satisfaction”

HIGH F5 IN “EMOTIONAL RESCUE”

Thin, drawled tenor with heavy blues phrasing; the high stuff comes out in a light, airy falsetto.

Note how low the belt sits at B4 while the range reaches F5: everything above the belt arrives in a light, airy falsetto, often as a whoop rather than a held note. The tone is thin and slightly pinched by design, vowels stretched and drawled, consonants chewed. Rhythm is the real technique here, landing late, dragging syllables across the beat, then snapping back. Sing it cleanly and on time and the character disappears.

Paul McCartney

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · UK · prominent since 1963 · known for “Hey Jude”

HIGH E5 IN “LONG TALL SALLY”

Flexible tenor that shifts from soft crooning to a hoarse rock shout inside the same song.

Two settings live in one voice: a light, nearly vibrato-free croon with soft aspirate onsets, and a hoarse open-throated shout he switches to without warning. The quiet mode is genuinely smooth, pitch-centered, no scooping. The shout brightens and flattens the tone and rides high toward E5. That mode draws all the attention, but the quiet one is the harder skill and the one carrying most of the material.

Roger Daltrey

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor UK · prominent since 1965 · known for “Won't Get Fooled Again”

HIGH C5 IN “LOVE, REIGN O'ER ME”

Chest-dominant tenor: thick midrange, gravel on the push, screams sung on the belt rather than falsetto.

Weight stays in the chest as the line climbs, so the tone thickens rather than thinning on the way to C5. Onsets are hard and often shouted, and the grain shows up only when he pushes harder: controlled distortion riding on a supported tone, not a rasp laid over the top. Vibrato is slight. The grit comes last in the learning order; grab it first and the second chorus is gone.

Jim Morrison

E2–Bb4 · 2 octaves + 6



Baritone USA · prominent since 1967 · known for “Light My Fire”

HIGH BB4 IN “WHEN THE MUSIC'S OVER”

Dark, resonant baritone with crooner control below and unpitched howls when he pushes past the staff.

Below the staff the voice is dark and round with a low larynx, closer to a crooner's setup than a rock singer's, and slow wide vibrato on held notes. Phrases often begin nearly spoken and grow into tone. Pushing past Bb4 he trades pitch for open howls, so there is no real mix to study. Students darken by pressing the tongue down and lose the words; that depth comes from an open throat, not a swallowed one.

Joe Cocker

G2–Bb4 · 2 octaves + 3



Baritone · full voice to A4 · UK · prominent since 1968 · known for “With a Little Help from My Friends”

The definitive gravel: a torn, convulsive blues shout that turned polite pop songs into testifying.

Rasp at this depth is a full-body event. The tone is shredded across its whole span, not just at peaks, produced with enormous breath drive and a wide-open throat, and the phrasing convulses: words arrive in spasms, early or late, exactly where a gospel shouter would place them. Sustained notes bloom into wide, slow vibrato. Study the phrasing separately from the rasp, speaking the lines in his timing. The distortion itself took him years and cost him plenty; borrow the timing, not the tissue damage.

Robert Plant

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor · full voice to E5 · UK · prominent since 1968 · known for “Whole Lotta Love”

Bluesy tenor with a bright, nasal-forward top and heavy vibrato; leans on falsetto wails above the belt.

Everything sits forward and high in the mouth, thin at the edges rather than round, with vibrato that comes on fast and wide almost as soon as a note lands. Blues bends and slurred approaches replace clean onsets. Above the E5 belt he releases into a ringing falsetto wail instead of pushing. Students usually try to muscle those cries in chest and end up squeezing the throat shut.

David Bowie

E2–A5 · 3 octaves + 5



Baritone · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 1969 · known for “Space Oddity”

Baritone with a wide color palette: theatrical vibrato low, thin brightness up top, heavy diction.

Color changes from song to song, but the mechanics repeat: a plummy, vibrato-heavy low register with theatrical vowel shaping, and a thinner brighter sound above the B4 belt that he lets stay light rather than reinforcing. Diction is deliberate, consonants placed, vowels chosen for character. Vibrato often arrives late in a held note and then widens. Imitators go straight for the accent and skip the vowel discipline that makes the character readable.

Ian Gillan

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to G5 · UK · prominent since 1969 · known for “Smoke on the Water”

HIGH BB5 IN “CHILD IN TIME”

High tenor that trades melody for siren-like screams; belts stay bright and forward with little weight.

Brightness is the whole engine: narrow vowels, high placement, very little weight carried upward, which is how the belt reaches G5 and the screams above it stay pitched instead of collapsing. Held notes pick up a fast shimmer of vibrato late. Sirens slide across an octave with no audible seam. Copy this by adding chest weight and you will jam around D5; the trick is subtracting mass, not adding force.

Rod Stewart

E2–C5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to A4 · UK · prominent since 1969 · known for “Maggie May”

Sandpaper rasp from a breathy onset; sits mid-range and pushes volume rather than height.

The rasp comes off a breathy onset: air first, tone second, which frays the edge of every word. He works a narrow middle band and finds intensity through volume and grit rather than altitude, topping out around A4 before the C5 goes thin. Phrases sit slightly behind the beat and the ends fall away rather than resolving. Grinding the throat to copy the texture gets you hoarse in a verse; it is aspirate, not squeezed.

Paul Rodgers

E2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 4



Baritone · UK · prominent since 1970 · known for “All Right Now”

LOW E2 IN “WARBOYS” · HIGH G#5 IN “CATCH A TRAIN”

Warm, gravelled blues-rock voice; unhurried phrasing, thick middle register, controlled rasp.

Restraint is the discipline: a warm, grainy chest voice used mostly in the middle octave, with space left around every phrase. He blends chest and head into one seamless mix, saving the top for single climactic moments. Onsets slide from just under pitch, blues-fashion; vibrato is slow and even. Rasp arrives only under pressure, never as decoration. Students copy the grit and skip the economy; his authority comes from what he declines to sing.

Jon Anderson

C#3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor UK · prominent since 1971 · known for “Roundabout”

HIGH F#5 IN “I'M DOWN (LIVE)”

Bell-clear high tenor; floating, vibrato-light lines that sit naturally above the staff.

Placement sits high and forward permanently: a light head-dominant tenor produced with minimal fold mass, so the top of the staff feels like his middle. He avoids falsetto flips because the whole instrument is already that light. Vibrato is sparing; lines are long, legato and mantra-like, with vowels kept narrow and bright. Imitators strain upward from chest and miss entirely; the register has to be approached from above, floating down onto pitches rather than climbing to them.

Peter Gabriel

F#2–A4 · 2 octaves + 3



Baritone full voice to G4 UK · prominent since 1971 · known for “Sledgehammer”

A grainy, soul-schooled baritone: Otis Redding pressure pushed through an English art-rock imagination.

Grain plus push defines the mature sound: a throaty, sandpapered baritone driven hard into its upper fourth, where the strain is audible and intentional, borrowed straight from Stax soul shouting. Underneath, phrasing is conversational and behind the beat. The rasp rides on strong breath pressure with the throat staying open; it is effortful but distributed effort. Build the push gradually across a phrase, arriving at full grain only on the peak word. Starting at maximum is how throats get hurt copying this.

Don Henley

F#2–D#5 · 2 octaves + 9



Tenor USA · prominent since 1972 · known for “Hotel California”

Reedy, grainy tenor with a country undertow; conversational verses that tighten into raspy climaxes.

Speech-level singing anchors everything: he sits in a narrow, reedy band just above his talking pitch and lets lyric stress, not volume, shape the line. Rasp is a controlled overlay that thickens toward climaxes, while vibrato stays minimal. Vowels are twangy and slightly nasal, which keeps quiet phrases present over a band. Copyists add drama too early; his builds are stingy, holding the grit back until the final choruses so the arrival actually registers.

Kenny Loggins

D2–C#6 · 3 octaves + 11



Tenor full voice to B4 USA · prominent since 1972 · known for “Footloose”

LOW D2 IN “SWEET MARIE” · HIGH C#6 IN “LET THERE BE LOVE”

Supple pop-rock tenor; breathy intimacy at rest, keening sustained top notes at full sail.

Breath control powers the style: long, arcing phrases that move from feathered, airy intimacy to bright, sustained top notes without losing line. He mixes early, keeps vowels narrow on the climb, and uses falsetto as a deliberate color at the extremes. Rhythmic feel is supple, floating around the beat. The imitation error is starting loud; his crescendos work because the first bars are genuinely soft, and singers who open at full voice have nowhere to build.

Freddie Mercury

F2–F6 · 4 octaves



Baritone | full voice to F5 | UK · prominent since 1973 · known for “Bohemian Rhapsody”

HIGH F6 IN “GET DOWN, MAKE LOVE”

Baritone core sung as a tenor: fast vibrato, hard consonants, and a sudden switch into piercing falsetto.

Listen for a speaking weight heavier than the tessitura suggests: a baritone body carried up to an F5 belt. The vibrato is quick and narrow and starts almost at the onset. Consonants land like percussion, and phrases end cleanly rather than trailing off. Above the belt he drops the weight and flips outright into falsetto. Shake the jaw to fake that vibrato and it reads as a wobble; the real thing runs on steady breath, not motion.

Glenn Hughes

D2–D6 · 4 octaves



Baritone | full voice to A5 | UK · prominent since 1973 · known for “Burn”

LOW D2 IN “GETTIN' TIGHTER” · HIGH D6 IN “MISTREATED”

Funk-schooled rock voice swinging from smoky lows to piercing full-throated screams.

Register agility defines the instrument: he moves between smoky low crooning, gospel-inflected runs, and full-throated screams inside a single phrase. The belt is carried extremely high on intense twang and breath pressure, with falsetto reserved for color above it. Runs are rhythmically exact, funk-schooled, never smeared. Vibrato widens with volume. The trap for imitators is chasing the screams cold; he approaches extremes through years of mixed coordination, and copying the top without that scaffolding shreds tone instantly.

Sammy Hagar

D2–B5 · 3 octaves + 9



Tenor · full voice to A5 · USA · prominent since 1973 · known for “I Can't Drive 55”

LOW D2 IN “SAILIN'” · HIGH B5 IN “BLACK AND BLUE”

High-gain rock tenor; bright, brassy belts that cut through loud guitars without thinning out.

Belting carries almost everything: a bright, brassy chest-mix pushed high with strong twang and a raised larynx he somehow keeps free of squeeze. Falsetto appears rarely; he prefers full-voice intensity even at the extremes. Vibrato is quick and applied at note ends. Phrasing lands right on the beat, athletic and punchy. Singers copying him tend to drag chest weight up without the twang, which turns bright ping into flat yelling and burns out the top fast.

Steven Tyler

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 1973 · known for “Dream On”

Raspy high tenor built on screams and blues bends; top notes arrive as distorted cries, not clean tone.

Rasp is present at nearly every volume, sitting on top of a bright forward tone rather than replacing it. Phrases slide into pitch from below and often flick upward at the end. Above the E5 belt the sound turns to distorted cry and screamed falsetto instead of clean tone. Blues bends and quick melisma fill the gaps. The grit is layered over real support; produce it in the throat and you get noise.

David Coverdale

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Baritone UK · prominent since 1974 · known for “Here I Go Again”

LOW F2 IN “MISTREATED” · HIGH A5 IN “STILL OF THE NIGHT”

Smoky blues baritone with a wailing top; wide vibrato and rasp poured over slow-burn phrasing.

A baritone core carries this sound: dark, chesty vowels with a wide, slow vibrato that he lets swell at phrase ends. Top notes are taken on narrowed vowels with heavy twang and rasp, ridden on breath rather than pushed. His onsets are often aspirate, sliding into pitch for blues effect. The common copying error is scooping every note; he scoops selectively, landing key tones dead center so the drama reads as intent, not drift.

Geddy Lee

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor Canada · prominent since 1974 · known for “Tom Sawyer”

Piercing, narrow-toned high tenor; early records sit near the top of his range with a nasal edge.

Compact and edged rather than large, this is a tone built to slice through a loud band instead of filling a room. Much of the material sits so high that the bottom of the range barely gets used. Vibrato is fast and shallow where it appears; mostly the sound runs straight. Rhythmic placement is exact, syllables locked tight to the rhythm section. Reaching for that height with more pressure is the usual error; it comes from forward placement instead.

Bruce Springsteen

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Baritone USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “Born to Run”

HIGH C5 IN “BORN TO RUN”

Grainy baritone that works the low-middle and gets height by shouting through a raspy chest mix.

Most of the singing happens in the low-middle, close to speech, with grain in the tone even at conversational volume. Height comes from shouting through a raspy chest mix rather than lightening, so C5 sounds like effort and is meant to. Onsets are breathy or half-spoken and vibrato is nearly absent. Phrases stretch long and push toward the top of a line. Take the rasp without the breath behind it and you get hoarseness, not intensity.

Dennis DeYoung

E2–A5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “Come Sail Away”

LOW E2 IN “FIRE” · HIGH A5 IN “ROCKIN' THE PARADISE”

Theatrical tenor with fast, wide vibrato and crisp diction; show-tune polish inside arena rock.

Vibrato leads the sound: fast, wide, and constant, applied from the first beat of a sustain like a stage vocalist. Diction is exaggerated, vowels bright and forward, dynamics swelled phrase by phrase. He keeps a polished mix through the upper range rather than hard belting, so high lines stay round. The common error in imitation is treating the theatricality as volume; it is actually placement and vowel shaping, and shouting it flattens the elegance into parody.

Brad Delp

G#2–D6 · 3 octaves + 6



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 1976 · known for “More Than a Feeling”

LOW G#2 IN “I HAD A GOOD TIME” · HIGH D6 IN “LET ME TAKE YOU HOME TONIGHT”

Gleaming high tenor with pure sustained fifth-octave lines and stacked harmony instincts.

Head-mix blend is the engine: he carries a light, ringing coordination to the top of the staff so full-voice lines and falsetto meet seamlessly. Vowels stay tall and pure, vibrato modest, onsets clean. He tunes stacked harmonies against his own lead, so intonation discipline is absolute. The copying error is belting where he floats; those long fifth-octave sustains are balanced, twangy mix, and muscling them in pure chest guarantees cracking and pitch sag.

Phil Collins

F2–Db5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor · UK · prominent since 1976 · known for “In the Air Tonight”

HIGH DB5 IN “AGAINST ALL ODDS”

Grainy tenor that stays conversational down low, then shoves into a shouted chest top.

Down low the delivery stays conversational, nearly spoken, with breathy onsets and hardly any vibrato. Climbing into the top he stops blending and shoves, and the sound turns grainy and shouted with the vowel spread wide. Dynamics swing hard between those two states. Singers copying this start loud and leave themselves nowhere to go — the quiet, deliberately under-supported verses are what make the top of the chorus land.

Tom Petty

C2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 10



Baritone · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1976 · known for “Free Fallin’”

LOW C2 IN “ROOM AT THE TOP” · HIGH BB5 IN “I NEED TO KNOW”

Nasal, drawling low voice; laconic delivery that snaps into strained, urgent high wails.

Drawl shapes every line: a nasal, twang-heavy delivery sitting low, with vowels flattened and consonants lazy on purpose. He sings barely above speech, then jumps to strained, yelping top notes for emphasis, accepting the tension as part of the sound. Vibrato is nearly absent. Phrasing trails the beat, conversational and dry. The copying mistake is cleaning it up; rounding his vowels or supporting the yelps into prettiness deletes the attitude that is the entire point.

Lou Gramm

B1–A5 · 3 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 1977 · known for “I Want to Know What Love Is”

LOW B1 IN “BIG DOG” · HIGH A5 IN “NIGHT LIFE”

Muscular soul-rock tenor; grit-edged belts and smooth low verses in one instrument.

Compression gives the voice its muscle: a tight chest-mix with grit at the edges, driven by firm glottal closure and forward placement. He belts high on narrow vowels, keeping the sound punchy rather than wide, then releases into smoother low verses with barely any vibrato. Phrases start on the breath and finish clipped. Students copying the belt usually oversqueeze the throat; his intensity comes from breath pressure against a steady fold seal, not from neck tension.

Meat Loaf

F2–Eb6 · 3 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1977 · known for “Bat Out of Hell”

LOW F2 IN “MORE” · HIGH EB6 IN “JOHNNY B. GOODE (LIVE)”

Operatic rock drama: a huge, dark-hued voice that swells from croon to thunderous belt with theatrical vibrato.

Scale is the point: he treats every phrase as staged drama, opening with covered, rounded vowels and widening into a huge, chest-dominant belt. The vibrato is wide and theatrical, the dynamics terraced like an aria. He shifts weight gradually rather than flipping, so climaxes feel inevitable. Imitators grab the volume first and skip the head-voice balance underneath, which is what actually keeps the big notes spinning; without that balance the delivery turns into shouting by the second chorus.

Steve Perry

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 1977 · known for “Don't Stop Believin'”

Smooth tenor with an R&B bend to the phrasing; the mix stays connected right through the top of the belt.

The seam between registers is the thing to study: the mix stays connected right through the E5 belt with no audible gear change. Onsets are clean and pitch-centered, then vibrato arrives a beat or so into the note, even and moderate in width. Phrasing borrows from R&B, with small bends, delayed entries and a cry inside the vowel. Volume is the wrong lever here; the tone comes from narrowing the vowel and holding the larynx steady.

David Lee Roth

E1–D6 · 4 octaves + 10



Baritone · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1978 · known for “Jump”

LOW E1 IN “LAST CALL” · HIGH D6 IN “EXPERIENCE (LIVE)”

Swaggering low talk-sing that leaps into yelps, squeals and slides; showmanship built into the phrasing.

Showmanship drives the technique: a low, conversational baritone delivery that erupts into slides, screams and two-octave leaps used as punctuation. He treats pitch as elastic, bending into notes from below and decorating exits with growls and yelps. The upper extreme is a pinched, siren-like scream, not a sustained melody register. Students err by imitating the antics without the timing; his interjections land rhythmically, placed like drum fills, and the underlying voice stays relaxed and speech-based.

Kevin Cronin

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2



Tenor · USA · prominent since 1978 · known for “Keep On Loving You”

LOW G2 IN “TAKE IT ON THE RUN” · HIGH A4 IN “CAN'T FIGHT THIS FEELING”

Earnest, bright Midwestern tenor; plainspoken verses that swell into vibrato-heavy choruses.

Sincerity reads through the technique: a plain, bright tenor with speechy onsets, light vibrato saved for held notes, and choruses lifted by widening vowels rather than adding grit. He leans on strong mid-range support, rarely leaving the staff, and lets small cracks and catches stay in as expression. Students overpolish him; the appeal depends on those unguarded edges, and sanding them off with perfect legato removes exactly the vulnerability the phrasing is built to carry.

Sting

Eb2–E5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 1978 · known for “Every Breath You Take”

HIGH E5 IN “ROXANNE”

Reedy, narrow tenor with clipped phrasing; takes upper notes in a strained mix, not a full belt.

Reedy and narrow, placed forward and slightly nasal, with consonants clipping the ends of phrases short. Rhythm is the real tell: syncopated, pushed off the downbeat, percussive more than legato. Above B4 he moves into a tight, strained mix, so the sustained upper notes in Roxanne read as pressed rather than fully belted. That audible tension belongs to the sound; smoothed out into an even legato, the voice stops being recognizable.

Klaus Meine

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor · Germany · prominent since 1979 · known for “Wind of Change”

LOW G2 IN “EYE TO EYE” · HIGH C6 IN “NOW!”

Laser-focused tenor with keening sustain; clean, precise highs that ride over heavy riffs.

Precision defines this instrument: a focused, narrow-vowel tenor with intense twang that projects over heavy backing without excess weight. Sustains are dead straight before a fast, tight vibrato arrives. His high notes are mixed, not falsetto, achieved by keeping the larynx steady and the tone slim. Diction stays crisp even at full volume. The classic copying mistake is adding thickness for power; his power comes from resonance focus, and extra weight just blunts it.

Bono

Eb2–Db5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to B4 · Ireland · prominent since 1980 · known for “With or Without You”

HIGH DB5 IN “LEMON”

Chesty tenor with a pleading attack that scoops into pitch, plus a light falsetto he flips to.

Pleading is a technical choice here. Onsets scoop up from under the note, vowels stay wide and open, and vibrato shows up late in a phrase if at all. Chest carries to about B4; past that he either lets the tone thin and fray on purpose or flips into a light, airy falsetto rather than forcing. Rhythm is elastic and stretches across bar lines. Imitators over-scoop until nothing actually lands in tune.

Brian Johnson

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · UK · prominent since 1980 · known for “Back in Black”

Sits almost entirely in a strained, distorted upper register; little clean tone, high notes are shrieks.

Almost everything sits in a narrow band near the top of the range with a constant distorted edge, and the clean tone barely appears, so there is no soft setting for contrast. Rhythm is blunt and right on the beat, consonants clipped, phrases short. Vibrato is essentially absent. Distortion this dense has to come from loose tissue vibrating above a supported note; substitute raw pressure for that and you get one take out of it.

Bryan Adams

Eb2–E6 · 4 octaves + 1



Tenor · full voice to D5 · Canada · prominent since 1983 · known for “Summer of '69”

LOW EB2 IN “IF YOU WANNA BE BAD, YOU GOTTA BE GOOD (LIVE)” · HIGH E6 IN “VICTIM OF LOVE”

Sandpaper rasp over a bright tenor core; gritty mid-register drive that stays tuneful at full throttle.

The rasp rides on top of a clean tenor placement, not inside it; he compresses at the fold level and lets distortion bloom only on stressed syllables. Onset is glottal and percussive, vibrato narrow and late. Phrases are short, consonant-driven, punched from the chest with a lifted soft palate. Students copying him usually manufacture the grit in the throat, which chokes the tone; the growl has to sit over a supported, forward mix or it collapses into strain.

Joe Elliott

D2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 6



Baritone · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 1983 · known for “Pour Some Sugar on Me”

LOW D2 IN “SPACE ODDITY” · HIGH G#5 IN “FOOLIN'”

Grainy, deep-spoken rock voice that flips into a ringing head-voice top layered for stadium choruses.

Two voices coexist here: a deep, grainy speaking register and a bright head-voice extension he layers into wall-of-sound choruses. He flips early and unapologetically, letting the blend between chest and head happen in overdubs rather than in one line. Vowels narrow hard on top notes, with rasp added by compression at the edges. Copyists usually push chest too high trying to make the record's composite sound alone; he builds it from stacked, lighter passes.

Jon Bon Jovi

E2–D5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor USA · prominent since 1984 · known for “Livin' on a Prayer”

HIGH D5 IN “LIVIN' ON A PRAYER”

Bright nasal tenor that drives choruses in a hard chest mix and roughens at the top end.

Bright and noticeably nasal, with the sound pinned high in the mask so it carries over distorted guitars. Choruses ride a hard chest-heavy mix that roughens as it climbs, and the D5 at the top of Livin' on a Prayer is taken with the throat open and a slight bark on the vowel. Attacks land firm and consonant-first, and there is real chest weight sitting under the brightness, which keeps the nasal edge from going thin.

Axl Rose

F1–Bb6 · 5 octaves + 5



Tenor full voice to D5 USA · prominent since 1987 · known for “Sweet Child o' Mine”

LOW F1 IN “THERE WAS A TIME” · HIGH BB6 IN “AIN'T IT FUN”

Two voices in one: a low growl underneath, a thin cutting rasp on top, screams above that.

Two mechanisms do the work. Underneath sits a heavy, distorted low voice trailing into fry at the bottom; above the D5 belt the tone thins into a narrow, nasal rasp that cuts rather than fills, and the screams past that are almost pure edge with no weight behind them. Phrasing drags behind the beat, then snaps forward. The common mistake is squeezing the throat to find the rasp — compression makes that noise, not force.

Lenny Kravitz

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor USA · prominent since 1989 · known for “Are You Gonna Go My Way”

Retro-soul tenor with sandpaper edges; funk yelps, doubled unisons, and rock screams on top.

Retro soul framing shapes the voice: a wiry tenor with sandpaper edges, sung through vintage-style saturation that thickens an otherwise lean instrument. Phrasing alternates tight funk yelps, doubled unison lines, and long rock screams, all delivered with a high, bright placement. Vibrato is quick and shallow, ornamentation minimal but placed exactly on the groove. The mistake students make is chasing the rasp with throat pressure; the grain is mostly air-driven and microphone-close, and the funk articulation depends on clipping phrases short, breathing in rhythm, and trusting the pocket.

Scott Stapp

D2–D5 · 3 octaves



Baritone full voice to C5 USA · prominent since 1997 · known for “With Arms Wide Open”

LOW D2 IN “BULLETS” · HIGH D5 IN “RUNNING TO STAND STILL”

Cavernous, chesty baritone with heavy vibrato and rounded, darkened vowels; sounds carved from granite.

Weight defines this baritone: a cavernous, chesty production with rounded, darkened vowels, heavy vibrato, and a low larynx that gives every phrase an oaken thickness. The voice moves in broad strokes — long sustains, slow scoops into pitch, and belts around C5 delivered with maximum chest engagement. Head voice barely features. Students copying the darkness usually swallow the sound entirely; the depth here still projects because the tone stays connected to breath and the vowels, though covered, keep a firm forward core rather than sinking into the throat.

Matt Bellamy

E2–D6 · 3 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to D5 · UK · prominent since 1999 · known for “Uprising”

HIGH D6 IN “MICRO CUTS”

Thin, vibrato-heavy tenor that trades chest weight for a piercing falsetto with an operatic wobble.

Weight gets traded for ring. Tone is thin and forward with a fast, fairly wide vibrato running almost continuously, and above the D5 belt he moves into a falsetto that keeps that operatic wobble intact all the way up toward D6, which is where the upper writing in Micro Cuts sits. Chest stays comparatively light. The usual error is manufacturing the vibrato with the jaw rather than letting airflow produce it.

Chris Martin

D2–C6 · 3 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to Eb5 · UK · prominent since 2000 · known for “Yellow”

LOW D2 IN “GYPSY WOMAN” · HIGH C6 IN “POUR ME”

Feathery light tenor that floats into falsetto; gentle onsets, hymn-like phrasing, warm mid-range built for singalongs.

Light head-dominant production defines this instrument: a slim chest voice carried gently up to a soft mix, then an easy flip into falsetto that does most of the top-end work. Onsets are breathy, vibrato minimal, phrasing hymn-like and legato. The Eb5 area marks the practical ceiling of full voice; above it everything releases into airy head tone. Students copying him usually over-sing the falsetto — the trick is releasing air pressure early, keeping the larynx neutral, and letting resonance stay forward and bright rather than pushing chest weight upward.

Chad Kroeger

A1–E5 · 3 octaves + 7



Baritone · full voice to D5 · Canada · prominent since 2001 · known for “How You Remind Me”

LOW A1 IN “COIN FOR THE FERRYMAN” · HIGH E5 IN “LEGS”

Gravel-coated baritone with a compressed, distorted edge; low thick verses that erupt into sustained high grit.

Grit is the signature: a compressed, distorted baritone that stays overdriven from the first syllable, with a rasp produced above the folds rather than on them. Verses sit low and thick; choruses leap upward into sustained belts around D5 that hold their distortion without collapsing. Vibrato is minimal, phrasing square and anthemic. Singers copying the rasp by squeezing the throat lose their voice within a set — the distortion needs high breath energy, a lifted soft palate, and a clean underlying tone that could sing the line unfuzzed.

Jack White

E2–A6 · 4 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to E5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “Seven Nation Army”

LOW E2 IN “OVER AND OVER AND OVER” · HIGH A6 IN “CORPORATION”

Wiry, unhinged tenor wail; bluesy bent notes, sudden register leaps, and piercing flageolet squeals.

Wildness masks precision here: a wiry, thin-toned tenor that leaps registers mid-phrase, bending blues intervals and cracking on purpose. Chest belts around E5 are tight and piercing, while the extreme top is flageolet — a whistle-like squeal treated as an effect, not a melody register. Onsets are explosive, vibrato nearly absent, dynamics all-or-nothing. Students copying the mania usually let pitch collapse; underneath the flailing the intonation is exact, and the register flips are timed rhythmic choices, landed with the same discipline as a guitar fill.

Caleb Followill

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 2003 · known for “Use Somebody”

LOW A2 IN “MILK” · HIGH E5 IN “BLACK THUMBNAIL”

Frayed, strangled-sounding tenor rasp; slurred Southern phrasing that cracks open into falsetto.

Fraying is the aesthetic: a strangled, raspy tenor with slurred Southern diction, where words melt into open vowel sounds and the edge of the voice always sounds about to tear. Power concentrates up to A4, delivered with a tight, cry-like compression; above that the voice releases into a soft, well-controlled falsetto around E5. Vibrato is narrow and fast when it appears. Copying the rasp first is backwards — the underlying line is smooth and supported, and the tearing quality comes from vowel shape and compression, not from real throat strain.

Brandon Flowers

F#2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Mr. Brightside”

LOW F#2 IN “BONES” · HIGH G#5 IN “NEON TIGER”

Bright, theatrical tenor with a trembling edge; thick sustained tones held high over glittering synth-rock choruses.

Drama drives this tenor: tall vowels, firm onsets, and long sustained tones held with a fast, shimmering vibrato. The middle register is thick and trumpet-like, pushed forward against synth walls, and belts up to E5 keep full chest weight with wide-open mouth shapes. Head voice appears rarely; the instrument prefers to stay heavy. Singers copying him tend to spread the vowel on the big notes — he narrows instead, keeping the sound tall and rounded, and he releases phrases cleanly rather than sliding off pitch.

Dan Reynolds

G2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 1



Baritone · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2012 · known for “Radioactive”

LOW G2 IN “SECOND CHANCES” · HIGH G#5 IN “SONG 2”

Dark, percussive baritone with a drum-tight rhythmic attack; smoky low end that flips into ringing high mixes and gritty belts.

Percussion lives inside this baritone: consonants land like drum hits, onsets are glottal and rhythmic, and phrases ride the kick pattern rather than floating over it. The chest voice is dark and thick through the middle, with twang added to sharpen belts near G5. Falsetto is soft and hollow by contrast, used as a color rather than an extension. Students copying him often force volume from the throat; the power actually comes from compression and forward placement, with the tongue kept low and the sound anchored in speech.

Sam Fender

F#2–F5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · UK · prominent since 2019 · known for “Seventeen Going Under”

LOW F#2 IN “FRIDAY FIGHTING” · HIGH F5 IN “SATURDAY”

Keening high tenor with a Northern ring; long belted notes that sit high and cut through jangling guitars.

Height defines this tenor: the tessitura sits unusually high, and long open-throated notes ring with a bright, keening edge that cuts through dense guitars. The mix approaching F5 stays smooth and connected, never flipping audibly, with vowels narrowed toward ee and eh to keep the placement pingy. Vibrato is slow and even, arriving late on sustained tones. Students copying him usually reach for the top from below; he treats high phrases as the resting position and supports steadily, so the climb stays even.

Damiano David

A2–B4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone · full voice to A4 · Italy · prominent since 2021 · known for “Beggin’”

Måneskin's frontman: a dark, swaggering baritone with Italian vowel color, pushed into a snarling rock belt at the top.

Swagger sits on a low foundation. The speaking-range tone is dark and slightly oily, with pure Italian vowels that keep resonance tall where an American singer would spread, and the top is a pushed, snarly belt that stays just this side of a yell. Consonant attacks are theatrical, almost spat. Work the vowel color first: sing the line on pure ah and oh, no diphthongs, then add the snarl as a final layer. Starting with the snarl shreds the voice and misses the elegance underneath.

NEXT The women of rock →

11 The women of rock

The women in this chapter solved a problem the pop chapters never had to face at the same intensity: being heard, nightly, over drum kits and full stacks, in an era when the monitor engineer was optional and the audience was not. The solutions in these entries are a curriculum in projection. Some went through the middle of the noise — chest-dominant belts with enough twang to cut steel. Some went over it, in sirening head-voice registers the band could not touch. And some refused the fight entirely, planting a deadpan cool in the mix and letting the band rage around it.

Read these entries for the *mechanics of cut*: forward placement, narrow vowels at volume, brightness used as a weapon rather than a color. The belters here get louder by getting brighter — the sustainable trick the safety chapter endorses — because the unsustainable version did not produce four-decade careers, and several of these are four-decade careers.

There is also a tonal range in this chapter the genre's reputation hides. Between the banshees and the shouters sit smoke, rasp, torch and chill: voices that redefined toughness as timbre rather than volume. If your instrument is not a natural belt, those entries are your entry point to this chapter — proof that fronting loud music is a placement problem and an attitude problem before it is ever a decibel problem.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Tina Turner

G2–Eb5 · 2 octaves + 8



Contralto USA · prominent since 1960 · known for “Proud Mary”

HIGH EB5 IN “RIVER DEEP - MOUNTAIN HIGH”

Gravel-edged contralto that stays in chest voice and gets power from a hard, forward rasp.

Power lives in the lower middle here, not up top. The contralto stays in chest with a gravel edge sitting right at the front of the sound, onsets are frequently growled, and phrases push and shove against the beat rather than floating over it. Approaching Eb5 the tone narrows into a hard, rasp-edged cry. That grit rides on breath pressure behind a forward, wide-open vowel, which is how it stays loud without closing the throat down.

Grace Slick

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Contralto USA · prominent since 1966 · known for “White Rabbit”

HIGH D5 IN “SOMEBODY TO LOVE”

Flat declamatory chest tone with little vibrato; builds by adding volume, not by climbing.

Notes get stated, not sung around. The tone stays flat and straight, vibrato is minimal, and intensity builds by adding volume and hardening the vowel while the pitch stays put. Onsets are firm and unornamented, and lines land squarely on the beat with an almost spoken conviction. A student's instinct is to add vibrato and slides, which immediately softens the menace this approach depends on.

Janis Joplin

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 1967 · known for “Piece of My Heart”

Rasp-forward blues phrasing, heavy distortion and grit, pushed high in raw chest voice.

Grit is the instrument. Rasp sits on top of the vowel, notes get scooped into from underneath, and phrase ends fray out into a cry. Blues bends and repeated shouted syllables do the ornamenting rather than clean melisma. Full weight stops around F5; higher notes arrive as raw, unpolished pushes. The usual mistake is grinding the throat to fake the rasp instead of keeping the vowel open and letting airflow rough up the tone.

Ann Wilson

G2–E6 · 3 octaves + 9



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to A5 · USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “Barracuda”

Operatic power belt with a hard edge; holds high chest notes without letting them thin out.

Chest weight rides up past the top of the staff, with a hard, precise onset and a bright ring that cuts over loud guitars. The vibrato is even and moderately fast, starting almost the instant the note does. Above the A5 belt the tone thins into a clean upper register instead of a shout. Copy the volume without building the breath support underneath it and the sound turns throaty by the second chorus.

Stevie Nicks

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Contralto USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “Dreams”

Husky breath-driven alto in a narrow working band; wide vibrato, almost entirely chest voice.

Breath is part of the tone, not a flaw in it: air rides through every note and creates the huskiness. Onsets are soft, consonants get swallowed, and phrases lean slightly behind the beat. Vibrato is wide and slow, and it usually arrives late in a sustain. Everything sits in chest voice inside a narrow band, so colour has to come from texture. The instinct is to tighten the throat to manufacture that texture, when the sound depends on staying loose.

Debbie Harry

F3–E5 · 1 octave + 11



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1976 · known for “Heart of Glass”

HIGH E5 IN “HEART OF GLASS”

Cool deadpan delivery that flips to a thin bright top; light onsets, very little vibrato.

The detachment is the performance: light onsets, almost no vibrato, short clipped vowels, and a delivery that sits exactly on the beat without pushing. When the line rises the tone thins into a bright, narrow upper register instead of belting, which keeps the deadpan intact. Over-emote, or add weight up top, and the flat unbothered quality that is the actual style disappears.

Joan Jett

E3–C5 · 1 octave + 8



Contralto USA · prominent since 1976 · known for “I Love Rock 'n' Roll”

Speech-level snarl in a narrow chest band; drive comes from consonants and timing, not pitch.

Drive comes from the consonants. She sings at speech level in a narrow chest band, snarling the front of each word and clipping the ends, so rhythm rather than pitch carries the energy. Vibrato is nearly absent and the vowel stays bright and tight. Trying to make it pretty, or adding runs, kills the effect — it depends on staying blunt and dead on the groove.

Pat Benatar

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano full voice to G5 USA · prominent since 1979 · known for “Love Is a Battlefield”

Trained placement applied to hard rock; clean cutting mid belt with a fast, narrow vibrato.

Every onset lands exactly on pitch with no scoop, and the vibrato is narrow and quick, closer to a classical rate than a rock shout. Placement stays forward, which is how a belt around G5 cuts through a wall of guitars without extra volume. Above that the tone lightens rather than thickens. The pitch precision is the whole effect; rasp layered over it just blurs the line.

Dolores O'Riordan

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano Ireland · prominent since 1990 · known for “Zombie”

Keening Irish lilt with a deliberate yodel across the register break; nasal-forward, direct.

That flip across the register break is deliberate. Chest snaps up into a light, keening upper voice like a yodel, and it lands at the same point in the phrase every time. The tone is nasal-forward and direct, ornaments come as quick grace notes and turns, and sustains start straight before the vibrato widens in. Smooth that break away in the name of polish and the whole character goes with it.

Gwen Stefani

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “Don't Speak”

Bright cartoon-clear tone with wide vibrato, parked in a punchy mid belt and rarely soft.

Everything is aimed forward and bright. She scoops up into notes, holds a punchy mid-range with a wide and fairly slow vibrato, and rarely drops to anything soft; consonants get clipped short in the punk-derived phrasing. The top of the range comes in lighter rather than heavier. Pushing volume to match the attitude misses the point, because the cut is coming from placement.

Sharon den Adel

G3–D6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano Netherlands · prominent since 1997 · known for “Ice Queen”

Light airy soprano with straight-toned sustains; keeps weight out of the upper register.

Weight stays out of the top. Onsets are breathy, sustains are largely straight-toned with a narrow vibrato easing in near the end, and the upper register floats instead of pushing. Size comes from resonance and the space around the voice, not from chest weight carried upward. Mixing in more chest to make it bigger thickens the tone and loses the light, hovering quality the style is built on.

Floor Jansen

E3–E6 · 3 octaves



Soprano full voice to A5 Netherlands · prominent since 2000 · known for “Élan”

Trades operatic head voice for full metal belt mid-phrase with no audible gear change.

Watch for the gear changes, because you will not hear them. Operatic head voice and a full belt up around A5 trade places inside a single phrase, and the extension above stays free rather than pressed. Vibrato is under conscious control and can be switched off for straight-toned lines. That belt without the support and breath management holding up the classical side collapses into a shout.

Avril Lavigne

F3–E5 · 1 octave + 11



Mezzo-soprano Canada · prominent since 2002 · known for “Complicated”

Nasal mezzo with flat, speech-like phrasing and a hard chest belt she rarely lifts to head voice.

Flat and speech-like by design: phrasing tracks how a sentence would be spoken, vowels stay nasal and forward, vibrato is nearly absent. Notes get approached with a slur or scoop from below, then held dead straight. Chest weight dominates the climb and she rarely lifts into head voice, which keeps the sound blunt and young. Placement is forward rather than clamped, so the nasality is where the tone sits, not a squeezed throat.

Amy Lee

E3–E6 · 3 octaves



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2003 · known for “Bring Me to Life”

Dark rounded lower register joined to a classical-leaning head voice by a smooth mix.

The registers are joined with no audible seam. A dark, rounded lower voice meets a classical-leaning head voice through a smooth mix, so climbing the range reads as one colour getting brighter rather than a gear change. Onsets are soft on quiet lines, and the vibrato is slow, even, and does not appear until well into a sustain. Pressing the larynx down to chase that darkness only makes the tone heavy instead of round.

Hayley Williams

F3–D6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Misery Business”

Bright forward mix that stays punchy at speed; climbs into a belt instead of a shout.

Speed is the hard part. The tone is bright and placed well forward, consonants are clipped, and phrases push slightly ahead of the beat while staying in tune at tempos where most singers flatten. She climbs into a belt around G5 and lightens above it rather than shouting. Vibrato is sparse and sustains mostly straight. Most people shout from the chest instead and are out of air by the second verse.

Lzzy Hale

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2009 · known for “I Miss the Misery”

Thick chest-weighted belt with controlled rasp, plus screamed falsetto above the staff.

Two layers work at once: a thick, chest-weighted belt around G5 and a controlled rasp laid over it, added and removed at will. Down near G2 the tone goes speech-like and grounded. Past the belt the sound moves into a screamed upper register rather than more chest, and that gap up to C6 is where the style shows. Build the clean belt first; reaching for the rasp on day one usually means squeezing the throat to get it.

NEXT Alternative, punk and new wave →

12 Alternative, punk and new wave

This chapter documents the great rebellion against pretty singing, and its central irony: refusing conventional beauty turned out to require its own exacting techniques. The post-punk baritones stripped away vibrato, ornament and warmth until a semitone of movement carried a song — and discovered that controlled affectlessness is harder than emoting. The new wave croons rebuilt theatrical singing out of irony and synthesizers. And the grunge generation weaponized the break itself — yarls, cracks, howls from clean to distorted inside one phrase — turning what classical training spends years erasing into the genre's most copied gesture.

The entries here contain the atlas's highest concentration of *deliberate imperfection*, and the technique paragraphs keep making the same point from different angles: the imperfections are placed. The crack lands on the chosen word. The flat affect holds its pitch center. The scream is supported underneath exactly like a belt. What separated the era's lasting voices from its casualties was whether the chaos was a costume over control or the real thing — and the entries do not romanticize which was which.

Borrow from these voices with the safety chapter open. Phrasing, restraint and register-flip expressiveness transfer cheaply; the sustained distorted catharsis at the chapter's grunge end is the most expensive sound in this book outside metal, and the entries of the

singers who produced it sustainably all describe the same foundation: enormous breath support wearing a torn shirt.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Ian Curtis

G2–E4 · 1 octave + 9



Baritone · full voice to D4 · UK · prominent since 1979 · known for “Love Will Tear Us Apart”

Joy Division's flat-affect baritone: a gray, unornamented monotone whose power is its refusal to perform feeling.

Affectlessness is the aesthetic. The voice sits in a narrow, low band, nearly vibrato-free, vowels unglamorous and consonants plain, delivered as if reading rather than performing, and the emotional charge comes from that refusal colliding with desperate lyrics. Intonation drifts flat-ward at phrase ends, part of the grain. Practice singing a melody at conversational volume while stripping every learned expressive habit: no swells, no scoops, no vibrato. It is harder than it sounds, and the restraint is the entire art.

Nick Cave

D2–G5 · 3 octaves + 5



Baritone Australia · prominent since 1980 · known for “Red Right Hand”

LOW D2 IN “TOWER OF SONG”

Craggy, preacher-like baritone that sways between menacing murmur and unhinged howl.

Speech is the root register: a dry, chesty baritone that starts as intoned talking and escalates by widening the pharynx into bellowed, preacher-cadence peaks. Onsets are glottal and deliberate; vibrato is scarce, replaced by pitch bends that sag for menace. Agility is limited and irrelevant; the instrument works through dynamics, diction, and dramatic pacing, from murmured D2 territory to strangled falsetto cries. Imitators sing too prettily; the delivery depends on treating each line as rhetoric, letting intensity, not melody, carry the build across a song.

Dave Gahan

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone full voice to E4 UK · prominent since 1981 · known for “Enjoy the Silence”

Depeche Mode's dark crooner: a resonant machine-age baritone, nearly vibrato-free, that smolders instead of emotes.

Stillness carries the menace. The tone is deep, hooded and deliberately level, with vibrato all but removed and dynamics compressed to a narrow band, so that a semitone of melodic movement lands like an event. Vowels are darkened toward oh; consonants are clipped and precise against the machines. Sing a phrase while consciously suppressing vibrato and keeping the larynx comfortably low, without pressing. Most students discover their voice wobbles the moment they stop pushing; his control of that stillness is the skill.

Boy George

D2–A5 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to B4 · UK · prominent since 1982 · known for “Karma Chameleon”

LOW D2 IN “THE CRYING GAME” · HIGH A5 IN “NUMBER ONE”

Plush blue-eyed-soul voice; low, languid phrasing with a reggae lilt and a conversational croon.

Languor is the calling card: a plush, low-set soul voice delivered with conversational ease, reggae-tinged phrasing that drags luxuriously behind the beat, and vowels kept round and plummy. Chest voice tops out near B4, warm rather than forceful, with the area above handled in a soft, veiled head tone. Vibrato is gentle and late. Students copying him push for power and ruin the effect — the style depends on under-singing: light onsets, generous breath flow, and emotional weight carried by timing and diction instead of volume.

Robert Smith

C#3–C5 · 1 octave + 11



Tenor · full voice to G#4 · UK · prominent since 1982 · known for “Just Like Heaven”

The Cure's eternal adolescent: a quavering, tearful tenor that sounds perpetually on the verge of either sobbing or smiling.

The wobble is the signature: an unstable, sped-up vibrato that reads as barely held-back crying, over a thin, forward tenor with almost no chest weight. Pitch bends sharp-ward at moments of excitement, a controlled mannerism rather than error. Phrases tumble out slightly ahead of the beat, breathless. To borrow it, sing with a deliberately loose jaw and let the vibrato run faster and narrower than feels polished, keeping the core of each note centered. Stabilizing the wobble kills the character.

Anthony Kiedis

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Baritone · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 1984 · known for “Under the Bridge”

Narrow baritone built for rhythmic talk-singing; thin falsetto used as color on choruses.

Range is not the point. Most lines live inside a fifth, and the interest is rhythmic — talk-singing locked to sixteenth-note subdivisions with consonants used percussively, verses holding a flat pitch center on purpose. Choruses lift into a thin falsetto used as color rather than weight, with the full sound topping out around A4. Adding melodic ornament is exactly the wrong instinct; tighten the subdivision instead.

Morrissey

F#2–B4 · 2 octaves + 5



Baritone · full voice to G4 · UK · prominent since 1984 · known for “There Is a Light That Never Goes Out”

The great miserabilist croon: a plummy baritone that swoops, sighs and breaks into sudden falsetto yelps mid-word.

Croon first, then sabotage it. The core is an old-fashioned, rounded baritone with generous portamento between notes, closer to a 1950s balladeer than to punk, and the modern edge comes from interruptions: falsetto yelps, moans and octave flips dropped mid-phrase like italics. Vibrato is wide and unhurried. Practice sliding between chord tones with a completely relaxed jaw, then add one deliberate falsetto break per verse. The slides need real legato; without it the yelps have nothing to disrupt.

Michael Hutchence

B1–F#5 · 3 octaves + 7



Baritone · full voice to C5 · Australia · prominent since 1985 · known for “Never Tear Us Apart”

LOW B1 IN “EVERYTHING” · HIGH F#5 IN “ZERO-2-0”

Sultry, breathy baritone that purrs low and snarls high; swaggering pitch bends and raw, clean belts.

Seduction lives in the low register: a breathy, sing-talky baritone that purrs just above speech, with pitch bends and behind-the-beat phrasing doing the persuasion. The upper register is striking by contrast — clean yet raw belts up to C5, snarled vowels, and virtually no falsetto anywhere. Onsets are soft, consonants feline, dynamics built on restraint until the chorus opens. Students copying him overdo the breathiness and lose pitch core; the whisper quality sits on an exactly tuned center, and the swagger comes from rhythmic placement, not from volume.

Chris Cornell

E2–A5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to F#5 · USA · prominent since 1988 · known for “Black Hole Sun”

HIGH A5 IN “BEYOND THE WHEEL”

Grit-heavy tenor that stays connected into a high sustained scream; wide vibrato on held notes.

Grit sits on top of a fully connected chest tone rather than replacing it, so the rasp never costs him pitch. Onsets are firm, almost glottal, and vibrato arrives late and wide once a note has been held a while. Above the staff he keeps that F#5 belt in a narrowed vowel with a lot of twang instead of opening the throat. Reach for it as a shout and the squeeze takes the ring away.

Kurt Cobain

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Baritone USA · prominent since 1989 · known for “Smells Like Teen Spirit”

HIGH E5 IN “ANEURYSM”

Rasped baritone that shifts from muttered verses to a torn, throat-forward shout at the chorus.

Verses sit barely above speech, dry and without vibrato, the pitch center allowed to sag. The chorus arrives as a throat-forward shout built from a compressed vowel and hard consonants rather than raw volume, and the phrasing drags a fraction behind the beat. Going straight to full-force screaming sounds nothing like it and falls apart by the second chorus; the tone is loud speech held on a pitch.

Layne Staley

E2–G5 · 3 octaves + 3



Baritone USA · prominent since 1990 · known for “Man in the Box”

HIGH G5 IN “LOVE, HATE, LOVE”

Nasal-edged baritone with a heavy chest push; his stacked harmonies with Cantrell define the sound.

Nasal buzz carries the tone forward while the weight underneath stays thick and baritone-heavy, which is why the voice reads as pressed even at moderate volume. He holds long notes nearly straight, letting a slow wide vibrato in at the very end, and doubles himself in close harmony that demands identical vowels take after take. Copying the nasality by pinching the throat is the usual mistake — it belongs in the resonance, not the larynx.

Billy Corgan

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1991 · known for “1979”

Nasal, reedy tenor with a whining edge; cuts through dense guitars by placement, not volume.

Placement is high, forward and frankly nasal, with a reedy whine that cuts through loud guitars by frequency rather than volume. Tone stays straight, vibrato barely appears, and breaks in the line are left in rather than smoothed over. Rounding the sound to make it prettier removes the one quality that lets it be heard, and pushing air at the C5 belt turns that edge into strain.

Eddie Vedder

D2–E5 · 3 octaves + 2



Baritone · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1991 · known for “Alive”

Deep, rounded baritone with heavy vibrato and swallowed diction; sits low and pushes rather than lifts.

Everything is dark and back-placed, with a low larynx and vowels that close in on themselves, so words blur while the tone stays round. Vibrato is wide and starts almost immediately. The ringing part of the voice lives under that B4 belt; notes above it come out thinner and yelped rather than fuller. Chasing the depth by pressing the tongue down flattens pitch and kills what diction is left.

Scott Weiland

E2–C#5 · 2 octaves + 9



Baritone USA · prominent since 1992 · known for “Interstate Love Song”

Croon-to-snarl baritone, often filtered through a megaphone; leans on slides into the note.

Low phrases are crooned close to the mic, then the same line hardens into a snarl as it climbs toward C#5. Pitches get approached from underneath with an audible slide, and vibrato, when it comes at all, is narrow and quick. Overdone, that scoop makes every note arrive late; the slide should finish before the beat rather than on it, so the target pitch is already there when the syllable lands.

Thom Yorke

F2–F5 · 3 octaves



Tenor UK · prominent since 1992 · known for “Creep”

Light tenor that flips early into a thin, airy falsetto; small vibrato, softened consonants.

Weight stays light and the flip into falsetto happens early, well below where a tenor could still push, and that early flip is the character of the sound. Breath stays in the tone, consonants soften almost to nothing, and vibrato is small and shallow. Trying to keep chest voice alive all the way to that F5 is the usual error — the top is meant to thin out and go quiet, not open up.

Billie Joe Armstrong

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Basket Case”

Snarling nasal tenor with a put-on accent; a narrow band worked hard, almost entirely in chest.

A narrow band worked hard — nearly all of it chest, from F2 up to around C5 — with a nasal snarl and a stylized vowel shift that bends words away from his speaking accent. Tone is straight, with almost no vibrato, and onsets clip tight to the guitar's eighth notes. Copying this means committing to the sneer; sung prettily, the notes survive and the entire character disappears.

Jeff Buckley

E2–D6 · 3 octaves + 10



Tenor full voice to F5 USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Hallelujah”

HIGH D6 IN “GRACE”

Very wide tenor with seamless falsetto shifts, long melisma, and near-whispered dynamic drops.

Listen for how little seam there is between mix and falsetto: the shift happens inside a vowel rather than between notes, which is what lets long melismatic runs stay even. Dynamics drop to almost nothing and rebuild, audible throughout his reading of Hallelujah, and vibrato arrives late and narrow. Height comes from releasing pressure, not adding it — students push for the top and the ornaments stiffen into steps.

Rivers Cuomo

Eb2–G5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Say It Ain't So”

LOW EB2 IN “OOH” · HIGH G5 IN “DEVOTION”

Plain-spoken, boyish tenor; deadpan verses, power-chord-wide choruses, and clean falsetto tops.

Plainness is deliberate: a boyish, unaffected tenor delivered almost without vibrato, singing melodic leaps with the flat affect of someone reading aloud. The tone is clean and slightly nasal, diction precise, dynamics restrained even when the guitars are enormous. Falsetto is pure and unadorned, used for tops rather than drama, with full voice reaching G5 when a chorus demands it. Copying students add expression and miss the point — the charm is the deadpan, so the pitch must be exact, the rhythm square, and every phrase completely unornamented.

Alanis Morissette

B2–C6 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano Canada · prominent since 1995 · known for “You Oughta Know”

Mezzo with hard consonants, sudden yelps into head voice, and heavy pitch bending on long notes.

Consonants land hard and early, words crowd ahead of the beat, and long notes get bent well off center before resolving. Sudden yelps jump into a bright head voice, sometimes an octave above where the phrase was sitting. Those bends work only because they start and finish on pitch; students slide vaguely and land nowhere, then copy the nasal edge by squeezing rather than placing it forward.

Chino Moreno

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “Change (In the House of Flies)”

Tenor split between a soft, breathy falsetto and a raw shout, often layered in one phrase.

Contrast is the technique: a soft, airy head tone at low volume in one bar, a raw open shout in the next, sometimes stacked across the same phrase. The quiet side needs steady airflow and no pressing at all. Full voice stops around D5, and what sits higher is distorted rather than sung. Students switch the shout on first and never build the soft half that gives it meaning.

Shirley Manson

F3–A5 · 2 octaves + 4



Contralto · UK · prominent since 1995 · known for “Only Happy When It Rains”

Smoky low contralto, half-spoken in the verses, opening into a flat, cool-toned belt.

Smoke and breath fill the low third of the voice, half-spoken through verses, consonants sneered rather than articulated cleanly. The lift into a chorus adds volume and brightness but keeps the same cool, uninvested affect, and vibrato stays minimal by choice. Warm it up with swell and emotion and the detachment that makes the delivery land goes with it.

Fiona Apple

C3–A5 · 2 octaves + 9



Contralto USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Criminal”

Contralto anchored in a husky low register; conversational timing with sudden gravel on peaks.

Speech shapes the phrasing — timing stretches and compresses against the beat, and diction stays crisp even at the husky bottom of the range. Weight is chest-heavy with a low, settled larynx, and gravel shows up only at the peaks of a line, then clears. Smoothing it into legato is the error; the lines are meant to arrive unevenly, with abrupt dynamic surges instead of a steady swell.

Brandon Boyd

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor full voice to D5 USA · prominent since 1997 · known for “Drive”

Warm tenor with a loose, breathy falsetto and scooped phrasing; light attack on consonants.

Warmth comes from a relaxed jaw and aspirate onsets: notes are breathed into rather than struck, often scooped up from just below. Above D5 he lets go into a loose, unpressed falsetto with obvious air in it, and rhythm sits slightly behind the beat, close to conversation. The common error is hitting consonants hard, then squeezing the falsetto to match chest volume; it should get lighter, not louder.

Serj Tankian

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Baritone · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1998 · known for “Chop Suey!”

Operatic-leaning baritone with fast register jumps, trills, and pinched nasal placement.

Wide leaps between a heavy chest bottom and a pinched, bright head tone happen fast and land exactly on the beat — the theatrics are metrically strict. Add trills, staccato glottal attacks, exaggerated vowel shapes, and syllables fired at speed. Copy the character and the rhythm is the first thing to go. The full-voice ceiling sits near B4; everything above it is deliberately narrow and forward rather than powered.

Chester Bennington

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2000 · known for “In the End”

HIGH A5 IN “GIVEN UP”

Clean tenor with a rasp layer and screamed extension; abrupt switch between sung and torn tone.

Two tones operate here and they work as separate systems. Underneath is a bright, cleanly supported tenor with precise onsets and nearly straight tone up to that E5 belt; over it sits a distorted scream that reaches higher without the clean voice going with it. Manufacturing the rasp in the throat itself muddies both — the clean line has to stay intact underneath the distortion.

Julian Casablancas

C2–F#5 · 3 octaves + 6



Baritone · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “Last Nite”

LOW C2 IN “OFF TO WAR” · HIGH F#5 IN “ONE WAY TRIGGER”

Distorted megaphone baritone croon; slurred cool in the verses, strained top-of-chest cries in choruses.

Distortion frames this baritone: a filtered, megaphone-style croon that sits low, slurred, and detached, with melody delivered through half-closed vowels. The natural instrument underneath is warm and surprisingly precise, sliding between notes with controlled portamento. Climaxes push into a strained top-of-chest cry around E5, and later material leans on a soft, pure falsetto. Students copying the cool usually go flat and call it style; the detachment rides on accurate pitch centers, and the strain in the high cries is a placed, supported sound rather than an accident.

Gerard Way

F#2–F#5 · 3 octaves



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Welcome to the Black Parade”

LOW F#2 IN “DRUGSTORE PERFUME” · HIGH F#5 IN “HONEY, THIS MIRROR ISN'T BIG ENOUGH FOR THE TWO OF US”

Nasal, theatrical tenor that swings from croon to ragged yell; drama in every consonant.

Theatricality shapes every phrase: exaggerated diction, wide dynamic swings, and a nasal, forward buzz that reads clearly over distorted guitars. Chest voice carries most of the range, from soft croon to ragged, distorted yelling, with belts around E5 delivered on spread, defiant vowels. Vibrato is irregular and expressive rather than polished. The common copying error is manufacturing rasp in the throat; the grit here rides on top of a supported, forward tone, and the melodrama comes from consonant emphasis and dynamic contrast, not from constant full-volume singing.

Patrick Stump

C3–B5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Sugar, We're Goin Down”

Pop-punk's secret soul singer: a slurred, syllable-dense delivery hiding a genuinely agile, Elvis Costello-meets-Motown tenor.

Diction is the disguise. Words blur together in a slurred rush, but the pitch underneath is exact, and the voice is a real soul tenor: high mixed belts to C5, quick turns at phrase ends, and a falsetto he can snap into at full speed. The slur removes the theatre-kid crispness that would fight the genre. Learn the melody clean first, then deliberately smear the consonants while keeping every pitch center. Smearing pitch and diction together is just mumbling.

Alex Turner

E2–G5 · 3 octaves + 3

Tenor UK · prominent since 2006 · known for “Do I Wanna Know?”

LOW E2 IN “WHY'D YOU ONLY CALL ME WHEN YOU'RE HIGH?” · HIGH G5 IN “FOUR OUT OF FIVE”

Louche croon with lazy slides, thick Sheffield vowels, and a smoky falsetto reserved for late-night hooks.

Crooning defines the approach: a low, lazy delivery built on slides, scoops, and back-of-the-mouth vowels that blur one word into the next. The chest voice is warm and conversational, sitting in a narrow comfortable band, with portamento doing the expressive work instead of vibrato. Falsetto arrives as a deliberate contrast — soft, distant, slightly detached. Students copying him often exaggerate the slur until pitch centers vanish; the slides actually land precisely on target, and the swagger comes from timing behind the beat, not from approximate tuning.

Kellin Quinn

B2–A5 · 2 octaves + 10

Tenor USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “If You Can't Hang”

LOW B2 IN “BLOOD LINES”

Piercing, boyish high tenor that lives above the staff, flipping between bright belts and feathery falsetto.

Height defines everything: a light tenor mixed far forward into the nose and cheekbones, living naturally where most voices strain. He treats the fifth octave as home tessitura, alternating a ringing, twangy mix with quick flips into breathy falsetto, often inside a single word. Vibrato is light and fast; onsets are clean, occasionally cracked on purpose for emotional effect. Runs stay simple; the appeal is placement, not melisma. Students reach up to these lines from chest and shout; the part only works from a heady, small-mouthed mix built on twang.

Tyler Joseph

A2–F6 · 3 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Stressed Out”

LOW A2 IN “NEXT SEMESTER” · HIGH F6 IN “LET ME DO IT FOR YOU”

Reedy, conversational tenor that jumps from rap cadence to strained-on-purpose belts and airy falsetto hooks.

Speech-level singing is the foundation here: rap cadence, sung hooks, and shouted climaxes all sit on the same conversational placement. The tone is reedy and slightly nasal, with fast, tight phrasing and almost no vibrato until a note is sustained. Belts around D5 are bright, twangy, and deliberately strained-sounding, while the falsetto above is thin and airy. A student copying the strain literally will blow out quickly — the distress is acted through vowel shading and dynamics, not through actual throat squeeze, and the support underneath stays constant.

Mitski

E3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 2



Soprano · USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “Nobody”

Restrained indie soprano — clean, steady, almost vibratoless lines that break into raw chest cries.

Stillness is the discipline: Mitski holds long, even tones with minimal vibrato, placing the voice in a clear, unornamented middle that reads as calm until it doesn't. Climaxes push into open chest toward F#5, slightly raw by design, while verses sit low near E3 in a darkened, rounded timbre. Onsets are soft, releases unadorned. The common error in imitation is adding expression; her power is subtraction — perfectly level lines that make the eventual crack devastating.

NEXT Metal →

13 Metal

Metal is where rock's altitude arms race went professional. The air-raid sirens in this chapter sustain pitches, night after night, that classic rock visited on special occasions — and the entries make clear how: this is trained singing, head voice and reinforced mix developed with an athlete's discipline, far closer to operatic production than the leather suggests. The genre even reimported opera directly, in the symphonic wing's classically schooled sopranos, making this the one chapter where conservatory technique and blast beats share a stage.

The other pole is the low theatre: growls, screams and bass-baritone menace. The sustainable versions documented here are false-cord techniques — noise generated above the folds while the instrument underneath stays healthy — and the entries treat them as the skilled work they are. Between the poles sit the shape-shifters who cover the whole map in one set, clean to brutal and back, which may be the most complete technical package in modern singing.

Two things to take from this chapter even if you never sing a note of metal. First, vowel discipline: extreme range at extreme volume forces narrow, consistent vowels, and every entry's altitude depends on them. Second, the scheduling: metal singers tour harder than almost anyone, and the durable ones ration their extremes with actuarial precision — the highest scream and the lowest growl appear where the set needs them, not wherever enthusiasm strikes. That is the safety chapter's whole argument, demonstrated at the sport's highest level.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Ozzy Osbourne

G2–D5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor UK · prominent since 1970 · known for “Crazy Train”

Thin nasal tenor with a pleading edge; narrow span, but the timbre cuts through dense guitars.

Narrow span, unmistakable colour. The placement is thin and nasal with a pleading upward edge, and it cuts through thick guitars precisely because it is not big. Notes get scooped into from below, vibrato is slow and shallow, and sustains stay level in dynamic rather than swelling. With nothing reaching past D5, the character lives entirely in timbre and phrasing. Students overweight it and lose the whine that makes it read.

Rob Halford

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor full voice to D5 UK · prominent since 1974 · known for “Breaking the Law”

HIGH C6 IN “PAINKILLER”

Moves from gritted chest snarl into piercing falsetto shrieks with almost no audible seam.

The gap between the D5 belt and the C6 top is the whole map of this voice. Below it, gritted chest tone with hard consonant attacks and a snarl layered onto an already supported note. Above it, he releases into a thin, piercing falsetto and rides it, so the shriek carries without weight. Most singers try to muscle that top note in chest, and the line gives out before the verse is over.

Ronnie James Dio

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “Holy Diver”

Chest-dominant power, fast narrow vibrato, vowels stay focused even at full volume.

Chest voice carries nearly everything here, with vowels kept small and focused so the tone stays clear at full volume. Vibrato is fast and narrow, and it starts almost as soon as a note lands rather than blooming late. Attacks are clean instead of scooped, and phrases end deliberately rather than trailing off. Copying it usually goes wrong in the jaw: singers open too wide, the tone spreads, and the pitch centre slides.

Glenn Danzig

C#2–Eb5 · 3 octaves + 2



Baritone full voice to C#5 USA · prominent since 1977 · known for “Mother”

LOW C#2 IN “CAT PEOPLE (PUTTING OUT THE FIRE)” · HIGH EB5 IN “SKINCARVER”

Bluesy, brooding croon-to-howl — an Elvis-shaped baritone soaked in doom and punk menace.

Elvis phrasing, punk engine: a chesty baritone crooned through rounded, retro vowels, with a wide lounge-singer vibrato snapped shut by hard glottal accents. He belts through the fourth octave to C#5 on pure chest, adding rasp by overdriving fold closure rather than false-fold layering, which gives the growl its bluesy, vocal-cord bite. Melisma is minimal; lines swing in long crooned arcs punctuated by barked releases. The classic student error is imitating the sneer instead of the support; the swagger is a byproduct of huge, steady airflow.

Bruce Dickinson

E2–C6 · 3 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to G5 · UK · prominent since 1979 · known for “The Number of the Beast”

HIGH C6 IN “THE NUMBER OF THE BEAST”

Air-raid-siren tenor: forward placement, wide vibrato, holds high belts without thinning out.

Listen for the brass in the tone: a narrow, forward placement that stays bright rather than dark, with vibrato that often arrives late and then widens. Chest connection holds all the way up to the G5 belt, and the C6 wails sit above that as a thinner, siren-like extension. Students imitating him squeeze the throat for volume. The sound comes from a supported cry and a tall, narrow vowel instead.

King Diamond

F2–D6 · 3 octaves + 9



Countertenor · full voice to C5 · Denmark · prominent since 1981 · known for “Welcome Home”

Two voices in one part: clipped mid-range narration against thin, wailing falsetto shrieks.

A dry, clipped mid-range handles the narrative lines, then the same phrase leaps into thin, edgy falsetto for shrieks that climb well above the C5 belt. The flip has to be released rather than pushed, so reaching for it from a pressed throat never quite arrives. That falsetto is deliberately weightless, closer to a whistle edge than to force, and a fast flickering vibrato keeps it moving.

Geoff Tate

E2–C6 · 3 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1983 · known for “Silent Lucidity”

HIGH C6 IN “QUEEN OF THE REICH”

Trained-sounding tenor: even legato, ringing sustain, more classical vowel shaping than most.

Rounded, classically placed vowels sit closer to art song than to shouting, carried on even legato with a long ringing sustain. Full weight stops at the B4 belt; above it the tone thins deliberately into head voice, which is what keeps the fifth- and sixth-octave notes controlled instead of strained. Vibrato is measured and often delayed. Where imitators add pressure, he adds space.

James Hetfield

E2–C5 · 2 octaves + 8



Baritone · USA · prominent since 1983 · known for “Enter Sandman”

Rhythmic consonant-driven baritone, raspy edge, phrasing clipped tight to the riff.

Rhythm is the instrument here. Consonants land on the riff like a picking hand, syllables get clipped short, and the tone is a mid-baritone with a dry rasp rather than a smooth sustain. Notes are often approached from underneath with a quick bend and then cut off. Copying it fails when singers stretch the vowels: the moment the phrasing loosens off the guitar figure, the whole effect disappears.

Michael Kiske

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to D5 · Germany · prominent since 1987 · known for “I Want Out”

Bright, boyish high tenor that stays connected and vibrato-light through fifth-octave lines.

The high tenor placement stays bright without going thin, connected through the D5 belt and ringing in a boyish way rather than shouting. Vibrato is sparse, so long notes hold nearly straight and only shimmer as they release, and fifth-octave lines arrive on even legato instead of a scream. Chasing the brightness on its own pushes it into the nose, where the low overtones that keep the tone round drop away.

Mike Patton

Eb1–Eb7 · 6 octaves



Baritone · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1989 · known for “Epic”

Six cited octaves of extended technique: growls, croons, falsetto squeals, throat-noise texture.

Guttural growls, close-mic crooning, falsetto squeals, throat noise and character voices swap inside the space of a bar, so extended technique is the material rather than a decoration on it. The crooned baritone in the middle is the anchor everything departs from and returns to. Across a cited Eb1 to Eb7, most of that span comes from switching mode instead of stretching chest voice, and the pitch accuracy underneath the noises is the part that gets skipped.

Sebastian Bach

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to C5 · Canada · prominent since 1989 · known for “18 and Life”

Rasp-heavy high tenor that sustains fifth-octave belts, then slips up into scream falsetto.

Rasp is baked into the tone rather than added at the ends of phrases, sitting on a high tenor that holds a sustained C5 belt and then slips upward into a scream that is really reinforced falsetto. Vibrato is wide and arrives late, after the note has been held straight for a beat or more. Students go for the scream cold. It only works launched from an already connected, well-supported belt.

Peter Steele

F1–G5 · 4 octaves + 2



Bass-baritone · full voice to G#4 · USA · prominent since 1991 · known for “Black No. 1”

LOW F1 IN “CINNAMON GIRL” · HIGH G5 IN “XERO TOLERANCE”

Cavernous bass-baritone rumble — a gothic crooner's drawl that sinks to subterranean lows.

Depth here is architecture, not effect: a true low voice resonating in an unusually long vocal tract, sung with lazy, legato onsets and a crooner's micro-vibrato. He parks the larynx low and lets subglottal space do the amplifying, down to F1 at the extreme. Full voice tops out around G#4 before deliberate distortion takes over for dramatic peaks. Phrasing drags languidly behind the beat, vowels stretched wide. Students chase the lows by pressing down; the notes only speak when the throat stays open, the volume modest, and the air slow.

Devin Townsend

F2–C6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to C5 · Canada · prominent since 1993 · known for “Kingdom”

HIGH C6 IN “KINGDOM”

Stacked wall-of-voice belt plus harsh screams; swings from near-whisper to full-throated push.

Near-whispered breathy phrases open out into a wall of stacked belted layers, and harsh screaming stays a separate texture rather than a colour applied to the belt. Layering does much of the work on record, so one voice trying to match that size pushes far too hard. Full weight tops out around C5, the C6 material is carried lighter and thinner above it, and vowels stay wide through the big sustains.

Maynard James Keenan

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor · USA · prominent since 1993 · known for “Sober”

Breath-controlled tenor: long even sustains, rasp saved for the peak of a phrase.

Long sustains hold steady from first moment to last, with very little vibrato until the release, which puts breath management out front as the thing you notice. Rasp is rationed, so the line stays clean and covered until edge arrives right at the peak of a phrase. Phrasing floats loosely across the accompaniment instead of locking to the downbeat. Grit applied everywhere flattens that contrast completely.

Jonathan Davis

A1–F#5 · 3 octaves + 9



Baritone · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Freak on a Leash”

LOW A1 IN “DEAD BODIES EVERYWHERE” · HIGH F#5 IN “DEAD BODIES EVERYWHERE”

Shape-shifting nu-metal voice: breathy croons, scatted syllables, growls and anguished high wails from one throat.

Registration whiplash defines this instrument: breathy, low-larynx croons drop into pitched fry at the bottom, flip into throat-wide growls, then leap to keening cries around C5. His scat passages are percussive nonsense syllables driven by diaphragm pulses, closer to beatboxing than melody. Distortion comes from false-fold rattle layered over real pitch, so even the barks track the key. Phrasing lurches deliberately between whisper and wail with almost no vibrato. Students copying the growls usually grind their true folds; the aggression must sit above the tone, never inside it.

Till Lindemann

E2–F4 · 2 octaves + 1



Bass-baritone · full voice to D4 · Germany · prominent since 1995 · known for “Du Hast”

Rammstein's granite bass-baritone: rolled Rs, machine-press diction and a low register that functions as percussion.

Consonants are the star. The famous rolled R and hyper-plosive German diction turn every line into rhythm-section material, delivered on a deep, dark, deliberately monotone bass-baritone that moves in small steps and almost never ornaments. When intensity rises he adds a controlled growl at the onset, not a scream. Drill the alveolar roll until it starts instantly on any vowel, and keep the pitch line flat and heavy. Melodrama in the melody would puncture the menace; the flatness is the theatre.

Tarja Turunen

F3–E6 · 2 octaves + 11



Soprano Finland · prominent since 1996 · known for “Nemo”

Classically placed soprano over distorted guitar: covered vowels, vibrato-rich head voice.

Classical habits stay intact over distorted guitar. Vowels are covered, the larynx sits low and settled, and vibrato runs continuously through a whole note instead of appearing at the end of it. The tone stays covered as it climbs rather than opening out bright, and the top of the range is sung in head voice with no shout in it. Diction stays rounded throughout, and pushing chest voice too high is what costs imitators that covered colour.

Ville Valo

F#1–B5 · 4 octaves + 5



Baritone full voice to G4 Finland · prominent since 1997 · known for “The Funeral of Hearts”

HIGH B5 IN “DON'T SHAKE ME LUCIFER”

Dark romantic baritone that plunges to cellar lows and lifts into airy falsetto without losing its gloom.

Gloom rides on technique: a low baritone placed back in the pharynx for shadow, sung with soft, almost sighed onsets and a slow, romantic vibrato. He caps full voice around G4, then floats an unusually connected falsetto for everything above, which is why the top never sounds strained. Lows down to F#1 are released, not pushed; minimal air pressure, maximal resonance. Phrasing is legato to the point of liquid, consonants softened. Students copying him push chest too high and crack; the register handoff has to happen early and quietly.

Corey Taylor

E2–A5 · 3 octaves + 5



Baritone USA · prominent since 1999 · known for “Duality”

Grit-heavy mid baritone that flips to shredded screams and back to clean nasal-forward melody.

Grit sits on top of a genuine mid-baritone core, and the two modes trade off inside a single line: shredded scream on the aggressive phrase, then a clean, nasal-forward melodic tone with almost no rasp on the hook. Onsets are hard and consonant-led. The clean half is harder to copy than it sounds, since going straight for the distortion drops the support underneath it and the result reads as strain rather than weight.

David Draiman

Bb1–G#5 · 3 octaves + 10



Baritone full voice to G5 USA · prominent since 2000 · known for “Down with the Sickness”

LOW BB1 IN “HAUNTED” · HIGH G#5 IN “WALK”

Percussive, staccato snarl over a dark baritone core, with machine-tight rhythmic phrasing and sustained distorted highs.

Staccato compression is the engine here: clipped, percussive onsets fired in rhythmic runs, each syllable glottally articulated like a drum hit. The core tone is a dark baritone placed in the chest and pharynx, with distortion generated by false-fold engagement over a stable clean fold line, which is why the snarl never wrecks the pitch. Sustains bloom into a wide, slow vibrato. Full voice runs remarkably high, with documented tops near G5. Imitators bark from the throat and lose the meter; the style demands abdominal snap and a relaxed jaw.

M. Shadows

D2–A5 · 3 octaves + 7



Baritone · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 2003 · known for “Bat Country”

HIGH A5 IN “BEAST AND THE HARLOT”

Gritty baritone snarl that rides metalcore riffs with a chesty rasp and surprisingly agile high belts.

A dense, chesty mix drives this voice: baritone weight carried to C5 with a rasp added at the fold level, not layered on afterward. He compresses hard, keeping the larynx stable while grit rides the tone's edge. Falsetto up to A5 appears only in distant overdubs. Phrasing is riff-locked and consonant-forward, with short, punched onsets. Singers imitating him squeeze the throat to fake the rasp and shred their tone; the distortion works because the underlying mix stays balanced and the air stays compressed, never breathy.

Simone Simons

G3–C#6 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · Netherlands · prominent since 2003 · known for “Cry for the Moon”

Warm, smoky mezzo with classical polish, floating head-voice highs over symphonic walls of sound.

Classical scaffolding supports a fundamentally contemporary mezzo: raised palate, low breath anchoring, and a warm chest register that she blends upward through a seamless middle mix into rounded head voice. Vibrato is trained, medium-speed, and applied selectively; straight tone for verses, spin for sustained peaks. She avoids hard belting, preferring to let head resonance carry volume over dense orchestration. The student error is darkening artificially to sound operatic; her color comes from vowel shape and breath depth, not a depressed larynx. Work the messa di voce before the high phrases.

Myles Kennedy

Bb1–D6 · 4 octaves + 4



Tenor · full voice to F#5 · USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Blackbird”

LOW BB1 IN “COME TO LIFE” · HIGH D6 IN “TRAVELLING RIVERSIDE BLUES”

Bright, laser-focused tenor that stays clean and controlled from bluesy lows to ringing fifth-octave belts.

Bel canto discipline underpins this tenor: a lifted soft palate, narrow vowels, and a forward, nasal-leaning placement that keeps the tone clean rather than rasped. He belts through F#5 on a supported mix, reserving true falsetto for ornamental peaks up to D6. Vibrato is even and late-arriving, onsets are legato and unforced. Students copying him usually spread the vowel and push chest weight upward; the sound depends on resonance, not pressure, and on patient breath pacing across long ascending phrases.

Oli Sykes

Eb2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · UK · prominent since 2006 · known for “Can You Feel My Heart”

LOW EB2 IN “PARASITE EVE” · HIGH G#5 IN “WONDERFUL LIFE”

Torn-paper screams beside fragile, confessional cleans — an emo-metal voice built on texture over polish.

Texture outranks polish: the harsh vocabulary spans false-fold screams, pitched fry, and mid-range shouts, all riding real pitch centers rather than noise, while the cleans stay deliberately plain; thin, slightly flat-footed, and confessional, topping out around Bb4. Onsets in clean passages are breathy; in harsh passages the distortion starts above the folds before the vowel opens. Phrasing favors blunt, spoken rhythm over melisma. The student error is scraping the true cords to copy the screams and shouting the cleans; both modes depend on low air pressure and a relaxed, open throat.

Ronnie Radke

D2–G5 · 3 octaves + 5

Tenor USA · prominent since 2006 · known for “Popular Monster”

LOW D2 IN “BROKEN” · HIGH G5 IN “I WASH CARS”

Elastic tenor that swerves from rapped verses to glossy pop hooks to full-throated post-hardcore highs.

Genre-hopping demands modular technique, and this tenor has it: rapped verses ride speech-level compression with crisp consonant attack, pop choruses brighten into a twangy, forward mix, and post-hardcore climaxes add false-fold grit over sustained pitch. Transitions land mid-line without audible gear changes, which is the hard part. Vibrato stays narrow and sparing; onsets are precise even at conversational speed. The student trap is treating each mode as a different voice; his registration stays constant while resonance and distortion swap on top, so drill the clean mix first, then bolt on the effects.

Andy Biersack

D2–F5 · 3 octaves + 3

Baritone USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “In the End”

LOW D2 IN “RIBCAGE” · HIGH F5 IN “SHADOWS DIE”

Deep, resonant rock baritone — crypt-low verses that swell into anthemic, fist-up choruses.

Low resonance carries the brand: a young, dark baritone sung from the chest with the larynx relaxed and vowels rounded toward speech. Verses sit deliberately deep, almost spoken, with firm glottal onsets; choruses lift into an anthemic, open-throated call built for crowd doubling rather than agility. Vibrato is minimal, sustains straight and broad. Falsetto appears only as decoration at phrase tops. The usual mistake is manufacturing depth by swallowing the tone; his lows project because the sound stays forward and the jaw stays loose, even at the bottom of the staff.

Tobias Forge

D2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 6



Baritone · full voice to D5 · Sweden · prominent since 2010 · known for “Square Hammer”

LOW D2 IN “DARKNESS AT THE HEART OF MY LOVE” · HIGH G#5 IN “LIFE ETERNAL”

Suave, theatrical baritone croon — pop smoothness draped over doomy riffs, rising to keening falsetto peaks.

Croon first, metal second: the baritone sits mid-larynx with rounded, Europop vowels, gentle legato onsets, and a fast flicker of vibrato at phrase ends. Chest voice carries melody up to about D5 before he pivots to a heady falsetto for peaks near G#5, always landing the flip on a vowel, never a consonant. Dynamics stay conversational; drama comes from arrangement, not push. Singers copying him oversell the theatricality and go operatic; the recorded voice is intimate, slightly nasal, and disciplined about vowel consistency across register shifts.

Elize Ryd

E3–F#6 · 3 octaves + 2



Soprano Sweden · prominent since 2011 · known for “Drop Dead Cynical”

LOW E3 IN “O HELGA NATT” · HIGH F#6 IN “DO OR DIE”

Gleaming pop-soprano sheen over djent-tight riffs, with sky-high head notes and dance-floor phrasing.

Pop technique at metal tempo: a light soprano mixed high into the mask, bright EQ, tight fast vibrato, and rhythmic, dance-music phrasing that lands squarely on the grid. She belts with a thin, twangy edge rather than weight, then releases into head voice for the top octave, keeping vowels narrow so pitch stays locked at speed. Onsets are clean and clipped for stacked studio harmonies. Imitators bring rock heaviness up the scale and go flat under the tempo; the style requires agility, forward placement, and disciplined breath economy over brute power.

Noah Sebastian

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Baritone USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “Just Pretend”

LOW A2 IN “THE FOUNTAIN” · HIGH D5 IN “THE LETDOWN”

Smoky, restrained baritone that glides between whispered R&B-tinged cleans and razored metalcore screams.

Breath is the primary color here: a low-set, darkened baritone delivered with deliberate air across the cord closure, pop-style microphone intimacy, and minimal vibrato. Cleans sit in a narrow, speech-level band with soft, aspirate onsets; screams are produced above the folds with false-fold distortion while the pitch center stays put. He phrases behind the beat, letting consonants smear for mood. The common mistake is whispering instead of supporting; his airiness rides full compression underneath. Copy the breath control and low placement before attempting the distorted layers.

Tatiana Shmayluk

A2–G5 · 2 octaves + 10

Mezzo-soprano Ukraine · prominent since 2016 · known for “Pisces”

LOW A2 IN “COPYCAT” · HIGH G5 IN “SCISSORS”

Instant-switch voice: guttural growls flip to glassy, bright cleans mid-bar with unsettling ease.

Two engines share one chassis: a bright, forward clean voice with fast, narrow vibrato, and a battery of false-fold growls, gutturals, and pitched fry underneath. The switch is the trick; she flips between them mid-phrase with no reset breath, keeping the larynx loose so neither mode contaminates the other. Cleans are placed in the mask with crisp, almost pop diction; harsh tones are shaped by tongue and pharynx rather than volume. Students force the growl from the throat and blow out the cleans; hers work because each system trains separately, then interleaves.

Josh Kiszka

C3–C#6 · 3 octaves + 1

Tenor USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Highway Tune”

LOW C3 IN “THE OCEAN” · HIGH C#6 IN “THE COLD WIND”

Reedy, banshee-bright wail straight from the Plant school — piercing high cries over boogie riffs.

Wail placement rules: a compact tenor squeezed into an intensely bright, nasal channel, with heavy twang and a high tongue creating the siren-like cut. He sustains full-voice cries high above the staff, tips into falsetto for peaks near C#6, and decorates with fast blues curls and yelped octave leaps. Vibrato is quick and shallow; onsets often slide upward into the note. Volume is loud but the mechanism is small. Students imitate the sound by screaming wide-mouthed and blow out; the cry comes from narrowing, not force, with the soft palate high and air metered.

NEXT The soul men →

V PART

Soul, R&B and gospel

14 The soul men 175

15 The soul and R&B women 193

16 Modern R&B 208

17 Gospel and a cappella 233

CONTENTS

14 The soul men

Almost every voice in this chapter learned its trade in church, and it shows in the shared toolkit: call-and-response phrasing, melisma as testimony rather than decoration, the shout built and released like a sermon's climax, and the falsetto — soul's great signature — floated above the congregation as the sound of feeling exceeding words. When the entries here describe a run, a delayed resolution, or a note bent on approach, they are describing gospel technique wearing a secular suit, and every genre in this book from country to K-pop has picked its pockets.

The chapter divides by register strategy. The high tenors pushed chest voice to its ceiling and lived there, urgent and bright. The falsetto specialists made the top floor the main residence. The velvet baritones — soul's quiet aristocracy — did the opposite work, perfecting warmth, diction and restraint at speech pitch. And the shouters ran the full gospel dynamic arc in every song. Where entries give a full-voice ceiling, reading those ceilings side by side is a lesson in how many different machines can produce the same emotional result; most entries in this chapter give none, and for those the technique paragraph is the better guide.

What transfers most cheaply from this chapter is timing. Soul phrasing — behind the beat, conversational, syllables placed like a drummer's ghost notes — can be practiced by any voice at any volume, and the entries repeatedly identify it as the trait imitators miss while they chase

the runs. Learn one verse's timing exactly before touching a single ornament; that order is the chapter's consensus advice.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Ray Charles

C2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 10

Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 1954 · known for “Georgia on My Mind”

Gospel-schooled tenor with a rough edge, bending pitch and dragging behind the beat on purpose.

Nasal-forward, grainy tone that keeps a cry in it even at low volume. Notes get approached from underneath, bent through the blues third, then released with a narrow, quick vibrato that only shows up at the end of a phrase. Words sit behind the beat on purpose. Above the A4 belt the sound tightens instead of opening out. Students copy the rasp by squeezing the throat; the grit belongs in the tone, not in the grip.

James Brown

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7

Baritone · USA · prominent since 1956 · known for “I Got You (I Feel Good)”

Shouted baritone used as percussion; screams and grunts placed on the beat.

Placement carries more of the load than melody. Most of the singing happens inside a narrow band of the baritone range, shouted with a hard glottal attack, and the grunts, yelps and short rasped bursts are struck like drum hits on specific beats. Sustained notes are rare; energy comes from repetition and rhythmic accent. Copy the screams without the timing and the whole thing collapses, and what should stay short and punchy gets oversung.

Jackie Wilson

A2–C#6 · 3 octaves + 4

Tenor USA · prominent since 1957 · known for “Higher and Higher”

LOW A2 IN “WHAT KIND OF FOOL AM I?” · HIGH C#6 IN “BABY WORKOUT”

Ringing, vibrato-rich soul tenor with operatic swoops and full-voice altitude.

Operatic power in a rhythm-and-blues frame: a ringing tenor with fast, wide vibrato, immaculate legato, and high full-voice attacks that never thin out. He swoops into notes from below, ornaments with rapid turns, and shifts from croon to shout inside a single bar. The larynx stays remarkably free at the extremes. Students copying him try to muscle the top notes; his altitude comes from released, forward resonance and a vibrato that keeps the tone spinning instead of locking.

Sam Cooke

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7

Tenor USA · prominent since 1957 · known for “A Change Is Gonna Come”

Clean gospel-trained tenor; yodel-like turns and easy legato instead of grit.

Clarity does the work here: even airflow, clean onsets, and long connected lines with almost no rasp. The signature move is a yodel-like turn that hops briefly into a lighter register and back inside a single syllable, used as punctuation at the end of a phrase. Vibrato is even and modest. Reaching for grit to sound soulful is backwards here; the feeling comes from pitch accuracy, breath control, and where the turn lands.

Curtis Mayfield

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor USA · prominent since 1958 · known for “Move On Up”

High, thin tenor sung mostly in a floated falsetto with very little vibrato.

Almost everything stays in the light register: thin, sweet, gentle breathy onsets, and a tone left nearly straight. Absence of vibrato is a choice, not a limitation; it keeps the vocal sitting calmly on top of busy rhythm sections. Lines stay high in the staff and stay quiet, relying on the microphone for size. Two habits ruin an imitation: adding chest weight to feel more powerful, and adding vibrato to feel more expressive.

Smokey Robinson

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor USA · prominent since 1960 · known for “The Tracks of My Tears”

Feathery high tenor; falsetto entries so smooth the register change is hard to hear.

The whole line rides on very little air pressure, feathery and placed well forward. The crossing into falsetto is blended so smoothly you hear a change in color rather than a break, which takes a steady breath and a resistance to getting louder as the line rises. Phrases arch long and stay legato, with a small vibrato appearing only at the end. Trying to add volume at the transition is the fastest way to make the seam audible.

Marvin Gaye

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “What's Going On”

Three voices in one: growl at the bottom, smooth mid, airy falsetto layered over the top.

Three distinct colors get used as separate instruments: a gritty low register near F2, a warm smooth middle, and a breathy falsetto floated on top toward Bb5. Onsets are soft and aspirate, almost sighed into place, and phrases lean slightly behind the beat. Vibrato is narrow and arrives late. The common mistake is powering the falsetto; it works because it stays quiet and airy against the fuller mid voice.

Otis Redding

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Baritone USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “(Sittin' On) The Dock of the Bay”

Raspy, pushed baritone that stammers and repeats phrases to build pressure.

A thick baritone driven hard, with rasp riding on top of the tone rather than replacing it. Onsets are often glottal, words get stammered and repeated to build pressure, and lines push slightly ahead of the beat so the band sounds like it is chasing the singer. The top of the range is shouted, not floated. The grit is not throat scrape; it comes from breath compression and bright forward vowels, and it should never hurt.

Bobby Hatfield

B2–Eb6 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor USA · prominent since 1963 · known for “Unchained Melody”

LOW B2 IN “IS IT SO WRONG” · HIGH EB6 IN “IF I ASKED YOU”

High, glassy tenor built for long climbing arcs that crest in floated head voice.

Silver-toned high tenor specializing in the long climb: phrases built as single arcs that start low and crest in ringing head voice. His vibrato is slow and even, his onsets clean, and his top notes float rather than punch, extending into a pure head register at the extreme. Melisma is sparse and always structural. Students copying him grab at the climax note; the climb must be paced by breath, each step legato, so the peak arrives with air to spare.

Stevie Wonder

C2–E6 · 4 octaves + 4



Tenor full voice to E5 USA · prominent since 1963 · known for “Superstition”

Nasal-forward tenor with gospel melisma; slides from chest into a bright, controlled falsetto.

Sound sits high and forward, buzzing in the mask, which is why it cuts through a horn section without much volume. Notes are usually approached from underneath with a quick scoop, and vibrato shows up only at the tail of a long note. Chest carries to roughly the belt around E5; everything above that is a thin, deliberate falsetto reaching toward E6. Copying the nasal buzz and the runs without the rhythmic placement misses where the phrasing actually lives.

David Ruffin

A2–E6 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor USA · prominent since 1964 · known for “My Girl”

LOW A2 IN “I GET EXCITED” · HIGH E6 IN “RAINY NIGHT IN GEORGIA”

Gravel-and-plead soul tenor whose controlled fray climbs into screamed full-voice peaks.

Raw-grained tenor whose signature is controlled fray: a pleading rasp that intensifies as lines climb, stretched over a firm rhythmic core. He belts high and rides screamed peaks at the top of the range, using hoarseness as expression rather than accident. Phrasing tugs against the pulse, with sobs and spoken asides breaking the line. Students copying him start with the rasp and lose the pitch; his grit sits on top of accurate, supported tone, and the cracks are placed, not accidental.

Wilson Pickett

Bb2–E6 · 3 octaves + 6



Tenor USA · prominent since 1965 · known for “In the Midnight Hour”

LOW BB2 IN “I'M IN LOVE” · HIGH E6 IN “MUSTANG SALLY”

Brass-lunged soul shouter: punched phrases, wide vowels, genuinely pitched screams.

Full-throttle Southern soul shouting: a brassy tenor driven by huge breath pressure, short punched phrases, and screams that stay genuinely pitched at the top of the range. Vowels are wide, consonants explosive, vibrato almost absent, so intensity substitutes for ornament. He rides one dynamic, loud, with strategic drops for contrast. Students copying him tear at the top; his screams are supported yells with the pharynx open, launched off the diaphragm in short bursts, never sustained past what the air can carry.

Aaron Neville

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor USA · prominent since 1966 · known for “Tell It Like It Is”

High tenor with a wide, warbling vibrato and gospel turns on nearly every held note.

Vibrato is the signature: wide, quick, and present almost from the moment a note begins, giving the tone a warble that most singers spend years trying to remove. Onsets are gentle and slightly breathy, and nearly every held note gets decorated with a gospel turn or a small quaver upward. The range sits high and light. Imitating this by wobbling the pitch from the throat sounds unsteady; the oscillation has to stay even and come from the breath.

Al Green

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1967 · known for “Let's Stay Together”

Light tenor that keeps breaking into a soft, moaning falsetto over laid-back phrasing.

Weight stays light on purpose. Instead of pressing at the top of the chest register, the voice flips into a soft moaning falsetto mid-word, then drops back down, so the break becomes an ornament rather than a problem to hide. Phrasing hangs behind the groove, with little sighs and hums filling the gaps. To imitate this, learn to release where you want to push; a student who belts the same lines loses the whole effect.

Donny Hathaway

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor USA · prominent since 1970 · known for “A Song for You”

Church-rooted tenor with a hard-edged mid range and a wide, urgent vibrato.

Most of the singing happens in a hard-edged middle register carried in chest weight up toward C5, with a wide urgent vibrato that widens further as a phrase intensifies. Onsets can be firm or scooped depending on emphasis, and phrases stretch and compress freely against a steady rhythm section. The ornaments are gospel-shaped rather than pop-shaped, landing on the vowel and resolving downward. Substituting loudness for that urgency just presses the tone flat.

Bill Withers

F2–A4 · 2 octaves + 4



Baritone USA · prominent since 1971 · known for “Ain't No Sunshine”

Plain-spoken baritone, narrow range, conversational timing and almost no ornament.

Everything sits close to speech. A narrow range topping out around A4, almost no vibrato, plain onsets, and timing that follows how a sentence would actually be spoken rather than where the bar line falls. Ornament is nearly absent, so word stress and pauses carry the meaning. This is the hardest style to fake, because a student's instinct is to add runs and swells, and each addition makes the delivery sound less honest.

Philip Bailey

G2–D6 · 3 octaves + 7



Countertenor · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 1972 · known for “Easy Lover”

HIGH D6 IN “REASONS”

Baritone speaking range under a penetrating falsetto that carries entire lead vocals.

Note the gap: a chest belt topping out near B4 under a range extending to D6. Everything high is a pure, penetrating falsetto that carries full lead lines and sustains without wobble, not a chest note. Tone up there is clean and almost boyish, with fast even vibrato on held notes and a genuinely low speaking register underneath. The usual error is trying to belt those pitches in chest, which strains and still sounds nothing like it.

Teddy Pendergrass

E2–Bb4 · 2 octaves + 6



Baritone · USA · prominent since 1972 · known for “Close the Door”

Heavy baritone with a gravel edge; moves from near-whisper to full-throated shouting.

Sheer weight is the whole instrument. With a top only around Bb4, nothing depends on high notes; the drama comes from dynamics, moving from a near-whisper to a full-throated shout inside one phrase, with gravel appearing as intensity rises. Onsets are firm and vowels stay wide and dark. Going straight to the shouting skips the quiet end, where the contrast is built, and then the loud passages have nowhere left to go.

Barry White

D2–E4 · 2 octaves + 2



Bass USA · prominent since 1973 · known for “Can't Get Enough of Your Love, Babe”

Deep bass built for spoken-sung delivery: narrow working range, enormous resonance.

Delivery sits between speech and song, mostly inside a narrow band low in the bass range, with long sustained resonance and very little melodic movement. Pace is unhurried, consonants are relaxed, and the tone stays smooth rather than pressed. Since the range tops out around E4, everything rests on resonance instead of reach. Forcing the larynx down to fake the depth produces a muffled, breathy sound; real weight comes from an open, relaxed throat and slow air.

Lionel Richie

F2–G5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor full voice to A4 USA · prominent since 1974 · known for “Hello”

Warm, unhurried tenor that leans on breathy tone over volume and steps up to a light falsetto.

Air is part of the tone here, not a fault. Lines start soft, with an aspirate onset, and stay near speech volume even when sustained; a slow, narrow vibrato shows up only at the tail of a long note. Above the A4 belt he moves into a light falsetto rather than driving the chest voice higher, and phrasing sits square on the beat with almost no ornament. The trap is oversinging it, because the warmth comes from steady breath and relaxed vowels at low volume.

Daryl Hall

E2–C6 · 3 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 1976 · known for “Sara Smile”

Agile blue-eyed-soul tenor; conversational runs, melisma, and glowing falsetto ad-libs.

Improvisation sits at the center: a nimble soul tenor that treats melody as a starting grid for runs, anticipations and falsetto flips. His mix is light and forward, gliding through the passaggio without a bump, with melisma placed on weak beats so grooves stay intact. Falsetto extends the top by a full register. Students transcribe his ad-libs and sing them stiffly; the skill to copy is rhythmic placement, landing ornaments inside the pocket, not the licks themselves.

Michael McDonald

G#2–A5 · 3 octaves + 1



Baritone · USA · prominent since 1976 · known for “What a Fool Believes”

LOW G#2 IN “WHERE WOULD I BE NOW” · HIGH A5 IN “UP THERE”

Husky, woolly baritone that flips into falsetto mid-phrase; soul phrasing with distinctive muffled diction.

That muffled diction is structural: he rounds and darkens every vowel, singing through a half-closed mouth so the tone stays woolly and thick. Underneath is a firm chest-mix that flips instantly into clear falsetto, often mid-word, with the seam left audible as a stylistic stamp. Chord-tone ad-libs come from a keyboard player's ear. Imitators exaggerate the mumble and lose pitch center; the blur is diction only, while his vowel core stays precisely tuned.

Prince

E2–B5 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 1978 · known for “Purple Rain”

HIGH B5 IN “THE BEAUTIFUL ONES”

Switches between smoky chest voice, piercing falsetto, and screams well above the staff.

Registers get swapped like guitar tones: a smoky, half-spoken low voice, a chesty belt up around E5, a piercing thin falsetto, and screams above that reaching toward B5. Consonants are clipped and placed exactly on the sixteenth-note grid, so the vocal doubles as a rhythm part. Vibrato is minimal until a note is held on purpose. Beginners chase the scream first, before the low conversational register and the rhythmic precision that make it land.

Luther Vandross

B2–A5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor · USA · prominent since 1981 · known for “Never Too Much”

Round, cushioned tenor with precise runs and falsetto used as ornament, not escape.

Nothing in the tone carries an edge, even at full volume: round, cushioned, warm, with a low larynx color. Runs are fast but fully articulated, each pitch landing rhythmically rather than smearing, and falsetto gets used as a decorative flick at the top of a phrase instead of an escape hatch. Dynamics swell gradually inside single notes. Smeared runs and over-scooped entries kill it; the style depends on clean starts and exact intervals.

Seal

Eb2–G5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor UK · prominent since 1990 · known for “Kiss from a Rose”

LOW EB2 IN “WHAT'S GOING ON” · HIGH G5 IN “CRAZY”

Husky, grained tenor; smoky low register blooming into ringing, rounded high sustains.

Grain and warmth define the sound: a husky tenor whose low register is smoky and intimate, blooming upward into rounded, ringing sustains. Melisma is used sparingly but with complete control, each run landing softly inside the beat. The passaggio is smoothed almost invisibly — notes migrate from chest warmth into heady mix without any audible gear change, with falsetto reserved for the very top around G5. Copying the huskiness with deliberate breathiness collapses the tone; his texture comes from the instrument itself, over steady support and tall, unhurried vowels.

Brian McKnight

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor USA · prominent since 1992 · known for “Back at One”

Trained tenor with clean legato and a falsetto he steps into without an audible seam.

The control is in the details: exact pitch on entry with no scoop, smooth legato, and a step into the light upper register that leaves no audible seam. Runs are melodic and unhurried rather than crowded, and vibrato stays even and controlled at the end of long notes. Volume changes come from breath support, not squeeze. Sliding into every note from below undoes the clean, connected line that gives the style its polish.

Usher

Bb2–A5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Yeah!”

Agile pop-R&B tenor; clipped rhythmic phrasing and a light, breathy upper register.

Consonants get cut short so the vocal snaps against the beat, with placement kept bright and forward. Runs are brief and rhythmic rather than long and showy, often used to fill a half-beat gap. The upper register thins out and turns breathy instead of belting, and ad-libs stack around the lead line. Imitators tend to smooth the phrasing into even legato, which drains the groove, and they hold notes that should be clipped off early.

CeeLo Green

Bb1–C6 · 4 octaves + 2



Tenor full voice to C5 USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “Crazy”

LOW BB1 IN “GO-GO GADGET GOSPEL” · HIGH C6 IN “WORKIN' MAN'S BLUES”

Rasp-edged gospel-soul tenor: huge open belts, keening falsetto leaps, and joyful swing.

Gritty, joyful soul tenor with sanded edges: rasp sits on top of a supported, rounded chest tone rather than replacing it. He belts hard to C5 with wide-open vowels, jumps into a keening falsetto above that, and lands runs with gospel timing, triplets pulling against the backbeat. Vibrato is fast and generous. Students copying him imitate the rasp with throat squeeze; his distortion rides on airflow over a stable larynx, so the grit never costs him pitch or stamina.

D'Angelo

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “Untitled (How Does It Feel)”

Slurred phrasing that drags behind the beat, with falsetto harmonies stacked in blocks.

Consonants get softened and slurred so words blur into each other, and lines sit noticeably behind the beat while the band stays put, which creates the drag that defines the feel. Falsetto lines are stacked in dense harmony blocks, each one small and breathy. Pitches often bend into place rather than starting there. Singing this cleanly on the beat, with crisp diction, produces something technically correct and completely wrong stylistically.

Maxwell

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Ascension (Don't Ever Wonder)”

HIGH C6 IN “THIS WOMAN'S WORK”

Sings long stretches in falsetto with a narrow, flute-like tone and slow vibrato.

Whole verses live in falsetto, with a narrow flute-like tone that stays quiet and close to the microphone. Vibrato is slow, shallow, and arrives well after the note has settled. Reaching toward C6 works because the sound gets lighter as it climbs rather than louder. Powering the falsetto up there is the wrong instinct; the skill is holding a very small, steady stream of air and trusting the amplification.

Musiq Soulchild

C3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 6



Tenor · full voice to G#4 · USA · prominent since 2000 · known for “Love”

Neo-soul's smoothest talker: a warm, even tenor that bends syllables like taffy and hides virtuosity inside conversation.

Syllable elasticity is the trademark: words stretch, compress and slur across beats until lyric and run become the same gesture, in a warm, even tenor that never shows seams between registers. The famous stutter-phrasing chops one word into rhythmic fragments, then resolves the line smooth. Ornaments live inside the diction, not on top of it. Take one lyric line and practice five different rhythmic placements of the same pitches. His genius is that the fifth version still sounds like plain talking.

John Legend

E2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 6



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “All of Me”

Church-trained tenor; clean chest tone, light rasp on push, and an easy step up to falsetto.

Clean, forward chest tone with a little grain that only shows when he leans in. Onsets are precise rather than scooped, and runs stay short: three or four notes placed at the end of a line instead of draped over it, since any more than that buries the straight-line clarity underneath. Bb4 is the ceiling for full weight, and above it the voice releases into falsetto with no audible seam, carrying an even, moderate vibrato.

Leon Bridges

B2–G4 · 1 octave + 8



Tenor · full voice to F4 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “River”

Sixties soul in present tense: a gentle, grain-warmed tenor with Sam Cooke's poise and none of his-era's shouting.

Poise over power, always. The tone is soft-grained and slightly covered, phrases delivered with a calm, upright placement that echoes Sam Cooke, and ornament limited to small end-of-phrase turns and the occasional yodel-flip. Dynamics move gently; the voice invites rather than insists. Sing his melodies at genuinely low volume with full breath support, resisting every urge to lean in on peaks. The restraint is a positive act, and its difficulty is invisible until you try to hold it for a whole song.

Rag'n'Bone Man

G2–B5 · 3 octaves + 4



Baritone · UK · prominent since 2016 · known for “Human”

LOW G2 IN “BITTER END” · HIGH B5 IN “TALKING TO MYSELF”

Huge gospel-blues baritone — preacher phrasing, blues bends, soft wooly falsetto contrast.

Gospel weight anchors everything: a wide, dark baritone delivered with huge breath support and a chest that stays engaged high into the belt. Rory shapes phrases like a preacher, swelling into downbeats, ornamenting with short blues bends instead of long runs. His falsetto is soft and wooly, used for contrast. Singers copying the size go straight to shouting; the mass comes from low-body anchoring and open pharyngeal space, with the throat surprisingly unclenched.

NEXT The soul and R&B women →

15 The soul and R&B women

If you could keep only one chapter of this atlas as a singing syllabus, keep this one. The women here hold, between them, every tool the book's vocabulary chapter defines: church-fired belts and runs, jazz-schooled bends and behind-the-beat cool, whisper-close quiet storm, rasp deployed as punctuation, and dynamic control that moves from confession to command inside a bar. The entries read like a curriculum because the tradition *was* one — each generation studied the last in church basements and on record, and the lineage is audible entry to entry.

Notice two structural facts as you read. First, the tessituras here sit lower than pop's: mezzo territory, speech-adjacent, which is why this chapter's technique transfers so well to average voices — the wonders are being worked in range you probably own. The stratospheric moments exist, and the cited extremes record them, but the authority lives in the middle, in tone and timing. Second, the ornament density is deceptive. The technique paragraphs keep measuring how *few* notes the greatest runs contain and how precisely they land; melisma in this tradition is architecture, resolved like harmony, not decoration sprayed over it.

Borrow in the order the entries suggest: tone first (weight, placement, the cry), timing second, runs last and slowed to quarter notes until exact. This chapter punishes approximation more than any other in the book, because every listener alive has its standards in their ears.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Etta James

G#2–B5 · 3 octaves + 3



Contralto USA · prominent since 1955 · known for “At Last”

Blues-weighted contralto: thick chest tone, growled note entries, wide and slow vibrato.

The growl lands on the attack and then resolves into thick, steady chest tone a beat later. Growl the whole way through and the effect disappears, because it only reads against clean tone underneath it. Vibrato is slow and wide and arrives late, once the note has been held straight for a while, and the melody moves by blues bends far more than by runs. Notes swell into their full size instead of starting there.

Aretha Franklin

G2–E6 · 3 octaves + 9



Mezzo-soprano full voice to G5 USA · prominent since 1961 · known for “Respect”

Gospel-schooled mezzo: hard chest register, melismatic runs, sudden shifts from growl to soft head voice.

Listen for the way weight shifts: chest tone driven hard up to a belt around G5, then a sudden drop into a soft, breathy head voice with almost no seam. Runs are gospel-shaped, pentatonic, aimed at a target note rather than sprinkled for decoration. Vibrato arrives late and narrow at the end of a sustain. Students copy the runs and miss the point, which is that the phrasing sits behind the beat and the consonants stay crisp.

Gladys Knight

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1961 · known for “Midnight Train to Georgia”

Warm, slightly husky mezzo that stays in chest voice and leans on phrasing over altitude.

Nothing here is about altitude. The whole story happens between E3 and D5, in chest voice, at close to speaking weight. Notes are entered gently and often a shade behind where the band puts them, then pulled back into time by the end of the line. Huskiness lives in the tone rather than in force. Singers hear soul and start adding runs, when the effect actually comes from restraint and from finishing every consonant.

Patti LaBelle

Bb2–E6 · 3 octaves + 6



Soprano full voice to Bb5 USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “Lady Marmalade”

Church-powered soprano with a piercing belt, abrupt octave leaps, and long sustained upper notes.

Ring carries further than volume here. The belt up toward Bb5 keeps a narrow, bright core even as the vowel spreads wide open, and shouting toward it only sends the pitch sharp and locks the throat. Octave leaps land clean, with the breath set before the jump rather than scooped into from below. Sustains run long, and the vibrato widens the longer the note is held.

Dusty Springfield

C3–Eb5 · 2 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano UK · prominent since 1963 · known for “Son of a Preacher Man”

Breathy, smoke-toned mezzo; heavy vibrato and chest-driven phrasing borrowed from soul records.

Air moves through nearly every note, so the tone keeps a soft edge and consonants land late and gentle rather than struck. Vibrato is wide and slow, usually arriving on the tail of a long note instead of under it. Phrases sit slightly behind the beat, chest-weighted through the middle of the staff and thinning as they climb toward Eb5. Students copying the breathiness let support collapse with it; the airflow has to stay pressurized underneath or the pitch sags.

Chaka Khan

F2–B5 · 3 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1974 · known for “Ain't Nobody”

Gritty low register into a bright, cutting upper mix; improvises like a horn player over the groove.

Grit sits on the onset rather than running through the whole note: a short scratch at the front, then clean tone behind it. Up high the sound thins into a bright, forward mix that cuts through a dense band instead of adding weight to it. Phrases start off the downbeat and land in the drummer's gaps, often trading a written line for a rhythmic scat figure. Pushing volume for that brightness is the usual error; it comes from placement and a fast, narrow vibrato.

Minnie Riperton

D3–F#7 · 4 octaves + 4



Soprano · full voice to F5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 1974 · known for “Lovin' You”

HIGH F#7 IN “YOU TAKE MY BREATH AWAY”

Light, agile soprano who moves up into clean whistle tones with no audible register break.

Register changes never announce themselves, because the weight never increases on the way up: chest thins into head voice, head voice narrows into whistle, and the vowel keeps its shape through both. Whistle notes are placed rather than screeched, quiet and pitch-centred with barely any vibrato on them. Build this from the top down out of a soft head voice. Forcing chest weight upward is what keeps the whistle from engaging at all.

Anita Baker

C#3–C#6 · 3 octaves



Contralto · USA · prominent since 1983 · known for “Sweet Love”

Velvety contralto with jazz phrasing; sits low, scoops into notes, seldom pushes volume.

Low and quiet, fully supported, with the microphone doing the amplifying instead of the singer. The tone stays dark and rounded at close to conversational volume. Notes get approached from underneath on a slow scoop, and the vibrato that follows is wide and unhurried. Higher up the sound lightens into an airy head tone rather than belting. Power is not the difficulty at all; holding that dark colour quietly is, without sliding into breathiness or settling under the pitch.

Mary J. Blige

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1992 · known for “Family Affair”

Raw chest-dominant mezzo with a nasal edge and clipped, conversational phrasing.

Everything is placed forward and slightly nasal, which is what gives the sound its edge over a hip-hop drum track. Phrases get clipped short and delivered in chest voice, nearer to talking than to singing, with ad-libs crowding in behind the main line. Small breaks and catches are left in rather than smoothed away. Clean the tone up and the character goes with it; the work is keeping that raw edge while the pitch centre stays exact.

Toni Braxton

Bb2–Bb5 · 3 octaves



Contralto USA · prominent since 1992 · known for “Un-Break My Heart”

Unusually low contralto; dark, breathy bottom end and tight vibrato even when pushing.

Most of the interest lives in the bottom third of the range, down toward Bb2, where the tone goes dark and slightly breathy without losing its centre. Onsets are aspirate, air first and pitch a moment later, and the vibrato that follows stays tight and fast even under pressure. Lines build by adding intensity rather than pitch. Higher-voiced singers attempting this jam the larynx down to fake depth and end up muffled; the colour comes from a relaxed, low speaking placement.

Brandy

G2–E6 · 3 octaves + 9



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “The Boy Is Mine”

Husky mid-weight mezzo built for stacked harmony; fast, light runs kept low in the mix.

Breathy mid-weight tone, and yet the runs come out fully articulated, every note separated instead of smeared into a slide. They are metered rather than free, which is why rushing them is where most attempts fall apart. The belt around E5 stays in mix and never opens into a shout, and riffs sit tucked underneath the lead line, dropped into the gaps between phrases so they read as arrangement rather than display.

Monica

B2–B5 · 3 octaves



Contralto · USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “The Boy Is Mine”

Dark, weighty chest voice with a husky edge, driving church-bred runs straight through the beat.

Monica anchors phrases in a dense chest voice that keeps its rasp and weight down where speech lives. Her onset is firm, almost spoken, and she drives melisma from the diaphragm so each note of a run lands separately. The mix carries chest color surprisingly high before flipping late into head voice. Students copying her tend to imitate the grit by squeezing the throat; the darkness comes from low placement and relaxed pharyngeal space, not pressure.

Lauryn Hill

Bb2–A5 · 2 octaves + 11



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Doo Wop (That Thing)”

Forward, nasal placement and rap-adjacent timing; belts inside a narrow, tightly held band.

Timing is the instrument. Sung lines get the same rhythmic precision as spoken ones, syllables landing on subdivisions instead of on beats, and the placement stays high, narrow and a little nasal. The band pushed hardest is a narrow one, and approaching A5 the tone thins rather than opening out. Widen the vowels into legato and the character evaporates, so the vowels stay short and the consonants drive the groove.

Erykah Badu

G2–D5 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1997 · known for “On & On”

Thin, nasal jazz-inflected tone with bent pitches and phrasing dragged behind the beat.

Pitch here is elastic on purpose. Notes bend up into place, slide off the end, and sometimes settle deliberately between the two nearest pitches, while the tone stays thin and nasal, sung close to the microphone with very little vibrato on it. Phrases drag behind the beat and catch up only at the cadence. None of that is the hard part. The control is, because bending without steady air underneath it just reads as flat.

Macy Gray

A2–D6 · 3 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1999 · known for “I Try”

LOW A2 IN “LATELY” · HIGH D6 IN “COME TOGETHER”

Frayed, smoky talk-singing that cracks and dissolves on purpose, hiding wide range inside character.

Macy speaks more than she sings, dragging a frayed, smoky rasp across the pitch and letting words crack on purpose. Her onset is breathy-then-gripped, sustains wobble deliberately, and phrase endings dissolve into air. Underneath the character voice sits a real range, from low chest tones up to bright head-voice peaks. Students copying her fake the crackle with throat tension; hers comes from loose folds and heavy airflow, and forcing it without support wrecks intonation fast.

Jill Scott

C3–E5 · 2 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2000 · known for “A Long Walk”

Round, full-bodied mezzo that slides between spoken delivery and open, jazz-toned sustains.

Two modes alternate inside a single verse: near-spoken delivery half in time with the band, then an open, round sustain with real jazz tone on it. Vowels stay wide and the placement is warm instead of nasal. Ornaments tend to be short scat figures rather than long melismatic runs. Crossing between the modes is what trips people up, since the sung notes need full breath support the instant they arrive, so the spoken sections have to be supported too.

Alicia Keys

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to Eb5 · USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “Fallin’”

Smoky mezzo with a slight nasal edge; belts from the chest and clips notes short for rhythm.

Compression, not air. Notes begin with a firm glottal edge and a slightly nasal placement, and that is where the huskiness lives; breathing the tone out to sound smoky works against it. She clips syllables short and lets the rests carry the groove, landing a fraction behind the beat. The Eb5 belt keeps chest weight instead of thinning into a mix, with only a shimmer of narrow vibrato on the release.

India.Arie

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Contralto · USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “Video”

Woody, low-lying contralto calm — acoustic soul sung at speaking weight with sparse ornament.

India.Arie keeps the larynx low and the tone woody, singing acoustic-guitar phrases in a true contralto tessitura. Her onset is simultaneous and unforced, dynamics stay inside a narrow, intimate band, and ornaments are sparse, placed only where the lyric asks. Chest resonance dominates even on upper passages, which she rounds rather than brightens. Students copying her mistake quiet for unsupported; the stillness requires steady appoggio, tall vowels, and the patience to leave space unfilled.

Amy Winehouse

C3–Eb5 · 2 octaves + 3



Contralto UK · prominent since 2003 · known for “Rehab”

Contralto with jazz-era diction, heavy vibrato, and a cracked, smoky bottom register.

Consonants come clipped and the vowels sit narrower than modern pop asks for. That, plus a low and slightly smoky placement near C3, is most of the character, and copying the accent without the breath support underneath it gets nowhere near the sound. Notes are slid into and slid out of. A wide, slow vibrato lands on nearly every sustain, and the timing lags the beat by a fraction all the way through.

Joss Stone

C3–G5 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano UK · prominent since 2003 · known for “You Had Me”

Smoky, grainy soul mezzo — cool and husky down low, gutsy and warm in the belt.

Grit is the organizing principle: Stone adds rasp by compressing at the cords, then releases into clean warmth mid-phrase for contrast. Her low range near C3 keeps a cool, smoky cover, while belts toward G5 open into a wide, gospel-shaped vowel with fast vibrato arriving late. Runs are loose and behind the beat, more sung speech than drill. Copying her rasp with throat squeeze causes fatigue; the distortion rides on steady airflow and a released jaw.

Fantasia

C3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “When I See U”

Husky, grainy soul shout with gospel bends, percussive onsets and a growl always within reach.

Fantasia drives breath hard through a husky, gospel-schooled instrument, turning the rasp into an expressive dial she opens and closes at will. Onsets are often glottal and percussive, phrases bend behind the beat, and she shouts-then-croons within a single line. Runs come from church tradition: pentatonic, weighted, finished with a growl. Students copying her force the rasp from the folds; hers rides on strong support and a dropped jaw, and she releases it before strain sets in.

Jennifer Hudson

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano full voice to A5 USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “And I Am Telling You I'm Not Going”

Heavy chest weight carried into the fifth octave; belts stay full instead of thinning to falsetto.

Chest weight is carried unusually high, so a belt near A5 keeps the thickness it had an octave lower instead of thinning into mix. Vowels open wide at the top, and the note is held straight before a slow vibrato is allowed in at the end. Attacks land firm and on pitch with little scooping. Attempting this without the breath pressure behind it is how singers strain, since the size comes from support and space rather than from squeezing.

Jazmine Sullivan

A2–C#6 · 3 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G#5 · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Bust Your Windows”

Flips between growled chest notes and airy, agile upper runs; rasp used as an effect, not a default.

A growled, gritty chest note gets answered a beat later by an airy, fast run well above it, sometimes inside a single phrase. Rasp switches on for one word and off again, which tells you it is being produced deliberately rather than simply lived in. Belts around G#5 stay connected before releasing into breath. Leave the rasp on continuously and it stops registering altogether, since the contrast against clean tone is the entire effect.

Emeli Sandé

D3–F5 · 2 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · UK · prominent since 2011 · known for “Next to Me”

Bright-edged mezzo with a trumpet-like belt, tight fast vibrato, and hymn-like directness.

Economy defines this voice: Sandé chooses one placement — forward, bright, slightly brassy — and commits, so every note from D3 to F5 sounds like the same instrument. Her vibrato is narrow and quick, switched on at phrase ends. Belts keep weight and character right up to F5 without widening, and melisma is deployed sparingly, in short gospel-rooted cells. Students copying her overdecorate; the style is declamatory, hymn-plain, with consonants planted and every vowel fully voiced.

Andra Day

E3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C#5 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Rise Up”

A time-traveling soul voice: Billie Holiday's bent notes and smoke, wired to a modern gospel belt.

Jazz inflection meets church power. Verses lean on Holiday-style delays and note-bends, the pitch approached from underneath and worried around its center, in a smoky tone with a distinctive nasal glint. The chorus then squares up into a straight, supported gospel belt. The two vocabularies alternate; they never blur. Learn a verse with every bend mapped, then deliver the chorus with none. Singers who bend the belt or straighten the verses lose the tension that makes the arc land.

Yebba

D3–G5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “My Mind”

HIGH G5 IN “MY MIND (LIVE AT SOFAR SOUNDS)”

A church-raised force of nature: crying mix, spiraling runs and dynamics that leap from whisper to wail inside a bar.

The cry is the core: a bright, weeping edge in the mix that keeps maximum intensity emotionally legible instead of merely loud, learned leading worship in an Arkansas church. Runs spiral through unexpected chromatic turns and land somewhere other than where they started. Dynamics are extreme and sudden. Isolate the cry on one sustained note, a slight sob placed above the sound, before attempting volume; the wail without the weep is just shouting, and her quiet singing carries the same charge as her loudest.

NEXT Modern R&B →

16 Modern R&B

Modern R&B is soul rebuilt for headphones. The church lineage is intact — listen to the harmony stacks and the run grammar — but the delivery contract changed: where the classic tradition projected to the back pew, this generation confides at six inches, and the entries here document the consequences. Falsetto became the lead register rather than the special effect. Runs learned to decay into breath. Nonchalance became a produced aesthetic, sloppiness engineered with studio precision. And a counter-movement of baritones planted flags in the cellar, proving the genre had been renting only the top half of the male voice for a generation.

The technique paragraphs in this chapter return constantly to one theme: the apparent casualness is exact. The flips land on chosen syllables; the mumble holds its pitch centers; the stacked harmonies that make one voice sound like a choir require the lead to tune like a section player. Modern R&B is the atlas's clearest demonstration that *relaxed* and *imprecise* are different properties, and that the first is manufactured from the second's opposite.

For the practicing singer this is the most immediately usable chapter in the soul wing. The volumes are conversational, the tessituras moderate, the tools — onset control, register blending, breath-as-texture — all safe to drill at home. What it demands instead is patience with detail: the loop method from the borrower's chapter, run at short

phrase length, is the only way the exactness underneath this style becomes audible enough to copy.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Aaliyah

C#3–A5 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano | full voice to G#5 | USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Try Again”

LOW C#3 IN “DEATH OF A PLAYA” · HIGH A5 IN “NEVER COMIN' BACK”

Cool, airy head-mix glide over stuttering beats — intimacy and precision instead of power.

Aaliyah floats a small, cool head-mix over intricate rhythmic phrasing, singing softly enough that the microphone does the projection. Her onsets are aspirate and gentle, runs are compact and precise rather than showy, and harmony stacks carry much of the color. The belt tops out around G#5 but she rarely leans on it, preferring restraint. Students copying her often whisper instead of phonating; the trick is a clear, connected tone at low volume, with breath moving constantly underneath.

Faith Evans

C#3–C#6 · 3 octaves



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “Love Like This”

Honeyed, jazz-tinged croon; long legato runs that melt behind the beat over hip-hop drums.

Faith rides a honeyed mid-register with jazz-inflected timing, sliding into notes from just beneath and blooming them with slow vibrato. Her runs are long, legato, and behind the beat, more Marvin-style croon than percussive gospel. Head voice is warm and covered rather than piercing. She layers her own backgrounds into thick pads. Students copying her rush the ornaments; the style depends on unhurried breath cycles, soft palate lift, and finishing each phrase before starting the next.

Tamia

Eb3–D6 · 2 octaves + 11



Mezzo-soprano Canada · prominent since 1995 · known for “Officially Missing You”

Pristine, bright mix that blooms into clear head voice, with exacting intonation on long, high sustains.

Tamia balances a bright, forward mix with genuine head-voice bloom, moving between them without a visible seam. Her intonation is unusually exact on sustained high lines, vibrato arrives late and even, and runs are shaped in clean descending curls. She supports long crescendos from the ribs, letting a note grow without spreading. Students copying her usually attack the top notes; she approaches them on closed vowels, narrows first, then opens once the pitch is seated.

Kelly Rowland

C3–Eb6 · 3 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 1998 · known for “Motivation”

Warm, weighty mezzo middle with a rounded belt and wide vibrato that turns dance tracks humid.

Kelly sings from a weighty, warm middle register and builds phrases around it rather than around the extremes. Her belt is thick and rounded up to F5, finished with a wide, deliberate vibrato that she can delay for tension. Low phrases keep full tone instead of fry. Students copying her often thin out the middle to reach higher; she does the opposite, keeping the larynx settled and accepting a lower ceiling in exchange for evenness and warmth.

Pharrell Williams

Eb2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to A5 · USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “Happy”

LOW EB2 IN “DOUBLE LIFE” · HIGH BB5 IN “BREAKOUT”

Airy, boyish falsetto-led tenor with percussive phrasing and short full-voice shouts.

Feather-light tenor placement with a breathy, boyish timbre that reads younger than his speaking voice. Most hooks live in loose falsetto with air deliberately left in the tone; full voice appears in short stabs and the occasional shouted A5 climax. Phrasing rides behind the beat like a drummer's. Students copying him overfill the falsetto and lose the percussive consonants; the sound is thin by design, supported from low breath, with vowels kept close to speech.

Ashanti

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “Foolish”

Soft, rounded midrange stacked into pillowy self-harmonies; melody kept simple and conversational.

Ashanti layers soft, midweight lines into cushioned harmony beds, treating her lead vocal as one thread inside the arrangement. The tone is round and slightly nasal-forward, onsets are gentle, and she repeats short melodic cells rather than long runs. Sustains carry a slow, narrow vibrato. Students copying her underestimate the stacking discipline: each double must match vowel shape and decay exactly, and the lead must stay conversational, never pushed, or the blend collapses.

Akon

C3–Bb4 · 1 octave + 10



Tenor USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Lonely”

LOW C3 IN “LONELY” · HIGH BB4 IN “BEAUTIFUL”

Reedy, lilting tenor with mournful slides and West African-inflected trills over club beats.

High, lilting tenor with a reedy, slightly nasal core and constant gentle portamento between notes. He sits in a narrow band from the C3 floor to a Bb4 ceiling and gets variety from ornament rather than range: quick mordent-like trills, West African-inflected melisma, and long sustained vowels with almost no vibrato. Students copying him push volume into the nasality and go flat on the slides; the style needs light breath pressure and a precise landing pitch under every ornament.

Ciara

Bb2–A5 · 2 octaves + 11



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Goodies”

LOW BB2 IN “GIRL GANG” · HIGH A5 IN “UP & DOWN”

Light, reedy tone clipped tight to the beat — a dancer's voice, quick and cool.

Ciara treats the voice as part of the choreography: light, reedy, and rhythmically clipped, with consonants placed exactly on the beat. She sings mostly in a nimble low mix, harmonizing her lower notes and saving the thin, bright top for accents. Runs are fast, small-interval, and always land on the grid. Students copying her add too much weight; the style needs a lifted soft palate, minimal air pressure, and breath planned around dance movement.

Chris Brown

C3–G#5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor full voice to G4 USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “With You”

A dancer's light tenor: bright, elastic and rhythmically exact, built to stay effortless mid-choreography.

Efficiency governs everything: the tone is light and bright, produced with minimal engine so it stays steady through full-out choreography, and the athleticism goes into rhythm instead of volume. Runs are fast, clipped and placed exactly on subdivisions, more percussive than gospel-fluid, and the falsetto is thin, sweet and instantly available. Practice singing eighth-note runs while walking in tempo, then while dancing, keeping the tone unshaken. Weight is the enemy; a heavy version of this voice cannot move.

Keyshia Cole

C3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Love”

Metallic, raw-edged chest voice that lags the beat like pressured speech and snaps into tight-vibrato belts.

Keyshia pushes chest voice with a metallic, grainy edge, favoring raw directness over polish. Her phrasing lags the beat like speech under pressure, and she snaps into sustained belts with hard glottal onsets. Vibrato is quick and tight, applied at peak volume. The husk in the tone is real but controlled. Students copying her copy the shout and miss the anchor: her sound needs firm abdominal support and a stable jaw, or the edge turns into spread, sharp-leaning pitch.

T-Pain

B2–F5 · 2 octaves + 6



Tenor full voice to Bb4 USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Buy U a Drank (Shawty Snappin')”

The Auto-Tune icon who never needed it: underneath the robot gloss, a rich, gospel-raised soul tenor with real weight.

Precision made the effect work: Auto-Tune only snaps cleanly when the input pitch is already close, and his is, which is why the processed lines sound liquid where imitators sound glitchy. Unprocessed, the voice is a warm, wide soul tenor with easy runs and a fat, supported mid-range, schooled in church. Practice his melodies dry, hitting centers dead-on with plain tone, before adding any effect. The plugin is an aesthetic layered onto accuracy; it does not create it.

Trey Songz

F2–G5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Bottoms Up”

LOW F2 IN “INSIDE PT. 2” · HIGH G5 IN “NEIGHBORS KNOW MY NAME”

Plush bedroom-R&B tenor stacked with falsetto ad-libs and metronomic melisma.

Sweet-toned R&B tenor with a light, high-set placement and constant ornamental motion. He starts phrases with soft glottal onsets, ends them with falling melisma, and layers falsetto ad-libs over his own lead line. Full voice stays plush up to F5, with a quick flip above it rather than a hard belt edge. Students copying him over-sing the runs; his passagework is metronomic, each note articulated by the tongue rather than the throat, and the breathiness is an overlay on tone, not a substitute for it.

Ne-Yo

Eb2–A5 · 3 octaves + 6



Tenor · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2006 · known for “So Sick”

LOW EB2 IN “STORY TIME” · HIGH A5 IN “MAKIN' A MOVIE”

Polished lyric tenor with conversational verses, narrow forward vowels, and clean F5 belt climaxes.

Clean, centered lyric tenor built on a light chest mix that never over-weights the larynx. He keeps vowels narrow and forward, releases phrase endings with a soft straight-tone before a late, shallow vibrato, and reserves full belt for F5 climaxes. Runs are written like melodies: short, diatonic, landed on chord tones. Students copying him usually over-darken the tone and muscle the top; the sound depends on keeping the verse almost conversational so the chorus lift feels doubled.

Kid Cudi

A1–F5 · 3 octaves + 8



Baritone · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Day 'n' Nite”

LOW A1 IN “SUPERBOY” · HIGH F5 IN “WORTH”

Droning sub-bass hums beneath yowling open-throat wails; the contrast is the style.

Low hums are the foundation: a woolly baritone that drones sustained chest tones down toward A1, then vaults into an open, yowling belt around D5 for hooks. The middle voice is talky and loose, with pitch treated as gesture. His signature is the hum-to-wail contrast inside one song. Students copying him press the low notes; subterranean pitches need slack folds and big resonating space, not force, and the high wails require an open throat with nothing held back in the jaw.

Solange

D3–E6 · 3 octaves + 2



Soprano · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Cranes in the Sky”

HIGH E6 IN “COSMIC JOURNEY”

Floated, straight-tone head voice tuned like synth pads; minimalist R&B sung at whisper weight.

Solange lifts into head voice earlier than most R&B singers, treating everything above the mid-staff as a place for floated, straight-tone color. Her belts are rare and light; instead she stacks precise falsetto-adjacent harmonies with minimal vibrato, tuning them like synth pads. Low notes are soft-spoken but centered. Students copying her push chest upward and sound strained where she sounds weightless; the move is an early, unashamed register shift with breath kept slow and even.

Drake

D2–C5 · 2 octaves + 10



Baritone Canada · prominent since 2009 · known for “Hold On, We're Going Home”

Soft, covered baritone melodies that sit on speech contours and tight repeated intervals.

Conversational baritone singing that hugs a narrow third-octave band, with a soft, covered tone and melodies built from speech contours. Onsets are gentle, vibrato nearly absent, and hooks repeat small intervals until they hypnotize. Head voice appears sparingly and quietly. Students copying him under-rate the pitch discipline; the half-sung style still requires exact intonation on tight intervals, a relaxed jaw, and rhythmic placement a hair behind the beat, because slack pitch turns the style into mumbling.

Jason Derulo

A2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor full voice to F5 USA · prominent since 2009 · known for “Whatcha Say”

LOW A2 IN “DON'T WANNA GO HOME” · HIGH BB5 IN “BREATHING”

Nasal-bright pop tenor that flips between punchy full voice and high floating falsetto tags.

A bright pop tenor who leads with a pinched, nasal-forward placement that cuts through dense production. He flips cleanly between full voice and a heady falsetto, tags phrases with quick melisma, and glides through pitch like a warm-up exercise. Belt tops around F5 stay narrow and twangy rather than wide. Students copying him choke the top by opening the vowel too far; the cut comes from twang and a high tongue position, not volume, and the falsetto needs steady airflow, not squeeze.

Janelle Monáe

C#3–Eb6 · 3 octaves + 2



Soprano USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “Tightrope”

LOW C#3 IN “BABOPBYEYA”

Shape-shifting funk instrument: croon, patter and raspy upper-mix wails traded inside a single song.

Janelle switches between crooned jazz phrasing, rapid patter, and wild, raspy upper-mix exclamations, often inside one verse. Articulation is theatrical: crisp consonants, exaggerated vowel shifts, James-Brown-style rhythmic stabs. Her mix takes on a deliberate scream-adjacent edge at climaxes while staying on pitch. Vibrato is narrow and fast. Students copying her chase the mania and lose the diction; the control comes from classical-grade breath pacing beneath the showmanship, with every effect planned to the bar.

Mac Miller

C#2–E4 · 2 octaves + 3



Baritone USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “Self Care”

LOW C#2 IN “GOOD NEWS” · HIGH E4 IN “GOOD NEWS”

Low, smoke-soft murmur that sings just above speech with jazz-wise note choices.

Smoke-softened baritone murmur with a frayed edge, sitting low and singing barely above speech. Melodies move stepwise in a narrow band, phrases exhale downward, and the C#2 floor appears as sung rumble rather than effect. Jazz-leaning chord awareness shows in the note choices more than the delivery. Students copying him let the softness go breathy and flat; the mumble still needs core tone, closed-enough folds, and intervals placed exactly, or the laid-back feel reads as out of tune.

Miguel

C3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to G#4 · USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “Adorn”

Psychedelic soul athletics: a gleaming tenor with a rock edge, sliding between silk falsetto and full-throated wail.

Blend is the weapon: chest, mix and falsetto are welded so smoothly that a single phrase can start as a croon and end as a Prince-style wail with no audible gear change. The falsetto gleams with a metallic edge rather than breathiness, and he sustains it at volumes most tenors reserve for chest. Work long slides from chest into falsetto on oo, keeping the intensity constant across the seam. The wail is earned through that evenness, not through pushing harder at the top.

Childish Gambino

Bb1–C6 · 4 octaves + 2



Tenor · USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Redbone”

LOW BB1 IN “ALGORHYTHM” · HIGH C6 IN “ME AND YOUR MAMA”

Shape-shifting funk tenor sliding from talky lows to screamed belts and quivering falsetto.

Elastic and theatrical, moving from a talky low register near Bb1 up through screamed full-voice climaxes and a keening falsetto. He treats registration as costume: airy croon, funk yelp, preacher rasp, sometimes all inside one verse. Falsetto carries whole songs with a fast flicker vibrato; his high belts are distorted on purpose. Students copying him chase the scream first; the control lives in his soft singing, pitch-true falsetto with a released jaw, and the distortion must sit over support or it shreds.

Frank Ocean

C#2–G5 · 3 octaves + 6



Tenor · full voice to F#4 · USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Thinkin Bout You”

The mumbled confession as art form: a hazy tenor drifting between talk, melody and a fragile, exposed falsetto.

Falsetto carries the feelings the words won't say. The chest voice is kept conversational, slightly slurred and unforced, and at emotional peaks he abandons it entirely for a thin, deliberately fragile falsetto that sits high and unprotected, cracks left in. Pitch is loose by design in verses, exact in the falsetto hooks. Practice the handoff: speak-sing a line, then float the next phrase in soft falsetto without resetting your breath. Strengthening the falsetto until it sounds confident misses the point of its fragility.

Tyler, the Creator

B1–B5 · 4 octaves



Baritone · full voice to A5 · USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “EARFQUAKE”

LOW B1 IN “WHARF TALK” · HIGH B5 IN “TAMALE”

Rumbling monotone baritone lows against cracked, earnest falsetto hooks.

Cavernous speaking-range baritone rap sits beside a surprisingly tender sung falsetto, two instruments in one artist. Low lines rumble toward B1 with deliberate monotone weight; sung hooks flip into a cracked, earnest falsetto and a strong mix that can push to A5 in shrieked peaks. Pitch is sometimes bent flat for character. Students copying him polish the falsetto too much; the charm is a controlled amateurishness, supported underneath, with the cracks landing on expressive words.

Coco Jones

B2–C#6 · 3 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2012 · known for “ICU”

Rich, wide-open chest voice with broad vibrato and belts that keep full color to the top.

Coco opens her chest voice wide and rich, with a deep-set lower register and a belt that keeps full color through G5. Her vibrato is broad and anchored, runs are deliberate and fully voiced rather than skated, and she shifts into head voice only after the belt has made its point. Diction stays theater-clean. Students copying her go for size immediately; the richness comes from low breath anchoring and tall, rounded vowels, not from sheer push.

Jhené Aiko

B2–E6 · 3 octaves + 5



Soprano · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “The Worst”

Pitch-perfect whisper-singing: fry onsets, narrow slides, breath woven into the texture.

Jhené whispers at pitch, keeping phonation so light that the line hovers between speech and song. She leans on vocal fry as an entrance, slides between notes in narrow glissandi, and lets sibilants and breath become part of the texture. Her upper register is a filmy head voice, never pushed. Students copying her lose the pitch core inside the airiness; the whisper still needs precise fold closure at the center, tuned quiet rather than merely breathy.

Normani

C#3–Eb7 · 4 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Motivation”

Bright, dance-built mix with clean belts and an occasional glassy whistle flash at the very top.

Normani mixes light chest tones with a bright, dance-ready top, belting cleanly to G5 before handing lines to head voice and, at the extreme, a piercing whistle up to Eb7. Her phrasing is percussive and breath-managed for choreography, with short, punchy sustains. Runs stay compact. Students copying her treat the whistle as the goal; it is an occasional ornament, produced with tiny fold contact after full release of the belt weight, never pushed from chest.

FKA twigs

E3–F6 · 3 octaves + 1



Soprano · UK · prominent since 2014 · known for “Two Weeks”

LOW E3 IN “FIGURE 8” · HIGH F6 IN “PREFACE”

Fragile, cry-tinged soprano thread trembling over sparse electronics, gliding from murmur to flute-high head tones.

Twigs starts tones as a fragile, cry-tinged thread and lets them tremble at the edge of breaking, a schooled control disguised as vulnerability. She glides between chest murmur and high, flute-like head voice with portamento, ornamenting like early-music soprano lines over electronic pulse. Dynamics operate at whisper scale. Students copying her confuse the tremble with instability; it is a supported cry reflex, larynx tilted, airflow tiny and constant, and the pitch underneath never actually wavers.

Tinashe

B2–E6 · 3 octaves + 5

Soprano USA · prominent since 2014 · known for “2 On”

LOW B2 IN “C'EST LA VIE”

Seamless, cool-toned mix that stays weightless from bass-adjacent lows to airy falsetto peaks.

Tinashe blends chest and head into one seamless, cool-toned mix that stays light no matter how high the line climbs. Her lower register is unusually solid for a soprano, and she moves through the break without any audible gear change. Runs are airy, fast, and slightly under-sung by design. Students copying her over-project; the style lives at half breath pressure, with pop-and-lock rhythmic precision in the phrasing and falsetto floated rather than aimed.

Bryson Tiller

A2–C6 · 3 octaves + 3

Tenor USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Don't”

Half-sung, half-rapped murmur with sighing phrase-ends and rare falsetto lifts.

Murmured, close-mic R&B phrasing that lives right at the speech-singing border. The tone is soft-edged and midweight, with minimal vibrato and phrase shapes that fall away like sighs; falsetto floats in for single words rather than full lines. Rhythm is the engine, and he places syllables like a rapper, slightly behind the beat. Students copying him confuse quiet with unsupported; the intimacy requires steady compressed airflow at low volume, and every slurred pitch still lands centered.

Kehlani

D3–E5 · 2 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Nights Like This”

Conversational R&B: a warm, slightly smoky mezzo that glides between melody and near-rap without a visible seam.

Flow is the discipline here. Lines slide from pitched melody into rhythmic speech and back inside a single bar, and the trick is that the speech is still supported and placed exactly where the melody was, so the seam never shows. Runs are short, tucked at phrase ends, more punctuation than display. Take one verse and mark which syllables are sung versus spoken, then keep the larynx and breath identical across the switch. Letting the spoken parts collapse into the throat breaks the illusion.

Post Malone

E2–E5 · 3 octaves



Baritone · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Circles”

LOW E2 IN “LEAVE” · HIGH E5 IN “BROKEN WHISKEY GLASS”

Fry-onset croon with twangy edge, constant upward slides, and a quick wobbling vibrato.

Wounded-croon delivery: a midweight voice with a bright, twangy edge, heavy vocal fry on onsets, and a fast tremolo-like vibrato that wobbles at phrase ends. He slides into most notes from beneath and lets a country-style cry color the sustained vowels. Belts stay narrow and pinched rather than open. Students copying him overdo the fry until pitch collapses; the style needs the fry to release into clean tone immediately, and the persistent slide must land dead center or the whole line sounds seasick.

Anderson .Paak

C3–F5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to G4 · USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “Come Down”

Drummer-brain soul: a raspy, grinning tenor that phrases like a snare pattern and smears bar lines for fun.

Groove placement is the genius. Phrases start late, rush the middle and snap the last syllable onto the pocket, a drummer's instinct applied to melody, in a sandy, sun-cracked tenor with a permanent smile in the vowels. The rasp is light and constant, never pushed. Falsetto arrives as quick yelps, not held lines. Practice singing over a metronome while deliberately dragging then catching up inside each bar. Straightening his timing to the grid removes the exact thing that makes it his.

H.E.R.

C3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C#5 · USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “Best Part”

Silk-textured neo-soul: a smoky mezzo with guitarist's phrasing, runs placed like fills between the vocal lines.

A guitarist's ear shapes the singing: phrases breathe like lead lines, with runs dropped in the gaps the way a player fills between chords, never on top of the lyric. The tone is smoky and slightly veiled, vibrato slow, dynamics kept low so the texture stays velvet. Runs favor pentatonic shapes, which is why they sound played. Practice singing a verse, then answering yourself in the rests with a three-note run. Cramming ornaments inside the lyric line is what she never does.

Daniel Caesar

C#3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to G#4 · Canada · prominent since 2017 · known for “Get You”

Church chords, bedroom volume: a feathery gospel tenor that stacks itself into choir harmony and floats the top lines.

Head voice does the heavy lifting. The lead tone is feather-light, mixed toward head even in the middle of the range, with gospel harmony instincts underneath: he hears himself as one voice of a stack, which keeps the lead unforced and tuning immaculate. Runs are unhurried, four and five notes, resolved like amen cadences. Record yourself singing a simple line, then stack two harmonies above it and re-sing the lead to sit inside them. Solo-singer loudness is the habit to unlearn here.

Steve Lacy

C#3–E5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to G#4 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Bad Habit”

Guitar-first slacker soul: a nonchalant tenor that flips into falsetto mid-word and treats sloppiness as a produced choice.

Nonchalance takes precision. The delivery slouches: lazy onsets, words half-swallowed, falsetto flips dropped casually mid-syllable, but the flips land on exact pitches and the doubled vocals line up tight, which is the tell that the mess is manufactured. The falsetto is bright and guitar-like, often harmonizing with his own lead. Practice flipping registers on a single word without pausing the phrase, at conversational volume. If the flip needs a running start, it reads as effort, and effort is the one thing this style cannot show.

SZA

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Kill Bill”

Breathy, conversational tone that slips between speech, soft belt, and thin airy top notes.

Nearly everything happens at conversation volume, breath left in the tone, phrase ends trailing off into speech or a whisper. Rhythm floats: syllables land late, then hurry to catch up. The soft belt around C5 is as loud as it gets, and above that the sound thins into an airy head voice instead of getting stronger. Small bends and slides do the job vibrato would normally do. Project it and the style disappears.

XXXTentacion

C3–F5 · 2 octaves + 5



Baritone · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “SAD!”

LOW C3 IN “SAD!” · HIGH F5 IN “HOPE”

Close-mic, breaking mid-voice that swings between whisper and pitched full-voice cry.

Bare, unprocessed-sounding delivery: a light, boyish mid-voice that cracks on purpose, recorded close enough to hear breath and room. Sung lines sit in a small comfortable range with simple stepwise tunes; intensity comes from dynamic swings between whisper and a full-voice cry near F5. Vibrato is minimal and unsteady by design. Students copying him treat the rawness as an absence of technique; the quiet verses need genuine breath control, and the cries must be pitched, not just loud.

Ella Mai

C3–G#5 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano UK · prominent since 2018 · known for “Boo'd Up”

Low, conversational melody with rounded London vowels and short, exact runs on the line endings.

Ella Mai sits in a low, conversational pocket, singing melody like dialogue with a soft London vowel color. Her runs are short, precise, and rhythmically placed, decorating line endings instead of dominating them. Tone stays rounded and slightly covered, with fry-touched onsets and restrained dynamics. Students copying her over-ornament; the style is built on economy, locking simple phrases to the drums and letting repetition, not range, create the hook.

Halle Bailey

C3–C6 · 3 octaves



Soprano full voice to G5 USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Part of Your World”

Feather-quick runs and bell-clear head voice, sweet-toned and classically poised.

Halle spins fast, feather-light runs with almost classical purity, each note articulated from the breath instead of the throat. Her head voice is clear and bell-toned, entered smoothly from a bright mix, and her belt stays sweet rather than brassy up to G5. Vibrato is quick, shimmering, consistent. Students copying her muscle the runs with jaw movement; hers ride on a still jaw, moving air, and vowels kept narrow so the pitch spins freely.

Juice WRLD

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5

Baritone USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Lucid Dreams”

LOW G2 IN “ALL GIRLS ARE THE SAME” · HIGH C5 IN “BLACK & WHITE”

Plainspoken melodic drawl, improvised in long takes with expressive line-end bends.

Freestyle-born melody-making: mid-voiced, slightly husky, with hooks improvised in long unbroken takes and pitch bent expressively at line ends. His tone is plain and unornamented, no runs and minimal vibrato, so emotion carries through timing and lyric stress. He sits mostly in one comfortable octave with brief pushed peaks near C5. Students copying him mistake plainness for ease; holding steady pitch on repeated notes without vibrato is exposed work, and every bend has to return to center.

Ravyn Lenae

C#3–C#6 · 3 octaves

Soprano USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Love Me Not”

LOW C#3 IN “DEEP IN THE WORLD” · HIGH C#6 IN “4 LEAF CLOVER”

High, glassy head voice with hummingbird vibrato, stacked into wide, straight-tuned harmony clouds.

Ravyn floats head voice as her home base, a high, glassy timbre with fast, fluttering vibrato that reads almost like a synth LFO. She layers herself in wide stacks, tunes upper harmonies dead straight, and drops to chest only for grounding contrast. Onsets are feathered, dynamics tiny. Students copying her treat the top as falsetto escape; hers is connected head voice with real cord closure, kept small on purpose and placed far forward.

Ari Lennox

Bb2–E6 · 3 octaves + 6



Soprano USA · prominent since 2019 · known for “Shea Butter Baby”

Plush, behind-the-beat neo-soul warmth; loose, blue-note runs poured out in a thick lower mix.

Ari rounds every phrase with a plush, soul-steeped warmth, singing mostly in chest and a thick lower mix that she bends with lazy, behind-the-beat phrasing. Runs spill out loose and conversational, full of blue notes, and her vibrato is wide and unhurried. Head voice is robust rather than wispy. Students copying her tidy the phrasing up and lose the feel; the slur is intentional, built on legato airflow, soft consonants, and total rhythmic confidence.

Summer Walker

D3–E5 · 2 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano full voice to A4 USA · prominent since 2019 · known for “Girls Need Love”

Whisper-soul: a feathered, half-asleep mezzo whose runs dissolve into breath before they finish.

Air is the instrument's finish. Every note carries deliberate breathiness, and runs decay: they start pitched and evaporate into pure breath by the last note, a diminuendo inside a single ornament. The tessitura stays low and close to speech, and dynamics rarely rise above a murmur. Work on running air over the cords while keeping the pitch core audible underneath, then practice runs that fade to nothing on purpose. Singers who keep full tone through her runs sound like they are correcting her.

Giveon

F#2–F#4 · 2 octaves



Baritone · full voice to E4 · USA · prominent since 2020 · known for “Heartbreak Anniversary”

A velvet anomaly: true baritone R&B in a falsetto era, with a wide, wowing vibrato that bends notes like a bowed saw.

Vibrato is the fingerprint: unusually wide and slow, arriving early in the note and wobbling the pitch so far that it flirts with the neighboring semitone before settling, over a plush, dark baritone that sits an octave below most modern R&B leads. Phrases end with a characteristic downward curl. To study it, sustain mid-range notes and let vibrato widen gradually past comfortable, keeping the center anchored. Most low voices imitate his darkness and miss that the wobble, not the depth, is the signature.

Teddy Swims

E2–A5 · 3 octaves + 5



Baritone · USA · prominent since 2020 · known for “Lose Control”

Gravel-heavy baritone that climbs into rasped high belts, with gospel runs on the way down.

Weight first. The tone sits low and thick, closer to a speaking growl than a croon, then opens into a rasped upper range that keeps chest character rather than thinning out. Matching his volume gets nowhere near the sound, because the grit is a texture laid over a steady pitch center. Dynamics swing hard inside a single line, the wide vibrato arriving late, and descending melisma is a habit: he lands the phrase, then unspools four or five notes on the way down.

Victoria Monét

B2–A5 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C#5 · USA · prominent since 2020 · known for “On My Mama”

Exhale-relaxed head-dominant mix; bright, small tone with horn-smooth runs sunk deep in the pocket.

Victoria leans on a head-dominant mix so relaxed it reads as exhale, keeping full-voice weight below C#5 and floating everything above it. Her tone is bright but small, with tasteful fry starting low phrases and vibrato used sparingly, mostly on final sustains. Runs are smooth, connected, horn-like. Students copying her aim for volume and lose the pocket; the sound requires singing at conversation level, releasing jaw tension, and letting compression come from the microphone.

NEXT Gospel and a cappella →

17 Gospel and a cappella

Everything the soul chapters borrowed, this chapter owns outright. Gospel is the source code: the run grammar that resolves like harmony, the shout built in waves, the squall — that controlled, ecstatic break at the top of a climb — and the dynamic arc that takes a room from silence to shaking in four minutes. The entries here describe the tradition's specialists at full strength, and the technical headline is stamina-with-abandon: these are the book's most demanding sustained sings, delivered weekly for decades, which is only possible because the abandon rides on ferocious, invisible support.

The chapter's second population is the a cappella and ensemble athletes — voices whose virtuosity is *blend*: tuning to each other in real time, trading lead and section roles, covering bass-to-whistle territory between a handful of people with no instruments to hide behind. Their entries are the atlas's best documentation of skills solo singing never tests: locking vowels with another voice, balancing to a chord, hearing yourself as a part.

Two borrowings recommend themselves. From the gospel wing, take the *build*: pick any song you sing and design its dynamics as a staircase the way these entries describe, arriving at full voice only when the song has earned it. From the ensemble wing, take the humility drill: record a simple melody, stack one harmony under it, and re-sing the lead to fit the chord. Every voice in this chapter got its authority from serving a room first; the technique follows the posture.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Mahalia Jackson

E3–F5 · 2 octaves + 1

Contralto · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 1947 · known for “Take My Hand, Precious Lord”

Chest-heavy contralto; slides into pitches and stretches syllables instead of landing them squarely.

Almost nothing lands squarely on the beat. Notes get approached from below, stretched, then leaned on until the vibrato arrives, slow and wide, at the end of the tone rather than the start. Weight stays in chest up to the D5 belt, with dynamic swells inside a single syllable. Students sing this loud and straight; the shape lives in the scoops, the time-stretching, and the sudden drops to almost nothing.

Karen Clark Sheard

F3–Eb6 · 2 octaves + 10

Soprano · full voice to Bb5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 1981 · known for “The Safest Place”

Wide chest belt plus a usable whistle register; stacks fast melisma over sustained cadences.

Two very different instruments answer each other here. Underneath, a wide chest-mix belt up to Bb5 with grit on the attack; above it, a clean whistle register used as punctuation rather than decoration. Melisma comes in fast stacks over a held cadence, often landing on the ninth or the flat seventh. Students chase the whistle first. Build the belt and the run vocabulary, because the top notes only read over that foundation.

Marvin Winans

A2–F5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · USA · prominent since 1981 · known for “Tomorrow”

Nasal, tightly focused tenor with wide vibrato; held notes thin out into falsetto at the top.

Placement is high and narrow, forward in the mask, which is what cuts through a full choir. Vibrato is wide and fast, often shaking harder at the end of a long note. Notice the gap between the Bb4 belt and the F5: those top notes thin deliberately into falsetto instead of thickening. Push chest up into that gap and the placement collapses along with the vibrato, which is where most imitations come apart.

Amy Grant

F3–E5 · 1 octave + 11



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1982 · known for “Baby Baby”

Conversational mezzo close to speech range; slight rasp, little ornament, breath-driven phrasing.

Speech is the reference point. Most lines sit between F3 and the C5 belt, close to talking pitch, with a light dryness in the tone and a trace of rasp underneath. Ornament is nearly absent, and phrases are shaped by where the breath falls rather than by riffs. The E5 top comes lightly. Over-singing flattens the whole effect, because the intimacy depends on staying at conversational volume.

Sandi Patty

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 1982 · known for “We Shall Behold Him”

Classically schooled soprano with a bright forward top and clean sustained highs at full volume.

Everything points to classical placement: steady breath support underneath, a bright forward ring, and sustained notes near C6 taken at full volume without thinning. Vibrato is present from the moment the tone starts, even and narrow. Legato lines get shaped as one long arc instead of word by word. The support has to come first, since high sustains expose breath that was snatched rather than set up.

Michael W. Smith

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 1983 · known for “Friends”

Thin, bright tenor built for high keys; reaches for head voice instead of pushing chest upward.

The tone stays forward and the chest weight stays deliberately light, which is what keeps it bright and slender rather than big. Melodies sit high for a tenor, and rather than dragging chest past the A4 belt the sound shifts into head voice and holds that slimmer shape up to D5. Onsets are clean, vibrato modest. All of it depends on releasing weight as the line rises, which feels smaller from the inside than it sounds from out front.

Fred Hammond

E2–Bb4 · 2 octaves + 6



Bass-baritone · full voice to G4 · USA · prominent since 1985 · known for “No Weapon”

Deep bass-baritone with thick low resonance; half-speaks phrases over funk and quartet grooves.

Bottom-heavy and unhurried. The E2 region gives a thick chest resonance that stays un-pushed, with lines half-spoken over the groove and the voice only opening toward the G4 belt for a payoff. Attack is relaxed and often just behind the beat, with quartet-style bends on the ends of words. Imitators reach for volume, but the character comes from resonance and rhythmic patience instead of force.

BeBe Winans

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 1987 · known for “Addictive Love”

Warm mid-weight tenor that slips into a soft-edged falsetto with no audible gear change.

Onsets are soft and aspirate rather than hard and glottal, and the body of the tone sits mid-weight and warm. The distance between the A4 belt and the E5 top tells you what happens up there: instead of pushing chest, the tone thins and slides into a rounded falsetto, and the handoff is hard to hear. Vibrato is gentle and late. Work that connection quietly at first, because forcing it makes the seam obvious immediately.

CeCe Winans

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 1987 · known for “Alabaster Box”

Light lyric soprano, very even across the break; sparse ornament and a narrow, steady vibrato.

Listen for how little changes between F3 and the G5 belt: the same vowel shape, the same narrow vibrato, no seam where the register should shift. Ornament is sparse and placed, usually one small turn at the end of a line rather than a cascade. Anyone working on this should strip the runs out first, hold the tone identical through the transition, and let the top float instead of driving it.

Yolanda Adams

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 1987 · known for “Open My Heart”

Smoky bottom under a bright top; breathy onsets and clipped, jazz-leaning phrase endings.

Air comes before tone on almost every onset, consonants get clipped, and phrase endings cut off early the way a horn player would take them. Below the F5 belt the sound is smoky and thick; above it the tone lightens into head voice instead of pushing. Sitting a fraction behind the beat is part of it. Belt the soft passages and it collapses; the quiet, airy delivery is carrying the whole thing.

Tamela Mann

F3–C#6 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano USA · prominent since 1993 · known for “Take Me to the King”

LOW F3 IN “TAKE ME TO THE KING” · HIGH C#6 IN “GOD PROVIDES”

Massive gospel soprano that moves from grounded alto warmth to ringing, sustained climaxes without strain.

Mann builds every climax from the breath down: wide ribcage anchor, low-larynx warmth in the verses, then a mixed belt that keeps thyroid tilt so the top rings instead of shouting. Her vibrato is broad and slow, arriving after a straight-tone hold. Runs are deliberate — fewer notes, heavier landings. Near F3 she speaks on pitch; approaching C#6 she narrows the vowel and lets resonance do the sizing. The copying error is volume-first belting; her loudness is a byproduct of anchored breath and a released jaw, never a push from the throat.

Kim Burrell

E3–D6 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano full voice to A5 USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “I See a Victory”

Jazz harmonic sense in a gospel frame; chromatic runs, then sudden drops to a spoken chest tone.

Harmony drives the line. Runs move chromatically through altered notes rather than sliding up a pentatonic shape, and phrases get displaced across the bar so the resolution arrives late. A climb toward A5 in full voice can drop without warning into a near-spoken chest tone at conversational volume. Copying the runs note-for-note misses it: the ear has to hear the passing chords first, or the chromatics just sound like mistakes.

Donnie McClurkin

B2–E5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “We Fall Down”

Reedy, high-placed tenor with quick access to falsetto and a narrow, fluttering vibrato.

Reedy and high-placed, with a narrow fluttering vibrato sitting right on top of the tone. Falsetto is a step away at any moment, so lines slip in and out of it mid-phrase without ceremony. Long notes get thinner as they go rather than louder. Full voice tops out around the A4 belt, and the E5 belongs to a lighter mechanism. Copying this with a heavy chest sound loses the reediness completely.

Marvin Sapp

D#2–F5 · 3 octaves + 2



Baritone · USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Never Would Have Made It”

LOW D#2 IN “MY TESTIMONY” · HIGH F5 IN “THE BEST IN ME”

Preacher's baritone that builds from spoken grit to sustained, wide-vibrato cries at the top of the belt.

Sapp preaches and sings with one mechanism: speech-quality onset, mask-forward placement, and phrases that accelerate like sentences rather than scan like bars. His baritone sits dark and grounded near D#2, but the climactic cries ascend in mix, wide vibrato blooming only at the sustain. He repeats motifs with rising intensity — same notes, more compression — which is the gospel build imitators rush. Students also over-darken the tone to sound weighty; his depth comes from breath anchoring, not vowel swallowing. Practice sustained vowels that crescendo without spreading, then add the growl as color, last.

David Phelps

E2–D5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor USA · prominent since 1997 · known for “End of the Beginning”

LOW E2 IN “ARMS OPEN WIDE” · HIGH D5 IN “LET THE GLORY COME DOWN”

Gleaming gospel tenor with operatic ring, huge sustained climaxes, and a floated head voice for quiet verses.

Phelps runs a classically schooled tenor through gospel phrasing: lifted soft palate, ringing squillo, and long-breath legato lines that crescendo through sustained vowels. His vibrato is constant and symmetrical, even at full volume. He approaches climaxes by vowel modification so the top stays connected instead of flipping. The low extension near E2 is soft-spoken color, not projection. What students copy wrong is the volume arc: they start loud and have nowhere to go, while he banks breath early and spends it on the final phrase, ending at D5 still supported.

Chris Tomlin

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor full voice to B4 USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “How Great Is Our God”

Light, airy tenor with modest chest weight; writes in keys that park him in his upper mix.

Airy and unforced, with modest chest weight and a slightly breathy edge on the low notes. Keys are chosen to park the voice in upper mix around B4, which is why the melodies feel high but rarely strained. Rhythm stays square, sung close to the beat so a room can follow it on first hearing. Adding power is the mistake; the thinness is exactly what makes these lines singable by a crowd.

Smokie Norful

D2–D#5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “I Need You Now”

LOW D2 IN “CAN'T NOBODY” · HIGH D#5 IN “WORTHY”

Husky piano-man gospel tenor; murmured lows, pleading melisma, and belts that arrive like answered prayers.

Norful phrases from the piano bench: rubato breaths, suspended silences, and melodic lines that resolve just behind the harmony. The core sound is a husky, compressed mix with a raised-chest belt that pleads rather than proclaims. His lows toward D2 are murmured chest tones close to the mic; his top near D#5 arrives through staged repetition, each pass a step more compressed. Melisma is fast but gravity-bound, always falling back to the tonic. Imitators oversing the runs and miss the restraint — most of his intensity is dynamic contrast, a whisper set right before a wail.

Tim Storms

B0–B4 · 4 octaves



Bass full voice to D4 USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “Lonesome Road”

LOW B0 IN “LONESOME ROAD” · HIGH B4 IN “LONESOME ROAD”

Subterranean basso profondo rumble that blurs into pure vibration; Guinness lists him for lows deeper than human hearing.

Storms anchors everything in slack, low-pressure vocal folds: subglottal pressure stays tiny, closure stays gentle, and the tone drops toward B0 as fry and true phonation blur together. Resonance comes from a lowered larynx and huge pharyngeal space, not force. Above D4 he flips to a soft, unforced falsetto rather than pushing chest. Students copying him usually squeeze the throat chasing depth; he releases instead, letting air pass slowly and the folds go slack. Slow airflow, tall posture, zero neck tension — the depth is a relaxation trick, not a strength trick.

Avi Kaplan

Eb1–Db5 · 3 octaves + 10



Bass · full voice to E4 · USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Little Drummer Boy”

Bass who drops into fry and subharmonics for pedal tones well under the written staff.

Below the staff is where the character is. Pedal tones near the bottom come from vocal fry and subharmonic reinforcement rather than ordinary phonation, which is why they read like an octave doubler under the chord. Higher up the tone turns soft and folk-leaning, with light breath and simple ornament toward the E4 belt. Pressing down to reach those low notes is the classic error; they need a loose setup and very little air.

Kirstin Maldonado

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Can't Sleep Love”

Theatre-trained mezzo with a firm chest belt, tight vowel shapes and controlled vibrato.

The vowels are the giveaway: narrow, forward, and identical take to take, sitting under a chest-mix belt that keeps its brightness through G5. Onsets are precise rather than scooped, vibrato gets switched on deliberately at the ends of sustains, and diction stays crisp at speed. Above the belt the sound thins into a light head voice. Loosen the vowel shape and the belt immediately loses focus.

Mitch Grassi

F2–C7 · 4 octaves + 7



Countertenor | full voice to C5 | whistle register | USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Hallelujah”

Countertenor who lives above the staff: light chest, agile head voice, whistle notes on top.

Living above the staff changes the whole setup. Chest stays light, the head voice is agile enough to run sixteenths cleanly, and whistle notes get used as accents near the very top rather than as sustained material. R&B ornament arrives small and bright: quick riffs, bent thirds, tight melisma. None of that altitude comes from pressure underneath. It comes from taking weight off, which is the opposite of what pushing high feels like.

Scott Hoying

F2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 5



Baritone | full voice to C5 | USA · prominent since 2011 · known for “Sing”

Baritone bottom with a bright high mix; percussive consonants anchor a cappella arrangements.

A baritone bottom that anchors a stack, then a bright forward mix up to the C5 belt whenever the lead line comes around. Consonants get cut percussively so rhythm reads in an unaccompanied texture, and vowels are matched tightly to whoever sits next in the harmony. Vibrato stays controlled, mostly held back until the end of a phrase. Sing it with a wide vibrato and the chord blurs.

Geoff Castellucci

B0–Bb5 · 4 octaves + 11



Bass-baritone · full voice to E4 · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Sixteen Tons”

LOW B0 IN “VALHALLA CALLING” · HIGH BB5 IN “PEACHES”

Cavernous, woofer-deep bass with a grinning croon on top and playful fry drops far below the staff.

Castellucci builds his sound on subharmonic and fry blends: near B0 he lets the folds beat at half rate, keeping the jaw loose so the pitch reads lower than the effort. His speaking-level mix carries to about E4 before he hands off to a bright, character-driven falsetto up to Bb5. Onsets are playful and percussive — he treats consonants as rhythm. The trap for imitators is muscling the low notes with pressed compression; his lows are quiet at the source and loud in the mic. Close-mic craft, relaxed larynx, exaggerated diction: that is the engine.

Tasha Cobbs Leonard

D3–A5 · 2 octaves + 7



Contralto · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Break Every Chain”

Dark, thick contralto that stays in chest; builds by adding weight rather than climbing higher.

Weight, not height, is how the build happens. The voice sits dark and thick through the F5 belt, vowels kept round and back, and intensity grows by adding body and repeating a phrase rather than climbing toward the A5. Onsets are firm without being harsh, and vibrato arrives late on the sustains. The trap is shouting; add depth and breath pressure gradually and keep the larynx settled as the volume rises.

Lauren Daigle

E3–A5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “You Say”

Husky, grainy mezzo pitched low in her range; heavy rasp on consonants, slow wide vibrato.

A husky, slightly pressed tone with grain riding the consonants, and melodies written low enough that whole verses sit just above the E3 floor before anything lifts. Vibrato is slow and wide and shows up at the end of a held note rather than the beginning. Phrasing drags behind the beat, words chewed rather than pronounced. That grain is a byproduct of the low, relaxed placement, not something to squeeze out on purpose.

NEXT Country →

PART VI

Country, folk and jazz

18 Country 248

19 Folk and the songwriters 273

20 Jazz and the standards 290

CONTENTS

18 Country

Country is the most misunderstood technique chapter in the book, because its defining sound — twang — gets heard as an accent when it is actually an acoustic technology. That bright, narrow, penetrating buzz is what let unamplified voices cut through honky-tonk noise, and the modern genre kept it as identity: the entries here describe voices getting *louder by getting narrower*, from the classic criers to the current stadium baritones. The related signature, the break — that quick flip into falsetto and back, the yodel's descendant — turns up across generations as country's preferred emotional punctuation, always placed, never accidental.

The other structural fact is tessitura: country lives at speech pitch more faithfully than any other genre here, because the genre's contract is storytelling and stories are told, not belted. That makes this chapter the most singable chapter in the atlas for average voices, and it makes the accent question unavoidable. The entries treat regional vowel color as part of the instrument — as load-bearing as any placement choice — and the borrower's advice that follows from them is blunt: work on the vowels or pick different repertoire, because neutralizing them removes the actual sound.

What this chapter teaches beyond its borders: diction under drawl (every word lands despite the slur), dynamic honesty (peaks rationed to where the story peaks), and the discipline of sitting in a narrow, comfortable band for forty minutes and making variety out of phrasing

instead of altitude. Every genre's singers get better at their own music after a month in this room.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Hank Williams

A2–A4 · 2 octaves

Tenor USA · prominent since 1947 · known for “Your Cheatin' Heart”

HIGH A4 IN “LOVESICK BLUES”

Thin keening tenor that flips into yodel breaks; hard nasal placement, cries on the vowel.

Nasal placement is extreme and deliberate, and that is what gives the thin, keening carry over a band. Vowels get a cry on them, an audible pinch that reads as ache, and the register break is thrown wide open into a yodel flip, clearest in Lovesick Blues. Timing pushes slightly ahead of the beat. The break tends to get dodged entirely, or the flip gets attempted on a closed vowel, which will not release.

George Jones

B1–B4 · 3 octaves



Baritone USA · prominent since 1955 · known for “He Stopped Loving Her Today”

LOW B1 IN “RADIO LOVER” · HIGH B4 IN “COULDN'T LOVE HAVE PICKED A BETTER PLACE TO DIE”

Pinched, bending baritone that curls every syllable — grief carried through ornament and sudden drops to the bottom of the staff.

Jones bends pitch the way a steel player bends strings: he scoops into a syllable, curls it through a triplet, and clips it with a hard glottal stop. The tone stays pinched and nasal up top while the jaw drops for sudden dives toward B1. Keep the larynx loose and let vowels distort; students who sing his lines cleanly miss the point, because the ornament carries the grief, not the lyric.

Johnny Cash

E2–E4 · 2 octaves



Bass-baritone USA · prominent since 1955 · known for “Ring of Fire”

Narrow bass-baritone with a flat, spoken attack; adds volume rather than pitch at the top.

Speech is the starting point. The tone sits low and forward with almost no vibrato, and phrases land squarely on the beat next to that clipped, chugging rhythm. Onsets are soft rather than punched. Near the E4 ceiling he adds breath and volume instead of brightness. Students go wrong by pressing the larynx down to manufacture depth, which kills the flat, easy speaking quality the whole sound depends on.

Patsy Cline

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Contralto USA · prominent since 1957 · known for “Crazy”

Warm contralto with a controlled sob on held notes and heavy, deliberate slides between them.

Weight sits in the chest register for most of the range, with slow, heavy portamento carrying you between notes rather than clean intervals. Vibrato arrives late on a sustained tone, often preceded by a small catch that reads as a sob. Toward D5 the sound thins gently instead of belting. Overdone, that catch turns into a wobble; it works as one placed break inside an otherwise steady line.

Loretta Lynn

G3–D5 · 1 octave + 7



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1960 · known for “Coal Miner's Daughter”

Nasal Appalachian mezzo, hard consonants, a bent and talking approach to the melody line.

You hear the nose first: placement is high and forward, vowels flattened toward speech, consonants struck hard enough to become part of the rhythm. Melody gets bent, notes approached from under and pushed up into, sometimes talked more than sung. Chest-weighted tone covers most of the G3-D5 span with no flip into anything lighter. Round the vowels out and the accent goes with them, and the accent is where the feeling actually lives.

Willie Nelson

G2–F4 · 1 octave + 10



Tenor USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “On the Road Again”

Light nasal tenor that lags behind the beat and slides into notes instead of landing on them.

Almost everything here is timing. Notes arrive late, behind where the band puts them, then slide up or down into pitch instead of starting there. Tone stays light and nasal, close to speech, with very little vibrato and no push at the F4 ceiling. Copy the drag but resolve early and you land back on the beat too soon; the phrase should only catch up at the very end of the line.

Merle Haggard

F2–E4 · 1 octave + 11



Baritone USA · prominent since 1965 · known for “Okie from Muskogee”

Relaxed baritone with jazz-tinged timing; bends up into notes and stays behind the beat.

Phrasing leans back the way a jazz singer's does, notes set a hair behind the beat and bent up into from below. Tone is relaxed and mid-weight, never pressed, with light vibrato that only surfaces as a note is ending. The E4 top is reached by opening the vowel rather than adding volume. Students copy the looseness and lose the tuning; behind the beat still has to be precisely behind it.

Waylon Jennings

E2–D4 · 1 octave + 10



Bass-baritone USA · prominent since 1965 · known for “Good Hearted Woman”

Dark chesty bass-baritone pushed against a hard backbeat; almost no head-voice extension.

Chest register does all the work: dark, thick, and driven straight at a hard backbeat, consonants landing on the accent. There is essentially no lighter extension above the D4 top, so lines stay low and repeat instead of climbing. Onsets are firm, close to glottal, and vibrato is minimal. Copying the darkness by dropping the jaw and swallowing the tone just makes it muddy; this sound is dark but still forward.

Tammy Wynette

G3–E5 · 1 octave + 9



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1966 · known for “Stand by Your Man”

HIGH E5 IN “STAND BY YOUR MAN”

Mezzo who uses her own register break as a teardrop catch at the ends of lines.

The register break is not hidden, it is used. Phrases build in chest, then at the end of a line the voice deliberately cracks up into a lighter register for a beat, the teardrop catch. Otherwise the tone is warm and even, with moderate vibrato and slow, weighted slides. Get this wrong and you crack randomly mid-word; the catch has to be placed, in the same spot in the phrase every time.

Dolly Parton

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Soprano USA · prominent since 1967 · known for “Jolene”

Bright soprano, fast narrow vibrato, thin forward tone that cuts through banjo and fiddle.

Placement is high and forward, close to the nose, which is what lets a light soprano cut through banjo and fiddle without volume. Vibrato is fast and narrow and starts almost as soon as a note does. Notes are often begun with a small breathy onset and decorated with quick grace-note flips. Climbing toward Bb5 the tone thins into head voice rather than thickening. Imitators add weight and lose the sparkle.

Glen Campbell

F2–A4 · 2 octaves + 4



Tenor USA · prominent since 1967 · known for “Rhinestone Cowboy”

Bright, exact session-singer tenor — clean onsets, even vibrato, and pop polish over country heartbreak.

Campbell sings like a session player thinks: dead-center pitch, even vibrato saved for the tail of long tones, and consonants placed exactly on the beat. The tone is bright, forward, and unforced through the passaggio, with a light head-voice turn instead of a push above the staff. Copy the restraint first; students usually oversell the big phrases he undersells, and the Nashville polish collapses into karaoke.

Kenny Rogers

D2–D5 · 3 octaves



Baritone USA · prominent since 1968 · known for “The Gambler”

LOW D2 IN “THE HOODOOIN' OF MISS FANNIE DEBERRY” · HIGH D5 IN “I DON'T WANNA HAVE TO WORRY”

Husky, air-edged baritone that tells stories at speech level, gravel riding on an easy breath.

Rogers works a husky, air-edged baritone with the rasp sitting on top of a relaxed, speech-level production. He phrases like a storyteller: short spoken pickups, long settled vowels, and a small vibrato that arrives late. The grain is a texture, not a strain; students who manufacture the gravel by squeezing the throat lose his ease and his pitch. Keep the delivery conversational and let the huskiness ride on breath.

John Denver

G2–B5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor USA · prominent since 1971 · known for “Take Me Home, Country Roads”

LOW G2 IN “SOME DAYS ARE DIAMONDS (SOME DAYS ARE STONE)” · HIGH B5 IN “THANK GOD I'M A COUNTRY BOY (LIVE)”

Open, ringing head-voice tenor that stays boyish at volume, with a clean yodel flip at the top.

Denver rides an open, ringing head-mix with almost no audible register shift; the sound sits high in the mask and stays boyish even at volume. Vibrato is narrow and steady, onsets are clean, and sustained vowels stay pure rather than diphthonged. His yodel-flip up toward B5 is a controlled break, not a crack. Students copying him tend to push chest too high instead of letting the tone lighten early.

Emmylou Harris

G3–D5 · 1 octave + 7



Soprano USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “Boulder to Birmingham”

Silvery soprano with a fragile edge on sustained notes; built to sit above a lead vocal.

Tone is silvery and slightly thin, with a fine tremor rather than a wide vibrato on sustained notes, and that thinness is what lets it sit above a lead vocal without fighting it. Onsets are gentle, pitch placed a touch high in the note. Ornament is sparse and vowels are matched carefully, the mark of a harmony singer. Reach for more volume and the tone thickens, and the fragile edge is the first thing lost.

Reba McEntire

E3–F5 · 2 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano full voice to D5 USA · prominent since 1977 · known for “Fancy”

Oklahoma twang over a strong chest belt; breaks into a deliberate cry at the top of phrases.

Twang does the work up front: a bright, narrow, forward vowel that keeps the belt from sounding heavy. Chest-weighted mix carries confidently to about D5, and above that toward F5 the sound releases into a thinner cry rather than more push. Consonants are crisp, and line endings often break upward into that cry on purpose. Shouted from the throat, the belt spreads and tires fast; the narrow vowel is what makes it carry.

George Strait

A2–E4 · 1 octave + 7



Baritone USA · prominent since 1981 · known for “Amarillo by Morning”

Unhurried baritone, almost no vibrato, phrasing shaped for two-step and Western swing.

Restraint is the technique. The tone is even and unbrightened, vibrato nearly absent, onsets clean with no scoop into pitch. Phrasing sits inside the shuffle or swing feel and rarely displaces a note for effect. Melody gets sung close to as written, ornament limited to a small turn at a cadence. Singers imitating this add runs and vibrato to fill the space, which is exactly what the style takes out.

Vince Gill

A2–C5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor full voice to A4 USA · prominent since 1984 · known for “Go Rest High on That Mountain”

High sweet tenor thinning into clean falsetto; harmony-trained blend, steady even vibrato.

Two registers, joined carefully. Full voice reaches about A4 with a sweet, unheavy tone, and above that the sound thins into clean falsetto toward C5 with no bump at the seam. Vibrato is even in both rate and width, tuning sits exact, and vowels are matched the way a harmony part has to match. The thing to avoid is muscling the top; it wants to get lighter as it climbs, not louder.

Wynonna Judd

E3–E5 · 2 octaves



Contralto USA · prominent since 1984 · known for “No One Else on Earth”

LOW E3 IN “SHE IS HIS ONLY NEED” · HIGH E5 IN “LOVE BY GRACE”

Thick gospel-blues contralto — growled onsets, wide vibrato, a murmur that swells to a roar.

Judd plants her sound in a thick contralto chest voice colored by gospel and blues: growled onsets, back-phrased lines, and a wide vibrato that opens up on held notes. She swells from a murmur to a roar within a single phrase while the pitch center never drifts. Students copying her start at the roar; the power reads because it emerges from genuine softness, with the throat staying open.

Randy Travis

F2–E4 · 1 octave + 11



Baritone USA · prominent since 1986 · known for “Forever and Ever, Amen”

Round, resonant baritone with long downward slides and a heavy drawl on line endings.

Resonance is low and round, the sound sitting behind the teeth rather than up in the nose. Long downward slides finish most phrases, and diphthongs get drawled so the second vowel becomes its own small note. Vibrato is narrow and arrives late, when it arrives. Take on the drawl and the pitch tends to sag with it; every slide still has to land on a definite note instead of trailing away.

Alison Krauss

G3–D5 · 1 octave + 7



Soprano USA · prominent since 1987 · known for “When You Say Nothing at All”

Straight-tone soprano, nearly breathless, exact intonation and very little ornament.

Very little happens on purpose here, which is what makes it hard. Tone stays straight with only a trace of vibrato late in a long note, dynamics stay quiet, and pitch is placed dead center with no scoop in. Onsets are soft, almost breath-first. Ornament is nearly absent, so every vowel is exposed. Sing this with normal vibrato habits and you find out how much of your tuning the vibrato was hiding.

Garth Brooks

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 1989 · known for “Friends in Low Places”

Sturdy baritone that takes its grit from breath pressure; stage-shout delivery up high.

Grit here comes from breath pressure against a fairly open throat, not from scraping. Onsets are aspirate, a little air ahead of the tone, and vibrato is wide and shows up at the ends of long notes. Approaching A4 the delivery turns into a stage shout, chest-weighted and open-vowelled. Copy the volume without the air behind it and you get a squeezed, hoarse sound that will not survive a set.

Alan Jackson

E2–B4 · 2 octaves + 7



Baritone USA · prominent since 1990 · known for “Chattahoochee”

LOW E2 IN “IT'S FIVE O'CLOCK SOMEWHERE” · HIGH B4 IN “WHO'S CHEATIN' WHO”

Easy Georgia drawl over a mid-set honky-tonk baritone — scooped vowels, lazy vibrato, exact pitch.

Jackson keeps everything in an easy honky-tonk drawl: wide Georgia vowels, gentle scoops into almost every downbeat, and a lazy vibrato that barely waves. The voice sits mid-baritone and never pushes; high phrases are leaned into with twang rather than belted. What students miss is the vowel work — he sings the accent, bending words into two-syllable shapes, and the pitch stays exact underneath all that drawl.

Trisha Yearwood

D3–A5 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1991 · known for “She's in Love with the Boy”

LOW D3 IN “WHERE YOUR ROAD LEADS” · HIGH A5 IN “IN ANOTHER'S EYES”

Round, exact mezzo with seamless registers — long legato swells and dead-center intonation.

Yearwood owns one of country's most exact instruments: intonation dead center, long legato lines, and dynamic swells that build across whole verses rather than single notes. Her chest voice is round and unforced, and she crosses into head voice with no seam, keeping vibrato even throughout. Students copying her focus on the big finishes; the discipline is in the quiet bars, where every vowel stays perfectly matched.

Martina McBride

F3–F5 · 2 octaves



Soprano USA · prominent since 1992 · known for “Independence Day”

Country soprano who belts from a braced chest mix; clean vowels, no scoop into the high notes.

The vowels stay square, and every note begins straight on pitch with no slide up to it. The belt runs on a braced chest mix with the ribs held wide, staying bright and even from mid-staff up toward F5 instead of thickening as it climbs. Vibrato stays narrow and arrives late, often only in the last beat of a held note. Dropping the jaw for extra power swallows the forward ring that carries the belt.

Faith Hill

C3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano full voice to F5 USA · prominent since 1993 · known for “Breathe”

Warm mezzo with a bright, tall belt and seamless head-voice release — pop-clean diction over country warmth.

Hill balances a warm lower-middle register against a bright, spread belt that stays plumb up to F5. Her onsets are precise, her vibrato even and unhurried, and she moves between chest and head with a smooth mix instead of an audible gear change. Diction stays polished, almost pop-clean. Students copying her tend to widen the belt vowels too early; she keeps them tall until the phrase peaks, then releases into head voice.

Tim McGraw

F2–B4 · 2 octaves + 6



Baritone USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Live Like You Were Dying”

LOW F2 IN “SHE'S MY KIND OF RAIN” · HIGH B4 IN “LAST DOLLAR (FLY AWAY)”

Nasal, twang-forward baritone that cuts the mix on resonance, not power — talk-sung verses, sliding choruses.

McGraw leans on a nasal, twang-forward placement that keeps a modest voice cutting through loud band mixes. He speaks-sings the verses, slides up into choruses, and lets the vibrato stay tight and fast. The sound is more resonance than power: cheekbone buzz, narrow vowels, relaxed jaw. Students chasing his tone usually add throat weight; the twang should come from the soft palate area, not from pressure.

Shania Twain

E3–E5 · 2 octaves



Mezzo-soprano full voice to C5 Canada · prominent since 1995 · known for “You're Still the One”

Bright mezzo with a clipped percussive attack, slipping into a thin upper register on hooks.

Attack is percussive and clipped, consonants working as rhythm, phrases cut off early rather than held out. Chest mix belts comfortably to about C5, and above that toward E5 the tone deliberately thins on hook notes for contrast. Vibrato is light and used sparingly. Smooth all of it into a legato line and the rhythmic snap the whole delivery is built on drains away.

LeAnn Rimes

F3–F5 · 2 octaves



Soprano USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Blue”

HIGH F5 IN “BLUE”

Fast, wide vibrato and a clean yodel flip between chest and head voice, trained from childhood.

That fast, wide vibrato is the fingerprint, and it sits under nearly the whole length of a held note rather than showing up at the end. The chest register is thick for a soprano, and the register change becomes an ornament in its own right: a deliberate yodel flip up into head voice and straight back down, clean enough to use as rhythm. Notes are often bent into from underneath, with short, precise turns. The flip works by releasing the chest note, not by forcing through it.

Trace Adkins

D2–G4 · 2 octaves + 5



Bass-baritone USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “You're Gonna Miss This”

LOW D2 IN “LADIES LOVE COUNTRY BOYS” · HIGH G4 IN “THEN THEY DO”

Boom-deep chest voice with a cutting nasal twang — thunder low, spoken swagger up the middle.

Adkins drives a huge, dark chest voice with a pronounced nasal twang riding on top, so the sound is both cavernous and cutting. He speaks phrases low in the range, then swells into sustained tones with a slow vibrato. The low notes stay connected to breath rather than dropping into fry. Students copying him confuse loud with deep; his resonance comes from tracheal space and posture, not shouting.

Kenny Chesney

D#2–F#4 · 2 octaves + 3

Tenor USA · prominent since 1997 · known for “No Shoes, No Shirt, No Problems”

LOW D#2 IN “HEMINGWAY'S WHISKEY” · HIGH F#4 IN “YOU HAD ME FROM HELLO”

Light, sanded tenor that sits in the pocket — conversational mids, quiet low drops, falsetto used as color.

Chesney works a light, reedy tenor that sits conversationally in the middle of the staff and rarely strains for drama. The tone is sanded smooth, slightly nasal, with quick decays and little vibrato until a note is held. He drops surprisingly low in quiet ballad verses and floats falsetto for color rather than height. Students overdo his ease as blandness; the skill is diction and groove placed exactly on the band's pocket.

Keith Urban

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4

Tenor Australia · prominent since 2000 · known for “Somebody Like You”

LOW F2 IN “GETTIN' IN THE WAY” · HIGH A5 IN “RAISE THE BARN”

Husky low tenor with pop phrasing — twangy mid-octave belts and a breathy falsetto for color.

Urban is a low-set tenor who sings close to speech, with a husky edge and pop-style phrasing that lands just behind the guitar groove. His belt carries into the mid-fourth octave on pure twang, and above that he flips to a breathy falsetto for color. Onsets are soft, endings often fall away. The mistake students make is muscling his high lines; he narrows the vowel and keeps the volume moderate.

Blake Shelton

D2–C#5 · 2 octaves + 11



Baritone USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “God's Country”

LOW D2 IN “NEON LIGHT” · HIGH C#5 IN “THAT THING WE DO”

Warm, roomy baritone with slow-burn vibrato — resonant lows and a light country curl up top.

Shelton anchors his sound in a wide-open chest voice with a big, slow-burn vibrato and generous back-vowel space. Low phrases toward D2 stay resonant because he keeps the soft palate high instead of swallowing the tone. Up top he mixes surprisingly light, sliding into notes with a country curl. Students copying him overdo the darkness; his warmth comes from space, not from pressing the larynx down.

Josh Turner

Ab1–C#5 · 3 octaves + 5



Bass-baritone USA · prominent since 2003 · known for “Your Man”

HIGH C#5 IN “HAYWIRE”

Cavernous, relaxed bass-baritone — subterranean lows that bloom instead of fry, topped by a mellow belt.

Turner produces his depth with a low, stable larynx and enormous pharyngeal space, letting notes near Ab1 bloom instead of fry. The voice stays velar-dark yet clearly pitched, with a slow, wide vibrato on sustained tones. His upper range is a mellow, rounded belt he uses sparingly. Students imitating him press the larynx down and growl; the real sound is relaxed, resonant, and quieter than it seems.

Carrie Underwood

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · full voice to G5 · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Before He Cheats”

Supported belt that hands off to a clean head voice; rasp on peaks without losing center.

Mix carries a lot of chest weight up to about G5 and the transition is smoothed rather than broken, so you rarely hear the gear change. Past the belt the voice releases into a clean head register reaching toward C6 without thickening. Rasp gets added on peak notes as surface texture while the core pitch stays centered. The common error is yelling the belt on a wide vowel instead of narrowing it and keeping air moving.

Miranda Lambert

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Mezzo-soprano · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “The House That Built Me”

LOW E3 IN “MAMA'S BROKEN HEART” · HIGH D5 IN “SOMETHIN' BAD”

Bright, pressurized chest-mix with a controlled snarl — intimacy to full blast inside one phrase.

Lambert trades range for pressure: a bright, brassy chest-mix driven hard through the middle of the voice, with Texas vowels and a controlled snarl on consonants. Quiet verses turn suddenly intimate, almost airy, before she slams back to full voice. Vibrato stays narrow. The student error is treating her belt as anger; the volume is supported and placed forward, never squeezed at the throat.

Kacey Musgraves

G3–D5 · 1 octave + 7



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2013 · known for “Rainbow”

Soft-edged mezzo close to the mic, breath left in the tone, melody kept conversational.

Everything stays close to the microphone and close to speech. Air is left in the tone deliberately, onsets are soft, and vibrato is minimal, a small tail at the end of a note rather than through it. The line sits mid-staff where talking is comfortable, consonants relaxed. Sung at full volume the style disappears, so the real work is staying intelligible and in tune at that low a dynamic.

Sturgill Simpson

Eb2–C#6 · 3 octaves + 10



Baritone USA · prominent since 2014 · known for “Turtles All the Way Down”

HIGH C#6 IN “CALL TO ARMS (LIVE)”

Slurred outlaw baritone that builds from croon to overdriven full-voice wail without losing pitch.

Simpson starts from a slurred, marble-mouthed outlaw baritone, then detonates: he drags belts upward with increasing rasp toward the top of the range. The low register is loose and conversational; the top is compressed, distorted on purpose, and held with startling breath support. Vowels stay dark even at extreme volume. Students copying the scream first get hurt; the graduated build from croon to overdrive is the actual technique.

Chris Stapleton

F2–B4 · 2 octaves + 6



Baritone USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Tennessee Whiskey”

HIGH B4 IN “TENNESSEE WHISKEY”

Gravel-heavy baritone with gospel-blues runs; carries high lines in full voice, not falsetto.

Distortion sits on top of a well-supported baritone tone, so the grain never swallows the pitch. Phrasing comes out of gospel and blues: melisma around the flatted third and seventh, notes bent into from underneath, vibrato withheld until a sustain is nearly over. High lines toward B4 stay in full voice rather than flipping. Made with the throat itself, that rasp goes hoarse inside a set; it belongs on the airflow above a steady tone.

Kane Brown

E2–F4 · 2 octaves + 1



Baritone USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “Heaven”

LOW E2 IN “SHORT SKIRT WEATHER” · HIGH F4 IN “HEAVEN”

Plush low baritone with pop-R&B phrasing — dark tone, soft onsets, melody kept close to speech.

Brown blends a plush low register with pop-R&B phrasing: melisma kept short, consonants soft, rhythm slightly behind the beat. The voice is naturally dark, with a rounded, almost sung-spoken onset and minimal vibrato. He rarely leaves the staff, so the interest lives in tone shading. Students copying him chase depth by darkening artificially; his low notes stay bright-cored and forward even at the bottom.

Luke Combs

A2–A4 · 2 octaves



Baritone · full voice to G4 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Beautiful Crazy”

Blue-collar power: a big, grainy baritone that belts like a rock singer but phrases like a barstool storyteller.

Power without polish is the brand. The belt is genuinely large, driven from a deep breath anchor with a coarse grain riding the top, but it arrives in service of plainspoken phrasing: no runs, no falsetto, notes struck square and held honest. The rasp thickens as he climbs toward G4 and stays supported underneath. Build the volume on open mid-range vowels before taking it up; the grain must sit on a full column of air, or a night of this style becomes a week of silence.

Tyler Childers

E2–C6 · 3 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Feathered Indians”

LOW E2 IN “TIRTHA YATRA” · HIGH C6 IN “GREATEST STORY EVER TOLD (LIVE)”

Keening Appalachian tenor — hard twang, bleating vibrato, deliberate cracks into high lonesome falsetto.

Childers sings with a hard, keening Appalachian twang: bright, nasal, and pushed right at the front of the face. He belts to about A4 in full voice, cracks deliberately into falsetto above it, and lets pitch bend sharp-side on emotional peaks. Vibrato is fast and bleating. The trap for students is politeness — clean, rounded vowels erase the mountain edge that defines the whole sound.

Morgan Wallen

A2–G4 · 1 octave + 10



Baritone · full voice to F4 · USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Last Night”

The defining country voice of its moment: a curled, nasal East Tennessee baritone with a built-in break in the vowels.

The curl is everything: vowels bend through a nasal, back-of-the-throat shape, the East Tennessee accent left fully intact, and the tone carries a light perpetual rasp that thickens on pushed notes. Phrase ends drop into a little spoken fall-off, half sigh, half shrug. The melody rides speech rhythm rather than strict meter. To study the sound, exaggerate the accent on the vowels first and add pitch second. Singers who neutralize the accent have removed the actual instrument.

Cody Johnson

F#2–G#4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone · USA · prominent since 2019 · known for “'Til You Can't”

LOW F#2 IN “ON MY WAY TO YOU” · HIGH G#4 IN “ON MY WAY TO YOU”

Arena-strength rodeo baritone — fast tight vibrato, hard consonants, choruses ridden at the top of chest.

Johnson pushes a rodeo-strength baritone with a fast, tight vibrato and hard consonant attacks that read from the back of an arena. He rides the top of chest voice for whole choruses, narrowing vowels to keep the ring without spreading. Verses drop to a low, breath-heavy croon. Students copying him hold nothing back and blow out; he banks energy in verses so the final chorus still has headroom.

Orville Peck

E2–F#5 · 3 octaves + 2



Baritone Canada · prominent since 2019 · known for “Dead of Night”

LOW E2 IN “BIG SKY” · HIGH F#5 IN “ANY TURN”

Reverb-drenched western baritone croon — long slides, theatrical vibrato, keening high climaxes.

Peck croons in a deep, reverb-loving baritone modeled on classic western balladeers: long portamento slides, exaggerated vibrato, and theatrical dynamic swells. He keeps the soft palate high for a plummy, rounded tone, then vaults into a keening upper register for climaxes. The yodel-adjacent breaks are deliberate ornaments. Students copying him underestimate the breath cost of those slow slides; each phrase is one unbroken column of air.

Jelly Roll

G2–G4 · 2 octaves



Baritone full voice to F4 USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “Save Me”

Testimony over genre: a scarred, gospel-weighted baritone carrying rap cadence into country's altar-call tradition.

Confession shapes the sound: a heavy, gravel-floored baritone that pushes toward a preacher's crack at phrase peaks, with rap-trained diction keeping dense lyrics rhythmically locked underneath. The break in the voice on top notes is deployed like a witness's faltering, then recovered with a surge of volume. Vibrato is minimal; conviction substitutes for ornament. Practice speaking the verses in strict time before singing them, then let the chorus open into full-body volume. The credibility lives in that contrast between control and collapse.

Lainey Wilson

A3–C#5 · 1 octave + 4



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “Heart Like a Truck”

LOW A3 IN “HEART LIKE A TRUCK” · HIGH C#5 IN “HEART LIKE A TRUCK”

Brassy, nasal chest-mix in a thick Louisiana drawl — vowel bends carry the groove and the attitude.

Wilson sings through a broad Louisiana drawl with the twang cranked high: nasal, brassy, and proudly regional. Her chest-mix stays thick through the middle, and she bends into notes with quick country scoops, adding a rasp flare on emphasis. Vibrato is moderate and late. Students copying her flatten the accent to be safe; the vowel bends are structural, carrying both the groove and the attitude.

Zach Bryan

G2–F#4 · 1 octave + 11



Baritone full voice to E4 USA · prominent since 2022 · known for “Something in the Orange”

Anti-polish as principle: a cracked, shouting-from-the-porch baritone that treats roughness as proof of honesty.

Rawness is the contract with the listener. The voice strains visibly at the top of phrases, cracks left in the take, with a reedy, wind-burned tone and volume that surges on emotional peaks rather than building smoothly. Meter stretches to fit the words, a songwriter's phrasing, not a session singer's. If you borrow this style, keep the support honest underneath the apparent strain: the crack should be a controlled release, not an actual failure. Manufactured roughness over weak breath is the fastest route to real damage.

NEXT Folk and the songwriters →

19 Folk and the songwriters

This chapter houses the atlas's most persuasive argument that a voice is a delivery system before it is an instrument. The songwriters here include some of the narrowest cited ranges in the book alongside some of the most idiosyncratic timbres — reedy, cracked, nasal, whispered, weathered — and nearly every one of them built a longer, deeper catalog than singers with twice the span. The entries explain how: when the contract is *believe me* rather than *behold me*, intimacy, diction and timing do the work that range does elsewhere, and eccentricity of tone stops being a flaw and becomes a signature.

Technically the chapter rewards close reading. The fingerpicked generations developed conversational rubato — phrases stretched against steady guitar — that is among the subtlest timing work in the book. The head-voice sopranos of the tradition float text on almost no weight, an economy worth studying by every voice that oversings. And the low end of the chapter, the gravel philosophers, demonstrates how far pure grain and placement can carry melody-adjacent speech.

The borrowing advice is almost suspiciously cheap: this is the one chapter whose core techniques — quiet, clarity, honest timing — can be practiced by any voice on day one without risk. The hard part is tolerance for exposure. No production, no band, no volume to hide in; the loop-recording drill from the method chapter is merciless here, which is exactly why a month of folk repertoire audits your fundamentals better than any exercise book.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Joan Baez

F3–B5 · 2 octaves + 6



Soprano USA · prominent since 1960 · known for “Diamonds & Rust”

Bright soprano with a fast, narrow vibrato and clean vowels; little rasp and almost no chest push.

The vibrato is the signature: fast, narrow, and present almost from the instant a note begins, rather than blooming at the end. Vowels stay bright and unmodified, onsets are clean with no aspirate breath, and the line moves in smooth legato with small ornamental turns at cadences. Rasp is absent, and chest weight never climbs into the upper range. Speed is what keeps that vibrato sounding folk rather than operatic; widen it and slow it down and the character changes entirely.

Bob Dylan

E2–A4 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1962 · known for “Like a Rolling Stone”

Nasal, talk-sung phrasing; pitch bends and rhythmic pushback carry more than sustained tone.

Hear how much of the sound is placement rather than tone: the resonance rides high and forward in the nose, vowels stay narrow, and there is almost no vibrato to lean on. Consonants do the work, and notes are approached from below or slid off at the end of a line. Words crowd ahead of the beat, then hang back. Students copy the nasal color and miss the real skill, which is the rhythmic pushback of the phrasing on something like Like a Rolling Stone.

Paul Simon

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1964 · known for “The Sound of Silence”

Light, even tenor that stays conversational and slips into thin falsetto rather than pushing chest.

Conversational is the operative word. Onsets are soft and breath-led, the volume barely changes across a verse, and diction stays crisp enough that every consonant reads. Around the upper limit he thins out and releases into a light falsetto instead of driving chest weight up. Vibrato is narrow and arrives late, if at all. Singers imitating this tend to add power at exactly the point where he takes it away, which flattens the intimacy.

Neil Young

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor Canada · prominent since 1966 · known for “Heart of Gold”

Thin, nasal high tenor with heavy vibrato; sits near the top of his range for most of a song.

Most of a song lives in a narrow band near the top of the range, which is why the sound reads as thin and nasal. The larynx stays light, the tone never thickens, and a fast, breath-driven vibrato wobbles through sustained notes. Attacks are gentle and slightly under pitch before settling. The fragility is structural rather than incidental: add chest weight or volume anywhere in that band and the reedy quality the whole style rests on disappears.

Leonard Cohen

D2–E4 · 2 octaves + 2



Bass-baritone Canada · prominent since 1967 · known for “Hallelujah”

LOW D2 IN “YOU WANT IT DARKER”

Speech-level bass-baritone, gravelly and unhurried, dropping to near-spoken low notes late in life.

Think speech first, pitch second. The tone is dry, gravelly, and nearly free of vibrato, sustained by steady air rather than resonance, and phrases land behind the accompaniment with unhurried timing. Down near the bottom of the range the sound is more spoken than sung, with the microphone carrying what volume cannot. Nothing is pressed downward to find that depth; the low notes arrive by relaxing into speech, and they stay quiet once they get there.

Van Morrison

G2–D5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor Northern Ireland · prominent since 1967 · known for “Brown Eyed Girl”

Raspy tenor that repeats and stretches syllables, sliding between blues shouts and scat phrasing.

Rhythm and repetition matter more than sustained tone here. Syllables get stretched, doubled, and worried at until they turn into rhythmic figures, and lines slide between a blues shout and wordless scat phrasing. The rasp comes from breath pressure against a fairly open throat, not from squeezing, and it thickens as volume rises. Phrases enter late and catch up. Because the grit rides on air instead of a tight throat, the flexibility survives the volume.

Joni Mitchell

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano · Canada · prominent since 1968 · known for “Both Sides Now”

Early records float in light head voice with wide leaps; her later voice settled lower and huskier.

Everything sits in a light, unpressed head voice, with the top of the range reached by releasing weight rather than adding it. Leaps of an octave or more land dead center with no scoop, and the tone stays mostly straight, vibrato appearing only as a phrase settles. Later work lives lower, huskier, and closer to speech. Volume never climbs with the pitch: up toward C6 the sound thins instead of thickening, and that thinness is what keeps the intervals accurate.

James Taylor

F2–A4 · 2 octaves + 4



Baritone · USA · prominent since 1970 · known for “Fire and Rain”

Warm, breath-controlled baritone with soft attacks and vibrato held back until a phrase ends.

Notice how little the voice moves and how much the breath does. Onsets are soft, almost released rather than started, the tone stays warm with the resonance low and round, and vibrato is withheld until the last beat of a phrase, then added narrowly. Consonants close gently. Lines sit just behind the guitar. The dynamic stays small and steady from the first line to the last, with the microphone supplying volume the voice never reaches for.

Tom Waits

A1–G5 · 3 octaves + 10



Bass-baritone · full voice to G4 · USA · prominent since 1973 · known for “Downtown Train”

LOW A1 IN “CROSSROADS” · HIGH G5 IN “$29.00”

Gravel-crusted rasp — a junkyard bass-baritone that growls, barks and croons through carnival shadows.

Sandpaper is cultivated here, not accidental: a bass-baritone driven through deliberate ventricular-fold engagement, so grit coats every sustained tone. Beneath the gravel sits real control; chest voice to about G4, a coarse, hooting falsetto above it, and lows that bottom near A1 on slow, wide-open vowels. Onsets growl into pitch from underneath; phrasing staggers like a carnival barker, rushing and dragging inside the bar. Students shred their voices scraping for the texture; the rasp must come from above the folds, with the true cords vibrating cleanly underneath.

Sinéad O'Connor

F3–A5 · 2 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · Ireland · prominent since 1987 · known for “Nothing Compares 2 U”

Whisper-to-cry dynamics inside a few bars; a clear tone that breaks into hard rasp at full volume.

The range of dynamics inside a couple of bars is the technique. A phrase can start as a breathy near-whisper with the tone barely engaged, swell into a clear, straight mezzo, then fracture into hard rasp at the top of the crescendo. Cracks and breaks are placed, not accidental. Vibrato is scarce, arriving only at the end of a held note. Beginners start at full volume and leave themselves nowhere to go, which removes the entire shape.

Tracy Chapman

D3–D5 · 2 octaves



Contralto USA · prominent since 1988 · known for “Fast Car”

Dark contralto with a tight, buzzy edge; pushes intensity through consonants instead of vibrato.

Weight sits low and dark, with a tight, buzzy edge that keeps the sound cutting rather than muddy. Intensity is delivered through consonants and through how firmly a vowel is attacked, not through volume or vibrato, which stays minimal. Phrasing locks tightly to the guitar and rarely rushes. Singers reaching for the color often drop the larynx to manufacture darkness; that thickens the tone and kills the buzz that makes the voice legible at low volume.

Tori Amos

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1992 · known for “Cornflake Girl”

Bright mezzo that scoops into notes and flips to airy head voice, with frequent glottal breaks.

Notes are frequently approached from below with an audible scoop, and glottal catches punctuate lines like percussion. The mezzo core is bright and slightly edgy, then releases into an airy head voice up high instead of belting through. Timing floats freely against the piano, stretching and compressing phrases. The scoops are selective rather than constant, and the glottal catches are placed on purpose, which is easy to mishear as a loss of control.

Sarah McLachlan

F3–B5 · 2 octaves + 6



Soprano Canada · prominent since 1993 · known for “Angel”

Clear soprano with an airy top and long, steady sustains; shapes lines rather than adding runs.

Long, even sustains define this, held on steady air with the tone clear and slightly airy in the upper range. The register transition is smoothed rather than featured, so a line can climb without any audible gear change. Vibrato arrives late and stays narrow, and ornaments are almost absent; shape comes from crescendo and vowel color instead. These melodies are built to be carried straight through, and runs laid on top of them only add clutter.

Jewel

E3–E6 · 3 octaves



Soprano USA · prominent since 1995 · known for “You Were Meant for Me”

HIGH E6 IN “WHO WILL SAVE YOUR SOUL”

Clear folk soprano that glides between plainspoken chest tone, yodel flips, and a floating, quasi-operatic head voice.

Register flips are the signature here: Jewel treats the break as an instrument, yodeling across it on purpose with split-second accuracy. Her chest voice stays conversational and word-led, then the head voice blooms suddenly at the top, pure and vibrato-warmed toward E6. Breath control is exceptional — long folk phrases taper without wobble. Singers copying her tend to smooth out the flip; the style needs a deliberate, audible register change, plus low-larynx ease down at E3.

Rufus Wainwright

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · Canada · prominent since 1998 · known for “Cigarettes and Chocolate Milk”

Operatic-leaning tenor with wide vibrato and long legato lines; a nasal ring through the upper mix.

Vibrato is wide and slow, closer to a recital voice than a pop one, and it runs through most sustained notes rather than arriving at the end. Vowels stay tall and connected, so phrases move in long legato with audible portamento between pitches, and a nasal ring brightens the upper mix. Sitting toward the top of the range, the tone narrows rather than thickens. That ring is a product of resonance and vowel shape, not volume, so it stays audible in quiet passages too.

ANOHNI

A2–F5 · 2 octaves + 8



Contralto · UK · prominent since 2000 · known for “Hope There's Someone”

Contralto with slow, wide vibrato and a hollow, flute-like sustain that carries most of the expression.

The vibrato is the instrument: slow, wide, and present almost from the onset rather than arriving at the tail of a note. Tone stays hollow and flute-like, with a lot of air in the sound and very little chest weight even down at the bottom of the range. Phrases are sustained rather than rhythmic, and pitch is allowed to bend into a note instead of landing square on it. Copying the wobble by shaking the jaw is the usual mistake — it comes from a released, low-pressure breath, not from muscle.

Sufjan Stevens

B2–A4 · 1 octave + 10



Tenor USA · prominent since 2003 · known for “Chicago”

LOW B2 IN “CONCERNING THE UFO SIGHTING NEAR HIGHLAND, ILLINOIS” · HIGH A4 IN “CONCERNING THE UFO SIGHTING NEAR HIGHLAND, ILLINOIS”

Whisper-soft indie tenor — breathy falsetto home base, close self-harmonies, zero-vibrato calm.

Hushed almost to a whisper, this tenor treats falsetto and breathy head tone as home base, dropping to full voice only for grounding phrases near the bottom of the staff. Sufjan double-tracks himself in close harmony, keeps vibrato out entirely, and shapes lines in long, even eighth-note ribbons. Consonants are feathered so nothing punctures the calm. Imitators who add projection break the spell; the technique is sustained quiet phonation with unwavering pitch.

Regina Spektor

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano USA · prominent since 2004 · known for “Fidelity”

Elastic delivery that switches between clipped staccato, trills, and thin squeaks at the very top.

Delivery is elastic and percussive: clipped staccato syllables, sudden trills, rolled and over-pronounced consonants, and thin squeaks right at the top of the range. Glottal stops and small hiccup accents fall on unexpected beats, treating the voice as a rhythm instrument alongside the piano. The tone itself is bright and unforced. The frequent misread is treating these noises as decoration; they are rhythmic events, and imitating them without locking the timing makes the whole thing sound arbitrary.

Florence Welch

F3–B5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · UK · prominent since 2008 · known for “Dog Days Are Over”

Open-throated mezzo belt with a wide vibrato, usually stacked into choral upper harmonies.

Belted notes are produced with an open throat and a wide, slow vibrato, and the stated belt around E5 marks where chest-based power stops. Above it the tone lightens into head voice, which is why the highest pitches read as choral rather than driven. Vowels stay open and vertical, powered by generous breath. Much of the thickness on record is stacked harmony rather than one line, and the belt itself rides on open resonance more than on sheer volume.

Justin Vernon

F2–F5 · 3 octaves



Tenor · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Skinny Love”

Bon Iver's layered falsetto in tight harmony stacks; the chest voice stays quiet and slightly strained.

Falsetto leads almost everything, sung at modest volume close to the microphone and then stacked into tight harmony so the blend, not the individual note, carries weight. Onsets are breathy, vibrato is barely there, and the chest register stays quiet with an audible edge of strain that is part of the character. The low end of the range is rarely used at full voice. Nothing here trades on power, and the strain in the upper lines works as texture rather than effort.

James Blake

F2–F5 · 3 octaves

Tenor UK · prominent since 2011 · known for “Retrograde”

Falsetto-first and close-miked, breathy at low volume, then thickened with pitch-shifted layers.

Volume stays low and the microphone stays close, so a breathy falsetto with very little vibrato becomes the default sound. Sustains are straight, almost unmoving, and consonants soften into the vowel rather than cutting it. The register shift is handled by never really committing to chest weight at all. Thickness on record comes from doubled and pitch-shifted layers rather than a bigger voice, so the unprocessed line stays quiet even as the arrangement grows around it.

Passenger

D#2–A4 · 2 octaves + 6

Tenor UK · prominent since 2012 · known for “Let Her Go”

LOW D#2 IN “HOME” · HIGH A4 IN “LET HER GO”

Thin, nasal folk tenor — mask-bright storyteller tone, crisp diction, barely any vibrato.

Nasal by choice, precise by habit: Passenger sends nearly all resonance into the mask, producing that thin, folk-teller brightness that reads as intimate at any volume. Range demands are modest, but the phrasing is exacting, with lyrics front-loaded and consonants crisp against fingerpicking. Sustains use straight tone first, a flicker of vibrato last. Students copying the nasality often pinch the soft palate shut; his version keeps a relaxed throat, so the twang never turns shrill.

Hozier

E2–E5 · 3 octaves



Baritone · full voice to B4 · Ireland · prominent since 2013 · known for “Take Me to Church”

Gritty baritone that stacks a gospel-inflected rasp under a clean, sustained falsetto.

Two voices are in play. Down low the baritone runs gritty, with gospel-flavored rasp and blues bends applied to short melodic figures, sometimes growling into the bottom of a phrase. From the stated belt around B4 upward the sound thins toward a lighter, cleaner register instead of driving chest weight any higher. The contrast between those two colors, rather than the size of either one, is what carries a chorus.

Vance Joy

B2–A5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor · Australia · prominent since 2013 · known for “Riptide”

LOW B2 IN “RED EYE” · HIGH A5 IN “MISSING PIECE”

Grainy, rounded indie tenor — lazy onsets, yawny vowels, and a feathery falsetto flip.

Sunny, grainy, and conversational, this tenor works a small tessitura with a distinctive yawn-tinged vowel shape that rounds every line. Vance leans on straight tone, letting the ukulele-strum rhythm carry momentum, and lifts into a feathery falsetto for colour rather than climax. The register change is audible and left charmingly exposed. Copying him too cleanly sterilizes the sound; the slight vowel distortion and lazy onset are the identity, sitting just behind the beat.

Jacob Collier

D2–D6 · 4 octaves



Baritone · full voice to G5 · UK · prominent since 2016 · known for “Moon River”

Wide range used compositionally: low chest notes, stacked falsetto, and deliberate microtonal slides.

Range is used as an arrangement tool rather than a display. Low chest notes are sung quietly and precisely, the upper register is stacked in falsetto for harmony, and slides between pitches are deliberate and often land between the usual twelve, so intonation has to be exact. Phrasing borrows jazz timing, hanging behind and then catching up. Trying to reproduce the extremes first is backwards; the tuning and the smoothness of each transition are what make it work.

Clairo

G3–C5 · 1 octave + 5



Contralto · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Sofia”

LOW G3 IN “SOFIA” · HIGH C5 IN “SOFIA”

Murmuring, low-lit contralto — near-speech volume, stepwise melodies, endings that dissolve into breath.

Murmured close-mic singing raised to a method: Clairo phonates at near-speech volume in a low, warm register, letting breath and room tone become part of the timbre. Melodies move stepwise, vibrato is nearly absent, and phrase endings dissolve instead of resolving. The upper limit stays a gentle mixed head tone. Copying this by simply singing quietly misses the core: her pitch and rhythm are exact, and the softness is compression, not collapse.

Phoebe Bridgers

C#3–E5 · 2 octaves + 3



Soprano · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Motion Sickness”

HIGH E5 IN “WHEN THE PARTY'S OVER”

Hushed, close-mic indie soprano — feathery straight tone, murmured lows, and rare, aching belts.

Whisper-adjacent singing, done with control: Bridgers keeps subglottal pressure low, letting air haze the tone while pitch stays dead center. Her straight-tone sustains barely waver, doubling into ghostly unisons. Lines sit speech-low near C#3, and when she finally opens into a D5 belt the contrast does the emotional work. Consonants are soft, phrase ends often fall off pitch deliberately. Imitators push volume for feeling; her dynamic ceiling is low, and the mic supplies the size.

Dermot Kennedy

E2–C6 · 3 octaves + 8



Baritone · full voice to A4 · Ireland · prominent since 2019 · known for “Outnumbered”

LOW E2 IN “AN EVENING I WILL NOT FORGET” · HIGH C6 IN “KISS ME”

Gravelly low baritone that erupts into compressed chest belts and high keening falsetto.

Gravel rides on top of a genuinely low-set baritone: Dermot speaks-sings near the bottom of the staff, then drives choruses with a compressed chest belt around A4 that distorts at the edges by design. Above that he flips into a keening falsetto that contrasts sharply with the growl. Imitators usually manufacture rasp with throat squeeze; his grit comes from airflow against firm folds, and the pitch centre never wavers underneath the texture.

Lizzy McAlpine

E3–C#5 · 1 octave + 9



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2022 · known for “ceilings”

LOW E3 IN “CEILINGS” · HIGH C#5 IN “CEILINGS”

Hushed, air-first mezzo — speechy low tessitura, jazz-tinged passing tones, brief clear head-voice peaks.

Feather-light onsets define the style: Lizzy begins tones with air already moving, so notes seem to fade in rather than start. She sits in a low, speechy mezzo tessitura, orbiting a few steps around the melody with jazz-tinged passing tones, and saves her clear head voice for brief, unforced peaks. Dynamics stay hushed. Students copying her usually whisper; she is quiet but fully phonated, with pitch dead-centre under all that air.

Noah Kahan

B2–A4 · 1 octave + 10



Tenor full voice to F#4 USA · prominent since 2022 · known for “Stick Season”

HIGH A4 IN “STICK SEASON”

New England folk urgency: a bright, keening tenor that gallops through wordy verses and breaks upward like a shout across a field.

Urgency drives the phrasing: verses tumble out in dense, galloping strings of syllables, almost patter, then the hook leaps upward into a keening, open-throated call with a folk singer's forward bite and a hint of yodel at the flip. The tone is bright, reedy and unglamorous on purpose. Practice the verse diction at full speed with a metronome until no syllable clips, then let the chorus leap carry a touch of break. Muddying the words loses the breathless, confiding effect the style depends on.

Gigi Perez

E3–C#5 · 1 octave + 9



Contralto · full voice to A4 · USA · prominent since 2024 · known for “Sailor Song”

A striking true contralto: deep, hollow-toned and hymn-like, sitting an octave below where pop sopranos live.

Depth is the identity. The voice rests where many women speak, around the octave below middle C's neighborhood, with a hollow, woody color and a straight tone that breaks into slow vibrato only on held notes. Phrases repeat like liturgy, gathering weight through accumulation rather than climb. If your voice sits here, resist the industry pull toward brighter, higher keys; train the low register's resonance with descending slides on oh. Chasing soprano keys wastes what makes a voice like this rare.

NEXT Jazz and the standards →

20 Jazz and the standards

Jazz singing's founding move was treating the voice as one of the horns: entitled to reharmonize, obligated to swing, and judged on time feel above all. The entries in this chapter keep returning to that judgment. What separates these voices is rarely range — the cited spans here are moderate by atlas standards — and almost always *placement in time*: behind the beat without dragging, ahead without rushing, syllables laid against the ride cymbal with a drummer's intent. That skill, more than any sound, is what the technique paragraphs try to make practicable.

The chapter also documents the microphone's first great partnership. The crooners and song stylists here invented close-mic singing — speech-level dynamics, tone over projection, the audible smile — decades before pop rediscovered it, and their entries are the cheapest master class in microphone technique the book contains. Alongside them sit the virtuosi: the scat athletes with instrumentalists' harmonic ears, and the ballad specialists whose delayed, even vibrato and straight-tone control remain the reference for every genre's slow songs. The new jazz generation at the chapter's end proves the toolkit still mints careers.

Borrow in this order: time feel first (sing any standard against a metronome placing every syllable deliberately late, then deliberately early, until placement is a choice), straight-tone-then-bloom vibrato second, and harmonic ambition last. And note the chapter's quietest

lesson — almost nobody here belts. Authority in this tradition is earned at conversational volume, which makes it the safest advanced chapter in the book.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Louis Armstrong

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 1925 · known for “What a Wonderful World”

Gravel-and-air rasp, trumpet-shaped phrasing, scat treated as a second horn chorus.

Two instruments share one technique. The rasp is constant — a dense, gravelly tone with audible air behind it — and phrases are shaped like trumpet lines: short, punched, built around a rhythmic idea rather than a lyric line. Scat syllables are chosen for attack, hard consonants where a horn would tongue a note. Vibrato is fast and shallow, applied at the end of held notes. Singers imitating the gravel push it from the throat, which tires fast and misses the point: the phrasing is what carries it, not the texture.

Bing Crosby

F2–F4 · 2 octaves



Baritone USA · prominent since 1926 · known for “White Christmas”

Bass-leaning baritone sung close to the mic, warm and level, with small ornamental turns.

Sung as though the microphone were doing half the work: low placement, level dynamics, and no audible effort anywhere between F2 and F4. Small ornamental turns decorate the ends of phrases, and vibrato stays narrow and slow. White Christmas keeps the voice inside a comfortable middle where the bass-leaning warmth carries everything. To imitate it, take volume out rather than adding weight.

Billie Holiday

F3–C5 · 1 octave + 7



Contralto USA · prominent since 1933 · known for “Strange Fruit”

Narrow compass, heavy inflection: bent pitches, behind-the-beat placement, thin reedy top.

Two things carry this style, and neither is range: placement behind the beat and constant pitch inflection. Notes are approached from underneath, bent up into tune, then left before they settle. The top of a narrow F3 to C5 compass turns reedy and thin rather than opening out, and vibrato shows up late as a small flutter. Students copy the breathiness and the scoops, then sing them squarely on the beat, which loses the whole effect.

Ella Fitzgerald

D3–C6 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1935 · known for “A-Tisket, A-Tasket”

HIGH C6 IN “HOW HIGH THE MOON”

Flute-clear tone, exact intonation, scat lines phrased like a horn solo.

Onsets are clean and pitch-centred, with almost no slide into the note and a vibrato so narrow it reads as straight tone. Above the staff the voice thins into a light, flute-like head register instead of adding weight, which is how the compass reaches C6 without strain. The scat choruses in How High the Moon move in horn-shaped intervals, and speed without that pitch centre turns the same lines into mush.

Nat King Cole

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 1939 · known for “Unforgettable”

Soft-grained baritone, unusually clean diction, vibrato held back until a phrase ends.

Pressure is the enemy of this sound. Air arrives just ahead of tone, giving a soft, felt-covered attack, and consonants are articulated with the tongue tip rather than the jaw, which keeps the line unbroken. Vibrato is withheld through the body of a note and released only as it decays. To get near it, sing quieter than feels safe and resist the urge to darken the vowel.

Frank Sinatra

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 1940 · known for “My Way”

Conversational baritone, long legato lines, breath control that carries a phrase past the bar.

Listen for how little happens at the onset: air and tone start together, no scoop, and the vowel carries almost the whole note before a narrow vibrato arrives at the very end. Lines are built to run past the obvious breath point, so the phrase, not the bar, sets the shape. The top of the range opens out rather than getting louder — an A4 is sung, never belted. The swagger is the easy part to copy; the consonant timing underneath it is the actual work.

Peggy Lee

D3–A5 · 2 octaves + 7



Contralto USA · prominent since 1942 · known for “Fever”

LOW D3 IN “FEVER” · HIGH A5 IN “MY DEAR ACQUAINTANCE (A HAPPY NEW YEAR)”

Cool, hushed contralto purr that trades volume for pulse; a whisper riding a finger-snap groove.

Lee subtracts until only the essential pulse remains: short phrases, straight tone, and a dynamic ceiling barely above speech. Her onsets are aspirate by design, each phrase beginning as breath that condenses into pitch. Rhythm does the seduction — she places syllables a fraction late, then snaps one exactly on the beat. The D3 bottom is a spoken shadow; rare climbs toward A5 stay cool and unpressed. Students copying her add volume, vibrato and ornament, which destroys the effect. The study here is restraint: hold the groove, trust the microphone, and make silence do half the singing.

Mel Tormé

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor USA · prominent since 1943 · known for “Comin' Home Baby”

Soft-focus tone with almost no edge, paired with fast and accurate bebop scat lines.

Almost no edge in the tone — the sound is soft-focused, closer to a flugelhorn than a trumpet, with breath and tone blended so evenly that onsets barely register. Then the scat arrives, fast and harmonically exact, articulated at the front of the mouth so the consonants can keep up with the tempo. Above the staff he thins instead of pushing. Chase the smoothness alone and the rhythmic precision that makes it swing goes missing.

Sarah Vaughan

Eb3–C6 · 2 octaves + 9



Contralto USA · prominent since 1943 · known for “Misty”

Operatic weight low down, controlled vibrato, a top she floats onto instead of pushing.

Weight is the first thing to notice — the bottom of the range is genuinely dark and covered, closer to a trained contralto than a band singer. Vibrato is wide but metered, switched on and off deliberately. Rather than pushing toward C6 she lightens and floats, then drops back into chest inside a single phrase for contrast. The common mistake is manufacturing that darkness by pressing the larynx down; it comes from space, not force.

Dean Martin

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 1946 · known for “That's Amore”

Low-set relaxed baritone, slid entrances, phrases deliberately lagging the beat.

Everything sits low and loose. Entrances are scooped from below, phrases lag behind the band and catch up by the end of the line, and the whole thing is delivered at conversational volume close to the microphone. Vibrato is slow and shallow. Rhythm is the hardest part to steal — match the tone but sing on top of the beat, and the ease disappears immediately.

Dinah Washington

Eb3–E5 · 2 octaves + 1



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1946 · known for “What a Diff'rence a Day Makes”

LOW EB3 IN “MANHATTAN” · HIGH E5 IN “BLUE GARDENIA”

Bright, brassy, gospel-cut mezzo with razor diction; every syllable lands like a snapped snare.

Washington places everything in the mask: bright, twangy, almost brass-section resonance with total consonant clarity. Her vibrato is fast and shallow, switched on the instant a note stabilizes. Phrasing is strict — she sings on the front of the beat, bends a blue third, then cuts the note clean with no fade. Gospel-style ornaments stay small and rhythmic, never washy. The common copying mistake is adding smoke and slide; her power is precision. Keep the soft palate high, the tone pointed, and end each note on purpose, not by decay.

Tony Bennett

A2–A4 · 2 octaves



Baritone USA · prominent since 1951 · known for “I Left My Heart in San Francisco”

Bright forward baritone that widens as it gets louder rather than thinning at the top.

Here is a baritone that grows wider rather than thinner as it climbs. The tone is bright and set forward behind the teeth, the throat stays open, and loud notes gain ring instead of edge. Vibrato is steady, moderate in width, and present through the whole note. Vowels are held long and consonants clipped short. Sung with a raised soft palate this reads as bright; sung with a lowered one it collapses into nasal, which is the usual error.

Julie London

C#3–C#5 · 2 octaves



Contralto USA · prominent since 1955 · known for “Cry Me a River”

LOW C#3 IN “I LOVE YOU” · HIGH C#5 IN “'S WONDERFUL”

Smoky close-mic contralto, barely more than a warm murmur: all breath, intimacy, and after-midnight calm.

London works entirely inside a two-octave whisper: intimate, breath-heavy phonation with the microphone doing the projection a hall would normally demand. Her fold closure is deliberately incomplete, so every note carries air alongside tone. Phrasing is conversational rubato — she lags the pulse, letting the guitar walk ahead. The C#3 lows are nearly spoken; the C#5 top is a soft head-mix, never a lift in volume. Imitators equate breathiness with weakness and overblow it into fog; hers is controlled, pitched precisely at the center. Practice quiet sustained tones at close range until pitch survives the air.

Johnny Mathis

B2–G5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor USA · prominent since 1956 · known for “Chances Are”

High, feathery tenor; vibrato stays fast and narrow even at whisper volume.

High and feathery, weighted toward head resonance even in the middle of the range, with an onset so soft the note seems already in progress. Vibrato is fast and narrow and stays that way at whisper volume, which is the fingerprint of the voice. The upper reach is light mix and falsetto, never chest. Chances Are sits in that floated territory. Sing it loudly and the tone vanishes; it only exists at low pressure.

Bobby Darin

G2–E5 · 2 octaves + 9



Baritone USA · prominent since 1958 · known for “Mack the Knife”

LOW G2 IN “MORE” · HIGH E5 IN “SPLISH SPLASH”

Finger-snapping swing baritone with punchy attack, big-band drive, and a rock-and-roll edge when he wants it.

Darin attacks consonants like a drummer: hard onsets, clipped releases, and a swing placement that pushes the front of the beat where crooners lean back. The baritone core is bright and forward, with vibrato saved for held finales. He modulates energy by key change rather than volume — each lift resets the excitement. Down at G2 he growls conversationally; the rare E5 spike is a thrown-off falsetto exclamation, not a built note. Copyists smooth him out and lose the aggression: the style needs punchy diction, short phrase cells, and total rhythmic commitment on every syllable.

Nina Simone

G2–F5 · 2 octaves + 10



Contralto USA · prominent since 1958 · known for “Feeling Good”

Contralto with an unusually deep floor; speech-into-song delivery, pianist's sense of time.

Start from speech. Lines begin at conversational pitch and swell into sung tone, often with no vibrato at all until a long note has been held well past comfort. The floor of the range is unusually low for this voice type, and those low notes are placed heavily, almost spoken. Time is elastic: phrases arrive early or late against the accompaniment on purpose. Copying it means committing to the deliberate pace, not to volume.

Al Jarreau

G2–A5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor USA · prominent since 1975 · known for “We're in This Love Together”

Mouth-percussion textures under a light tenor that flips to falsetto without a seam.

Percussion is part of the singing here rather than a separate layer: clicks, pops and breath sounds get placed inside the melodic line, so rhythm and tune come out of one mechanism. The tenor itself is light and forward, and the move into falsetto is deliberately seamless — no break, no drop in volume, which is how the compass reaches A5. Bends and slides are constant. The usual trap is copying the effects until the melody stops being legible.

Bobby McFerrin

E2–E6 · 4 octaves



Baritone · full voice to G4 · USA · prominent since 1982 · known for “Don't Worry, Be Happy”

Alternates chest bass and high falsetto mid-phrase, chest-slapping his own rhythm track.

Alternating registers mid-phrase is the whole trick. Low chest notes are attacked with a glottal stop for a plucked, bass-like sound; above the G4 belt ceiling the voice releases into a light, well-supported falsetto that climbs a long way. Rhythm comes from body percussion and from breath sounds placed between the pitches. The demand is not range but instant switching — slur the transition and the illusion of two separate instruments collapses.

Harry Connick Jr.

E2–A#4 · 2 octaves + 6



Baritone · USA · prominent since 1989 · known for “It Had to Be You”

LOW E2 IN “NOTHIN' NEW FOR NEW YEAR (FOR ME)” · HIGH A#4 IN “WHEN MY HEART FINDS CHRISTMAS”

Relaxed New Orleans crooner baritone: light swing, conversational phrasing, a grin you can hear in the tone.

Connick sings the way he talks: mid-larynx, speech-level placement, short forward vowels, and a swing feel that lands slightly behind the beat. Vibrato is narrow and late, applied at phrase ends like a garnish. Down near E2 he thins to a dry, conversational rumble; toward A#4 he brightens the vowel instead of pushing volume. Students copying him overdo the croon and lose the rhythm section in their phrasing — his line is percussive first, pretty second. Keep the tongue lazy, the consonants crisp, and let the band set the air pressure.

Rachelle Ferrell

G2–D7 · 4 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · whistle register · USA · prominent since 1990 · known for “With Open Arms”

Elastic jazz-soul voice that dives into foggy lows, then flicks up to a needle-fine whistle register without a seam.

Ferrell moves through registers as one continuous dial: chest blends to head with no audible seam, belt compression releases above D5, and the whistle sits on top like a harmonic she can land on from anywhere. Her lows near G2 are foggy and air-rich by choice; her onsets are often breathy, then compressed mid-note. Melisma stays legato — runs are pitch bends with checkpoints, not note stacks. Imitators chase the extremes and skip the middle: the D7 only speaks because her passaggio is drilled to evenness. Train the join, not the peaks.

Diana Krall

E3–C5 · 1 octave + 8



Contralto · Canada · prominent since 1993 · known for “The Look of Love”

Low, husky and unforced; lines sit close to speech pitch and rarely climb.

Low and unhurried, with a dry huskiness that comes from slightly loose closure rather than from pushing. Lines sit near speech pitch and rarely climb, so tone colour and timing carry the interest. Onsets are soft, vibrato is minimal, and phrases land late and resolve quietly. Anyone imitating this tends to add volume; the style depends on holding it back.

Norah Jones

F3–C5 · 1 octave + 7



Contralto USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “Don't Know Why”

Breathy alto that stays mid-range: soft onsets, little vibrato, country-tinged slides.

Air is part of the sound. Onsets are aspirate, the tone stays warm and unpressed through the middle of the range, and vibrato is close to absent. The ornament habit is a short slide up or down into a note rather than a run, and nothing above C5 is asked for. The trap is confusing breathy with unsupported: the breathiness only works over steady airflow and firm ribs.

Michael Bublé

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone Canada · prominent since 2003 · known for “Home”

Crooner baritone with a pop-sized top; well-supported, lightly swung, very even tone.

Very even from bottom to top: no obvious seam, no thinning at A4, and consistent breath support under every note. Onsets are lightly aspirate, the swing is understated, and vibrato stays regular and unhurried. Ad-libs at the end of a chorus bring a little grit over a clear pitch. Evenness is the difficulty — it demands the same air pressure and the same vowel shape everywhere, which is duller to practise than it is to hear.

Cécile McLorin Salvant

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “Wives and Lovers”

Conservatory control over a wide compass; crisp diction, abrupt shifts to a thin girlish top.

Trained control shows up in the choices, not just the notes: straight tone opens a phrase, vibrato is then added as an effect, and the vowel gets reshaped mid-note for colour. Diction is crisp to the point of theatrical. Above the staff the voice thins abruptly into a small, girlish register, and that sudden change of character is deliberate. Smoothing that transition out removes the point of it.

Gregory Porter

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “Liquid Spirit”

Thick baritone with a gospel-shout attack on top and a resonant, grounded bottom octave.

Thick, round and low-placed, with a bottom octave that resonates rather than rumbles. The top of the range takes a gospel-shout attack: firm onset, forward vowel, an occasional growl laid over a clear pitch. Melisma is used sparingly and almost always on a strong beat. Liquid Spirit puts the shout and the grounded bottom in the same take. Build the low end first — that shout over a thin bottom just sounds strained.

Samara Joy

B2–D5 · 2 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 2022 · known for “Guess Who I Saw Today”

A young voice with an old soul: plush, dark-chocolate low register and horn-player phrasing straight from the Vaughan lineage.

Depth of tone is the calling card: a plush, rounded low register that recalls Sarah Vaughan, kept warm by tall vowels and a low, relaxed larynx, with vibrato deployed like a horn player's, straight tone first, then a measured bloom. Scat lines think harmonically, outlining substitutions rather than riffing pentatonics. Practice sustaining low-register notes with the vowel space of a yawn, no breathiness, then delay vibrato until beat three. The patience of that bloom is the lesson.

Laufey

F3–D5 · 1 octave + 9



Contralto Iceland · prominent since 2023 · known for “From the Start”

Bedroom jazz for a streaming generation: a cello-dark low voice, close-miked to a murmur, over standards-shaped songs.

Cello training shows in the singing: long bowed phrases, a dark, woody low register she keeps deliberately quiet, and vibrato applied late and evenly like a string player's, over melodies that resolve the way standards do. The microphone does the projection; the voice never pushes past mezzo-piano. Practice singing full phrases at whisper-adjacent volume while keeping the tone round rather than breathy, and let the lowest notes speak without pressing. Volume would break the spell this style depends on.

NEXT Opera and classical crossover →

PART VII

The trained voice

21 Opera and classical crossover 306

22 Musical theatre 322

CONTENTS

21 Opera and classical crossover

Opera is the control group of this atlas. Every other chapter documents voices shaped by the microphone; this one documents what the human voice does when it must fill a three-thousand-seat hall over an orchestra with no help at all. The answer is a technology — squillo, the resonance cluster that lets a voice knife through eighty instruments — and a discipline of breath, vowel and register unification that takes a decade to install. The entries here describe its results: voices even and intentional from bottom to top, projection as a trained acoustic trick rather than effort.

Notice that most of the cited ranges look *modest* next to the pop chapters. That reflects the job: an opera singer is hired for the span they can produce at full, hall-filling quality, night after night, not for the furthest note they have ever reached. The first chapter's caveats still apply, though. A cited top here can be a famous interpolation rather than a written note, or come from a recording made outside the opera house. Read against the atlas's method chapters, this chapter is what "full voice to the top of the figure" looks like as a career requirement — which is why so few entries carry a separate belt ceiling.

For the amplified singer, the transferable goods are the fundamentals at their highest development: breath as management, vowels as architecture, registers welded seamless, and the fach system's deep wisdom — voices last when they are cast within their weight class. You

do not need squillo to sing pop. You will never regret borrowing the practice habits that build it.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Enrico Caruso

B2–Bb4 · 1 octave + 11

Tenor Italy · prominent since 1902 · known for “Vesti la giubba”

Dark, baritonal tenor timbre on acoustic discs; transposed music down rather than reach past Bb4.

The color is dark for a tenor, close to a baritone through the middle of the staff, and the weight sits low rather than up in the mask. Attacks land firm and immediate, lines are joined with audible portamento, and the vibrato holds one moderate speed from start to finish. Up top the vowel is covered rather than opened out, and with Bb4 as the ceiling the interest is in how much happens underneath it. Press the larynx down to imitate that darkness and all you get is muffled tone.

Maria Callas

F#3–Eb6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano · Greece · prominent since 1947 · known for “Casta Diva”

HIGH EB6 IN “SEMPRE LIBERA”

Uneven but instantly identifiable across three registers; used chest weight and portamento as drama.

Three registers, each with its own color, and the seams between them are audible. Chest is heavy and unmixed down toward F#3, the middle veiled, the top bright and sometimes edged. Portamento carries the drama, while accents land on hard glottal onsets. Vibrato widens as pressure rises, and recitative comes out close to speech rhythm. Students copy the chest register with a clenched jaw and end up shouting rather than speaking on pitch.

Mario Lanza

C3–C5 · 2 octaves



Tenor · USA · prominent since 1947 · known for “Be My Love”

HIGH C5 IN “BE MY LOVE”

Operatic tenor with dense squillo; carries full chest weight to a sustained high C, no falsetto.

Everything rests on a ringing, concentrated core, the narrow metallic ping that lets an unamplified tenor sit on top of an orchestra without shouting. Full weight is carried up to C5 with no flip into falsetto: larynx low, palate high, the vowel darkening as it rises while the ring stays pinned in one thin band. Attacks are firm without turning glottal, and the vibrato runs even and moderately fast. The scale of the sound is a resonance effect, not a matter of moving more air.

Yma Sumac

B2–C#7 · 4 octaves + 2



Soprano · full voice to A5 · whistle register · Peru · prominent since 1950 · known for “Gopher Mambo”

HIGH C#7 IN “CHUNCHO (THE FOREST CREATURES)”

Switched between growled low chest and piercing whistle-register tones inside single phrases.

The trick is changing mechanism mid-phrase with no warning: a growled, rattling low chest sound, then a bright piercing tone up in whistle register, and nothing gradual in between. Vowels stay wide and open down low and clamp tight up high. Rhythm is percussive, locked to the accompaniment. Attack the whistle notes with force and they will not come, since that register needs very little air and a fully released jaw.

Birgit Nilsson

C#3–D6 · 3 octaves + 1



Soprano · Sweden · prominent since 1954 · known for “Liebestod”

Steel-bright dramatic soprano that rides a Wagner orchestra with trumpet-like top notes and zero wobble.

Nilsson projects on alignment, not muscle: a laser-focused core resonance that cuts a hundred-piece orchestra because the overtones cluster around the singer's formant. Her tone is nearly straight, vibrato tight and fast, intonation dead center for hours at a time. Attacks above the staff are direct — no scoop, no crescendo into the note, just placement. The middle near C#3 stays lean rather than plush. Toward D6 the sound gains edge instead of spread. Imitators add heft and wobble trying to sound dramatic; the actual mechanism is ruthless efficiency — small vibrating mass, enormous acoustic focus, tireless breath.

Leontyne Price

G3–C6 · 2 octaves + 5

Soprano USA · prominent since 1955 · known for “Pace, pace mio Dio”

HIGH C6 IN “O PATRIA MIA”

Creamy Verdi soprano with a wide, steady spin; floated high Cs over full orchestra without pushing.

The spin is the thing to listen for, a wide and steady vibrato that holds its rate, riding a narrow unwavering stream of air. Onsets arrive already spinning, with no scoop and no shove. High notes are floated and then released with a diminuendo instead of chopped off, and the register transitions are hard to locate. Students attack a high C from below and force it. The note has to be in place before the breath moves.

Montserrat Caballé

G3–C6 · 2 octaves + 5

Soprano Spain · prominent since 1956 · known for “Barcelona”

Known for pianissimo high notes spun on almost no air, then sudden shifts to full dramatic weight.

The signature device is a high note spun at a whisper: fold contact thinned right down, the vowel kept close, the air rationed, then a sudden shift into full dramatic weight with the vowel unchanged. Onsets are almost inaudible, vibrato slow and even. Chase that pianissimo by blowing more air and it collapses. It works the other way around, on less air held longer with the support untouched.

Joan Sutherland

G3–F6 · 2 octaves + 10



Soprano Australia · prominent since 1959 · known for “Il dolce suono (Lucia's Mad Scene)”

HIGH F6 IN “IL DOLCE SUONO”

Round, high-volume coloratura with easy staccato and trills; diction blurred in the upper extension.

Volume with roundness: the pharynx stays wide open, which is why the coloratura sounds cushioned rather than pecked, and why words dissolve above the staff as every vowel drifts toward a neutral schwa. Staccato is fired from the breath, not the throat, and trills stay fast and even. What students miss is that the size comes from space and a light onset, never from pressing.

Luciano Pavarotti

C3–C5 · 2 octaves



Tenor Italy · prominent since 1961 · known for “Nessun dorma”

HIGH C5 IN “AH! MES AMIS, QUEL JOUR DE FÊTE!”

Bright, forward Italian tenor with squillo that cuts; sang nine consecutive high Cs in full voice.

Everything is placed forward and narrow: the vowel stays small, the ring sits high in the mask, and the tone cuts without needing extra volume. Onsets are clean, with no scoop into the note. Vibrato is quick and even, present from the first instant. Climbing toward C5 he adds cover while keeping that forward point, so the top sounds open rather than squeezed. Students push air and widen the mouth, which kills the ring.

Plácido Domingo

A2–C5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor Spain · prominent since 1961 · known for “Granada”

Warm spinto weight and long phrases; later took baritone roles, extending his usable low register.

Weight is the first thing you hear: a thick, warm middle that keeps its size all the way down toward A2. Breath and tone arrive together, so nothing sounds struck. Phrases run long, crossing bar lines with no obvious refill. The vibrato turns over more slowly than a light lyric tenor's, and the approach to C5 stays covered and muscular. Imitators carry all that weight into the top and run out of air before the phrase ends.

Ivan Rebroff

F1–F5 · 4 octaves



Bass full voice to F4 Germany · prominent since 1966 · known for “Kalinka”

Billed at four octaves: deep Russian bass below, thin falsetto soprano well above the staff.

Two separate mechanisms, stacked, with the seam left plainly audible: a heavy pressed bass down toward F1, full voice topping out around F4, and a thin, unsupported falsetto well above the staff. The vibrato differs between them, slow below and fluttery above. Blending the two into one continuous register erases the whole effect. The switch is the point, not a seam to be smoothed away.

Jessye Norman

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano USA · prominent since 1969 · known for “Dich, teure Halle”

Broad, dark-hued dramatic soprano with contralto-like lows and unusually even breath control.

A broad, dark instrument with lows that read nearly contralto, and an unhurried approach to every entrance. Consonants land late, vibrato is slow and wide, and crescendos build across whole phrases instead of single notes. Nothing is rushed. Widen the throat to chase that size and the pitch center sags while the vowel blurs; the breadth comes from the length of the breath, not from opening wider.

José Carreras

C3–C5 · 2 octaves



Tenor Spain · prominent since 1971 · known for “Amigos Para Siempre”

Lyric tenor with a plaintive, slightly grainy tone; leaned on phrasing rather than sheer volume.

Grain in the tone and a slightly plaintive vowel color give this voice its ache. The attack is gentle, consonants stay clear, and the expression comes from timing: entries delayed, tempo pulled, dynamics dropped to almost nothing before a line opens out. Vibrato is thin and starts with the note instead of arriving late. The mistake is trying to make any of it bigger. The character lives in restraint, not in size.

Samuel Ramey

Eb2–F4 · 2 octaves + 2



Bass USA · prominent since 1973 · known for “Son lo spirito che nega”

LOW EB2 IN “SEMIRAMIDE” · HIGH F4 IN “SEMIRAMIDE”

Ink-dark operatic bass with athletic coloratura; cavernous depth that stays focused, agile, and theatrical.

Ramey pairs true bass depth with bel canto agility: the larynx stays low and stable while the articulation happens at the breath, so runs stay clean at speed without the tone lightening. His legato is instrument-like — vowels connect under the consonants, vibrato continuous and even down to Eb2. At the top near F4 he covers early, keeping roundness instead of spreading. Ornamented passagework is sung full voice, never marked. The student error is treating agility and depth as a trade-off; his coordination shows they share one requirement: minimal pressure, maximal resonance space, and rhythmically exact airflow.

Sarah Brightman

G3–E6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano UK · prominent since 1981 · known for “Time to Say Goodbye”

HIGH E6 IN “THE PHANTOM OF THE OPERA”

Thin, breathy classical-pop tone; stays in head voice up top rather than carrying chest weight.

Thin, airy and head-voice dominant, with no chest weight carried up past the middle. Onsets are aspirate, and vibrato is light, often late, sometimes withheld altogether for a straight tone. Vowels stay bright and compact, which is what lets the top of the range float, as it does through The Phantom of the Opera. Treat this material as belting and the quality goes at once. It depends on staying light exactly where the instinct says push.

Sumi Jo

A3–F6 · 2 octaves + 8

Soprano South Korea · prominent since 1986 · known for “Caro nome”

HIGH F6 IN “DER HÖLLE RACHE”

Feather-light lyric coloratura with silvery spin; ornaments ripple out in even, weightless beads.

Jo produces the lightest possible full tone: minimal vocal-fold mass, high head-dominant resonance from the middle register up, and ornaments articulated by airflow pulses rather than throat taps. Her trills are genuinely two pitches, measured and even. Above the staff to F6 the voice narrows to a spinning thread that still projects because the squillo stays centered. Low phrases near A3 are deliberately underweighted — she never borrows chest to fake size. Imitators press for volume and lose the float; the correct study is messa di voce on small vowels until dynamics move without weight.

Cecilia Bartoli

F3–D6 · 2 octaves + 9

Mezzo-soprano Italy · prominent since 1988 · known for “Agitata da due venti”

Rapid-fire coloratura driven by audible diaphragm pulses; small, tightly focused mezzo core.

Every note in a run is re-articulated by a small pulse from the body, and you can hear it: the coloratura sounds beaded rather than smeared. The core tone is compact and tightly focused instead of large, onsets are crisp, vibrato quick. Students go wrong in two directions, either slurring the runs into one smooth stream or producing the pulses with the throat rather than the breath.

Bryn Terfel

F2–A4 · 2 octaves + 4

Bass-baritone UK · prominent since 1989 · known for “Votre toast (Toreador Song)”

Big, grainy bass-baritone with hard consonants; moves between Wagner, Mozart and stage musicals.

Consonants do the rhythmic work here, percussive on the attack and bitten rather than smoothed, carried on a big and grainy instrument. The vibrato is broad and unhurried next to a lyric baritone's, and the low end toward F2 keeps its body instead of thinning out. Operatic legato and a more speech-driven delivery sit side by side depending on the material. The error is manufacturing the grain as throat rasp; it is resonance and consonant energy.

Dmitri Hvorostovsky

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2

Baritone Russia · prominent since 1989 · known for “Dark Eyes (Ochi Chornye)”

Smooth Verdi baritone with a metallic edge and long, unbroken legato on a single breath.

Legato is the whole method: long lines joined without a seam, often stretched further than most singers would attempt, with the vowel shape barely shifting from note to note. There is a metallic edge inside an otherwise smooth tone, and the vibrato stays even at every dynamic. The climb to A4 is fully covered. Squeeze the throat chasing that metal and you lose it, because it comes from steady airflow and a consistent vowel.

Renée Fleming

G3–C6 · 2 octaves + 5



Soprano USA · prominent since 1991 · known for “Song to the Moon”

Silvery lyric soprano with a soft-edged onset and heavy use of floated, breath-mixed high notes.

Aspirate onsets, notes approached from slightly under, and a fast shallow vibrato that arrives a moment after the tone begins: every edge is softened. Upper notes are mixed with breath and floated rather than driven, which produces the silvery quality. Students hear the breathiness and imitate only that, losing the firm core beneath it. The airiness is a color laid over a supported tone, not a replacement for one.

Andrea Bocelli

C3–B4 · 1 octave + 11



Tenor Italy · prominent since 1994 · known for “Con te partirò”

HIGH B4 IN “NESSUN DORMA”

Light lyric tenor recorded close to the mic; softer, more crooned attack than stage projection.

Recorded close, this is a light lyric sound with a crooner's attack: breath leaks in ahead of the tone, and the resonance sits forward and a little nasal. Vibrato is quick and shallow. Notes near the B4 ceiling are thinned and mixed rather than fully opened, so they read intimate instead of projected. Reach for operatic size by adding chest weight and the softness that defines the sound disappears.

Anna Netrebko

G3–D6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano Russia · prominent since 1994 · known for “Sempre libera”

Started lyric and darkened toward dramatic roles; thick middle register under a bright, cutting top.

A thick, meaty middle sits beneath a top that brightens and cuts, and the contrast between the two is the sound. Onsets are decisive, with a touch of glottal edge for attack, and vibrato is moderate and steady. The extension toward D6 comes from a lighter mechanism, not from middle-register weight. That is precisely what students get wrong, hauling the thickness upward until the passaggio jams.

Jonas Kaufmann

B2–C5 · 2 octaves + 1



Tenor Germany · prominent since 1994 · known for “Pourquoi me réveiller”

Unusually dark, covered tenor sound with baritone-like lows and a tightly held, muscular top.

Cover comes on early here, so the sound stays dark and gathered through the middle where most tenors brighten. Onsets are soft, vibrato narrow and slightly delayed. By C5 the tone reads compressed and muscular rather than open and ringing, which is the trade that darkness costs. Copy it with a depressed tongue root, though, and you get a throaty, unfocused note instead of a covered one.

Juan Diego Flórez

C3–E5 · 2 octaves + 4

Tenor Peru · prominent since 1996 · known for “Ah! mes amis (La Fille du régiment)”

Bel canto's high-C machine: a light, agile leggero tenor that fires nine full-voice C5s in one aria, every night, no falsetto.

Leggero lightness makes the altitude possible: the instrument is deliberately lean, brilliant and forward, never carrying more weight up the scale than the top can support, which is how nine full-voice high Cs in a single aria stay repeatable across a career. Coloratura runs are articulated from the diaphragm, each note struck, not smeared. The lesson for any voice is proportion: match the weight you carry upward to what your lightest top note can hold. Heavier is not better; sustainable is better.

Josh Groban

G2–A4 · 2 octaves + 2

Baritone USA · prominent since 2001 · known for “You Raise Me Up”

Pop-classical baritone recorded warm and close; opens into a full ring across the top fourth.

Close-mic'd and warm, with a low register that sits near speech and almost no vibrato, then a gradual opening as the line climbs until there is full ring by the top fourth toward A4. Vibrato arrives late in sustained notes and widens as it goes. Much of the swell is the vowel opening plus microphone distance rather than added force. Shove at the top notes and the phrase stops growing.

Diana Damrau

Bb3–G#6 · 2 octaves + 10

Soprano Germany · prominent since 2002 · known for “Der Hölle Rache”

HIGH G#6 IN “FRÜHLINGSSTIMMEN”

Glittering German coloratura: laser staccati above high C, a warm lyric middle, and theatrical bite in every run.

Damrau's coloratura runs on appoggio breath support and a high, forward point of resonance: staccati above the staff are released from the body, not chipped from the throat. Her onset is clean and glottal-light, the vibrato even and quick, and text stays vivid even in fioritura — consonants ride on top of a legato air column. Low phrases near Bb3 stay slender rather than chesty. What students get wrong is treating the top as a separate mechanism; her G#6 is the same narrow, spinning column as her middle, just smaller vowels and firmer support.

Philippe Jaroussky

D3–G#5 · 2 octaves + 6

Countertenor France · prominent since 2004 · known for “Ombra mai fu”

Crystalline countertenor: pure, vibrato-light falsetto with liquid coloratura and choirboy clarity.

Jaroussky refines falsetto into a full instrument: light fold-edge phonation tuned with such consistent closure that it behaves like a soprano head voice, even and vibrant across the compass. His coloratura is airflow-driven, each note articulated by a support pulse while the throat stays passive. Vibrato is slim and constant; dynamics move by resonance size, not pressure. Near D3 he shades toward modal color; at G#5 the tone remains poised and small-cored. Imitators force volume into falsetto and get hoot; his carrying power comes from formant tuning and absolute breath economy, built on messa di voce drills.

Jackie Evancho

G#3–A5 · 2 octaves + 1



Soprano USA · prominent since 2010 · known for “O Mio Babbino Caro”

LOW G#3 IN “PURE IMAGINATION” · HIGH A5 IN “IMAGINER”

Dark, veiled crossover soprano; a small instrument with an adult's slow vibrato and long legato lines.

Evancho darkens her vowels deliberately: low larynx, covered tone, and a slow, wide vibrato that reads far older than the instrument producing it. The sound is veiled rather than brilliant — air is allowed through the fold closure as a stylistic wash. Phrases arc in long crescendo-decrescendo shapes with portamento connecting intervals. Near G#3 the sound is barely voiced; at A5 it opens into a rounded head tone without metallic edge. The imitation trap is manufacturing maturity by weight; the workable lesson is her legato discipline and unhurried phrase pacing, not the darkened color itself.

NEXT Musical theatre →

22 Musical theatre

Musical theatre is where the belt became a licensed profession. The women and men in this chapter deliver climactic full-voice singing on a schedule no other genre attempts — eight shows a week, months at a stretch — and that schedule is the invisible author of every technique their entries describe. Theatre belting is mix engineering under another name: chest-quality brightness carried on head-voice efficiency, narrow vowels at the top, intensity that reads as maximum while spending far less than maximum. When an entry here describes a famous eleven-o'clock note, it is describing a note designed to be repeatable, which is a different and harder achievement than a note designed to be recorded once.

The chapter spans the tradition's two dialects. Legit technique — the classically rooted, vibrato-forward sound of the older repertoire — sits beside the contemporary belt that took over as pop scores arrived, and several entries document careers fluent in both, switching styles per show the way session players switch instruments. Diction is the shared constant: every word to the back row, over an orchestra, without amplification's help for most of the form's history.

Steal three things from this chapter regardless of your genre. The marking discipline: theatre singers rehearse at partial voice and perform at full, the exact opposite of amateurs who blow out in rehearsal. The vowel modification at volume, documented entry after entry. And the acting posture — every phrase delivered as a thought

occurring now — which is, on the evidence of this book, the cheapest upgrade available to technically solid singers who somehow remain boring.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. ▌ marks the top of full voice.



Ethel Merman

F3–D5 · 1 octave + 9



Mezzo-soprano USA · prominent since 1930 · known for “There's No Business Like Show Business”

Unamplified chest belt with a trumpet-like edge, no audible register shift, pitch dead center.

This is chest voice used like a brass instrument: bright, forward, and remarkably even in volume across the whole range to D5, with no register shift anywhere to hear. Pitch sits dead centre and the note arrives at full size immediately instead of growing into it. Vibrato stays narrow and steady rather than wide. Vowels are open and consonants crisp enough to carry a room without a microphone. That volume is resonance and breath balance at work, not throat force.

Judy Garland

F3–Eb5 · 1 octave + 10



Contralto USA · prominent since 1939 · known for “Over the Rainbow”

HIGH EB5 IN “THE MAN THAT GOT AWAY”

Contralto with a tremulous forward vibrato, thick chest resonance, and an audible catch on held notes.

Listen for the shake: a fast, narrow vibrato placed well forward in the mask, sometimes widening into an audible waver across a sustained note. That waver rides on a pulse in the breath rather than a squeeze in the throat, which is why the tone stays open even while it moves. Chest resonance holds thick well above the middle of the staff, and phrase endings tend to break off with a small catch instead of tapering out. Consonants get attacked firmly, vowels stay wide and speech-like.

Julie Andrews

G3–C6 · 2 octaves + 5



Soprano UK · prominent since 1956 · known for “The Sound of Music”

Bell-clear soprano with exact intonation and light vibrato; very little chest-voice pressure.

Clarity comes from clean vowels and very little air in the tone. Pitch centre is exact, onsets are quiet and precise, and the vibrato is light enough that long notes read as nearly straight. Chest register is used sparingly and released early, so the climb toward the top of the range happens in clear head voice with no gear change audible. Diction stays crisp without hardening the vowel. The bottom of the range is where the illusion usually breaks, given a weight this voice never carries.

Bernadette Peters

G3–A5 · 2 octaves + 2



Soprano · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 1968 · known for “Children Will Listen”

Small breathy soprano with a fluttering vibrato; thins the top on purpose for a childlike color.

Breath is left in the tone deliberately: you can hear air travelling alongside the pitch, and the vibrato flutters fast and shallow rather than swinging wide. Volume stays small, so the C5 belt reads as an emotional break instead of a display. Above it she thins into a narrow, childlike head tone rather than filling it out. Phrasing sits well behind the beat, with real silence inside a line. The trap is copying the breathiness without support, which lets pitch sag.

Michael Crawford

A2–Bb4 · 2 octaves + 1



Tenor · UK · prominent since 1973 · known for “The Music of the Night”

Light breath-heavy tenor with narrow vibrato; favors head voice over chest pressure.

There is very little weight in the instrument by design: a slim, breath-mixed tenor that leans into head resonance instead of pressing chest upward, so the approach to Bb4 gets softer rather than louder. Vibrato is narrow and even, tucked inside the tone instead of decorating it. Onsets are gentle, with air arriving a fraction before the pitch, and consonants are shaped lightly so the legato never breaks. Anyone imitating this adds chest weight for the high phrases, which is exactly the wrong instinct.

Patti LuPone

E3–G5 · 2 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 1979 · known for “Don't Cry for Me Argentina”

Dark chest-dominant belt, wide vibrato, and a consonant-heavy attack that lands every syllable.

Everything begins with the consonant. Hard t's, d's and s's set the rhythm before the vowel arrives, and the tone underneath is dark, thick, low-placed chest carried all the way to the D5 belt. Vibrato is wide and slow, more a shudder than a shimmer. Phrases stretch and compress against the accompaniment instead of sitting square on it. The common error is mistaking that weight for volume and simply shouting; the size comes from a low, settled larynx and a very full breath.

Colm Wilkinson

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to A4 · Ireland · prominent since 1985 · known for “Bring Him Home”

Reedy tenor with pronounced vibrato and a plaintive edge on long sustained high phrases.

Reediness comes from a narrow, slightly nasal resonance rather than a wide open throat, and it gives the upper range a thin pleading edge instead of a heroic ring. Vibrato is prominent and fairly wide, present from the instant the note starts. Long high phrases are sung quietly and held, thinning toward the end of the breath instead of being reinforced. Copying the vibrato without the reedy placement produces a wobble; that narrowness is what keeps it in focus.

Lea Salonga

F3–D6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano · full voice to D5 · Philippines · prominent since 1989 · known for “On My Own”

Clear, vibrato-light soprano with precise legato; shifts to a bright chest belt for pop lines.

Her sound is unusually tidy. Onsets begin right on the pitch with no scoop, vowels stay narrow and matched from note to note, and vibrato is withheld until the last beat of a long tone. Between the D5 belt and the top of the range she moves into a light head register with almost no seam, so the change reads as a shift of colour rather than a change of gear. Imitations go wrong by adding weight and constant vibrato; the plainness is the technique.

Audra McDonald

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · USA · prominent since 1994 · known for “Summertime”

Classically placed lyric soprano with fast vibrato; drops to plain speech-tone for storytelling.

Classical placement shows in the vowels: tall, rounded, spinning on a fast narrow vibrato that stays consistent from the bottom of the staff to the top. The interesting move is what she sets against it, dropping mid-phrase into a plain, nearly spoken tone with the vibrato switched off, then letting it return. There is no belt in play; the upper range is supported head voice. The contrast is the point, and the spoken passages are what make the sung ones land.

Idina Menzel

G2–D6 · 3 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 1996 · known for “Let It Go”

Nasal-forward mix and a hard-edged chest belt that stays loud without thinning near the top.

Listen for a narrow, bright tone placed high in the nose and pressed against the front teeth; that forward buzz is what keeps the belt loud up to F5 instead of thinning. Quiet lines start breathy and nearly spoken, then the belt arrives with a firm push and no gradual ramp. Vibrato is slow and shows up late, often only as the note releases. Nothing in the sound is round or covered; the whole effect depends on keeping it narrow and in front.

Hugh Jackman

A2–B4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone · Australia · prominent since 1998 · known for “The Greatest Show”

Baritone with a bright forward belt; speech-driven phrasing, short sustains, restrained vibrato.

Delivery is built on speech. The rhythm of the line follows the rhythm of the sentence, so notes are released as soon as the word is finished instead of being held for their own sake. Tone is baritone-thick but placed forward and bright, and the top of the range near B4 is taken with a firm forward mix rather than an open ring. Vibrato barely appears. Imitators over-sing the sustains and lose the conversational drive the phrasing depends on.

Kristin Chenoweth

G3–F6 · 2 octaves + 10



Soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 1999 · known for “Popular”

HIGH F6 IN “GLITTER AND BE GAY”

Coloratura top with easy staccato leaps, plus a separate brassy belt she switches into abruptly.

Two voices sit side by side. One is a light coloratura that leaps and detaches cleanly, each staccato note re-articulated from the breath rather than chopped in the throat, and it runs far above the staff. The other is a brassy, nasal-forward belt topping out near F5. She swaps between them mid-phrase with no blending, and the abruptness is part of the comedy. Smoothing the join would remove the effect, and reaching for coloratura pitches from inside the belt is what strains it.

Sutton Foster

F3–A5 · 2 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 2002 · known for “Gimme Gimme”

Bright mixed belt with comic timing built into the phrasing; sustains high notes without hardening.

Comic timing is built into the singing rather than layered on afterwards: words land early or late against the beat, and a line can drop to speech and back inside a single phrase. The belt is a genuine mix instead of pure chest, bright and forward and light enough that sustaining near F5 neither hardens nor spreads. Onsets are clean, vibrato modest and late. Chesting the belt for extra volume locks the top and removes the flexibility the timing needs.

Nicole Scherzinger

D3–G#6 · 3 octaves + 6



Soprano · whistle register · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “Buttons”

Athletic pop-theatre soprano — muscular belts, precise melisma, and a head voice that opens into whistle territory.

Control at every altitude: Scherzinger drills melisma with dance-track precision, each run landing on grid, supported from a strong appoggio. Her chest voice is muscular and dark-tinted near D3, her belts squarely projected, and the top blooms through head voice into occasional whistle tones toward G#6. Vibrato is polished and even. Theatre discipline shows in her consonants and long sustains. Imitators chase the high notes first; the foundation is the rock-solid middle she never lets wobble.

Jonathan Groff

A2–C5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor · USA · prominent since 2006 · known for “You'll Be Back”

Round warm tenor with clean onsets; steady sustain and almost no scooping into pitches.

Notice how little decoration there is. Pitches start exactly where they finish, with no slide up into them and no fall off the back, and the tone stays round and warm rather than edgy. Sustains hold at even volume with small, late vibrato. Because the range tops out around C5 and sits in a comfortable legit placement, the whole effect rests on accuracy of the onset. Scoops and swells added on top read immediately as effort, because there is nothing decorative here to hide behind.

Lea Michele

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2006 · known for “Don't Rain on My Parade”

Broad nasal belt with heavy vibrato; pop riffing layered over legit theatre technique.

Placement is high and nasal, which broadens the belt and keeps it bright all the way to E5. Vibrato is heavy and fast, arriving early in the note and staying for its full length. Underneath sits a legit theatre foundation, full breath and matched vowels and long sustains, with pop riffs and quick turns laid over the top, sometimes inside one phrase. Attacks are firm and scooped slightly from below. Pinching the throat to get the brightness narrows the tone without adding ring.

Aaron Tveit

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to B4 · USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “Come What May”

Rock-leaning tenor with a compressed high mix; pushes volume instead of switching registers.

Everything here runs on compression. The tone stays narrow and pressed, and volume rather than a register change does the work as the line climbs to the B4 belt and past it. There is no flip to falsetto; the top thins but holds its chest colour. Vibrato is fast, small, and mostly saved for the release. Attacks come straight on, with a light rasp on loud consonants. Loudness without that narrow setup becomes pushed air instead of raised intensity.

Sierra Boggess

G3–E6 · 2 octaves + 9



Soprano USA · prominent since 2008 · known for “The Phantom of the Opera”

HIGH E6 IN “THE PHANTOM OF THE OPERA”

Lyric soprano with a floated top and easy pianissimo; even vibrato through the passage.

Steady, unhurried air does all the work here, and it is what lets the very quiet high notes stay in tune and keep their vibrato. Through the passage between registers the tone does not change weight or colour, so nothing pushes and nothing thins, and the top of the range floats rather than projects. Onsets are soft and exactly on pitch. Singers chasing this hold the breath back to get quiet, which stops the vibrato and lets the note settle flat.

Ramin Karimloo

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor full voice to Bb4 Canada · prominent since 2009 · known for “Til I Hear You Sing”

Baritone-weighted tenor with rock grit; carries chest colour higher than most legit theatre tenors.

The instrument sits low and heavy for a tenor: a thick bottom reaching down to G2, and that same dark chest colour carried up through the Bb4 belt rather than lightened into a legit tenor mix. Grit is applied selectively, on the attack of one important word, then dropped again. Vibrato is broad and slow. Phrases build across a long line instead of arriving at full size. Without deep support underneath, carried chest of that weight collapses into plain pushing.

Jeremy Jordan

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 2012 · known for “Santa Fe”

High tenor belt with a metallic ring; adds grit up top and flips to falsetto past the break.

Ring is the giveaway: a hard metallic edge from close fold contact and a narrow resonance space, which pushes the belt to C5 and keeps it cutting through a band. Above that he adds grit on the attack, then flips openly into falsetto instead of dragging chest higher, so you hear the seam and are meant to. Rhythm is aggressive and consonants land early. The grit rides on breath pressure rather than throat squeeze, which is why the metallic edge survives it.

Ben Platt

A2–F5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to D5 · USA · prominent since 2015 · known for “Waving Through a Window”

Tight cry-heavy high mix with audible glottal breaks used as expression rather than fault.

The core sound is a narrow cry, thin and forward, and that is what carries the mix to D5 without full chest weight. Onsets frequently begin with a small glottal catch, and the voice is allowed to crack or break at the end of a phrase; those breaks are placed, not accidents. Consonants get clipped and the rhythm often runs slightly ahead of the beat. The usual mistake is faking the crack by cutting off the breath, which destabilises the whole line.

Cynthia Erivo

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · UK · prominent since 2015 · known for “I'm Here”

Gospel-rooted belt with fast melisma and controlled rasp, releasing into clean head voice.

Gospel-style ornament sits on top of theatre discipline: fast melisma with every note of the run separately articulated, bends into pitches from below, and a rasp added to the front of a word then removed within the same phrase. The belt drives to F5 on real chest weight, and rather than force past it she releases into a clean, unpressed head voice for the notes above. That release is the hard part; most singers either stay in the belt and push or lose the tone entirely in the switch.

Auli'i Cravalho

F3–E5 · 1 octave + 11



Mezzo-soprano · USA · prominent since 2016 · known for “How Far I'll Go”

HIGH E5 IN “HOW FAR I'LL GO”

Bright youthful mezzo; unforced belt into the fifth octave, steady pitch, very little vibrato.

Bright and forward from the first syllable, with a thin, focused tone and almost no vibrato, so long notes read as very straight and very young. Each note starts dead on pitch, never scooped up into. Across the top of the staff the belt stays in a bright mix rather than gaining chest weight, opening toward E5 with more space instead of more push. The pressure comes off at exactly the point where a louder singer would add it, and resonance does the carrying.

Loren Allred

E3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 2



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · USA · prominent since 2017 · known for “Never Enough”

HIGH F#5 IN “NEVER ENOUGH (THE GREATEST SHOWMAN)”

The voice of 'Never Enough': a cinematic mezzo that builds one long crescendo from velvet verse to full-throated peak.

Architecture makes this performance famous: one dynamic staircase, managed so gradually that the final belt feels inevitable rather than loud. The verse tone is warm and covered, vibrato slow and wide; as the song climbs, the vowels open one notch per section, never all at once. Map any big ballad the same way, marking where each five-percent increase happens, and save the widest vowel for the last chorus. Starting at eighty percent is why most covers of this song plateau.

Rachel Zegler

Db3–E6 · 3 octaves + 3



Soprano · full voice to C5 · USA · prominent since 2021 · known for “Tonight”

HIGH E6 IN “GROWN-UP CHRISTMAS LIST”

Classic musical-theatre soprano — warm chest lows, a poised legit mix, and clear, ringing head voice.

Legit placement, modern mix: Zegler supports a classic theatre soprano line with tall vowels, clean legato and a head voice that rings toward E6 without shrillness. Her mix-belt tops out around C5, kept round and well-anchored rather than pushed, and the low register near Db3 stays warm and unforced. Vibrato is even and arrives quickly, opera-adjacent in spin. Students copying her often belt where she mixes — the sound reads bigger than it is because placement, not pressure, carries it.

NEXT Latin voices →

PART VIII

The world's voices

23 Latin voices 338

24 K-pop, J-pop and global pop 358

25 Reggae, Afrobeats and African voices 383

CONTENTS

23 Latin voices

This chapter covers more distinct vocal traditions than any other in the book, because "Latin" is a market category laid over a continent of genres. The entries span:

- **Ranchera:** enormous single-breath phrases and controlled quiebre cracks.
- **Bolero and balada:** velvet croons.
- **Salsa:** improvising soneros, phrasing against clave like horn players.
- **Tropical pop:** bright, danceable belts.
- **The folk traditions:** singer-poets.
- **Urbano:** melody compressed into rhythmic, Auto-Tune-glossed speech, the voice as a percussion instrument with vowels.

Reading across them, two shared technical values emerge. Breath length: several of these traditions treat the long, unbroken phrase as the fundamental unit of expression, and their entries describe support work that would satisfy an opera coach. And vowel purity: Spanish's five clean vowels give these voices their characteristic directness of tone — no diphthong drift, resonance stable across the note — which is a borrowable discipline for singers in any language and the single fastest fix for muddy sustained notes.

The chapter's present tense belongs to the bilingual generation, moving between English and Spanish phonetics inside one song and using the switch as a color change. Their entries, alongside the corridos revival's raw regional timbres, make this the atlas's best demonstration that tradition and experiment are not opposites: every modern sound in this chapter is built directly on one of the old techniques, usually within audible distance of it.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Celia Cruz

E3–G5 · 2 octaves + 3



Contralto | full voice to E5 | Cuba · prominent since 1950 · known for “La Vida Es Un Carnaval”

Brassy forward chest tone built to cut through horn sections; percussive improvised soneos.

The tone is forward and chest-dominant, with hard consonants and almost no breath in it, sitting closer to a brass section than to a crooner. Improvised soneos come out percussive and speech-rhythmic, trading with the band rather than floating over it, and the belt around E5 stays bright instead of covered. Rhythm is the hard part. Those calls are placed precisely against the montuno, and singing them loosely turns declamation into noise.

Elis Regina

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to G5 · Brazil · prominent since 1965 · known for “Como Nossos Pais”

Bright forward mezzo with abrupt dynamic swings and hard consonant attacks.

Dynamics move in sudden steps rather than gradual curves, so a phrase can travel from near-whisper to a bright forward belt inside a bar. Consonants are attacked hard, putting a percussive edge on the front of each word, and the belt up at G5 keeps chest color instead of softening. Timing pushes slightly ahead of the beat. Students even out the swings into a smooth line, and the theatrical contrast disappears.

Mercedes Sosa

E3–E5 · 2 octaves



Contralto · Argentina · prominent since 1965 · known for “Gracias a la Vida”

Dark chest-dominant contralto; little vibrato, plain declamation, weight on the vowel.

Weight sits on the vowel. Tone is dark, chest-dominant and nearly straight, vibrato appearing only faintly at the end of long notes, so the effect is declamatory rather than lyrical. Phrases are shaped like speech, pauses used as punctuation, dynamics shifting slowly. Nothing is decorated. Adding vibrato and rubato to sound more expressive flattens the plain, deliberate delivery that gives folk material its weight.

Vicente Fernández

A2–C5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor Mexico · prominent since 1966 · known for “El Rey”

HIGH C5 IN “EL REY”

Open-throated ranchera tenor; full-voice top notes held long past the band.

Big vowels, a settled larynx, no nasal squeeze. The sound is built from openness before anything else, with a wide slow vibrato riding the long notes. Those top notes get held well past the point where the band expects to move on, volume steady rather than tapering, and the grito lands deliberately at phrase ends as a rising shouted cry. Dragging chest weight upward instead of opening the throat first is what turns the imitation stiff and sharp.

Caetano Veloso

A2–C5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor full voice to G4 Brazil · prominent since 1967 · known for “Alegria, Alegria”

Light breathy tenor pitched close to speech; soft onsets, almost no vibrato.

The delivery sits close to speech and barely rises above it, built from soft aspirate onsets, a light breathy tone and almost no vibrato, which leaves the pitch center fully exposed. Phrases stay short and conversational, often sitting behind the guitar rather than on top of it. Around G4 he keeps a gentle mix instead of opening out. Singing this quietly takes more breath control, not less, or the pitch sags.

Milton Nascimento

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to A4 · Brazil · prominent since 1967 · known for “Travessia”

Full chest register under a floating falsetto he treats as a second, instrument-like voice.

There are effectively two instruments at work. The chest register is warm and reaches down toward G2 with a belt around A4; the falsetto floats well above it, often on wordless lines, and functions as a separate voice entirely. The switch between them is audible but unhurried, with no grab at the transition. Falsetto vibrato is slow and narrow, and below the break there is almost none. Belting what he sings in falsetto loses the airy quality the approach depends on.

Julio Iglesias

B2–G4 · 1 octave + 8



Baritone · Spain · prominent since 1968 · known for “Hey”

LOW B2 IN “APRIL IN PORTUGAL” · HIGH G4 IN “SOLAMENTE UNA VEZ”

Hushed romantic baritone crooning at half-volume, all breath and intimacy over strings.

Iglesias sings at conversation volume on purpose: a low-pressure, breathy onset, minimal vibrato until the tail of the note, and phrases shaped like murmured speech. He rarely leaves the middle of the voice, keeping everything between B2 and G4, so the art is in micro-dynamics, rubato, and vowel color rather than range. The tone is placed softly in the mask with plenty of air in the mix. Students copying him usually over-sing; the aesthetic collapses above mezzo-piano.

José José

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to B4 · Mexico · prominent since 1970 · known for “El Triste”

HIGH D5 IN “EL TRISTE”

Clean lyric tenor; accurate on stepwise ballad climbs, near-seamless chest-to-mix handoff.

Onsets land precisely without turning glottal, vibrato stays narrow and steady, and the climb through the passaggio into mix near B4 arrives with no seam and no shift of color. Ballad lines build stepwise, one degree at a time, which leaves intonation exposed the whole way up. Volume is not what makes the top work; the tone stays slim and resonance does the growing.

Juan Gabriel

A2–C5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to A4 · Mexico · prominent since 1971 · known for “Amor Eterno”

Reedy ranchera tenor that slips into falsetto mid-phrase, with loose conversational timing.

Phrases lean late, stretch, then scramble to catch up, so a ranchera line ends up sounding spoken as much as sung. The tone underneath is reedy and narrow with a bright edge that carries over horns. Mid-phrase the voice breaks upward into falsetto and drops back again, treating the crack as an expressive move rather than a fault. Smoothing that transition out to sound polished removes the exact thing that makes the delivery his.

Camilo Sesto

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to C5 · Spain · prominent since 1972 · known for “Vivir Asi Es Morir de Amor”

HIGH E5 IN “GETSEMANI”

High cutting tenor with a rock edge; loud upper sustains carried on heavy vibrato.

This is a tenor that lives at the top of the staff, bright and edged on the consonants, where the C5 belt is a working note rather than a stunt and E5 is within reach. Sustains come out loud, carried on a wide vibrato that starts fast and stays wide. Phrases climb instead of sitting still. Grabbing at the throat is the usual mistake, when the top needs a narrow vowel and steady breath.

Luis Miguel

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to B4 · Mexico · prominent since 1982 · known for “La Incondicional”

Warm bolero tenor; open vowels, unbroken legato, gradual crescendo into sustained notes.

Those long bolero sustains run for bars, so the breath has to sit at steady pressure rather than get shoved out at the start, and that is where most imitations come apart. Vowels stay wide open and the line never breaks: phrases arrive on a soft, aspirate onset and grow by crescendo instead of by attack. Vibrato is even and enters early in the note. Around the B4 belt he blends into a warm mix rather than shouting, which keeps the peak of a phrase round.

Gloria Estefan

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · Cuba · prominent since 1985 · known for “Conga”

Rounded mezzo with even vibrato; ballad lines stay inside a comfortable mid-belt.

Warm vowels and gentle onsets keep the tone round, and a mid-rate vibrato holds the same width whether a phrase is loud or soft. Ballads live in a comfortable middle and step up to the F5 belt without changing color, so nothing sounds strained. Uptempo material trades sustain for crisp rhythmic accents. There is no grit to reach for here, because the appeal is a smooth, unhurried line.

Selena

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · USA · prominent since 1989 · known for “Como La Flor”

Bright mezzo with a thick lower-middle and plain, unornamented cumbia phrasing.

The lower middle carries real weight and stays undecorated, which is why cumbia lines land so squarely on the beat. Onsets are clean; vibrato is light and arrives late in a sustain rather than at the start. Up to the F5 belt the tone stays chesty and forward, and above it she thins into a lighter head voice. Piling runs onto these melodies erases the plainness they were built on.

Thalía

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Soprano · full voice to F5 · Mexico · prominent since 1990 · known for “Amor a la Mexicana”

Light bright soprano; thin low notes, girlish forward mix carrying the upper hooks.

F3 is a genuine floor and it stays quiet down there, thin rather than supported. The working sound above it is a bright girlish mix that carries hooks to about F5 without much chest weight behind them. Onsets are soft, vibrato fast and shallow, and phrase ends often lift slightly. Adding body low down is the usual miscalculation, since the character depends on staying slender with high placement.

Ricky Martin

B2–C5 · 2 octaves + 1



Tenor · full voice to A4 · Puerto Rico · prominent since 1991 · known for “Livin' la Vida Loca”

Grainy pop tenor with a short usable top; leans on rhythm, shouts and falsetto flips.

Grain in the tone does a lot of work, because the comfortable belt stops around A4 and C5 is the ceiling. Rather than climbing past that he leans on rhythm: short barked phrases, spoken interjections, and quick flips into falsetto for anything above the break. Vibrato stays minimal. The hooks are written low on purpose, so taking them in full chest only produces strain when the energy is meant to come from attack and groove.

Alejandro Fernández

F#2–C5 · 2 octaves + 6

Baritone · Mexico · prominent since 1992 · known for “Me Dediqué a Perderte”

LOW F#2 IN “SÉ QUE TE DUELE” · HIGH C5 IN “ME DEDIQUÉ A PERDERTE”

Virile ranchero baritone: dark low phrases, a proud ringing top and mariachi-sized sustain.

Fernández projects like a stage actor: dark, chesty vowels at F#2 up through a ringing, covered top at C5, all carried on long, even breath. His vibrato is broad and proud, applied to nearly every sustained tone, and he shapes ranchera phrases with big dynamic arcs, swelling into the cry and then backing off. The tone never spreads; even at full volume the vowels stay tall. Copying him requires his rib-open support, because without it the covered top collapses into throat.

Cristian Castro

G2–C6 · 3 octaves + 5

Tenor · Mexico · prominent since 1992 · known for “Azul”

LOW G2 IN “ME QUEDÉ” · HIGH C6 IN “NO PODRÁS”

Sweet lyric tenor with a weightless mixed voice that floats ballad climaxes into the fifth octave.

Castro's calling card is a seamless mix: he thins chest gradually as he ascends, so fifth-octave notes sound like an extension of speech rather than a gear change. The tone is sweet and rounded, vibrato moderate and even, with head resonance dominating from the passaggio all the way to C6. He can also settle down to G2 with surprising body. Copying him means practicing messa di voce on high sustained notes; singers who grab volume at the top break the illusion of weightlessness.

Marc Anthony

A2–E5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to C#5 · USA · prominent since 1993 · known for “Vivir Mi Vida”

Cutting salsa tenor; nasal placement and tight vibrato on high sustained calls over horns.

Placement is high and nasal by design, because that is what cuts through a full horn section. Sustains sit up near the C#5 belt with a fast, tight vibrato that starts almost immediately. Phrases get clipped short and set against the clave instead of sung legato. Beginners chase the loudness and end up shouting under pitch; the intensity here is forward resonance, not air pressure.

Shakira

E3–D6 · 2 octaves + 10



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · Colombia · prominent since 1995 · known for “Hips Don't Lie”

Nasal-edged chest voice with a fast natural vibrato and Arabic-inflected melisma.

Nasal placement is the whole sound — the tone stays forward and slightly pinched, which lets a fast, narrow vibrato ride on a chesty middle. Ornaments come from Arabic-style melisma: quick microtonal slides and trills threaded between beats. Above the E5 belt she flips into a light, hooty upper register rather than pushing. Students chase the buzz by squeezing the throat, but that buzz belongs in the mask with the larynx loose.

Enrique Iglesias

C#3–G#4 · 1 octave + 7



Tenor · full voice to F#4 · Spain · prominent since 1996 · known for “Hero”

The whispering heartthrob: a breathy, intimate light tenor that made proximity, not power, the selling point.

Proximity is the product: a light tenor delivered half-whispered into a close microphone, air deliberately mixed into the tone, consonants softened to a murmur, so every listener hears a private serenade. Pitch rises into a gentle, strained upper register that stays sympathetic rather than impressive. Dynamics barely move; intensity comes from getting quieter, not louder. Practice singing at whisper volume while keeping the pitch line exact, and resist clearing the breathiness. Cleaning up this voice would erase its entire appeal.

Luis Fonsi

E3–A4 · 1 octave + 5



Tenor · Puerto Rico · prominent since 1998 · known for “Despacito”

LOW E3 IN “AQUÍ ESTOY YO” · HIGH A4 IN “AQUÍ ESTOY YO”

Polished pop tenor, clean sustained ballad peaks and a smiling, forward tone that rides reggaeton just as easily.

Fonsi keeps the voice forward and smiling, with a clean, quick onset and a polished, even vibrato reserved for sustained peaks. Ballads sit squarely between E3 and A4, where he leans on crescendo-release shapes: start straight, swell, spin the vibrato, taper. Consonants stay crisp for rhythmic tracks and he never lets the tone splay. What students miss when copying him is the taper; ending big notes at full pressure reads as strain where his phrase endings float.

Natalia Lafourcade

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Soprano · full voice to E5 · Mexico · prominent since 2002 · known for “Hasta la Raiz”

Small airy soprano, head-voice dominant, folk-style straight tone with gentle vibrato.

Head voice dominates even through the middle, small and airy, with a folk-style straight tone that only blooms into gentle vibrato at the ends of phrases. Onsets are soft, consonants light, and the F3 floor is nearly spoken. Her belt at E5 stays slim and forward rather than thickening into chest. Loading weight underneath it to make the sound carry defeats the intimacy, which depends on staying quiet and steady on the air.

Jenni Rivera

C3–E5 · 2 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · USA · prominent since 2005 · known for “De Contrabando”

LOW C3 IN “LA GRAN SEÑORA” · HIGH E5 IN “RESULTA”

Blunt, brassy banda mezzo that spits consonants, bends notes like norteño accordion lines and belts heartbreak head-on.

Rivera attacks consonants hard and sings vowels with a blunt, open chest that stays engaged from C3 up to belted peaks near E5. Her ornaments come from banda phrasing: quick bends, falling releases, and a sobbed break she deploys on emotional peaks like punctuation. Vibrato is fast and pressed. She trades polish for presence — slightly pushed, deliberately raw. Students copying her round off the edges; the style demands consonant aggression and a chest-dominant mix held higher than is comfortable.

Maluma

D3–F4 · 1 octave + 3



Baritone Colombia · prominent since 2015 · known for “Felices los 4”

LOW D3 IN “FELICES LOS 4” · HIGH F4 IN “FELICES LOS 4”

Low-slung, conversational reggaeton croon: soft-edged, rhythmic, and closer to a murmur than a belt.

Maluma works almost entirely in a relaxed low mix, D3 to F4, and treats rhythm as the lead element: syllables land slightly behind the beat while the tone stays low-larynxed and conversational. He uses light vocal fry as an onset ornament and slides into pitches rather than attacking them. Dynamics barely move; intimacy is the whole engine. Singers copying him tend to add projection and vibrato, which breaks the murmured contract of the style. Keep it small, dry, and rhythmically exact.

Ozuna

F#2–C5 · 2 octaves + 6



Tenor Puerto Rico · prominent since 2016 · known for “Se Preparó”

LOW F#2 IN “CAMA VACÍA” · HIGH C5 IN “COMÉNTALE”

High, boyish and feather-light reggaeton tenor that glides over dembow like a falsetto that never lands.

Ozuna floats a light, high-set tenor that lives just under falsetto, vowels narrow and bright, air deliberately leaking through the tone. Top flicks at C5 are quick releases, never planted belts, and his occasional F#2 lows are spoken color. Melisma is small and fast, decorating line ends rather than driving them. The whole sound depends on low breath pressure and high placement; copying it with full-voice support makes it heavy, and heaviness is precisely what the style cannot carry.

Bad Bunny

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone · full voice to E4 · Puerto Rico · prominent since 2017 · known for “Titi Me Pregunto”

Low conversational baritone working a narrow band; rhythm and processing carry the melody.

The pitch range is deliberately small, most of the delivery sitting between F2 and the E4 belt, close to speech, with melody implied more than sung out. Onsets are soft, vowels dark and slack, and there is no vibrato to speak of. Interest comes from placement instead: syllables land just off the grid, dragging or pushing against the dembow. Over-projecting and over-tuning it strips out the conversational flatness the style runs on.

Christian Nodal

A2–G4 · 1 octave + 10



Baritone · full voice to F4 · Mexico · prominent since 2017 · known for “Adiós Amor”

Mariachi weight in a young frame: a dark, wide-vibrato baritone built on ranchera's long-breath phrasing.

Ranchera discipline underpins everything: long phrases sustained on one enormous breath, a wide, slow vibrato that opens fully on held notes, and a dark, chesty tone that stays rich even at the top of the staff. The famous quiebre, a small controlled crack into falsetto and back, decorates phrase peaks. Practice sustaining eight-second tones with the vibrato arriving after two counts, then add the quiebre as a quick flip. Thin, pop-placed tone cannot carry this repertoire's weight.

Karol G

E3–A5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to E5 · Colombia · prominent since 2017 · known for “Provenza”

Slightly raspy mezzo with breathy onsets, parked in a narrow mid-belt for reggaeton hooks.

Aspirate onsets let breath into the tone, the edges stay slightly raspy, and the whole delivery lives inside a narrow band around the E5 belt. Phrases lag a fraction behind the beat, which is what makes them feel unhurried. Vibrato barely appears, and notes get cut off rather than sustained. Sung fully supported and squarely on the grid, these hooks come out too tidy for the pocket.

Rosalía

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F#5 · Spain · prominent since 2017 · known for “Malamente”

Flamenco-trained melisma: glottal attacks, microtonal bends, light and agile up top.

Flamenco training shows in the attacks, which are hard and glottal, and in long melismatic runs that bend between notes instead of stepping cleanly, ornaments sitting a quarter-tone off before they resolve. A slight rasp runs through the middle, while the top near F#5 stays agile and light rather than thickening. Vibrato is often withheld, then added at the very end of a held note. Round those microtonal bends into ordinary scale tones and the idiom vanishes.

Ángela Aguilar

Eb3–G5 · 2 octaves + 4



Mezzo-soprano · Mexico · prominent since 2018 · known for “La Llorona”

HIGH G5 IN “¡QUE SUERTE!”

Bright young mariachi mezzo with a fast vibrato, crisp Spanish diction and clean sustained ranchera cries.

Aguilar sings ranchera with a schooled, upright production: tall vowels, clean legato, and a quick, tight vibrato she can start or still at will. Sustained cries up at G5 stay in a bright, forward mix rather than open shout, while her Eb3 chest lows keep spoken warmth. Ornamentation is classic mariachi — falsete flips, turns, sobbed onsets — executed with precision. Students copying her usually oversize the voice; her control reads bigger than her actual mass, which is the entire lesson.

Kali Uchis

C3–F5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to B4 · Colombia/USA · prominent since 2018 · known for “Telepatía”

Dream-soul bilingüe: a honeyed, retro-glossed mezzo drifting between English and Spanish, doo-wop and reggaetón.

Languor is the aesthetic: notes arrive slightly behind the beat on a honeyed, half-breath tone, with sixties girl-group vibrato at phrase ends and an easy float into a cooing head voice for the high lines. Switching languages changes the vowel color, brighter in Spanish, hazier in English, and she uses that contrast as an arrangement tool. Practice one chorus in each language, matching pitch while letting the vowels shift naturally. Rushing the beat is the quickest way to lose this style entirely.

Carín León

F#2–A#4 · 2 octaves + 4



Baritone Mexico · prominent since 2019 · known for “Primera Cita”

LOW F#2 IN “BOCA CHUECA” · HIGH A#4 IN “BOCA CHUECA”

Raspy norteño baritone that swells from cantina growl to full-chest cries without losing its ache.

León drives a grainy, compressed baritone with the throat slightly open-throttled, so every sustained note carries rasp on the surface and a clean core underneath. He plants low phrases at F#2 with speech weight, then belts to A#4 in full chest, bending into notes with mariachi-style scoops and sobbing releases. Vibrato is wide and late. The rasp is airflow-managed, not forced; students copying him grind for texture and lose the supported column that keeps his sound sustainable.

Omar Apollo

C3–F#5 · 2 octaves + 6



Tenor full voice to G4 USA · prominent since 2019 · known for “Evergreen”

Corridos heartbreak filtered through indie R&B: a plush falsetto-forward tenor with rancheras in its family tree.

Falsetto carries the confession: the upper voice is plush and rounded, floated over sparse guitar at the emotional peaks, while the chest voice underneath keeps a Mexican-American vowel warmth inherited from the rancheras his parents played. Runs are brief and descending, sighs turned into pitch. When he commits to full voice the belt is square and surprisingly sturdy. Alternate one phrase full, one phrase falsetto, keeping the breath line unbroken across the swap. That unbroken line is what sells the ache.

Rauw Alejandro

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Baritone Puerto Rico · prominent since 2020 · known for “Todo de Ti”

LOW G2 IN “ALGO MÁGICO” · HIGH C5 IN “TODO DE TI”

Auto-tune-glossed R&B-reggaeton voice sliding between a mellow baritone center and airy falsetto hooks.

Rauw layers a soft, centered baritone with constant micro-slides, treating pitch processing as a timbral effect rather than a crutch. Verses hover low, brushing G2, sung with a barely-open mouth and heavy air; hooks flip into a small, pure falsetto around C5 with no push at all. Transitions are deliberately audible, part of the aesthetic, and he phrases like a drummer, clipping syllables to the dembow grid. Students copying him over-support; the style needs less breath pressure than trained instinct supplies.

Peso Pluma

B2–F#4 · 1 octave + 7



Tenor full voice to E4 Mexico · prominent since 2022 · known for “Ella Baila Sola”

Corridos tumbados' rasped-reed voice: nasal, pinched and buzzing, phrased against tuba and charchetas like a lead instrument.

The pinch is deliberate: a nasal, reed-like buzz produced by narrowing the tone until it cuts through brass-heavy corridos arrangements, with phrasing that rides ahead of the beat in short, urgent spurts. Vibrato is quick and shallow, almost a flutter. The style speaks more than croons, and ornament comes as slides between chest tones. To explore it, sing through the nose deliberately on a mid-range line, then reduce until the buzz remains without the honk. The color is an acquired taste and an acquired skill.

NEXT K-pop, J-pop and global pop →

24 K-pop, J-pop and global pop

The center of this chapter is the idol system's product: singers trained from adolescence to dance at full output while delivering studio-grade vocals, auditioned annually against thousands, and drilled in ensemble discipline — hitting your line in a seven-way harmony after sprint choreography is a skill no Western tradition certifies. The main-vocal entries here describe the results: immaculate pitch under cardio load, mixed belts engineered for nightly repetition, and an agility standard set by survival shows where a shaky run ends a career. Alongside them, the ballad specialists of the Korean tradition sustain climactic belts that draw directly on trot and gospel lineages.

Japan's wing runs on different physics: a domestic industry so large it never needed export, producing genre-fluent stylists — city-pop sophistication, vocaloid-influenced precision at inhuman syllable rates, singer-songwriters swinging between woody lows and weightless falsetto. The chapter's remaining seats belong to the global outliers: playback legends whose ornament systems predate and outclass most Western melisma, and the multi-octave phenomena who tour the world on pure vocal spectacle.

What this chapter teaches best is *standards*: these industries quantify vocal skill — pitch under motion, harmony accuracy, consistency across two hundred shows — more explicitly than anywhere else in the book. The borrowable practice is theirs: drill songs while moving, record

everything, and treat consistency as the metric, because a voice that performs at its average is worth more than one that performs at its best.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.

C2 C3 C4 C5 C6 C7

Édith Piaf

B2–D5 · 2 octaves + 3



Mezzo-soprano France · prominent since 1936 · known for “La Vie en rose”

HIGH D5 IN “C'EST POUR ÇA”

Small body, huge chest voice: a brassy, fast-vibrato chanson sound that trembles and cuts through any orchestra.

Piaf produces sound like a trumpet: mask-forward, brassy, with a rapid, tight vibrato that starts the instant the note does. Her chest voice does nearly all the work, rolled r's and clipped French vowels punching each syllable, and top notes near D5 are taken as open chest calls, never covered. The B2 floor shows how dark the instrument sits. Imitators chase the tremble first; the tremble is a byproduct of intense forward placement and unwavering breath pressure, not a wobble you add.

Lata Mangeshkar

G3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 3

Soprano India · prominent since 1949 · known for “Lag Ja Gale”

Thin, light soprano; pinpoint intonation above the staff with straight tone and slim vibrato.

Slim, light, and placed high, with very little chest weight anywhere, because a narrow tone is what allows this much speed. The ornaments draw on a classical vocabulary: quick grace notes, tight oscillating turns, and smooth connecting slides that cross between pitches without a seam. Above the staff the vibrato thins out or drops away entirely, leaving a straight tone that sits dead centre in pitch. Weight is traded off on purpose here; adding any would cost the agility outright.

Charles Aznavour

D3–B4 · 1 octave + 9

Tenor France · prominent since 1956 · known for “La Bohème”

LOW D3 IN “LA BOHÈME” · HIGH B4 IN “LA BOHÈME”

Grainy, nasal-tinged French tenor that talks its way into song, warm below and pleading up top.

Aznavour half-speaks his lines, letting pitch emerge from inflection, then leans into sustained notes with a reedy, fast vibrato that sits high in the mask. The grain in the tone is deliberate: loose closure low around D3 for gravel, firmer closure as he climbs toward B4 so the top pleads instead of rasps. Phrasing follows text stress, not bar lines. Students copying him focus on the rasp and miss the discipline underneath: every syllable lands exactly on intent.

Teresa Teng

Eb3–B5 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano Taiwan · prominent since 1970 · known for “月亮代表我的心 (The Moon Represents My Heart)”

HIGH B5 IN “MORNING OF GOODBYE (さよならの朝)”

Honeyed light soprano with feather vibrato and seamless legato; sweetness carried on absolute breath control.

Teng's instrument is intimacy engineered: a light, high-placed mix with air feathered into the tone, vibrato small and quick like a pulse rather than a wave. She shapes Mandarin vowels forward and round, sliding between notes with tiny portamenti that never smear the pitch. Most phrases float in the middle, with lows near Eb3 warmed by breath and rare ascents toward B5 kept weightless. Copying her means practicing quiet: sustained soft singing with full cord closure, the hardest skill in the book.

Jacky Cheung

E3–C5 · 1 octave + 8



Baritone Hong Kong · prominent since 1985 · known for “吻別 (Goodbye Kiss)”

HIGH C5 IN “愛你痛到不知痛”

Rich Cantopop baritone with a metallic core, crooner phrasing and high notes pushed with open-throated ease.

Cheung centers everything on mid-range tone shaping: thick, resonant chest with a faint metallic ring, vowels rounded, vibrato settled and even. He works the octave above E3 for most of a song, spending climactic pushes toward C5 sparingly, approached with covered vowels and a firm breath lean. Dynamics do the storytelling — he crescendos through held notes instead of re-attacking them. Students copying him underrate his consonant timing; the crooner smoothness rides on precisely released word endings.

Faye Wong

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Mezzo-soprano China · prominent since 1992 · known for “我願意 (I'm Willing)”

LOW E3 IN “如果雲知道 (THE CLOUD KNOWS)”

Cool, weightless alt-pop voice: breathy attacks, sliding ornaments and a detached shimmer borrowed from dream-pop.

Wong sings off the breath deliberately: soft onsets, tone half-air and half-core, so notes seem to condense out of the track rather than start. Pitch is ornamented with slow slides and small falls, borrowed from dream-pop and Chinese inflection alike. Her comfortable band runs from about E3 to D5, and she rarely presses; dynamics move by microphone distance instead of muscle. Vibrato is minimal, almost incidental. Students copying the breathiness collapse support entirely — hers floats on a quietly firm column.

Laura Pausini

B2–F5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano Italy · prominent since 1993 · known for “La solitudine”

LOW B2 IN “IO CANTO” · HIGH F5 IN “IO CANTO”

Warm Italian mezzo with a fast, throbbing vibrato and open-vowel belts that crest on every chorus.

Pausini opens her vowels wide and keeps the sound frontal, so even mid-range lines feel projected. Her vibrato is quick and throbbing, engaged the moment a note settles, and she belts with tall Italian vowels rather than spread ones, which keeps the top ringing up toward F5. Low phrases near B2 turn husky and intimate. The habit to copy is her breath pacing across long crescendos; the habit to avoid is her belt without her appoggio, which turns shouty fast.

Lara Fabian

Eb3–D6 · 2 octaves + 11



Soprano · full voice to A5 · Belgium · prominent since 1997 · known for “Je t'aime”

LOW EB3 IN “IMMORTELLE” · HIGH D6 IN “QUI PENSE À L'AMOUR”

Wide-vibrato dramatic pop soprano whose long crescendos surge from a whisper to full-throated top notes.

Fabian is a study in graduated pressure: she starts phrases straight-toned and nearly still, then feeds in breath energy until the note blooms with a wide, pulsing vibrato. Her chest-mix belt stays plush and open through A5, and above it she releases into a freer head tone up toward D6. Down at Eb3 she sings on pure warmth, no push. Students copying her crescendos jump to full voice immediately; the whole effect depends on starting smaller than feels safe.

Ayumi Hamasaki

F3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 5



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · Japan · prominent since 1998 · known for “M”

Thin nasal mezzo with fast vibrato; drive comes from consonant attack more than chest volume.

The push in a chorus comes from consonants, not from chest volume. The tone is thin and forward with clear nasal resonance, vibrato fast and tight, and every syllable takes a hard attack that shoves the line on to the next one. The D5 belt stays narrow and bright rather than opening out. Add weight to compete with the arrangement and both the speed of the vibrato and the rhythmic bite go with it.

Hikaru Utada

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to D5 · Japan · prominent since 1998 · known for “First Love”

Low-set husky mezzo, conversational phrasing, R&B melisma kept small and slightly behind the beat.

This voice sits low and slightly husky, nearer to speaking than singing, breath audible in the tone and onsets beginning softly. Phrasing lags a fraction behind the beat, and melisma stays small, two or three notes, understated. The D5 belt keeps that conversational weight instead of opening out. Copying the laid-back timing usually just becomes late; the pulse has to stay exact underneath the relaxation.

Misia

F3–F6 · 3 octaves



Soprano · full voice to F5 · whistle register · Japan · prominent since 1998 · known for “Everything”

Full-bodied soprano who moves from breathy low verses to whistle notes held long and on pitch.

She works the range in layers rather than climbing it in one line. Verses can sit low and breathy with soft onsets; the chest belt then opens around F5 with full body and a wide, even vibrato; above that, whistle notes are entered cleanly and sustained on pitch instead of flicked at. Transitions get smoothed over, not jumped. The whistle is no party trick here, supported from the ribs the same way the belt below it is.

Park Hyo Shin

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · full voice to B4 · South Korea · prominent since 1999 · known for “Wild Flower”

Grainy tenor with stage-trained support; opens from near-whisper into a wide, ringing high belt.

He builds a phrase with dynamics rather than with extra notes. Lines begin near a whisper, grainy and slightly compressed, then open gradually into a wide belt that rings around B4, with a slow vibrato arriving only after the note settles. Consonants stay soft so the crescendo carries the feeling. Wild Flower runs that whole climb from near-silence up to full voice. Start at the loud end and there is nowhere left to go.

BoA

D3–C#6 · 2 octaves + 11



Soprano · South Korea · prominent since 2000 · known for “Only One”

Light, glassy soprano built for dance-pop — quick vibrato, crisp consonants, pitch locked to the beat.

A dancer's voice first: light, bright, and rhythm-locked, built to stay steady through movement. BoA mixes brightly with a lifted palate in the upper fourth octave, then shifts head-dominant above the fifth-octave line, where the sound turns glassy. Vibrato is shallow and quick. Those copying her often oversing; the style depends on crisp consonants, short phrases, and pitch that lands exactly on the grid, with agility kept simple rather than florid.

Jay Chou

A2–B4 · 2 octaves + 2



Baritone · full voice to G4 · Taiwan · prominent since 2000 · known for “青花瓷 (Blue and White Porcelain)”

LOW A2 IN “安靜 (AN JING)”

Mumbling, laid-back baritone that hides melody inside speech rhythm, rising to soft falsetto hooks.

Chou raps his melodies as much as he sings them: syllables tumble in front of the beat, tone lazy, low, and speech-like around A2, with almost no vibrato. When lines rise he keeps chest light up to G4, then brushes B4 in a soft falsetto that is deliberately fragile. Blurred diction is a stylistic choice that keeps focus on groove and harmony. Students copying him try to project; the aesthetic requires under-singing, near-spoken placement, and total rhythmic confidence.

Vitas

D2–Eb6 · 4 octaves + 1



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · Russia · prominent since 2000 · known for “Opera #2”

LOW D2 IN “GOOD-BYE” · HIGH EB6 IN “DEDICATION”

Techno-pop drama built on a laser-focused falsetto that climbs into the sixth octave over icy synths.

Vitas anchors everything in an unusually low-set speaking register, then vaults past his mixed ceiling around Bb4 into a hard, ringing falsetto that he treats like a lead instrument up to Eb6. The trick is compression: tiny vowels, high tongue, narrow resonance, so the top sounds sirened rather than breathy. Down at D2 he lets the cords slacken into fry-adjacent weight. Students copying him usually push chest too high instead of flipping early and resonating the flip.

JJ Lin

G2–G5 · 3 octaves



Tenor · full voice to D5 · Singapore · prominent since 2003 · known for “江南 (Jiangnan)”

Polished Mandopop tenor: creamy mid-range, precise runs and a head voice that thins to a glassy edge.

Lin sings on a cushioned, forward mix with immaculate intonation, carrying chest quality smoothly to D5 before handing off to a clean, flute-like head voice up to G5. Onsets are soft but precise, vibrato narrow and calm, and his R&B runs are articulated note-by-note rather than smeared. Lows around G2 stay relaxed and spoken. The register handoff is the teachable core: he thins gradually across the bridge, so students who flip abruptly miss the entire effect of continuity.

Taeyang

A2–F5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to B4 · South Korea · prominent since 2006 · known for “Eyes, Nose, Lips”

Raspy R&B tenor built on melisma, tight vibrato and a falsetto he flips into mid-phrase.

The rasp rides on top of a supported tone; it is surface texture, not a scrape at the cords. Phrases carry short melismatic turns and bends that land a hair behind the beat, and the vibrato is fast and narrow. At the top of the B4 belt he flips into falsetto mid-word, then drops back into chest without resetting the phrase, a move that recurs through Eyes, Nose, Lips. Manufacture the rasp in the throat and pitch center is the first thing to go.

Mika

F#2–G#5 · 3 octaves + 2



Tenor UK · prominent since 2007 · known for “Grace Kelly”

LOW F#2 IN “CRY” · HIGH G#5 IN “LOVE TODAY”

Glam-pop tenor bouncing between cheeky chest belts and a bright, elastic falsetto stacked in candy-colored layers.

Mika treats registration as a game: he sets up a line in bouncy, forward chest, then flips into falsetto mid-word and lands back without a seam. The falsetto is bright and pointed, driven by twang rather than air, which is why G#5 still cuts through a full band. His low F#2 asides are throwaway color, not structure. Copy the lightness first; singers who muscle the flips with volume lose the comic snap that makes his phrasing work.

Taeyeon

E3–C6 · 2 octaves + 8



Soprano full voice to F5 South Korea · prominent since 2007 · known for “I”

Nasal-bright soprano with compact vibrato; her belt stays thin yet cuts through dense mixes.

What cuts through an arrangement here is placement, not size. The tone rides forward with a nasal brightness, vibrato compact and quick, attacks clean and unaccented. Her belt around F5 stays narrow, more ring than weight, which is why it sits over a dense mix without shouting; above it she thins to head voice. Meet a loud track with added chest weight and the vowel thickens, burying the brightness that made the line audible.

G.E.M.

D3–F6 · 3 octaves + 3



Soprano · full voice to G#5 · whistle register · Hong Kong · prominent since 2008 · known for “泡沫 (Bubble)”

Compact soprano with huge lung pressure: sirening mixed belts, pop-rock grit and dolphin-high whistle flourishes.

G.E.M. compresses hard: a small frame producing big subglottal pressure, with a mixed belt that stays chest-heavy up to G#5 and a fast vibrato that kicks in under load. Verses sit low and husky near D3, sung close to the mic. Above the belt she releases either into clear head tone or a piercing whistle that can spike to F6. Runs are rhythmic and squared-off rather than gospel-loose. Copying her belt without her breath compression shreds consistency within a single chorus.

IU

D3–C6 · 2 octaves + 10



Soprano · full voice to E5 · South Korea · prominent since 2008 · known for “Good Day”

Small bell-clear soprano tone, exact pitch placement, and a light mix she keeps deliberately unforced.

Almost nothing decorative gets added. Onsets land without scoop, the tone is small, bright and bell-like with very little air in it, and vibrato appears as a flicker at the end of a sustain, if at all. Above the E5 belt she thins into head voice rather than pushing. The climbing high run that closes Good Day stays connected the whole way up. Breathiness and a wider vibrato would cost the precision that defines the sound.

Jonghyun

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · full voice to C5 · South Korea · prominent since 2008 · known for “Lonely”

Sharp ringing tenor with steady breath support; often ends phrases in controlled falsetto.

Ring is the defining quality: a bright, focused tone with even breath support, so long lines hold steady in volume and pitch. Onsets are clean, vibrato regular and fairly quick, and R&B turns are placed rather than sprayed. Phrases often finish in a controlled falsetto entered without a seam. The transition is what students miss, grabbing at falsetto instead of easing the weight off note by note.

LiSA

F3–F5 · 2 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · Japan · prominent since 2010 · known for “Gurenge”

Rock mezzo who takes anime choruses in a bright, strident chest mix and rarely drops to falsetto.

Nearly all of this happens in a bright chest-dominant mix, driven hard and kept connected across the whole F3 to F5 span rather than flipped to falsetto. Onsets are consonant-heavy and percussive, vowels wide and slightly strident, vibrato fast and applied late in a note. Rapid syllabic choruses like Gurenge require the breath be reset in tiny gaps. Most students take the volume without the support and run out of air by the second line.

Stromae

G2–G4 · 2 octaves



Baritone · full voice to F4 · Belgium · prominent since 2010 · known for “Alors on danse”

Chanson for the dancefloor: a theatrical Belgian baritone that swings between deadpan speech-song and Jacques Brel ache.

Theatre runs the voice: verses deliver rapid francophone speech-song with deadpan precision, every syllable machine-placed against the beat, then choruses open into a throbbing, Brel-inherited vibrato and a pushed, pleading upper register. The whiplash between the two modes is the drama. French nasal vowels are essential architecture, not accent. Practice the spoken sections with a metronome at full lyric speed, then the sung hook with generous, wide vibrato. Blending the two modes into one middle temperature loses the whole act.

Sohyang

E3–C7 · 3 octaves + 8



Soprano · full voice to C6 · whistle register · South Korea · prominent since 2011 · known for “Arirang Alone”

Trained soprano who stacks a supported high belt under a whistle register used as melody, not effect.

A belt sitting as high as C6 only holds because the breath under it is doing the work: larynx steady, vowel open, vibrato even and classical in width, no thinning into a scream. Above that, the whistle register works as a usable part of the instrument rather than a stunt, entered cleanly, held in tune, phrased like melody. The order matters. Whistle is the part people try to copy first, and the part that depends most on everything underneath it.

Ailee

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · South Korea · prominent since 2012 · known for “I Will Show You”

Thick gospel-schooled mezzo with a wide chest belt and audible grit at the top of the register.

Weight is the whole game. The chest register is thick and gospel-shaped, onsets are firm and closer to glottal than breathy, and the belt keeps chest quality all the way to F5 with a wide vibrato that opens as the note holds. Grit shows up at peaks as an edge riding on a supported tone. Chasing the volume without breath pressure underneath turns that edge into throat scraping.

Baekhyun

F2–E5 · 2 octaves + 11



Tenor · full voice to C5 · South Korea · prominent since 2012 · known for “UN Village”

Warm tenor with soft-edged attack and quick runs; the mix thickens rather than thins as it climbs.

Unusually, the tone gets rounder as it rises. Onsets are soft-edged, close to sighed, and runs stay quick and light with no grit. The mix around C5 keeps its warmth instead of narrowing to a point, and vibrato is moderate and steady. Ornaments are small and rhythmically tight. Treating those runs as fast scales is the common error; they are placed against the beat, and rushing them flattens the phrase.

Chen

G2–F5 · 2 octaves + 10



Tenor · full voice to C5 · South Korea · prominent since 2012 · known for “Beautiful Goodbye”

Forward, chest-heavy tenor; belted lines land with a slight cry instead of a shout.

Forward and chest-dominant from the bottom up. There is no scoop into notes; he arrives on pitch with a firm onset and a narrow pharyngeal cry that makes the C5 belt sound urgent rather than loud. Vibrato is steady, medium in width, and held through the ends of phrases. Above the belt he thins instead of pushing. Answering that urgency with volume raises the larynx and the cry becomes strain.

D.O.

F2–F#5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor · South Korea · prominent since 2012 · known for “That's Okay”

Soft-grained lyric tenor — warm low register, immaculate tuning, quick precise runs kept quiet and close.

Warm and rounded even at speaking pitch, this voice sits low for a tenor and gains its color from a relaxed jaw and tall vowels. D.O. ornaments melodies with short, precise runs, placing each passing note rather than smearing. Vibrato arrives late on held tones, narrow and calm. Imitators tend to breathe shallowly and chase his darkness by depressing the larynx; the actual sound is forward, unforced, and conversational up through the mid-fourth octave.

Kenshi Yonezu

F2–D5 · 2 octaves + 9



Baritone · full voice to A4 · Japan · prominent since 2012 · known for “Lemon”

Nasal baritone with a flat deadpan low register that tightens into a strained, plaintive high belt.

Two registers, deliberately unblended. The low register is flat and nearly deadpan, nasal and close-mic'd, with almost no vibrato. The upper register tightens into a strained, plaintive quality that keeps a hard edge instead of opening out — full voice is cited to about A4, and the tension is the intended effect rather than a fault. Consonants are clipped to serve rhythm, and phrases sit tight to the grid. Students copy the strain by squeezing the throat; the sound depends on breath support underneath it, or it goes hoarse within a song.

Loreen

B2–B5 · 3 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · Sweden · prominent since 2012 · known for “Euphoria”

LOW B2 IN “IS IT LOVE” · HIGH B5 IN “NEON LIGHTS”

Smoky low verses that bloom into hooded, resonant top notes; Nordic electro-pop sung like a ritual.

Loreen builds phrases from the floor up: verses sit in a dusky, half-breathy chest near her B2 lows, consonants softened, almost spoken. For choruses she narrows into a hooded, covered mix, keeping the larynx steady so B5 arrives dark instead of shrill. Vibrato is late and slow, applied only at phrase ends, and her ornaments lean on Middle Eastern-inflected turns. Students copying her over-darken and go breathy everywhere; the covered top only works because the support underneath is rigid.

Arijit Singh

C3–C5 · 2 octaves



Tenor · full voice to A4 · India · prominent since 2013 · known for “Tum Hi Ho”

Light nasal voice, breath-forward; slips into head voice at the top rather than pushing chest.

Breath leads the tone: light, slightly nasal in placement, conversational even as the dynamic rises. The distance between the A4 belt and the C5 ceiling tells you how the instrument is wired, because above that belt he thins into head voice rather than driving chest, so the highest notes arrive quieter and softer-edged. Attacks are gentle, vibrato slight and late, ornaments kept small. Pushed for volume, the fourth-octave phrases lose the intimacy the phrasing is built on.

Hua Chenyu

G2–Bb5 · 3 octaves + 3



Tenor · China · prominent since 2013 · known for “齐天 (Qi Tian)”

Shape-shifting art-pop tenor that leaps from murmured verses to wailing rock climaxes and floated falsetto.

Hua switches vocal costumes per song: breathy croon, punk shout, operatic float, sometimes within one arc from G2 up to Bb5. His default is a bright, forward tenor with quick vibrato, but he distorts on purpose — rasp, cry breaks, yodel-like flips — as arrangement choices, each cleanly supported underneath. High sustained wails sit in reinforced mix, not pure falsetto. Students copying the effects first end up forcing; the effects only work stacked on stable, unglamorous fundamentals.

Jimin

A2–F5 · 2 octaves + 8



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · South Korea · prominent since 2013 · known for “Serendipity”

Light, narrow tenor tone; favors soft head voice and fast vibrato over chest projection.

The distance between the Bb4 belt and the F5 ceiling never gets belted; he thins through it instead. Tone is narrow and slightly forward, onsets gentle, and the vibrato is fast and shallow, arriving late on held notes. Head voice does the work up top, kept light but connected. Reaching for volume in the upper mix flattens the tone into a shout and the vibrato disappears.

Jin

Bb2–B5 · 3 octaves + 1



Tenor · South Korea · prominent since 2013 · known for “Epiphany”

Light, airy tenor with a plaintive edge — glassy falsetto peaks and long, even sustains over BTS ballads.

A light tenor instrument that blooms above the staff: Jin keeps the larynx steady and lets air lead the tone, so sustained notes carry a slow, even vibrato instead of push. His falsetto is unusually connected to chest, and he glides between the two without a flip. Students copying him usually over-darken the low range; he keeps Bb2 territory soft and speech-like, saving pressure for climactic head-voice peaks.

Jungkook

F2–A5 · 3 octaves + 4



Tenor · full voice to C5 · South Korea · prominent since 2013 · known for “Euphoria”

Bright tenor, breathy on low lines, then a thin but unstrained mix that slides into falsetto.

Listen for how little weight he carries. Low lines come out on air, with soft aspirate onsets and almost no vibrato, then the tone narrows and brightens as it climbs. The mix around C5 stays slim rather than loud, and above it he releases into falsetto instead of driving. Students add chest weight and volume, which kills the ping and turns the falsetto handoff into an audible break.

V

D2–D5 · 3 octaves



Baritone · full voice to A4 · South Korea · prominent since 2013 · known for “Singularity”

Dark, husky baritone that sits speech-close and thins to airy falsetto instead of pushing chest.

The voice sits close to speech: dark, husky, slightly behind the beat, with a lot of breath mixed into the tone even at low volume. Full voice is cited to around A4, and rather than push chest higher he thins deliberately into an airy falsetto above that, keeping the volume low so the change reads as intimacy rather than strain. Onsets are soft, almost sighed. The common error is adding weight to imitate the darkness — the colour comes from a relaxed, low larynx and a quiet breath, not from pressing.

Solar

G#3–A5 · 2 octaves + 1



Soprano | full voice to F#5 | South Korea · prominent since 2014 · known for “Spit It Out”

HIGH A5 IN “ROAD TO SAMPO”

Cutting, mask-bright soprano — chesty mix that stays full to the top, with crisp rhythmic phrasing.

Bright, forward placement defines this soprano: the tone cuts through dense arrangements because she keeps resonance in the mask and vowels narrow. Her chest-dominant mix climbs unusually high, holding full-voice intensity to F#5 before head voice takes the last step. Phrasing is rhythmically exact, with ornaments used sparingly. Students copying her usually spread the vowel as they ascend and lose the ring; she narrows instead, letting brightness rather than volume create the cut.

Wendy

C#3–Eb7 · 4 octaves + 2



Soprano | full voice to G#5 | whistle register | South Korea · prominent since 2014 · known for “Like Water”

Bright R&B soprano — compressed belts, clean head-voice peaks, and a documented whistle top above the staff.

An R&B-schooled soprano who treats registers as one continuous hallway: chest stays bright and compressed, the mix carries belts toward G#5, and head voice takes over cleanly rather than thinning out. Her runs are counted, landing on chord tones, and she shades dynamics inside single syllables. The common copying mistake is shouting the belt; Wendy leans on breath compression and narrow vowels, which is why the top stays ringing instead of spread.

Rosé

F3–C6 · 2 octaves + 7



Soprano · full voice to E5 · New Zealand · prominent since 2016 · known for “On the Ground”

Reedy, slightly nasal soprano with wavering vibrato; prefers an airy top to full-chest volume.

Two things define it: a reedy, slightly nasal core, and a vibrato that wavers wide and a little unevenly, arriving early on sustains. Instead of pushing chest she lets the top go airy and translucent, so the E5 belt reads as intensity rather than volume. Consonants are soft, vowels narrow. That wobble is not a shake made in the throat; it comes from loose, unpressed airflow, and shaking for it produces a different sound entirely.

Dimash Kudaibergen

C2–C8 · 6 octaves



Tenor · full voice to F5 · whistle register · Kazakhstan · prominent since 2017 · known for “S.O.S. d'un terrien en détresse”

HIGH C8 IN “UNFORGETTABLE DAY (LIVE AT GAKKU)”

The six-octave phenomenon: bass lows to whistle highs in one performance, with conservatory technique at every altitude.

Register-switching at this scale is the real spectacle: subharmonic-reinforced lows, a classically placed tenor middle, a belt that stays supported past F5, then seamless handoffs into reinforced falsetto and whistle, each register entered with its own dedicated technique rather than stretched from the last one. Ornaments carry Kazakh traditional inflection. Study the handoffs, not the extremes: practice passing one vowel across chest, mix and falsetto with no volume bump at the seams. The six octaves are his; the smooth seams are learnable.

Jongho

A2–D6 · 3 octaves + 5



Tenor · full voice to A5 · South Korea · prominent since 2018 · known for “Utopia”

LOW A2 IN “HUG ME”

Full-throated K-pop belter — steel-cored mix that holds fifth-octave notes in full voice mid-choreography.

Built around a thick, pressurized mix, this tenor belts where most voices flip: sustained A5 phrases arrive in full voice with a fast, tight vibrato and no audible register seam. Onsets are clean and glottal-light even at maximum volume, and he holds pitch while moving hard through choreography-level breath demands. Copying the belt without his low-breath anchoring produces strain fast; the power comes from compression at the body, not squeeze at the throat.

Ado

E3–Bb5 · 2 octaves + 6



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to F5 · Japan · prominent since 2020 · known for “New Genesis”

Gritty mezzo alternating growled low verses with a hard forward belt and abrupt clean high notes.

Texture change is the structure. Low verses come out growled, with a rough distorted edge over the tone, then the belt lands hard around F5, forward and wide and unornamented, and above it the distortion drops away for an abrupt clean high note. Vibrato is minimal; straight tone is the default. Imitating the growl with real throat friction is unsustainable and takes the clean belt down with it.

Fujii Kaze

G2–D5 · 2 octaves + 7



Baritone · full voice to E4 · Japan · prominent since 2020 · known for “Shinunoga E-Wa”

Okayama soul: a loose, jazz-chorded baritone that slips from woody lows to weightless falsetto with pianist's harmony ears.

Harmony-first singing defines the style: melodies outline extended chords from his own piano voicings, delivered in a relaxed, woody baritone that flips into a weightless, feminine falsetto without ceremony. Japanese diction keeps consonants light, letting phrases swing. The lows are true and unforced; the falsetto is soft-edged, never breathy. Practice arpeggiating ninth chords vocally, chest for the bottom notes, falsetto for the top, one even breath across. The registers must feel like one keyboard, not two instruments.

Sam Ryder

C3–E5 · 2 octaves + 4



Tenor · UK · prominent since 2022 · known for “Space Man”

LOW C3 IN “SOMEBODY” · HIGH E5 IN “SET YOU FREE”

Sunny rock-pop voice with ringing high belts and a feathery falsetto that flips on a dime.

Ryder rides a high-set, sunny placement, mixing so far up that full-sounding notes and reinforced falsetto blur into one column. His head voice up to E5 stays connected because he keeps the vowel narrow and the soft palate high rather than blowing air. Onsets are clean and springy, vibrato quick and even, and around C3 he keeps the text conversational. The common mistake when copying him is belting the top instead of spinning it, which trades his release for shout.

NEXT Reggae, Afrobeats and African voices →

25 Reggae, Afrobeats and African voices

Every tradition in this chapter starts from the same premise: the groove is the lead instrument, and the voice's first job is to sit inside it correctly. Reggae's founders phrase against the one-drop with a horn section's patience, patois vowels rounding the tone; the toasters and dancehall deejays turn the voice fully percussive. Afrobeats' modern stars work by melodic economy — short cells, repeated and mutated, placed with producer-level precision against log drums and shakers — and the entries describe high, bright placements engineered to cut through dense percussion at streaming loudness rather than stage volume. The amapiano-adjacent voices go the other way, gliding breath-soft over the drums. And the elder statesmen of the continent's traditions — griot lineages, mbalax, Afro-jazz — contribute some of the book's most distinctive tonal signatures: keening, reedy, ecstatic colors carrying centuries of technique with no conservatory paperwork.

Across all of it, ornament is rhythmic before it is melodic. Where gospel bends pitch to intensify harmony, these traditions bend *time* — a syllable dragged a sixteenth, a run compressed to land on the drum's ghost note — and the technique paragraphs keep directing imitators to the drum pattern first, melody second.

The practical borrowings: melodic economy (build a hook from four notes and make interest through placement), percussive diction at low volume, and the placement lesson — brightness as audibility

engineering. This chapter's voices are heard over the busiest rhythm beds in the book while rarely singing loud, which is a trick every over-singer should study.

Range bars below share one axis, C1 to C8. | marks the top of full voice.



Miriam Makeba

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Mezzo-soprano · South Africa · prominent since 1954 · known for “Pata Pata”

Rich forward mezzo; crisp multilingual diction, click consonants, bell-clear controlled top.

Diction is half of it: crisp consonants, clean vowel changes across languages, and click sounds placed rhythmically inside the melodic line. Tone is rich and forward in the mask, with an even, controlled top that arrives bell-clear rather than pushed. Onsets are precise, vibrato moderate and steady, phrasing dance-driven and exact. Students smear the consonants chasing a smoother legato, and the rhythmic snap that carries the whole thing goes flat.

Fela Kuti

F2–A4 · 2 octaves + 4



Baritone · Nigeria · prominent since 1961 · known for “Zombie”

Rough mid-weight baritone built for call-and-response chant; talks pitch, shouts line endings.

Chant, not melody, organizes this baritone. Pitch is often spoken or half-sung, parked in a rough mid-weight middle, with line endings shouted for emphasis and left open for a group answer. Rhythm rules everything: syllables lock to the groove and repeat, and long sustains are rare. Vibrato is essentially absent. Smoothing the delivery into legato melody works against it, because the whole approach is percussive and conversational.

Jimmy Cliff

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor Jamaica · prominent since 1962 · known for “Many Rivers to Cross”

Bright gospel-leaning tenor; open vowels, long sustained upper notes, wide vibrato at phrase ends.

Open vowels and a lifted soft palate give this tenor its gospel brightness — forward, ringing, never covered. Attacks are clean and unscooped, phrases climb rather than sit, and long upper notes take a wide, slow vibrato that only switches on once the pitch has settled. Many Rivers to Cross shows that habit plainly. Bring the vibrato in too early and the straight-tone arrival that makes the note land disappears.

Toots Hibbert

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor Jamaica · prominent since 1962 · known for “Pressure Drop”

Rasping soul-shouter tenor; grit on every held note, pushes chest voice up until it frays.

Grit is the point, and it comes from air pressure meeting a firmly closed larynx, not from scraping the throat. Chest weight gets carried high and pushed until the tone frays, which is what gives held notes their rasp. Phrasing is shouted and rhythmic, landing hard on downbeats, with short interjections dropped between lines. Nothing releases into a light head register. The imitation that fails is the one that growls with no breath support underneath.

Bob Marley

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7

Tenor Jamaica · prominent since 1963 · known for “No Woman, No Cry”

Light nasal-forward tenor; clipped offbeat phrasing, thin bright top, easy slides into head voice.

Tone sits high in the nose and front of the mouth, light for a tenor reaching C5 — placement carries it, not pressure. Onsets are soft, often slightly breathy, and consonants get clipped so syllables land in the gaps left by the drum and bass. Vibrato stays narrow and arrives late. Above the staff he thins into head voice rather than belting. Students copy the vowels and miss the offbeat, which is where this voice actually lives.

Peter Tosh

F2–G4 · 2 octaves + 2

Baritone Jamaica · prominent since 1963 · known for “Legalize It”

Dark chesty baritone, flat and declamatory; sits near speech pitch with almost no vibrato.

Almost none of this leaves speech territory. The voice is dark and thick-cored, delivered flat and declamatory, with hard glottal onsets and very little vibrato to soften a held note. Lines stay inside a narrow working band and lean on rhythm and consonant weight for emphasis instead of pitch movement. Toward G4 the sound gets tighter and louder rather than lighter, and the phrase usually ends before the note has to bloom.

Dennis Brown

G2–D5 · 2 octaves + 7



Tenor · full voice to Bb4 · Jamaica · prominent since 1969 · known for “Money in My Pocket”

Round warm tenor with a smooth chest-to-head handoff mid-phrase and quick falsetto flips.

Two numbers explain this voice: a belt topping out near Bb4 and a range that keeps going to D5. Everything above the belt is head voice or a quick falsetto flip, and the handoff happens mid-phrase with no audible seam. Tone is round and warm, onsets gentle, vibrato even and moderate. Ornaments stay small — a turn, a scoop into a sustained note — and the highest notes arrive light rather than muscled up in chest.

Salif Keita

B2–D5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor · Mali · prominent since 1970 · known for “Madan”

Reedy high tenor with a nasal cutting edge; melismatic lines and sustained calls near the top.

Nasal, reedy placement gives this high tenor its cutting edge; the tone is thin by design, not by weakness. Lines run melismatic, decorated with fast turns and slides, and the upper register rides on that narrow forward placement instead of on chest weight. Sustained notes near the top act as calls, held straight before any vibrato shows up. Warming and covering the vowels loses the edge that lets the voice cut through a band.

Grace Jones

D3–Bb4 · 1 octave + 8



Contralto Jamaica · prominent since 1977 · known for “Pull Up to the Bumper”

Flat-toned contralto pitched near speech; hard consonants, dry chest resonance, vibrato withheld.

This contralto sits near speaking pitch and stays there, flat and dry and deliberately unwarmed. Chest resonance is present but never blooms, vibrato is withheld almost entirely, and consonants are struck hard so lines come out clipped and mechanical. Long notes hold straight through with no swell. Anyone imitating it tends to add expression — a vibrato, a crescendo, a lift toward Bb4 — and the coolness that carries the sound evaporates.

Youssou N'Dour

A2–D5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor full voice to B4 Senegal · prominent since 1979 · known for “7 Seconds”

High keening tenor shaped by chant ornament; rapid microtonal turns and a piercing bright top.

Ornament drives this voice more than sustain does. The tenor is high, bright and keening, full of rapid microtonal turns between neighboring pitches, and it tends to bend into a note rather than start cleanly on it. Chest carries to around B4; above that the sound stays piercing but narrows toward D5. Phrases finish in long calls. Flatten those turns into plain notes and the line loses everything that identifies it.

Angélique Kidjo

E3–E5 · 2 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to C5 · Benin · prominent since 1981 · known for “Agolo”

Brassy forward mezzo with heavy chest projection; percussive diction, long loud held notes.

Forward placement and a brassy core carry this mezzo, with real chest projection and a percussive attack on every consonant. Held notes stay loud and steady, driven from the breath rather than squeezed in the throat, and the belt carries to about C5 before the tone lightens on its way to E5. Rhythm is exact, usually locked to the drums. Undersinging it does not work — that volume needs full support to stay in tune.

Sade Adu

E3–D5 · 1 octave + 10



Contralto · UK · prominent since 1984 · known for “Smooth Operator”

Restrained contralto: narrow range, level dynamics, straight tone with vibrato barely used.

Restraint is the technique. Dynamics stay level, tone stays straight, and vibrato is applied so lightly you catch it only at the very end of a phrase. Onsets are soft and unaspirated, vowels rounded and cool, and lines stay inside a narrow working band without reaching for a climax. Melisma is rare. Nothing gets added that the line does not ask for, which is why extra volume or decoration reads immediately as wrong.

Cesária Évora

D3–Bb4 · 1 octave + 8



Contralto Cape Verde · prominent since 1988 · known for “Sodade”

Smoky low contralto sung softly close to the mic; conversational, unhurried, vibrato minimal.

Sung inches from the microphone at low volume, this contralto trades projection for detail — you hear the breath, the consonants, the smoke in the lower middle. Onsets are soft, the tempo unhurried, and phrases float a little behind the accompaniment. Vibrato is minimal and vowels stay dark and loose. Push it any louder and the intimacy that makes those low notes work is gone.

Buju Banton

E2–A4 · 2 octaves + 5



Bass-baritone Jamaica · prominent since 1992 · known for “Untold Stories”

Gravel-heavy bass-baritone; sandpaper texture, chanted rhythm, shouts the top rather than lifting.

Sandpaper texture rides on top of a genuinely low, heavy instrument, and the rasp is constant rather than an effect switched on for emphasis. Delivery is chanted and rhythmic, closer to declamation than to melody, with pitches often approached from below and left without vibrato. Near A4 the sound is shouted, not lifted into a lighter register. The low anchor underneath is what keeps that grain from collapsing into plain strain.

Shaggy

E2–F4 · 2 octaves + 1



Bass-baritone Jamaica · prominent since 1993 · known for “It Wasn't Me”

Very deep gravel bass-baritone used percussively; half-spoken toasting, few sustained pitches.

Rhythm and texture do nearly everything here. The voice works as a percussion instrument: half-spoken toasting, very few sustained pitches, and a gravelly bottom that stays close to the microphone instead of projecting. Onsets are dry and consonant-driven, and the top of the stated range barely gets used. The usual mistake is pushing volume to find the depth — the depth comes from a relaxed low placement and a quiet, close delivery.

Wizkid

G2–C5 · 2 octaves + 5



Tenor full voice to G4 Nigeria · prominent since 2010 · known for “Essence”

Light breathy tenor kept in a narrow band; low projection, sighing falsetto tails on line ends.

Keep it small. This tenor works in a narrow band with low projection, a breathy onset, and almost no chest push; the belt tops out around G4 while the range reaches C5, so the notes above that are falsetto sighs which fade rather than land. Phrasing is conversational, landing a fraction late against the groove. The common error is singing it loudly, because volume erases the intimacy that is the entire style.

Burna Boy

F2–C5 · 2 octaves + 7



Baritone Nigeria · prominent since 2012 · known for “Last Last”

Warm baritone with a smoky edge; drags behind the beat, then drops to soft airy falsetto.

A baritone with smoke through the middle and a relaxed, unforced onset. Phrases sit behind the beat, syllables stretched lazily across the groove, and lines often finish by dropping into a soft, airy falsetto instead of climbing in chest. Vibrato is barely present. That rhythmic drag is the hard part to copy — sing right on the beat and the whole thing tightens up and loses its slouch.

Tems

D3–D5 · 2 octaves



Contralto full voice to Bb4 Nigeria · prominent since 2018 · known for “Free Mind”

Husky contralto sitting far lower than most pop voices; hoarse-edged tone, lazy pitch slides.

Notice how low this sits: a D3 floor and a heavy, hoarse-edged middle in the region where most pop voices are already thinning. Onsets are lazy and frequently slide up into the pitch from underneath. Chest weight carries to about Bb4, above which the tone goes breathy on the way to D5. Vibrato is slow and used sparingly. Brighten the vowels or lift the placement and the huskiness goes with them.

Rema

C#3–E5 · 2 octaves + 3



Tenor · full voice to F#4 · Nigeria · prominent since 2019 · known for “Calm Down”

Afrorave's bright edge: a nasal, high-placed tenor that loops melodic cells like percussion and yodels at the seams.

Placement sits high and nasal by design, a bright, cutting tone that stays audible over dense percussion without volume, and melodies work as short repeated cells that mutate one note at a time, closer to drum programming than verse-chorus singing. Little yodel-flips mark the cell boundaries. Vibrato is rare; the interest is rhythmic. Loop one four-note phrase and practice shifting a single pitch each repetition while the groove stays locked. Through-composed phrasing misses how this music actually breathes.

Ayra Starr

E3–E5 · 2 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to B4 · Nigeria · prominent since 2021 · known for “Rush”

Sabi girl smoke: a low-set, velvet mezzo with lazy-lidded phrasing and sudden bright leaps that snap the ear awake.

Cool understatement rules the verses: a smoky, low-sitting mezzo delivering syllables slightly late and legato, Nigerian Pidgin inflections keeping the rhythm supple. Then a chorus line leaps an octave into a bright, girlish head tone, and the contrast between velvet and shine is the hook. Runs are compact, pentatonic and unhurried. Work the low register's clarity first, no fry, no push, then rehearse the leap so the top arrives light instead of grabbed. Both colors have to sound unforced.

Tyla

D3–D5 · 2 octaves



Mezzo-soprano · full voice to A4 · South Africa · prominent since 2023 · known for “Water”

Popiano's breathy shimmer: a light South African mezzo gliding on log-drum grooves, all sighs, slides and softness.

Glide is the operative word: phrases slide between notes on a breathy, sun-warmed tone, landing softly on the amapiano log-drum groove rather than striking it, with South African vowel color keeping the sound rounded. Runs are short downward sighs. Nothing is belted; intensity registers as closeness, the voice leaning into the mic. Practice connecting a five-note descent as one continuous slide with even breath, then place it fractionally behind a drum loop. Percussive, syllable-forward singing breaks the water-smooth surface the name promises.

NEXT The records →

PART IX

Appendices

26 The records 396

27 Every voice by type 403

CONTENTS

26 The records

Everything here is generated from the same data as the entries, so it updates as the library does. Where an extreme is famously tied to one recording, the recording is listed with the note.

Read the tables with the first chapter's caveats fully loaded, because records concentrate everything approximate about cited figures. An extreme is one recorded moment — often decades old, often live, sometimes a glissando's peak rather than a sustained pitch — and the singers on these lists could not necessarily reproduce their entry on demand, which they would tell you themselves. The spans table stacks a second caveat on top: a wide figure usually spans multiple vocal mechanisms, so it measures versatility of *production*, not the size of one continuous voice.

For calibration, the world beyond these tables: Guinness verifies extremes far outside anything here, including record lows by Tim Storms that sit below human hearing and are verified by instrument rather than ear; his entry in this atlas carries only his cited, audible floor. Those feats are real and irrelevant to music, which is a useful reminder of what these tables are — documentation of remarkable moments, not a leaderboard anyone should train toward. The atlas's own advice lives in the method chapters: the interesting part of every voice on these lists is the middle, and the middle never makes the record book.

The deepest floors

SINGER	FLOOR	HEARD IN	CITED RANGE
Tim Storms	**B0**	*Lonesome Road*	B0–B4
Geoff Castellucci	**B0**	*Valhalla Calling*	B0–Bb5
Avi Kaplan	**Eb1**	–	Eb1–Db5
Mike Patton	**Eb1**	–	Eb1–Eb7
David Lee Roth	**E1**	*Last Call*	E1–D6
Axl Rose	**F1**	*There Was a Time*	F1–Bb6
Peter Steele	**F1**	*Cinnamon Girl*	F1–G5
Ivan Rebroff	**F1**	–	F1–F5
Ville Valo	**F#1**	–	F#1–B5
Josh Turner	**Ab1**	–	Ab1–C#5
Jonathan Davis	**A1**	*Dead Bodies Everywhere*	A1–F#5
Tom Waits	**A1**	*Crossroads*	A1–G5

The highest ceilings

SINGER	CEILING	HEARD IN	CITED RANGE
Dimash Kudaibergen	**C8** (whistle)	*Unforgettable Day (live at Gakku)*	C2–C8
Mariah Carey	**G7** (whistle)	*Emotions*	F2–G7
Minnie Riperton	**F#7** (whistle)	*You Take My Breath Away*	D3–F#7
Ariana Grande	**E7** (whistle)	–	D3–E7
Wendy	**Eb7** (whistle)	–	C#3–Eb7
Mike Patton	**Eb7**	–	Eb1–Eb7
Normani	**Eb7** (whistle)	–	C#3–Eb7
Rachelle Ferrell	**D7** (whistle)	–	G2–D7
Yma Sumac	**C#7** (whistle)	*Chuncho (The Forest Creatures)*	B2–C#7
Mitch Grassi	**C7** (whistle)	–	F2–C7
Sohyang	**C7** (whistle)	–	E3–C7
Christina Aguilera	**C7** (whistle)	–	C3–C7

The widest spans

SINGER	CITED RANGE	SPAN
Dimash Kudaibergen	C2–C8	6 octaves
Mike Patton	Eb1–Eb7	6 octaves
Axl Rose	F1–Bb6	5 octaves + 5
Mariah Carey	F2–G7	5 octaves + 2
Geoff Castellucci	B0–Bb5	4 octaves + 11
David Lee Roth	E1–D6	4 octaves + 10
Mitch Grassi	F2–C7	4 octaves + 7
Rachelle Ferrell	G2–D7	4 octaves + 7
Ville Valo	F#1–B5	4 octaves + 5
Jack White	E2–A6	4 octaves + 5
Myles Kennedy	Bb1–D6	4 octaves + 4
Stevie Wonder	C2–E6	4 octaves + 4

The highest full-voice ceilings

Belted or full-voice tops, as distinct from falsetto, head voice or whistle: for many readers the most meaningful list on this page.

SINGER	FULL VOICE TO	CITED RANGE
Sohyang	**C6**	E3–C7
Zara Larsson	**B5**	D3–C#6
MARINA	**B5**	Bb2–C#6
Karen Clark Sheard	**Bb5**	F3–Eb6
Grimes	**Bb5**	D3–G6
Madison Beer	**Bb5**	C3–C6
Patti LaBelle	**Bb5**	Bb2–E6
Lara Fabian	**A5**	Eb3–D6
Kim Burrell	**A5**	E3–D6
Jongho	**A5**	A2–D6
Yma Sumac	**A5**	B2–C#7
Leona Lewis	**A5**	C3–F#6

The whistle club

Voices in the library with a documented whistle register. The flag is rare on purpose.

SINGER	CITED TOP	HEARD IN
Dimash Kudaibergen	**C8**	*Unforgettable Day (live at Gakku)*
Mariah Carey	**G7**	*Emotions*
Minnie Riperton	**F#7**	*You Take My Breath Away*
Ariana Grande	**E7**	–
Wendy	**Eb7**	–
Normani	**Eb7**	–
Rachelle Ferrell	**D7**	–
Yma Sumac	**C#7**	*Chuncho (The Forest Creatures)*
Mitch Grassi	**C7**	–
Sohyang	**C7**	–
Christina Aguilera	**C7**	–
JoJo	**Bb6**	–
Kim Petras	**Bb6**	–
Jack White	**A6**	*Corporation*
Nicole Scherzinger	**G#6**	–
Faouzia	**G6**	–
Grimes	**G6**	*Circumambient*
Leona Lewis	**F#6**	*Loving You*
G.E.M.	**F6**	–
Misia	**F6**	–
Tori Kelly	**E6**	–

SINGER	CITED TOP	HEARD IN
Karen Clark Sheard	**Eb6**	–

NEXT Every voice by type →

27 Every voice by type

The method chapters recommend borrowing first from voices built like yours; this appendix is the shelving system that makes it practical. Every entry in the atlas appears below exactly once, grouped by voice type and ordered low to high — basses first, sopranos last — with the cited range beside each name so you can scan a whole shelf at a glance.

A few reminders before you shop. The labels are habitat descriptions, not certifications — the voice-types chapter explains how loosely popular music wears them — and the ranges beside the names are cited spans, with everything that phrase implies about extremes and evidence. Within your own type, expect enormous variety: the point of a shelf is not that its voices sound alike but that their *architecture* is similar enough for techniques to transfer at face value. One shelf away, techniques still transfer with adjustment — usually a transposition — and the chapter on borrowing covers the exchange rate.

If you have taken the range test, find the shelf whose typical spans bracket your own numbers and start reading there. If you have not, the test takes a few minutes and turns this appendix from a list into a mirror. Either way, the shelf you belong to holds more careers, in more genres, than most singers expect to find there — which is the last thing this book has to say, and the most useful.

Basses

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Avi Kaplan	Eb1–Db5
Barry White	D2–E4
Ivan Rebroff	F1–F5
Samuel Ramey	Eb2–F4
Tim Storms	B0–B4

Bass-baritones

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Bryn Terfel	F2–A4
Buju Banton	E2–A4
Fred Hammond	E2–Bb4
Geoff Castellucci	B0–Bb5
Johnny Cash	E2–E4
Josh Turner	Ab1–C#5
Leonard Cohen	D2–E4
Peter Steele	F1–G5
Shaggy	E2–F4
Till Lindemann	E2–F4
Tom Waits	A1–G5
Trace Adkins	D2–G4
Waylon Jennings	E2–D4

Baritones

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Alan Jackson	E2–B4
Alejandro Fernández	F#2–C5
Alex Warren	G2–A4
Andy Biersack	D2–F5
Anthony Kiedis	F2–E5
Bad Bunny	F2–G4
Bill Withers	F2–A4
Bing Crosby	F2–F4
Blake Shelton	D2–C#5
Bobby Darin	G2–E5
Bobby McFerrin	E2–E6
Bruce Springsteen	F2–C5
Burna Boy	F2–C5
Carín León	F#2–A#4
Chad Kroeger	A1–E5
Chris Stapleton	F2–B4
Christian Nodal	A2–G4
Cody Johnson	F#2–G#4
Corey Taylor	E2–A5
Damiano David	A2–B4

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Dan Reynolds	G2–G#5
Dave Gahan	F2–G4
David Bowie	E2–A5
David Coverdale	F2–A5
David Draiman	Bb1–G#5
David Kushner	F2–G4
David Lee Roth	E1–D6
Dean Martin	F2–G4
Dermot Kennedy	E2–C6
Dmitri Hvorostovsky	G2–A4
Drake	D2–C5
Eddie Vedder	D2–E5
Elvis Presley	G2–Db5
Fela Kuti	F2–A4
Frank Sinatra	G2–A4
Freddie Mercury	F2–F6
Fujii Kaze	G2–D5
Garth Brooks	G2–A4
George Ezra	G2–B5
George Jones	B1–B4
George Michael	E2–A5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
George Strait	A2–E4
Giveon	F#2–F#4
Glenn Danzig	C#2–Eb5
Glenn Hughes	D2–D6
Gregory Porter	F2–G4
Harry Connick Jr.	E2–A#4
Harry Styles	E2–F5
Hozier	E2–E5
Hugh Jackman	A2–B4
Ian Curtis	G2–E4
Jacky Cheung	E3–C5
Jacob Collier	D2–D6
James Arthur	Bb2–A5
James Brown	F2–C5
James Hetfield	E2–C5
James Taylor	F2–A4
Jay Chou	A2–B4
Jelly Roll	G2–G4
Jim Morrison	E2–Bb4
Joe Cocker	G2–Bb4
Joe Elliott	D2–G#5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Jonathan Davis	A1–F#5
Josh Groban	G2–A4
Juice WRLD	G2–C5
Julian Casablancas	C2–F#5
Julio Iglesias	B2–G4
Kane Brown	E2–F4
Kenny Rogers	D2–D5
Kenshi Yonezu	F2–D5
Kid Cudi	A1–F5
Kurt Cobain	F2–E5
Layne Staley	E2–G5
Lewis Capaldi	F2–E5
Liam Payne	C#2–Bb5
Louis Armstrong	F2–G4
Luke Combs	A2–A4
M. Shadows	D2–A5
Mac Miller	C#2–E4
Maluma	D3–F4
Marvin Sapp	D#2–F5
Merle Haggard	F2–E4
Michael Bublé	G2–A4

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Michael Hutchence	B1–F#5
Michael McDonald	G#2–A5
Mike Patton	Eb1–Eb7
Morgan Wallen	A2–G4
Morrissey	F#2–B4
Nat King Cole	F2–G4
Neil Diamond	D2–G#4
Nick Cave	D2–G5
Noah Sebastian	A2–D5
Orville Peck	E2–F#5
Otis Redding	F2–C5
Paul Rodgers	E2–G#5
Peter Gabriel	F#2–A4
Peter Tosh	F2–G4
Post Malone	E2–E5
Rag'n'Bone Man	G2–B5
Randy Travis	F2–E4
Rauw Alejandro	G2–C5
Rick Astley	F2–D5
Scott Hoying	F2–Bb5
Scott Stapp	D2–D5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Scott Weiland	E2–C#5
Serj Tankian	F2–C6
Sombr	A2–F#4
Stephen Sanchez	C#3–F#5
Stromae	G2–G4
Sturgill Simpson	Eb2–C#6
Teddy Pendergrass	E2–Bb4
Teddy Swims	E2–A5
Tim McGraw	F2–B4
Tobias Forge	D2–G#5
Tom Jones	G2–Bb4
Tom Petty	C2–Bb5
Tony Bennett	A2–A4
Tyler, the Creator	B1–B5
V	D2–D5
Ville Valo	F#1–B5
XXXTentacion	C3–F5
Zach Bryan	G2–F#4

Tenors

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Aaron Neville	G2–Bb5
Aaron Tveit	A2–D5
Adam Lambert	F2–C6
Adam Levine	A2–C6
Akon	C3–Bb4
Al Green	F2–Bb5
Al Jarreau	G2–A5
Alex Turner	E2–G5
Anderson .Paak	C3–F5
Andrea Bocelli	C3–B4
Arijit Singh	C3–C5
Axl Rose	F1–Bb6
Baekhyun	F2–E5
Barry Gibb	F2–D6
Barry Manilow	D2–G5
BeBe Winans	A2–E5
Ben Platt	A2–F5
Benson Boone	G2–A5
Billie Joe Armstrong	F2–C5
Billy Corgan	F2–E5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Billy Joel	F2–C6
Bob Dylan	E2–A4
Bob Marley	F2–C5
Bobby Hatfield	B2–Eb6
Bono	Eb2–Db5
Boy George	D2–A5
Brad Delp	G#2–D6
Brandon Boyd	F2–A5
Brandon Flowers	F#2–G#5
Brendon Urie	E2–C6
Brian Johnson	A2–E5
Brian McKnight	A2–Bb5
Brian Wilson	C2–Bb5
Bruce Dickinson	E2–C6
Bruno Mars	G2–D6
Bryan Adams	Eb2–E6
Bryson Tiller	A2–C6
Caetano Veloso	A2–C5
Caleb Followill	A2–E5
Calum Scott	B2–C#5
Camilo Sesto	A2–E5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
CeeLo Green	Bb1–C6
Charles Aznavour	D3–B4
Charlie Puth	G2–C6
Chen	G2–F5
Chester Bennington	G2–A5
Childish Gambino	Bb1–C6
Chino Moreno	F2–A5
Chris Brown	C3–G#5
Chris Cornell	E2–A5
Chris Martin	D2–C6
Chris Tomlin	A2–D5
Christopher Cross	D3–A#4
Colm Wilkinson	G2–C5
Conan Gray	C3–G5
Cristian Castro	G2–C6
Curtis Mayfield	G2–Bb5
D.O.	F2–F#5
D'Angelo	G2–Bb5
Daniel Caesar	C#3–F#5
Daryl Hall	E2–C6
David Phelps	E2–D5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
David Ruffin	A2–E6
Dennis Brown	G2–D5
Dennis DeYoung	E2–A5
Devin Townsend	F2–C6
Dimash Kudaibergen	C2–C8
Don Henley	F#2–D#5
Donnie McClurkin	B2–E5
Donny Hathaway	F2–C5
Ed Sheeran	G2–A5
Elton John	F2–F5
Enrico Caruso	B2–Bb4
Enrique Iglesias	C#3–G#4
Frank Ocean	C#2–G5
Frankie Valli	A2–C6
Geddy Lee	F2–Bb5
Geoff Tate	E2–C6
Gerard Way	F#2–F#5
Glen Campbell	F2–A4
Hank Williams	A2–A4
Hua Chenyu	G2–Bb5
Ian Gillan	G2–Bb5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Jack White	E2–A6
Jackie Wilson	A2–C#6
James Bay	G2–C6
James Blake	F2–F5
Jason Derulo	A2–Bb5
Jason Mraz	F2–Bb5
Jeff Buckley	E2–D6
Jeremy Jordan	A2–E5
Jimin	A2–F5
Jimmy Cliff	F2–C5
Jin	Bb2–B5
JJ Lin	G2–G5
John Denver	G2–B5
John Legend	E2–Bb5
John Lennon	G2–D5
Johnny Mathis	B2–G5
Jon Anderson	C#3–F#5
Jon Bon Jovi	E2–D5
Jonas Kaufmann	B2–C5
Jonathan Groff	A2–C5
Jongho	A2–D6

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Jonghyun	F2–E5
José Carreras	C3–C5
José José	A2–D5
Josh Kiszka	C3–C#6
Juan Diego Flórez	C3–E5
Juan Gabriel	A2–C5
Jungkook	F2–A5
Justin Bieber	A2–Bb5
Justin Timberlake	A2–C6
Justin Vernon	F2–F5
JVKE	C3–F5
Keith Urban	F2–A5
Kellin Quinn	B2–A5
Kenny Chesney	D#2–F#4
Kenny Loggins	D2–C#6
Kevin Cronin	G2–A4
Klaus Meine	G2–C6
Lenny Kravitz	A2–Bb5
Leon Bridges	B2–G4
Lionel Richie	F2–G5
Little Richard	F2–Bb5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Lou Gramm	B1–A5
Louis Tomlinson	C3–A4
Luciano Pavarotti	C3–C5
Luis Fonsi	E3–A4
Luis Miguel	A2–D5
Luther Vandross	B2–A5
Marc Anthony	A2–E5
Mario Lanza	C3–C5
Marvin Gaye	F2–Bb5
Marvin Winans	A2–F5
Matt Bellamy	E2–D6
Matty Healy	F2–A5
Maxwell	A2–C6
Maynard James Keenan	F2–A5
Meat Loaf	F2–Eb6
Mel Tormé	G2–C5
Michael Crawford	A2–Bb4
Michael Jackson	Eb2–F6
Michael Kiske	F2–C6
Michael W. Smith	A2–D5
Mick Jagger	F2–F5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Miguel	C3–Bb5
Mika	F#2–G#5
Milton Nascimento	G2–Bb5
Morten Harket	A2–E5
Musiq Soulchild	C3–F#5
Myles Kennedy	Bb1–D6
Myles Smith	B2–G4
Nate Ruess	G2–A5
Ne-Yo	Eb2–A5
Neil Young	G2–C5
Niall Horan	F#2–B5
Noah Kahan	B2–A4
Oli Sykes	Eb2–G#5
Omar Apollo	C3–F#5
Ozuna	F#2–C5
Ozzy Osbourne	G2–D5
Park Hyo Shin	F2–E5
Passenger	D#2–A4
Patrick Stump	C3–B5
Paul McCartney	F2–E5
Paul Simon	A2–D5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Peso Pluma	B2–F#4
Pharrell Williams	Eb2–Bb5
Phil Collins	F2–Db5
Plácido Domingo	A2–C5
Prince	E2–B5
Ramin Karimloo	G2–C5
Ray Charles	C2–Bb5
Rema	C#3–E5
Ricky Martin	B2–C5
Rivers Cuomo	Eb2–G5
Rob Halford	F2–C6
Robbie Williams	F2–B5
Robert Plant	F2–A5
Robert Smith	C#3–C5
Rod Stewart	E2–C5
Roger Daltrey	F2–C5
Ronnie James Dio	F2–Bb5
Ronnie Radke	D2–G5
Roy Orbison	E2–E5
Rufus Wainwright	A2–D5
Salif Keita	B2–D5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Sam Cooke	A2–E5
Sam Fender	F#2–F5
Sam Ryder	C3–E5
Sammy Hagar	D2–B5
Seal	Eb2–G5
Sebastian Bach	F2–C6
Shawn Mendes	G2–E5
Smokey Robinson	A2–Bb5
Smokie Norful	D2–D#5
Steve Lacy	C#3–E5
Steve Perry	G2–A5
Steven Tyler	F2–C6
Stevie Wonder	C2–E6
Sting	Eb2–E5
Sufjan Stevens	B2–A4
T-Pain	B2–F5
Taeyang	A2–F5
The Weeknd	G2–B5
Thom Yorke	F2–F5
Toots Hibbert	G2–C5
Trey Songz	F2–G5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Troye Sivan	C3–F5
Tyler Childers	E2–C6
Tyler Joseph	A2–F6
Usher	Bb2–A5
Van Morrison	G2–D5
Vance Joy	B2–A5
Vicente Fernández	A2–C5
Vince Gill	A2–C5
Vitas	D2–Eb6
Willie Nelson	G2–F4
Wilson Pickett	Bb2–E6
Wizkid	G2–C5
Youssou N'Dour	A2–D5
Zayn	D3–B5

Countertenors

SINGER	CITED RANGE
King Diamond	F2–D6
Mitch Grassi	F2–C7
Philip Bailey	G2–D6
Philippe Jaroussky	D3–G#5
Sam Smith	G2–C6

Contraltos

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Amy Winehouse	C3–Eb5
Anita Baker	C#3–C#6
Annie Lennox	G2–A5
ANOHNI	A2–F5
Billie Holiday	F3–C5
Celia Cruz	E3–G5
Cesária Évora	D3–Bb4
Cher	F2–A5
Clairo	G3–C5
Diana Krall	E3–C5
Etta James	G#2–B5
Fiona Apple	C3–A5
Gigi Perez	E3–C#5
Grace Jones	D3–Bb4
Grace Slick	E3–D5
India.Arie	A2–C6
Joan Jett	E3–C5
Judy Garland	F3–Eb5
Julie London	C#3–C#5
Karen Carpenter	D3–Eb5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Laufey	F3–D5
Mahalia Jackson	E3–F5
Mercedes Sosa	E3–E5
Monica	B2–B5
Nina Simone	G2–F5
Norah Jones	F3–C5
Patsy Cline	E3–D5
Peggy Lee	D3–A5
Sade Adu	E3–D5
Sarah Vaughan	Eb3–C6
Shirley Manson	F3–A5
Stevie Nicks	E3–D5
Tasha Cobbs Leonard	D3–A5
Tems	D3–D5
Tina Turner	G2–Eb5
Toni Braxton	Bb2–Bb5
Tracy Chapman	D3–D5
Wynonna Judd	E3–E5

Mezzo-sopranos

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Adele	C3–Bb5
Ado	E3–Bb5
Ailee	F3–C6
Alanis Morissette	B2–C6
Alicia Keys	A2–Bb5
Amy Grant	F3–E5
Amy Lee	E3–E6
Andra Day	E3–F#5
Ángela Aguilar	Eb3–G5
Angélique Kidjo	E3–E5
Ann Wilson	G2–E6
Aretha Franklin	G2–E6
Ashanti	F3–C6
Auli'i Cravalho	F3–E5
Avril Lavigne	F3–E5
Ayra Starr	E3–E5
Ayumi Hamasaki	F3–Bb5
Barbra Streisand	Bb2–C6
Beyoncé	B2–Eb6
Billie Eilish	A2–B5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Bonnie Tyler	D3–G5
Brandy	G2–E6
Cécile McLorin Salvant	F3–Bb5
Cecilia Bartoli	F3–D6
Chaka Khan	F2–B5
Charli XCX	F3–F5
Christina Aguilera	C3–C7
Ciara	Bb2–A5
Coco Jones	B2–C#6
Cynthia Erivo	E3–C6
Debbie Harry	F3–E5
Demi Lovato	C#3–D6
Dinah Washington	Eb3–E5
Dolores O'Riordan	E3–C6
Dua Lipa	B2–G5
Dusty Springfield	C3–Eb5
Édith Piaf	B2–D5
Elis Regina	E3–Bb5
Ella Fitzgerald	D3–C6
Ella Mai	C3–G#5
Emeli Sandé	D3–F5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Erykah Badu	G2–D5
Ethel Merman	F3–D5
Faith Evans	C#3–C#6
Faith Hill	C3–Bb5
Fantasia	C3–Bb5
Faye Wong	E3–D5
Florence Welch	F3–B5
Gladys Knight	E3–D5
Gloria Estefan	E3–Bb5
Gwen Stefani	F3–Bb5
H.E.R.	C3–F#5
Halsey	C3–G5
Hikaru Utada	E3–Bb5
Idina Menzel	G2–D6
Janis Joplin	A2–Bb5
Jazmine Sullivan	A2–C#6
Jenni Rivera	C3–E5
Jennifer Hudson	A2–C6
Jessie J	C#3–C6
Jill Scott	C3–E5
JoJo	A2–Bb6

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Joss Stone	C3–G5
Kacey Musgraves	G3–D5
Kali Uchis	C3–F5
Karol G	E3–A5
Katy Perry	A2–C6
Kehlani	D3–E5
Kelly Clarkson	D3–Eb6
Kelly Rowland	C3–Eb6
Kesha	D3–E6
Keyshia Cole	C3–Bb5
Kim Burrell	E3–D6
Kirstin Maldonado	F3–C6
Lady Gaga	G2–C6
Lainey Wilson	A3–C#5
Lana Del Rey	C3–D6
Laura Pausini	B2–F5
Lauren Daigle	E3–A5
Lauryn Hill	Bb2–A5
Lea Michele	F3–Bb5
LiSA	F3–F5
Lizzo	E3–Bb5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Lizzy McAlpine	E3–C#5
Lola Young	E3–Bb5
Lorde	D3–A5
Loreen	B2–B5
Loren Allred	E3–F#5
Loretta Lynn	G3–D5
Lzzy Hale	G2–C6
Macy Gray	A2–D6
Madonna	F3–Bb5
MARINA	Bb2–C#6
Mary J. Blige	A2–C6
Meghan Trainor	Eb3–B5
Miley Cyrus	G2–E6
Miranda Lambert	E3–D5
Miriam Makeba	E3–D5
Normani	C#3–Eb7
Olivia Newton-John	F3–Bb5
Olivia Rodrigo	B2–Bb5
Pat Benatar	F3–Bb5
Patti LuPone	E3–G5
Pink	G2–Bb5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Rachelle Ferrell	G2–D7
RAYE	C#3–D6
Reba McEntire	E3–F5
Reneé Rapp	E3–G#5
Rihanna	B2–B5
Rosalía	F3–Bb5
Samara Joy	B2–D5
Sara Bareilles	B2–E6
Selena	E3–Bb5
Selena Gomez	C3–F5
Shakira	E3–D6
Shania Twain	E3–E5
Sia	C3–C6
Simone Simons	G3–C#6
Sinéad O'Connor	F3–A5
Summer Walker	D3–E5
Sutton Foster	F3–A5
SZA	E3–C6
Tamia	Eb3–D6
Tammy Wynette	G3–E5
Tatiana Shmayluk	A2–G5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Taylor Swift	A2–Bb5
Tori Amos	E3–C6
Trisha Yearwood	D3–A5
Tyla	D3–D5
Victoria Monét	B2–A5
Whitney Houston	A2–C6
Yebba	D3–G5
Yolanda Adams	E3–C6

Sopranos

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Aaliyah	C#3–A5
Alison Krauss	G3–D5
Anna Netrebko	G3–D6
Ari Lennox	Bb2–E6
Ariana Grande	D3–E7
Audra McDonald	F3–C6
Aurora	Eb3–E6
Ava Max	E3–C#6
Bebe Rexha	D3–B5
Bernadette Peters	G3–A5
Birgit Nilsson	C#3–D6
Björk	E3–C6
BoA	D3–C#6
Britney Spears	B2–F#5
Camila Cabello	D3–G5
Caroline Polachek	G#2–F6
Carrie Underwood	F3–C6
CeCe Winans	F3–C6
Celine Dion	Bb2–C6
Chappell Roan	E3–Bb5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Cyndi Lauper	F3–C6
Diana Damrau	Bb3–G#6
Diana Ross	Eb3–C6
Doja Cat	C3–B5
Dolly Parton	F3–Bb5
Elize Ryd	E3–F#6
Ellie Goulding	D3–A5
Emmylou Harris	G3–D5
Faouzia	C#3–G6
FKA twigs	E3–F6
Floor Jansen	E3–E6
G.E.M.	D3–F6
Gracie Abrams	F3–E5
Grimes	D3–G6
Halle Bailey	C3–C6
Hayley Williams	F3–D6
IU	D3–C6
Jackie Evancho	G#3–A5
Janelle Monáe	C#3–Eb6
Janet Jackson	C3–D6
Jessye Norman	E3–C6

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Jewel	E3–E6
Jhené Aiko	B2–E6
Joan Baez	F3–B5
Joan Sutherland	G3–F6
Joni Mitchell	E3–C6
Julie Andrews	G3–C6
Karen Clark Sheard	F3–Eb6
Kate Bush	C3–C6
Kim Petras	D3–Bb6
Kristin Chenoweth	G3–F6
Lara Fabian	Eb3–D6
Lata Mangeshkar	G3–Bb5
Lea Salonga	F3–D6
LeAnn Rimes	F3–F5
Leona Lewis	C3–F#6
Leontyne Price	G3–C6
Linda Ronstadt	E3–Bb5
Madison Beer	C3–C6
Maria Callas	F#3–Eb6
Mariah Carey	F2–G7
Martina McBride	F3–F5

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Melanie Martinez	F3–D5
Minnie Riperton	D3–F#7
Misia	F3–F6
Mitski	E3–F#5
Montserrat Caballé	G3–C6
Natalia Lafourcade	F3–Bb5
Nicole Scherzinger	D3–G#6
Patti LaBelle	Bb2–E6
Phoebe Bridgers	C#3–E5
Rachel Zegler	Db3–E6
Ravyn Lenae	C#3–C#6
Regina Spektor	F3–C6
Renée Fleming	G3–C6
Rosé	F3–C6
Sabrina Carpenter	E3–C6
Sandi Patty	F3–C6
Sarah Brightman	G3–E6
Sarah McLachlan	F3–B5
Sharon den Adel	G3–D6
Sierra Boggess	G3–E6
Sohyang	E3–C7

SINGER	CITED RANGE
Solange	D3–E6
Solar	G#3–A5
Sumi Jo	A3–F6
Taeyeon	E3–C6
Tamela Mann	F3–C#6
Tarja Turunen	F3–E6
Tate McRae	E3–F5
Teresa Teng	Eb3–B5
Thalía	F3–Bb5
Tinashe	B2–E6
Tori Kelly	B2–E6
Wendy	C#3–Eb7
Yma Sumac	B2–C#7
Zara Larsson	D3–C#6

END OF THE LAST CHAPTER Colophon →

A note on the figures

Every range in this book is a commonly cited figure — compiled from recordings and public discussion, not lab measurements — and the extreme notes are one-off recorded moments rather than anyone's everyday voice. The technique notes describe how voices sound on record.

And a note on practice: nothing here is medicine. If singing hurts, if you are hoarse and it will not clear, or if you ever see blood, that is a question for a doctor or a speech-language pathologist — there is no waiting period, and you do not need to be sure it is serious before you go.

Colophon

The Voice Atlas — Who sings what, how it sounds, and how to borrow it: the range, tone and technique of every voice in the library.. Written for Suede Sing, the browser vocal studio, and included with a Suede Pro subscription. 27 chapters in 9 parts.

Typeset from the same source the app reads, so the book and the in-app chapters can never disagree. Every contents row, part list and chapter footer in this file is a live link, and the contents double as the index — every singer covered is named there.